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Web Novel
Volume

21

Re:ゼロ

Re: Life in a different world from zero

から始める異世界生活

Manifesto

Hello, this is Phantaminum. This is a continuation of a project that aims to standardize nomenclature and formatting, while dividing Web Novel chapters in the same way the Light Novel does. Colored illustrations have also been added where possible for maximum enjoyment. You may find a list of all volumes I have already finished, or plan to work on, at the [final chapter of this document](#).

This document is a compilation of Re: Zero Web Novel chapters that correspond to Volume 27, spanning Web Novel Arc 7 Chapters 13 to 24. Witch Cult Translations ([website](#)), was used as a source of the translations for all the Chapters. Chapters 23 and 24 were produced with use of Machine Translation tools.

For the sake of completeness, I leave you with the same wall of text detailing what I did using the available translations. Feel free to skip it if you don't care/have already read it.

The original translations have been proofread, edited and reformatted by myself, on top of whatever original editing and proofreading work was done by Witch Cult Translations. This means that the formatting should remain consistent no matter which source is used.

I have tried to follow naming conventions present in the Light Novel as much as possible, only diverging when community-given names differed greatly. I have also tried to conserve as many of the original translator notes by Witch Cult Translations as much as possible.

As a fun quirk, I have done something which I admit is probably not consensual: to flip the languages whenever someone speaks what is colloquially coined as Engrish. This means, that in the case where the story uses English, where possible, Japanese will be written as Romaji (Japanese in Latin script). When this happens, a note was added with the original expression (and its translation), and the new expression that was converted to Romaji. Basically, I made everyone using Engrish look like weeaboos.

I hope you enjoy this as much as I did. If you have anything to point out, I'm often lurking in pretty much every Re: Zero discussion site, be it the Reddit Discord Server, the Subreddit, or 4chan's /a/ board. Alternatively, feel free to use [this document](#) to suggest corrections or other changes.

P.S.: Much thanks to Joy Kirbs from Discord for aiding me in redesigning the covers.

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Arc 7 Chapter 13 - As a Mortal

Light Novel Adaptation found in Volume 27, Chapter 1 “Those I Want to Protect”, Parts 1-2

Original Web Novel Chapter — [Complete](#)

Original Translation by Witch Cult Translations (Negi, [Kobosuhito](#)) — [Complete](#)

—Swaying, tottering, wobbling.

His consciousness wavered slowly.

Like a ship traveling across the vast ocean, it wobbled to the right, and to the left.

His consciousness teetered, its feeling heavy, and it felt as if he were going to become dizzy, despite his eyes being closed.

It was not enough. He did not have enough of everything.

Blood, flesh, bones, peace, anger, and happiness. Of those various things that formed a human, there was not enough.

He did not have enough of them, almost as if everything had been spilled somewhere, falling apart like droplets.

He had to gather them up, he thought.

He had to pick them up again, pack them in again, and then he had to stand up once again.

There was a place where he had to go. He had a desire that yearned to go there.

There was a reason why he had to live. He had a wish that cried out, I want to live.

That’s why, that’s why, that’s why...

Even if there was not enough of everything in him, even if he remained flawed and imperfect, he had to keep moving.

For that reason, Natsuki Subaru would—



Subaru: “—Ubeh!”

As soon as he awoke, Natsuki Subaru curled his lip at the sticky sensation on his face.

It felt like the area from his face to his chest was drenched. Its lukewarm sensation seemed similar to the sweat he would feel, on the morning after he had had a nightmare.

Combined with him spacing out with his head feeling heavy, he thought he might have had a fever, perhaps.

Subaru: “...The ceiling is unfamiliar.”

Subaru mumbled out what he saw in his field of vision, a shabby wooden ceiling, with the intent of making it sound like a cliché.

He was in a shack, built by putting wooden materials together in a crude manner, and far from adhering to any architectural style. Subaru was confused on what to think of it for a while, looking at the masterpiece that compensated for its inexperienced technique with raw muscle.

What had caused him to be in this shack? To remember that, Subaru recalled his memories at a gradual pace.

Subaru: “If I remember correctly, after I exited the convenience store and blinked, I found myself in another world, I met Emilia-tan there, and — it’s a bit long, so let’s omit the rest of the details.”

It was a monologue he would not let anyone else hear, but as he continued to joke around, the speed at which he could process his thoughts returned to him.

Yes, after young Natsuki Subaru had been summoned to a different world, he had met a super beautiful silver-haired girl, had gone on various great adventures after that, finally conquered the tower of sand, and had been sent away to a neighboring country.

Subaru: “I have no idea what I’m talking about...”

Anyway, the real situation at hand was how these bizarre situations kept persisting, almost to the point he wanted to bemoan his current predicament.

And then, although he searched through his own memories, he did not remember seeing this shabby ceiling, as expected.

Subaru: “Somewhere like the place in the Sanctuary is a narrow possibility, but the building from the time I was imprisoned by Garfiel was decent.”

Nowadays, the adorable Garfiel admired him and called him “Captain”, but the memory of being imprisoned by him, with his hands and feet tied together, lingered inside of Subaru, despite it being a memory from a world that was lost.

It was not as if Subaru held it against him, but being imprisoned was a valuable experience, so he could not quite forget it even if he tried.

However, the memories he had of his ceiling did not match the poor environment from back then.

He had been living life in a different world, in a place where the level of civilization was rather high, after all. Subaru, a man from the modern era, realized one of his few occasions of fortune right there and then.

While he was in filled with deep emotion, thinking about how he wanted to make that realization in a better environment—

Subaru: “—Hk.”

As he organized the disorderly contents of what went through his head like that, one by one, a sudden realization pierced through him without warning, almost like a clap of thunder.

Yes, this was not the Kingdom of Lugunica, but the Vollachian Empire.

In the neighboring country where he had been unexpectedly thrown into, the people he could rely on were not there—

Subaru: “Rem...!”

The girl who he had to protect no matter what had arrived in this country, together with him.

In addition to that, Subaru had been separated from her, and she was still with the dangerous men—

Subaru: “Am I an idiot? No, I am definitely an idiot...! This isn’t the time to...”

???: “—What are you busying yourself and making a racket for?”

Subaru: “—Ah.”

As Subaru immediately sat upright on the verge of going out to look for Rem with great determination, upon hearing a stiff voice thrown towards him from the side, his breath caught in his throat.

Subaru only noticed it as he sat up, but it seemed like he had been placed in a bed just as shabby as the ceiling. His eyes met with a pair of blue ones beside him, staring at him with a scornful gaze.

The eyes belonged to a girl with rather short blue hair, who was looking at him, her pretty eyes narrowed in a stern manner.

Subaru: “Re... m...?”

Rem: “—I’m not really positive about answering, “yes” to that. I still haven’t acknowledged that I am this person you call Rem, after all.”

Subaru widened his eyes as Rem spoke to him stiffly, sounding as if she were trying to sound impassive to the best of her ability.

However, she was right in front of him, she was speaking, and he could also feel her warmth and sense the gentle fragrance that wafted from her, as evidence of this being neither a dream nor an illusion. Yes, the warmth of her hand also counted.

Subaru: “Huh? A hand?”

Rem: “———”

Suddenly, Subaru was stunned as he realized his right hand was holding the girl’s — Rem’s hand, under the ragged cloth covering his body.

He had no recollection of what had exactly happened, however.

Subaru: “Wait, were you holding my hand until I woke up?”

Rem: “Huh? Don’t say something so disgusting. You can tell by looking at it. You seized my hand and refused to let go.”

Subaru: “O-ohh, I see. I guess that’s right. Yeah, I’m the one who was grabbing your hand...”

He had spurred Rem’s souring mood, unable to tell the difference between expectations and reality.

Apparently, he had been grasping Rem’s hand the whole time he had been unconscious— Even so, the fact she had not shaken him off weighed on his mind.

Rem: “What’s that look in your eyes?”

Subaru: “N-no, no, it’s nothing. Yes, it’s nothing.”

Rem: “I see. Let go of me already. Your hand is slimy with sweat.”

Subaru: “An enormous amount of damage done to an adolescent boy...!”

When said by a cute girl, it was a blow that would inflict an incurable wound, depending on the person receiving it.

Fortunately, Subaru only got away with nearly dying because he was made of tough stuff, but when he timidly let go of Rem’s hand, she brought her hand to her chest and wiped it on her clothes, resulting in him being hit by a follow-up attack.

Anyhow, aside from Subaru’s inner feelings—

Subaru: “Rem, are you hurt anywhere? If you are hurt anywhere, please don’t hide it and tell me.”

Rem: “Huh?”

Subaru: “Eh, what’s that face for...? Did I say anything weird...?”

Setting aside their first interaction, Subaru wanted to be certain of Rem’s safety. However, despite his question being rooted out of concern for her wellbeing, Rem’s reaction was terribly frosty.

Subaru spontaneously panicked, wondering if he had said something he should not have, but he did not have the faintest idea of what it was.

All he had stated had been about his worry for Rem, without anything out of the ordinary.

Rem: “...You’re the one who was seriously injured. You aren’t aware of it, even though you were at death’s door?”

Subaru: “Aware...? Umm, that’s...”

Rem: “I see, it seems like you aren’t— You can’t be trusted, just as I thought.”

Subaru swallowed as she met his eyes, all the while flinging out words of rejection at him.

She had lost her Memories, the smell of the Miasma that encircled Subaru had been of assistance in making a bad impression of him, and Rem’s attitude towards him had remained consistently stand-offish and cold.

Much more than that, he had been unable to create an opportunity to bridge the rift between her and himself this time.

Subaru had been really desperate, trying his best to save Rem from the Empire’s camp—

Subaru: “—Ah.”

Another piece of his deficient memory was filled, and it felt as if he were under an illusion that caused his brain to tremble.

The astonishment he currently felt was special to the point it rivaled Rem’s existence.

Subaru had risked everything to save Rem, after he had been captured by the Empire’s camp.

In the end, he had come across the tribe in the forest — the People of Shudraq, and underwent their ritual, along with the prisoner of war who had been placed in the same cage with him.

And then—

Subaru: “...I have a right hand... And it’s not black.”

Subaru mumbled as he lifted his right arm, looking at the torn sleeve and the arm that peeked out from there.

A dreadfully dark pattern that had surfaced on his right arm. An aftereffect of an encounter with the Sin Archbishops at the Watergate City of Pristella, but it was gone without a trace, despite having been indelible until now.

—That black pattern had treated the wounds of his tattered right arm.

It was an event he remembered as a horrible memory, but it seemed like it was neither a dream nor a nightmare. No, it was a nightmare, but it appeared to be something that had really occurred.

His crippled right arm had been healed, and Rem was at his bedside.

That meant Subaru had finished the Lifeblood Ritual without dying, and he was also successful in taking back Rem— Causing many casualties in return.

Subaru: “———”

Rem: “...You look pale. I think... you should stay in bed.”

She declared that as she looked at Subaru, who grew silent as he glanced down at his unnaturally taintless arm.

Showing her concern to someone when they looked ill, even if she did not have a good opinion of them, was probably a result of her innate kindness. Or it may have been because Subaru’s expression looked like a dead man’s.

A part of him wanted to depend on her kindness.

However, he could not do that. There were too many things he had to make sure of.

Subaru: “Thanks for worrying about me. But, I have a lot of things I need to ask you about... Just asking, but this house belongs to someone from the People of Shudraq, right?”

Rem: “They were calling themselves that, it seems.”

Subaru: “I see... If that’s the case, I want to see Mizelda-san and the others. Also.”

It was a subject he did not want to ask her about, but he could not afford to not verify it.

Rem, who had been imprisoned in the Empire’s camp, was here. If so, he was also curious about the person — Louis, who was similarly held captive over there.

To put it bluntly, he was worried.

Not about Louis’s safety, but more about the damage that would be caused if she were to be left alone.

Subaru: “I’m gonna be honest with you, but where’s that girl... Louis?”

Rem: “—You have a disgruntled look on your face. Why do you keep her at a distance?”

Subaru: “It’s hard to explain. And I have reasons you probably won’t understand even if I did.”

Any conversations regarding Louis would always incur Rem’s displeasure.

Subaru felt pained by that, but he also thought of it as a matter that could not be communicated by talking about it.

Subaru: “Anyway, where’s she? Was she left in the ca...”

Rem: “—You’d know if you looked to your left.”

Subaru: “Ah?”

Pondering over what she had told him, Subaru widened his eyes, and directed them to his left — towards the side opposite to Rem, who was at his right.

And then, glancing over, Subaru's face grew stiff from the delayed bewilderment.

Laying there was---

???: "Zzz... zzz..."

Subaru: "W...ha..."

Louis was sleeping soundly, showing off her innocent, sleeping face.

She was at his left side, sleeping in the same bed and wrapped in the same, ragged cloth. Saliva dripped down from her wide open mouth, and looking at her shameless display, Subaru finally caught onto the situation.

The identity of the stickiness and wet sensation on his chest and face, when he had awoken was---

Subaru: "-----!!"

Subaru let out a soundless scream.



???: "Ohh, Subaru! It seems like you've woken up without any *problem*."

The person who welcomed Subaru as he showed up at the clearing, guided by Rem, was Mizelda.

Her black hair dyed red, the young matriarch of the People of Shudraq walked over to Subaru, who exited the shack, and double-checked his condition from head to toe.

He let out a small, dry laugh at Mizelda's unreserved, yet powerful demeanor that felt rather refreshing.

Subaru: "I made it back alive, thanks to you. It seems like I've made you worry, too."

Mizelda: "Don't worry about *it*. If you were to *die*, all we have to do is return the soul of our brave comrade to the *skies*, and bury your corpse under the soil as we *mourn*. It's a good thing your soul *remained*, instead of that *happening*."

Subaru: “Mizelda-san...”

Crossing her muscular arms, the olive-skinned, tall Mizelda held her head high.

Her unpretentious words bore into his chest, and Subaru felt quietly, and deeply impressed by them. Although, to be honest, back when he had been captured by the Shudraq and placed inside that prison, he had steeled himself for another death.

Like that, while Subaru was impressed by her, Mizelda narrowed her eyes with a, “By the way,”

Mizelda: “It’s too bad you’re *taken*. Rem and Louis... will you add at least one more *person*?”

Rem: “Mizelda-san!”

Next to Subaru, Rem raised her voice at Mizelda’s somewhat mischievous-sounding offer.

She had a stern expression on her face, still shaky on her feet as she walked with her new wooden cane. Having woken up just a little while ago, Louis was clinging onto her arm, her eyes widening out of surprise at Rem’s voice.

While caressing Louis’s blonde hair, Rem called Mizelda by name once again, and then,

Rem: “You shouldn’t say that. I do not trust, or understand this person.”

Mizelda: “Then, could he be given to *me*?”

Rem: “Yes, of course. I will give him to you.”

Subaru: “The conversation isn’t reflecting my will!”

Louis: “Aaa! Uuu!”

With a prickly attitude, Rem agreed to the proposal to transfer Subaru.

When Subaru rushed to put a stop to it, Louis shouted as well, going along with the momentum of the atmosphere.

“I’m only *joking*”, Mizelda laughed as she heard him, but Subaru could not hold back his astonishment once he saw her affable disposition.

He could barely remember what had happened right after the Lifeblood Ritual.

Even after that, he still could not define the line that distinguished his memories from his desires, made to be favorable to him. Seeing how Mizelda was acting, it did not seem like a fantasy, however.

Subaru: “So, for once, I was able to build a good relationship with someone I’ve met for the first time. That’s great, but...”

Mizelda: “Mh, you look *pale*. Are you feeling *unwell*? I can cut off any impaired parts on your *body*.”

Subaru: “I feel like it’s going to turn out to be a disaster if I carelessly say, «Yes, please!», so I’ll decline.”

It was not a joke, but an earnest offer, probably.

He figured it could be a fatal mistake if he were to say, “Yes, please!” without thinking it through. Anyhow—

Subaru: “Last time, I didn’t have the time to look around leisurely, but...”

Going around in a circle to observe the village of the Shudraqians, Subaru muttered.

The village existed deep inside a vast forest, and it looked like a world where the level of civilization’s improvement had come to a halt, including the shack where Subaru had awoken.

It was a sight befitting the impression of what would be called an ethnic minority, living in an uncultivated jungle.

Amazons who lived their lives while taking part in hunting, with no male workers — it seemed like an undeveloped area, indeed, as Subaru saw no signs of civilization in the village.

Subaru: “Their numbers are few, so they can keep living by going hunting everyday... but, I...”

Rem: “_____”

Subaru murmured, knitting his eyebrows in a distressed manner while biting his lip.

Rem was wordlessly staring at his face from the side, with a cross look on her face. Whatever she was thinking in the depths of her blue eyes, the current Subaru was unable to perceive it.

He was scared of being unable to read her thoughts. He also could not smile back with ease at Mizelda, who had smiled at him.

That was why, in order to overcome this situation---

Subaru: "I want to talk to you, Mizelda-san--- I think I also need to speak to that guy... as well."

Mizelda: "...Yeah. You said it at a good *time*. He's probably at the meeting area with Taritta and the others right *now*."

Hearing Subaru's words, Mizelda nodded and jerked her chin.

She was pointing towards a large building at the back of the clearing -- a place that had been referred to as the meeting area. It was most likely a place that fulfilled its role as its name suggested, and setting aside whether it was the most fine-looking construct in the village or not, it seemed as if the role had been assigned to the largest building.

Subaru: "---Let's go."

Locating his destination, Subaru began walking in that direction.

He held out his hand to be of assistance to Rem, just in case, but she had rejected it. Taking Louis with her, she indicated that she would walk on her own with her attitude.

Laughing dryly at the invariable response Rem sent towards him, Subaru tightened his expression.

And then, the group passed through the entrance of the meeting area, and went inside. There---

???: "It seems like you are finally awake. Have you enjoyed yourself, Natsuki Subaru?"

Yes, he was greeted by a masked man, who sat on the ground of the meeting area with one knee raised.



Amidst the Shudraquians, who were surrounding a fire, a man had slipped into the center of the meeting place.

Subaru's cheeks twitched at his reception, and he was also at a loss for words.

Subaru: "-----"

???: "What is it? Surely, you shall not declare that you have lost your voice, in return for barely returning alive? A price such as that... Perhaps, it would be an appropriate price to pay, looking at the results."

Subaru: "No, I haven't lost my voice. My voice isn't gone, but I'm at a loss for words. What's with that mask of yours?"

Having said that, Subaru pointed at the man who spoke in an arrogant manner.

Placed on the man's face, where Subaru's finger was pointing at, was what looked like an oni mask, painted in red and white. However, since the Oni existed as a race in this world, it could not be an actual oni mask.

A mask that simply resembled the face of something frightening. That was what the man was wearing.

The man, sounding disinterested, responded to Subaru's indication with a, "Yes,"

???: "It is an offering. Originally, I had the intention of keeping my face hidden going forward. I suppose it will do. It was troublesome to re-wrap my face every time I washed it."

Subaru: "Yeah, it looks like you might get itchy if it gets dirty... Wait, it's not the time to be talking about that."

???: "Ohh?"

Grimacing at the man's indifference, Subaru walked towards him from the front without hesitating.

And then, seated in a circle together with the man, Taritta attempted to stop him with a "Hey". However---

???: "Halt, Taritta. It seems as if this person has business with me."

Taritta: “Y-yes... *however*...”

???: “When I say it is fine, then it is fine. Are there any other words that are necessary?”

Held back by none other than the man, Taritta shook her head and backed off.

It seemed like the man had won over a hefty amount of trust from the People of Shudraq, all within a short time period— No, considering that attitude, “control” was more appropriate than “trust”.

Taritta neither acted out of fear nor trust, but respect. The same applied to the other Shudraqians that surrounded the same area, at least.

Subaru had no idea what sort of method the man had used in order to do that, however.

Subaru: “For now, I just want to speak to you, one-on-one— Vincent Abellux.”

Vincent: “———”

Subaru declared, standing in front of the man who was sitting, gazing down at him. He could not see how the man’s expression had shifted behind his mask upon hearing Subaru’s words.

However, the air around the meeting place grew tense, and it was almost as if he could feel that the temperature had decreased.

The pressure in the atmosphere almost made him inadvertently hold his breath, but Subaru endured it with willpower alone. And then—

Vincent: “I shall overlook the first time because of your befuddlement, so do not make me repeat myself. Therefore, know that there shall not be a third time. You shall withhold yourself from uttering my name indiscreetly.¹”

Subaru: “...What if I say, «I don’t want to»?”

¹ Translation note from Witch Cult Translations: “Vincent may be referring to the time when Subaru was drugged.”

Vincent: “I shall administer punishment accordingly. I know a great number of ways to force you to surrender.”

The man stood up on the spot, glaring at Subaru while facing him directly.

Judging from the feeling of his proclamation and his demeanor, there were no falsehoods within the man’s words. There was no possibility of them being a bluff, either. Even if the number of moves he could make and the measures he could take were limited, Subaru was sure the man could implement the punishment he had been talking about.

Subaru: “You’re an annoying guy...”

Vincent: “Then, shall you make me say it a third time?”

Subaru: “—No, I’ll pass. I didn’t come here to argue— Abel.”

“It’s meaningless to remain stubborn”, Subaru thought, giving in first.

Like that— Subaru had decided he would heed the advice of the masked man and call him Abel. Drawing his chin back at Subaru’s decision, Abel commented, “A wise choice”.

Abel: “Had you not withdrawn, then there would have been an instance of bloodshed.”

Subaru: “Ha, you wish. I’ll probably offend you if I say this, but I think it’ll be just barely an even match if we both went at it.”

Abel: “If that is the case, you are the one who should look behind himself.”

Subaru: “Behind myself...?”

Abel said to Subaru, who had received his earlier words as provocation and crinkled up his nose. When he complied and turned around, his shoulders shook as he exclaimed, “Uweh!”.

Rem was standing there, watching the argument unfold between the two men with an icy stare.

Subaru: “U-umm, Rem-san? Your face...”

Rem: “No? It’s just... Even after you were about to die, having been asleep for three days, it seems like you’re ridiculously stubborn, refusing to take good care of your own body. Why don’t you just drop dead at the side of the road, then?”

Subaru: “Sorry! I’m sorry, I won’t do it again!”

Giving in to Rem’s cold eyes, Subaru apologized desperately.

In the end, he could not make any changes to Rem’s disappointed expression, but he had a sudden realization.

It came out of the blue, but there was a high possibility that the reason why Subaru had been able to survive, narrowly escaping from his death, was thanks to Healing Magic, unless there was some sort of miraculous elixir.

If that was the case, the person who did that was—

Abel: “Including that, I must speak with you.”

Subaru: “Abel...”

Abel had apparently deciphered Subaru’s feelings after seeing him hold his breath. He shrugged his shoulders lightly, then turned his face in Mizelda’s direction.

Abel: “Mizelda, make everyone leave. I only require myself and this man to be here.”

Mizelda: “Well, well, you’re just doing as you *please, now*. I would’ve been angry if you weren’t *handsome*.”

Taritta: “Sister, please get angry even if you’re up against a handsome *man*...”

While Mizelda obeyed Abel’s orders without any resistance, Taritta’s shoulders dropped as she looked at her sister.

However, Taritta had also followed Abel’s command earlier, so her words were unconvincing.

Once Mizelda, the chieftain of the tribe, had been persuaded, the other People of Shudraq would not stay put.

All of them streamed out of the meeting place, one after another. The problem was whether Rem, and in addition, Louis should be placed among the wave of Shudraqians, but—

Abel: “It is inconvenient for you to speak about your desired topic if that woman is here, is it not?”

Subaru: “Guh...”

He saw through the reason of my hesitation, Subaru thought, his breath catching in his throat from Abel’s words.

However, in the end, what Abel had said was correct. Subaru did not want Rem to hear the conversation that would come after this.

Subaru: “Rem, can you step outside with everyone else? It’ll be over soon... Or, well, I don’t know if we’ll get it done soon, but we won’t take too long.”

Rem: “When you put that way, it sounds like I’m the one who’s behaving like a spoiled child.”

Subaru: “I didn’t mean it like that... Then, can you step outside for now?”

Rem: “...What would you do if I were to say, «I don’t want to»?”

Subaru: “Eh!?”

He was astonished by Rem’s response, having believed his hands to be already full from dealing with Abel.

Subaru immediately understood she was ridiculing his interaction with Abel from a short while ago, but he was a complete pushover whenever Rem held her ground.

If it were possible, he wanted to grant any of her wishes and let her do whatever she wanted to do. However—

Subaru: “—. —I think... I don’t want you to... listen to this.”

Rem: "I could remain here by force."

Subaru: "Then... Then, I'm being cheap, but I'll run away in that case."

If Subaru started running, then Rem would not be able to catch up to him with her speed, since she had to use a cane.

That was the only point where Subaru could clearly surpass her right now. He had to say it was rather shameful of him, as Subaru could not think of anything else other than that.

Louis: "Uh."

Louis groaned as she pulled Rem's arm, in front of the distressed Subaru. Apparently, she was trying to take Rem out of the meeting place.

Looking at Louis, Rem chuckled,

Rem: "I'm sorry, I must've made you worry. It's just... I wanted to say mean things to this smelly person, just a little bit."

Louis: "Auh."

Subaru: "Smelly person..."

The term pierced him, deep and razor-sharp, more so than any other "mean things", but that was currently not of importance.

Just as she had told Louis, Rem quickly withdrew with a "Well then", and left the meeting place with the blonde girl in tow, while using her cane.

Subaru scratched his cheek as he watched Rem's back, with it never turning around for her to look back at him.

Whether Rem seriously did not have any interest in Subaru, or whether she had said that out of consideration, it was hard for him to make a judgement.

Of course, he would be happier if it were the latter, however.

Subaru: “She was brought here with the worst impression of me. I won’t wish for more, that’s my lifestyle.”

Abel: “You have downright ridiculous perseverance and vanity— Sit, I shall listen to what you have to say.”

And so, the two were left alone in the meeting area. Following what Abel said, Subaru dropped himself onto the ground, sitting cross-legged.

In front of him, Abel also seated himself on the ground, with one knee up. He watched Subaru through his mask.

Sitting opposite of the burning bonfire in the middle, the two men faced off against each other.

Subaru: “First thing I want to ask, how much of it was a dream, and how much of it was real.”

Abel: “Hm. I suppose that is a question no one but you would ask. How would you like me to answer? Everything was a dream, we avoided utter catastrophe and the situation is approaching a peaceful conclusion. Would hearing that satisfy you?”

Subaru: “You know, Utakata and «utter cata-strophe» kinda sound similar², you might confuse me with the girl if you say that...”

A young girl, one of the People of Shudraq. Subaru was pretty sure her name was Utakata.

The unintentional pun was confusing, but that was not the true meaning behind Abel’s words— No, Subaru understood what Abel had meant, and used that light joke as a brief escape.

Abel did not overlook Subaru’s timidity.

Abel: “I do not plan to keep up with your cowardice, Natsuki Subaru.”

Subaru: “...Yeah, I know— Attacking the Empire’s camp, that was real, correct?”

² Translation note by Witch Cult Translations: “In the Japanese text, Abel uses the word «泡沫». Subaru is making a joke/pun out of it because «泡沫» (the word) and «ウタカタ» (the girl’s name) are both pronounced «utakata».”

Abel: “Of course, that is correct. The Empire’s camp deployed outside of Buddheim was completely destroyed with the power of the Shudraq. The scene you saw was no illusion.”

—Again, Abel confirmed the reality of that scene.

Hearing that, Subaru felt something profoundly heavy pierce the back of his chest. Tightly biting his lips, he used the pain to keep his consciousness from fading.

That kind of easy escape was not permitted for Natsuki Subaru.

Subaru: “...I, I understand the situation now. You commanded the People of Shudraq and attacked the Empire’s campsite, chasing them away. That’s the jist of it.”

Abel: “Yes. However, that explanation is lacking. Let me supplement.”

Subaru: “Supplement?”

Abel: “I commanded the Shudraq to destroy the encampment. Moreover, that was done with no casualties suffered on our side.”

Subaru: “—So, is that you just bragging about how amazing your commanding ability is?”

Abel: “No, that is not the case— This feat is your achievement.”

Towards Abel, who shook his head, Subaru widened his eyes in surprise with an audible “Ah?”.

It was a completely unexpected statement. Abel actually acknowledging Subaru’s achievements was one thing in and of itself, but Subaru could not even fathom as to why he was getting any sort of credit.

What in the world was he talking about—

Abel: “Do you not understand? The reason why the Shudraq and I could achieve a flawless victory was because we had detailed knowledge of the enemy’s organization. We got this information from none other than you yourself.”

Subaru: “—Hah?”

On top of his raised knee, Abel spoke with his chin rested on his hand. Meanwhile, Subaru's thoughts came to a standstill.

Those words were completely contrary to his expectations. It did not just come out of left field, it gut-punched him from left field. Finding it difficult to accept the implications behind those words, Subaru opened and closed his mouth silently like a fish—

Abel: “If you roughly know the enemy's stationing, layout and personnel, the probability of success of a siege rises. In reality, we won with no casualties. That was your contribution. You even received a reward.”

Subaru: “Re... ward...?”

Abel: “We safely rescued your woman. I reward work. I do not have the ability to reward the dead. I thought that only while you still drew breath but... hm, the devil's luck in you is strong.”

Although he had been told that he had extremely good luck, Subaru was still in a state of shock.

It could be that, as far as Abel was concerned, those words were supposed to be considered a compliment or praise. However, unfortunately, Subaru did not have the capacity to accept them, nor did he have the mores rooted in him to do so.

That was natural, of course— Why did he have to be happy about being useful as a tool of war.

Subaru: “Why did I, even talk about the campsite...”

Abel: “It was the side-effects of the medicine. After finishing the Lifeblood Ritual, you were on the verge of death. There was a need to keep you alive until the takeover of the campsite and the rescue of the woman was complete. The medicine used kept your mind in a clouded state. Hence why you spoke.”

Subaru: “I just blabbed about anything that was asked of me...?”

Aghast, Subaru held his face in his hands, his voice trembling.

It was true, Subaru had a general understanding of the particulars inside the encampment. He had once spent several days in the camp as a chore boy after all.

He knew what was where and the rough number of people that were there. He also knew where their weapons and tools were stored, so if one were to crush those locations as a first strike, it was no question that they would get the overwhelming advantage. He understood that.

He understood, but so what if he did.

Subaru: “Medicine!? Are you messing with me!? Using that kind of thing without asking me! You...!”

Abel: “However, without it, you would have died, unable to reunite with the woman. It means the woman’s Healing Magic would not have reached you, either. There is no reason for you to speak ill of me, who let a dead man live.”

Subaru: “O-of course there is...! I... I didn’t want to assist in a war! So many people... died... but, you’re...!”

Abel: “—It seems like you are misunderstanding something.”

He said bluntly to Subaru, who was breathing heavily, positioned in a stance to denounce evil.

Pierced by the coldness in Abel’s tone, Subaru stiffened his cheeks.

Subaru: “Misunderstand, you say? What am I misunderstanding, exactly?”

Abel: “For example, we shall pretend your consciousness was not befuddled by the medicine. In order to rescue that woman, you would still need the aid of the Shudraq, nevertheless. Naturally, you would disclose what you know, and give it your all... If so, you would have spoken about who is assigned to where in the camping grounds.”

Subaru: “Ah, uh...”

Abel: “You understand it, do you not? The result would be the same. Whether you were on the verge of death or not, the secrets of the encampment would be exposed by your knowledge, and those soldiers would perish.”

Receiving Abel’s indication, Subaru searched for a way to protest it.

However, Abel was correct, and Subaru could imagine what would have happened in that case, off the top of his head.

In fact, had he lived through the Lifeblood Ritual in a better state, and had there been a discussion on forming a plan to save Rem, then Subaru would have talked about the Empire's camp.

He would have divulged the positions of the soldiers, as well as their numbers, and he would have used his knowledge to aid him in thinking up any measures to save Rem.

Subaru: "But, I would be a part of the council of war in that case. I would've definitely been against a strategy that would result in casualties. So..."

Abel: "You claim you would have been able to convince them? Would it have been possible for you to convince the people who do not know, nor have any other means aside from bloodshed, find a more appropriate method of carrying things out, and save the woman without any casualties, peacefully and civilly?"

Subaru: "That's..."

Abel: "I will tell you this— That... is what would be called a pipe dream."

Pierced by Abel's words, Subaru's soul shrieked as it bled out.

"No!", he wanted to yell, he wanted to deny Abel's words. However, everything that came out of his mouth was baseless, driven by emotion, and it would not be able to inflict a single crack on Abel's mask, nor make his expression waver.

The things they saw were different from one another. They led their own lives differently.

Contrasting views on life and death laid within Subaru and Abel, as well as the People of Shudraq. And, it was impossible to remove and break through such a wall.

During the short time in which he had lost Rem, at the very least. Certainly.

Subaru was sure of it.

Subaru: "...I didn't want to give up just because of that."

Abel: “In return for your perseverance, someone other than you would die. Perhaps, that person may be a complete stranger to you. Or they could be someone who may be akin to your other half. When you stand still and indulge in your foolish thoughts, it means you are allowing that to happen.”

Abel carried on with shoving it into his face, despite Subaru cursing the unforgivable reality while grinding his teeth.

Perhaps, in exchange for the harsh, unmerciful way of how things had been done, Abel had reeled in a definite result. However, why did he have the privilege of selecting which lives would be lost in return?

Subaru: “Who do you think you are? Do you think you’ve become a God or something.....?”

Abel: “Fool. I am neither a God nor a Hero. Naturally, I am also different from those wicked Observers who look down upon this world— I am a King. A King amongst Kings.”

Subaru: “———”

Abel: “The one who stands at the apex is called the Emperor by their people— I, am that.”

Abel announced, placing a hand on his chest daringly.

Subaru could not see his expression beyond the mask that hid his face. However, Subaru imagined Abel’s face, a face he had only seen once, displaying a bold smile, a bright fire lit within his eyes.

Emperor. Hearing that, the thought of holding his breath completely slipped from his mind.

The man had proved his existence with his own words, in such an imposing, majestic way.

And then, Abel— Vincent Abellux continued speaking to Subaru, the latter shell-shocked, the former maintaining the dignified tone of his voice.

Vincent: “——The seventy-seventh Emperor of the Sacred Vollachian Empire. That is me.”

Subaru: “———”

Vincent: “However, I have left my position as of now, having been ousted from the apex.”

Arc 7 Chapter 14 - Unbridgeable Values

Light Novel Adaptation found in Volume 27, Chapter 1 “Those I Want to Protect”, Parts 3-4

Original Web Novel Chapter — [Complete](#)

Original Translation by Witch Cult Translations (Negi, [Kobosuhito](#), [Taurace](#)) — [Complete](#)

Subaru: “———”

——The seventy-seventh Emperor of the Sacred Vollachian Empire.

Hearing Abel give his title, Subaru’s mind went blank.

The reason was not because he was unable to take in the meaning of the words, nor that he was afraid to square off against royalty.

Certainly, in this other world he was in, this was the first time Subaru had met royalty in person.

By the time when Subaru had been summoned to another world, all members of the Royal Family of the Kingdom of Lugunica had succumbed to illness. Felt was suspected of being a surviving royal, but she did not recognize herself as such, and since she had nary a trace of anything like majesty, Felt did not count.

In that respect, of all the people Subaru had met in this world, the ones of the highest station were the people he happened to see at the place of the Royal Selection, the dignitaries of the Council of Wise Men, or perhaps the Duchess Crusch.

Roswaal was also a Margrave of a remote region, which in itself was a high position—— Actually, as Emilia was a Royal Candidate in the selection of the next sovereign, what kind of position did that correspond to?

Subaru: “...Wait, this isn’t time to be running away from reality.”

Subaru restrained himself before his thoughts could become scattered and chaotic.

In any case, the important thing was that Abel had revealed himself to be the Emperor. Ever since he came across him on the jungle plain, Subaru had a feeling he was no ordinary person.

Still, he would never have imagined that this person actually held the position of Emperor. Provided that—

Subaru: “Well, if it’s actually true.”

Abel: “You doubt my word?”

Subaru: “It’s only natural to doubt it. How is it in the middle of a forest I just happen to get stuck with the most preeminent person in the country? I can easily believe your brazenness is Emperor-class, but...”

Then, Subaru paused, and scowled directly at the fiendish face Abel wore.

From Abel’s side, only the sharpness of his gaze could be felt as they stood facing each other, which was not fair. Certainly, there was a strength of will in Abel’s voice that only a person of importance could possess.

Having come in contact with people of various stations in this world, Subaru’s intuition verified that—Still, that was not what this was about.

Subaru: “It’s like I said before. How the hell am I supposed to trust a guy who doesn’t even show his face, huh?”

Opposite the open fire, through the flickering flames, Abel considered Subaru’s words.

Subaru glared harshly at Abel’s masked visage, referring to the words they had exchanged while he watched the burning encampment in a daze.

Abel’s face had been concealed by old rags rather than a mask then, but he had said the same thing to him.

And finally, having heard that, Abel had undone the binds and revealed his face of his own accord.

Abel: “You are a tiresome man, going on and on about inconsequential matters.”

While saying that, he set the mask to the side, in that same moment.

Subaru: “———”

Abel: “What is with that insolent look? There is nothing about me that is exceptionally different from you.”

Subaru: “...That’s true, in part. I’m sensing God’s spite in the arrangement.”

Staring fixedly at Abel’s face, the irony of it struck Subaru.

It could be said that Abel and Subaru were similar. However, that was only speaking in broad terms. When broken down to a finer degree, they were different on a grand scale.

Glossy black hair, an imposing sharp-eyed look. It was an overbearingly powerful impression, but his devilish face had a peculiar charm that was difficult to look away from——

That was the countenance of the Emperor of the Sacred Vollachian Empire.

Nevertheless, Subaru had no recognition of that face. From his position as a Knight of the Royal Selection Candidate Emilia, he had, somehow, also become involved in national affairs of a neighboring country.

Subaru: “Is that how it is? Even though you’re at the top of the nation, your face is...”

Abel: “There is no reason you would know it. From the beginning, my face has not been seen outside of the Imperial Capital. The reason being that there are far too many in this country aiming for my head.”

Subaru: “So it’s for self-defense? You must’ve really stirred up people’s resentment, huh.”

Abel: “No. It is because being powerful is the creed of the citizens of the Empire. The weak-willed must die, the frail must die, and the cowardly must die... because the strong deserve to have it all.”

Subaru: “———”

Abel: “The position of the Emperor is also no exception. It is the grounds for the Empire’s unparalleled strength as a nation.”

Resting his chin on his own knees, Abel spoke of Vollachia’s extreme ideology, leaving Subaru at a loss.

His words were not false. Having spent a few days at the Imperial Soldiers' camp, Subaru knew it too. Todd and the other imperial soldiers would likely greatly approve of Abel's words just now.

Them included, the citizens of the Empire earnestly believed in the notion that victory would balance out everything.

The way they existed was the embodiment of, "Long live the Empire".

If they could fulfil that, then they would not hesitate to burn down the jungle to exterminate a tribe.

If they could fulfil that, launching a surprise attack on their fellow countrymen and massacring the soldiers was also—

Subaru: "—Wait, that doesn't make any sense."

Abel: "What is it?"

Subaru: "For example... For example, if you were really the Emperor, then why did you attack the Imperial Soldiers' camp? If you just walked over there and spoke with the camp's higher-up, then..."

Abel: "Fool. How could I saunter over there with such nonchalance? I do not have a desire to end my own life. Do not lump me in with yourself."

Subaru: "I don't have a death wish either. But, suicide...?"

Subaru did not understand the reason as to why an Emperor interacting with his country's soldiers would be referred to as a suicidal act.

To Abel, all of those Imperial Soldiers should be his subordinates. It was unreasonable to consider it as a suicidal act to interact with them— No, there was a way to rationalize it.

That was—

Subaru: "If I haven't misheard it, then... Did you say you were ousted from the position of the Emperor?"

Abel: "It seems like you did not fail to hear it. However, I have also announced that I will not repeat myself."

Subaru: “Don’t joke around! It’s an important section, isn’t it. Uh, is it true that you’ve really been kicked out of the Emperor’s...”

With Abel’s unchanging expression, Subaru started to doubt whether he was a human like Subaru himself, or not.

Because if Abel’s circumstances were just as Subaru had predicted, then he must be in a situation that was practically hopeless.

The thought made Subaru hesitate to continue his words.

Abel: “Your way of thinking is correct.”

However, Abel nodded, stepping over Subaru’s hesitation with ease.

In front of Subaru, who was holding his breath, Abel’s gaze was lowered ever so slightly, staring at the burning fire. The wood crackled amidst the flames, and the faint noise sounded as if they were throes of death.

Abel closed one eye whilst listening to it,

Abel: “The group of Imperial Soldiers that had been deployed outside of Buddheim were dispatched by my political opponents, in order to dispose of me. To be precise, you have become embroiled in this.”

Subaru: “But... but, the people at the camp didn’t say anything about that. They said their objective was to negotiate with the People of Shudraq in the forest.”

It was not like Subaru had the ability to see through someone’s lies.

Even with that, he thought it unrealistic to consider that everyone, in a place where dozens of people had been crowded together, had coordinated their stories to match each other’s, all just to deceive the outsiders who were Subaru and Rem.

That was why the Imperial Soldiers— Todd and his group had believed they were after the People of Shudraq.

Subaru: “Though, capturing you being their true objective is...”

Abel: “Do not beat around the bush. They were plotting an attack. You are the one who said that. And then, in order to protect yourself and the woman, you have weighed the Shudraqians and the Imperial Soldiers on a scale.”

Subaru: “No...!”

Abel: “I am not mistaken. What has already occurred cannot be changed. Those soldiers will not come back to life. The dead will not speak of anything, nor are they able to exert their influence upon the living.”

Subaru: “-----”

—The dead would not come back to life.

Subaru squeezed his eyes shut, struck by Abel’s fierce words.

How dare he say whatever as he pleased, when he knew absolutely nothing?

—There was a way to revive the dead.

The method was the one and only Authority, which only Subaru was capable of holding.

Subaru: “-----”

If he were to Return by Death, then there was a possibility he could go back to the time before the encampment was wiped out.

Once he did that, Subaru could warn the Imperial Soldiers and save them from their deadly fate, perhaps. However, if he did that, then the safety of the People of Shudraq would be put in jeopardy.

He was trapped in a dilemma of choosing which side would be left standing at the cost of the other side. It was difficult to save both of them, when they stood diametrically opposed to each other.

More than anything—

Subaru: “I...”

Subaru did not have the courage to Return by Death for them.

Even if he did redo it, how much of a chance did he have at being even more successful? This time, the fact that Subaru and Rem were safe could be referred to as second best, rather than the very best.

Asking for anything more than that was equivalent to confronting an endless challenge.

In order to do that, letting his own life wear down would be---

Abel: "You are a foolish man, bearing enigmatic woes."

As Subaru asked and answered his own question, Abel's words had abruptly disturbed his ear drums.

Subaru's eyes flew open out of astonishment, unable to comprehend what Abel had said to him for a moment. Abel was staring at Subaru from the front, on the other side of the flickering flames.

It was almost as if Abel was pitying him with that gaze of his.

Abel: "Why would you always desire to curry favor with others?"

Subaru: "Curry favor? You're saying... I do that?"

Abel: "You are always gazing at others. You have intentionally constructed yourself to be that way. Similar to how a warrior would hone their skills, you have concealed your own heart with a deception called charity."

Subaru: "--Hk, it's none of your business!"

Intense rage coursed through Subaru as Abel spoke as if he understood him.

To someone who did not know anything about Subaru himself, nor about Return by Death, it was impossible for him to understand even a fraction of what Subaru was saddled with.

There was no reason for Subaru to be lectured, nor pitied.

Subaru: "You haven't answered my question at all! The Imperial Soldiers were after the People of Shudraq. They never mentioned anything about y..."

Abel: “It is a topic that is not disclosed to the foot soldiers. I suppose even the Commander is unaware. The Emperor having left his position... Is not something that could afford to be leaked out of the Imperial Capital. Neither do I, nor those who have deposed me, wish for the Empire to be shaken.”

Subaru: “———”

Abel: “Additionally, it was inevitable that they would target the Shudraqians. Forced out of the Emperor’s throne, the only hand an Emperor can take after escaping the Imperial Capital are the Shudraqians— Therefore, killing the People of Shudraq is equivalent to cutting my hands and feet and sinking me to the bottom of water when I am already half-drowning.”

Letting Abel’s nonchalant explanation sink in, Subaru’s questions melted away.

Why Todd and the rest of the Imperial Soldiers surrounded the jungle? Why they sought to negotiate with the People of Shudraq to demilitarize them or otherwise exterminate them? Only now did he understand the reason for it all.

Subaru: “...Why are the Shudraqians the only ones you can rely on?”

Abel: “An Emperor of Vollachia has saved Shudraq from a predicament in times past. Shudraqians never forget their debts. There is also the Lifeblood Ritual. They are my path to victory.”

The old debt that the tribe pridefully owed to the Emperor, and the way the Shudraqians respected their rituals.

Driven away from the Imperial Capital, Abel bet on that and attempted contact with the People of Shudraq. Consequently, Abel’s political opponents tried to prevent him from doing so, by dispatching Imperial Soldiers to the jungle to try and entomb the Emperor.

It was a bet with terrible odds, but one could say that he had won that gamble.

Superbly defying the opponent’s expectations, he repelled the enemy’s first wave that was meant to corner him. However, even Subaru knew— The opponent would not stay their hand here.

Subaru: “You, and your enemy’s battle hasn’t ended.”

Abel: “Of course— It would end if I were to die. However, I still draw breath. Therefore, to take back my things, I shall use my utmost power to go and reclaim them.”

That was the Emperor of Vollachia, Abel— Vincent Abellux’s choice.

To Subaru, the word “things” that Abel had used seemed like it had an asterisk next to it, with a note saying “this actually means country”. The scale in which Abel looked at things was too big for Subaru.

At the same time as being overwhelmed by his absurdity, Subaru came to realize something far too late.

Subaru: “So, you’re planning to... start a war using the People of Shudraq!?”

Abel: “Correct. I have made them promise cooperation. The results of the Lifeblood Ritual and the pact they made with the Emperor before. People who extol pride are easy to manipulate. They will undoubtedly fight with me.”

Subaru: “You’re saying... It wasn’t enough after doing all that!?”

Retaking the Emperor’s throne. To do that, there would inevitably be more battles to come.

Resulting in war— War, a fierce battle where humans would fight other humans, with their lives on the line.

Abel: “———”

The Imperial Camp, which had been burnt to the ground. As far as Subaru knew, there had been at least a hundred Imperial Soldiers there.

If Abel and the Shudraqians had only attacked that one encampment, even if there were some who managed to escape, there had been over a hundred casualties. If not, it was probably safe to say casualties had not reached a thousand.

—During the few hours Subaru spent unconscious, over a hundred lives had been lost.

Subaru: “Just because of that...”

Throughout the days he had lived in another world, this was the experience with the most casualties.

There had been victims at the White Whale subjugation and at the fight with Petelgeuse. There were people he could not save at the fights in Pristella, and even more in times now gone.

Compared to those unpreventable casualties, the number of lives lost here was greater.

Additionally, the enemies fought were not Witchbeasts nor were they evil entities. They were human beings.

They were not people who could not be reasoned with. They were people who could come to an understanding with dialogue.

Subaru: “Why... did they have to be killed...”

Abel: “There was no other method. That is all.”

Subaru: “...Is that really true? Did you seriously try and find another way? Before all your options were snatched away by murdering them, did you try to find another option until the very end?”

Abel: “———”

Abel narrowed his eyes at Subaru’s feeble grievances.

His look told Subaru that, instead of carefully considering Subaru’s opinion, he was questioning as to why he had to do something like that. He was questioning the fundamental part of Subaru’s argument.

It was not like he did not understand the words exchanged, nor was it that he was unwilling to partake in discourse.

The reason they could not come to an understanding despite this, was because Abel’s ethics were terrifyingly secluded from his own.

Fortunately for Natsuki Subaru, until now, he had not fallen into a situation where he had to build a relationship with someone whose values greatly differed from his.

The majority of people he had encountered in this other world were rational. They lent their ears to Subaru and interacted with him, while communicating their own opinions. Once upon a time, an idiotic

Subaru had failed to understand this and was thus unable to notice their tact, resulting in him throwing all that away. Even so, he managed until now.

The people he had been unable to come to an understanding, because of their different sets of values, were mostly either Witches or Sin Archbishops.

However, by defining them as “different” beings, Subaru could continue going on without having to knock morals with them.

But Abel was different. The People of Shudraq and the Imperial Soldiers were also different.

They held no ill will, they did not toy with life and death, and they did not wield tremendous power for selfish reasons.

Excluding their base principles, they were humans, just like Subaru.

But even then——

Subaru: “...I, just want to bring Rem home.”

The battle to retake Abel’s throne was going to commence.

If this were another person’s affair, or if it was a past event detailed in a biography or something similar, Subaru would eagerly turn those pages with excitement.

This was reality, however.

In a foreign country, where there was no one to rely on, a fierce internal struggle that would shake the very foundation of the country was about to take place. To intervene in this situation and try to change history, there were no plans to even entertain that thought, in Subaru.

The objective was to bring Rem and return to the Kingdom of Lugunica.

He needed to reunite with Emilia and Beatrice, his friends at Roswaal’s mansion as soon as possible. They had to celebrate Rem’s awakening, and discuss what to do moving forward.

Any issues other than that, he could not keep up with.

Subaru: “—Tell me the location of the nearest town or village. I’ll find a way back from there.”

Tapping his cheeks with both his hands, Subaru stated his single-minded goal.

Receiving that, Abel responded with a small sigh,

Abel: “Hoh, that makes sense. Nevertheless, it shall not be a simple path.”

Subaru: “Easy or difficult, if it is necessary, I will walk that path. A paved path though, if possible.”

Abel: “Hmph.”

Standing up in front of the snorting Abel, Subaru strongly bit the inside of his cheek.

Stimulating his brain with the pain, he struck down his rising doubts and faced forward. He looked towards Abel, who remained unmoving.

The lonely Emperor had one of his eyes closed, his gaze crossing over with Subaru.

Subaru: “I still haven’t thanked you. Putting aside the method in which you did it, thank you for rescuing Rem. I’m grateful for that.”

Abel: “It was not only the girl, another one was rescued too.”

Subaru: “That was unnecessary... Thanks to you, my worries will stay as-is for a while.”

Of course, even in the case Louis had been lost in the Imperial Camp, it did not mean that the problems Subaru held would be neatly resolved. If one were to narrow it down to just his problems with Rem, there was a rather high chance that his relationship with her would become more strained.

He did not know which was better. And because he did not know—

Subaru: “I will pick the path that I agree with. I have mixed feelings about it but... you do the best you can do. But, the People of Shudraq...”

Abel: “Are you saying I should not involve them? Either way, if you and I did not intervene, a scorched jungle was what awaited them. This is already their fight too.”

Subaru: “———”

There was no room for denial.

They were already in a position where they were forced to fight to protect themselves.

However——

Subaru: “It’s impossible for me... I don’t think I will ever be able to become like you.”

Shaking his head, Subaru muttered while looking at Abel.

Abel had one of his eyes closed—— The closed eyelid was opposite of the one before. To explain further, Abel’s blinking was unique. He would blink one eye at a time, never letting both eyes be closed at the same time.

Subaru recognized that this was done so that both eyes would never be closed even for an instant.

Subaru feared the Vollachian Emperor, who lived in a world where habits like that were formed just to survive as the one at the apex of the Empire of the Sword Wolf. He feared in reverence.

Listening to his mutterings, Abel, unsurprisingly with one eye closed,

Abel: “Naturally. You, nor anyone else would be fit to be my substitute.”

Stated that.



Leaving the People of Shudraq, Subaru and his group would be heading to the town closest to the Buddheim Jungle.

Such a decision had been made by Subaru. After the people surrounding him had listened to it, their reaction was unexpectedly mild.

???: “I *see*. It’s unfortunate, but if that is my comrade’s decision, it can’t be *helped*.”

That was Mizelda's reaction after hearing what Subaru had to say.

She regarded his decision with respect, her dignified face tinted with sadness to some degree, just as what her words suggested.

Truthfully, Subaru had made his declaration whilst bracing himself against verbal abuse, such as, "You're not a warrior if you don't fight!", so he felt all the more regretful because of her thoughtfulness.

Once Subaru had obtained permission from the chieftain, no one could stand in the way of his decision.

The existence of Uakata, who appeared to be more dejected than Mizelda, made Subaru feel reluctant to leave, as if something was tugging at the back of his hair. However, it would not become a reason for him to stay here.

Uakata: "Suu is going *somewhere*. Uu feels *sad*..."

Subaru: "Yeah, I'm sorry... Hey, do you know what's going to happen from now on?"

Subaru asked her, caressing the girl's head as she pinched his sleeve.

Not a single doubt was held against the values and their sense of unity, and there was no mistaking the fact that Mizelda's decision was the tribe's decision, but Uakata was still young.

If she had been pulled by the flow of the people around her without understanding anything—

Uakata: "—? A battle's going to start *now*. Uu will fight together with Mii, Taa, and *everyone*."

Subaru: "...I see."

As Uakata said that, showing off the bow she had equipped on her back, Subaru blew out a sigh.

He wanted young children to remain ignorant. As expected, such deceit was a facile idea that did not apply to this jungle.

In the first place, Uakata had once achieved putting Subaru to death by shooting him with a poisoned arrow.

Even if she did not look like it, she was definitely one of the People of Shudraq. She possessed the resolve to fight, as well as the resolve to kill her opponent.

Nevertheless---

Subaru: "Don't die, Utakata."

Utakata: "Uu won't *die*! Make sure you don't die, *too*. And do your *best*."

Although he attempted to cheer her on, a larger voice of encouragement was returned to him, causing Subaru to choke up, managing to respond to her by putting on a feeble smile.

In all honesty, Subaru could not imagine how much of a chance at victory that Abel and the Shudraqians would have in their battle.

Targeting Abel, who had been deprived of his status as an Emperor, their opponents had dispatched a subjugation force to the Buddheim Jungle.

That meant the enemy was in a state where they were able to move around the forces that made up the fighting strength of the Empire at their own discretion. Meanwhile, the only force that Abel held were the Shudraqians, and they were a small group of less than a hundred people.

Of course, there was a possibility that Abel would consecutively stack victory after victory, by utilizing an otherworldly, unfathomable plan similar to the one he had used to launch a one-sided assault on the Empire's Camp, forcing them to retreat, but---

???: "—Everything is all set."

Subaru: "—Hk."

While Subaru had been controlled by the very thoughts he had supposedly casted away by changing his mindset, someone called out to him from the side, like that.

Subaru immediately turned around, his shoulders jolting, and the person also widened her eyes from his momentum.

???: "—? What's the matter? Why are you so surprised?"

The person looking at the stiff-faced Subaru was Rem, who had said that.

With a wooden stick in one hand and carrying a small amount of baggage on her back, Rem appeared to have finished getting ready to leave the forest, just like Subaru.

—Yes, when Subaru had informed her that he had chosen to leave the forest, the person who had reacted to it in the most unexpected way had been none other than Rem.

To be honest, Subaru had thought she would oppose him stubbornly, therefore creating a need for him to persuade her.

In the worst case, he would forcefully take Rem outside while she was asleep, having steeled himself to part ways with the Shudraquians' village with the momentum of an escape under the cover of night.

However, Rem's reaction towards Subaru, who had revealed their circumstances to her with the expectation of being rejected, had been surprisingly simple.

Rem: "—I understand. I will finish making preparations by tomorrow."

That was why, even when Subaru looked at Rem once she had finished making preparations for travel, he could not really accept it as something that had actually occurred.

Rem: "...Uhh?"

Subaru: "Ah! No, sorry, I'm alright. Yeah, your preparations look great, too. Cute, cute."

Rem: "Huh?"

Subaru: "I mean, you're reliable! Thank you. With you being such a responsible person, I'm such a fortunate guy."

His reply was awkward to the point Rem stared at him with a doubtful look.

It was not like he wished to curry favor with Rem. Since he was in a condition where he would be saved by Rem's lack of resistance, of course, so maintaining their current relationship was the most desirable.

Ideally, he wanted her to warm up to him, however.

Subaru: “———”

He could test that out again when he had a calmer state of mind.

For now, his honest opinion was that he wished to distance himself from the presence of war, which hung densely in the air, as soon as possible.

Rem: “So, have you finished your preparations? It seemed like you had the time to be reluctant about leaving, but...”

Subaru: “Yeah, it’s all good. I didn’t have much baggage to begin with, and you’re going to be carrying most of them.”

Rem: “...But, you’re going to be carrying me.”

With a drop in the tone of her voice, Rem snuck a glance at the handmade, wooden framework that had been placed in the clearing.

It was a wooden rack that had been assembled for Subaru to carry Rem on his back while travelling, weaved out of a combination of thick branches and vines.

Rem was able to walk with some difficulty by use of her cane, but the journey from this place to the nearest town would take a few days.

In the meantime, he did not know how time-consuming it would be if he were to walk at the same speed as Rem. Because of that, the wooden frame had been created through the cooperation of Subaru and the Shudraquians.

Subaru: “It feels pretty *tezukuri*³, but there should be no issues with its durability. I already tested it out with Taritta-san, who’s heavier than you, so...”

Rem: “I’m not really concerned about heaviness or lightness, but I think you’re being rude to Taritta-san.”

³ English flip. Means “handmade” (手作り), originally “ハンドメイド” (handmade).

Incurring Rem's displeasure once again, Subaru scratched his cheek with a dry laugh.

And then, he directed his gaze behind Rem—— towards Louis, their fellow traveling companion. It went without saying, but if Subaru were to bring Rem with him, then Louis would also be accompanying them.

Subaru: "There's no way I could force a bomb onto everyone of the Shudraq, after all..."

Even if that was not the case, taking his eyes off a Sin Archbishop was purely preposterous.

There had been many instances where he had looked away from Louis, and that meant she had had plenty of opportunities to reveal her true nature, but he did not want to let her do that from now on.

Even if he had started to believe that Louis's behavior was not an act, but actually genuine.

Louis: "Ahh, uuh."

The girl in question had her long hair tied behind her head, and also had her white clothes mended, her attire giving her a wholly different impression.

Apparently, the Shudraqians had been fond of Louis in their village, and her repaired clothes were a gift from them.

Subaru: "Sorry for making your tribe do pretty much everything for us."

Mizelda: "Don't worry about it, *Subaru*. You have overcome the Lifeblood Ritual, displaying the brightness of your *soul*. The fact that we're lending our strength to you is obviously to honor our *comrade*."

Subaru: "Comrade..."

Subaru dropped his eyes at Mizelda's words, as she came over to see him off, her arms crossed.

He could not face Mizelda, who has been referring to him as her comrade with such friendliness. After all, he knew that a harsh battle was looming upon them, and he was aware of being one of the very people who had involved the People of Shudraq into that, yet he was trying to flee from this place.

Would something like that be what a fellow comrade, dignified and honorable just as the tribe had described him, actually do?

Mizelda: “Don’t trouble yourself about it, *Subaru*.”

However, Mizelda said that as if she had deciphered his inner thoughts.

Subaru: “Mizelda-san...”

Mizelda: “We fight to prove our *worth*. However, we create our future by protecting those dear to us until the *end*. It’s way of thinking that’s necessary in order to protect our *tribe*.”

Subaru: “———”

Mizelda: “Protect Rem and *Louis*. That is the honor we expect from our *comrade*.”

Subaru felt the corners of his eyes grow hot from Mizelda’s straightforward words.

He did not feel like correcting Mizelda, saying she had misunderstood about Louis. He had to at least fulfil that role, to answer to the trust Mizelda and the others had put in him.

Or, although he would never meet the Shudraquians ever again——

???: “We’re *ready*-. Now is a good opportunity to take our *leave*-.”

Right as Subaru had been spurred by Mizelda, a woman with yellow-tipped hair, waving her hand exaggeratedly — Holly, called over to him with a wide grin.

Next to her was Kuna, who had a slender build, her hair dyed green. The cheerful Holly and in contrast, the reticent-looking Kuna. Those two were the guardians of Subaru’s group.

Arrangements had been made so that the two Shudraquians would be protecting Subaru, Rem, and Louis, ensuring they would not be attacked by anything on their way to Guaral — the nearest town.

Subaru: “I’m super grateful for bodyguards, but I also feel like it’s too much. Even though...”

This was a foreign country, and Subaru had already died multiple times in the mere span of a few days.

He could not deny it was a unique situation, but it was the safest to take precautions. Subaru himself did not have enough prowess as a fighter to be confident in his own abilities, and it was fruitless to depend on Rem and Louis.

He could say nothing regarding Kuna, but he had also seen Holly lift a boulder effortlessly with his own eyes. They were more than reliable as the group's bodyguards during their journey.

And then—

Subaru: “—Rem, does it hurt anywhere?”

Subaru asked Rem over his shoulder, while pulling up the wooden rack.

Since they would be positioned back-to-back with the handmade frame between them, Subaru could not see Rem's face from where he was. He had tried packing in soft leaves and fabric to secure her body, but there would be a few inconveniences considering they would be traveling for a long time.

Rem: “I'm fine... Are you okay with this?”

Subaru: “I've been training myself moderately... at least. My stamina hasn't completely returned, but I want to prevent Holly and Kuna's hands from being full, in the case of emergency.”

In the first place, he was immensely thankful towards the two Shudraquians for being their escorts, but making them carry Rem on top of that was something he could never dare to ask for.

Subaru, demonstrating his stubbornness, Rem, carried by him, and Louis had lined up as a group. Accompanying them were Holly and Kuna, having finished their preparations despite being lightly dressed, and they all stood together.

Then, the People of Shudraq began crowding around the entrance of the village.

Mizelda: “Well then, may the tranquility and objective of our fellow *comrade*, Natsuki Subaru, be *fulfilled*.”

People of Shudraq: “—May it be *fulfilled*!”

Mizelda called out, standing in the front, and the other Shudraquians followed in unison.

Experiencing an illusion of feeling like the wind had blown, filling up the area, Subaru made sure to return their spirit with a “Yeah!”, along with a smiling face.

Subaru: “Thank you, everyone. Take care of yourselves and stay happy!”

As soon as he had said it, he realized that was a greeting terribly filled with deceit. Thinking about the turbulent path that awaited the tribe after this, “stay happy” were two words that sounded far too hollow and meaningless.

However, he could not say anything more than that. He could not wish for anything more than that.

He hoped for the pleasant, refreshing women to stay happy as they continued to live their lives.

Subaru: “———”

While wishing for that, Subaru searched for the man with the wicked mask among the line of people who had come to see his group off.

However, it was only natural that the man could not be found anywhere.

He was not someone who would send them off, nor did the relationship between him and Subaru involve something like that.

Even if Subaru were to spot the man, he would not have any words to tell him. That was why——

Subaru: “——We’re heading off!”

Louis: “Uu!”

As Subaru said that, almost in a desperate way, Louis’s loud voice overlapped with his words.

And then, Subaru and his group split themselves from the People of Shudraq, departing for Guaral, the nearest town, in an effort to escape from the war that would take place hereafter, taking their first step in doing so.

Arc 7 Chapter 15 - Those I Want to Protect

Light Novel Adaptation found in Volume 27, Chapter 1 “Those I Want to Protect”, Parts 5-6

Original Web Novel Chapter — [Complete](#)

Original Translation by Witch Cult Translations (Negi, [Kobosuhito](#), [Taurace](#)) — [Complete](#)

???: “—MUU!”

At that instant, there was a thud and a loud cry, and animals kicked the ground and fled.

On their way through the prairie, they had happened to come across a small forest. Amidst the shade of the trees, animals resembling deer had been eating grass. They were called black deer because of their impressive antlers and black fur. They also inhabited the Kingdom of Lugunica, and could be said to be one of the major animals of this parallel world.

In the center of the herd, from where they had fled from the sound and impact, one black deer had been left behind, collapsed atop the grass.

A thick arrow had pierced the black deer’s ribs, its heart destroyed by a single shot.

Its four limbs twitched and quivered in post-mortem convulsion, but, before long, that too stopped. In any event—

????: “I brought down the *meat*~!”

?????: “...«*Meat*». You could say black deer at *least*.”

????: “Huh? What did you say just *now*~? Kuna’s voice is soft, I can’t really hear *you*~”

The one who’d drawn the heavy bow and raised a cheer was Holly.

She wore a sunny smile, and the young girl beside her, Kuna, had muttered inaudibly, causing Holly to begin tilting her head to the side with a curious expression.

But, seeing that Kuna pouted her lips,

Kuna: “It was *nothing*! Drain the *blood*! Quickly *now*!”

Holly: “Ah, please *wait*-!”

Holly started lumbering to Kuna’s side, rushing after her. But before she got there, Holly stopped walking, let out an “Ohh”, and spun around to look back.

There, before Holly’s eyes, was the figure of their companion—

Holly: “It’s a lot, so we’re gonna go take a short *break*. Subaru, you wanna take one *too*-?”

Subaru: “...Um, uhh, not particularly, I’m totally fine, but sure.”

Pouring sweat like a waterfall, Subaru answered Holly’s proposal of a break.

Looking at Subaru, Holly said “I’m glad”, and ran back to Kuna’s side. Watching them leave, Subaru slowly fell to his knees on the spot.

Behind the totally exhausted Subaru, being carried in a wooden backpack, Rem took a small breath,

Rem: “...Stubborn.”

And muttered too softly to be heard by Subaru.



Subaru: “Man, that really took a lot out of me. I was able to withstand it because I’m the eldest son. But I wouldn’t be able to do it if I were the second son or the youngest.”

Putting together the twigs he’d collected, Subaru gave his explanation in a cool breeze.

Rem listened with an unamused look, and Louis listened with a blank expression, one that made it unclear what she was thinking. Nonetheless, Rem let out a short sigh, like she was exasperated with the matter.

Rem: “I do not understand what you mean. To begin with, is there a connection between having siblings and one’s perseverance?”

Subaru: “Now it’s kind of a dumb cliché, but I feel like there’s a correlation between one’s sibling status and relative fortitude. Like, they say the firstborn son is raised strictly by his parents, and the youngest child is spoiled, right?”

Rem: “I don’t know if that could be called «right». Doesn’t that not apply in the case of an only child?”

Subaru: “In that case, you end up getting spoiled while being raised strictly... Naturally, since I’m an only child, that means the special characteristics of the eldest and youngest son both apply to me.”

Considering his parents’ closeness, Subaru not having any siblings was quite the mystery.

Since he was aware he’d had his mom and dad’s love all to himself, he couldn’t help but wonder what having siblings would have been like, but that didn’t change the reality of it.

Subaru: “Besides, it’s not certain that I don’t have younger siblings now that I’m not there...”

Rem: “———”

Louis: “Aauuahh——”

While Subaru was imagining terrible things, Rem looked down, towards Louis, who was being playful on her lap.

While on the move, the wooden rack would be secured to Subaru’s back, but when placed on the ground, it could also serve as a chair. It was an item with exceptional potential.

Thanks to that, going through the trouble of picking Rem up or setting her down could be done without much hassle.

Although Rem probably thought the circumstances requiring her to keep asking Subaru for help were shameful, for the time being, she had to get through and accept that disgrace.

Rem: “Siblings...”

Subaru: “Uh huh?”

Rem: “Family born before me, or born after... Did I have any?”

Subaru: “Ohh...”

Rem inquired abruptly, and Subaru reflexively held his breath.

With a start he raised his head, while Rem was minding Louis’s hair threading her fingers, those blue pupils of hers turned toward Subaru.

In them a faint light flickered, with emotions he did not understand. He thought that perhaps Rem herself did not quite know those either. Nevertheless—

Subaru: “It’s the first time. That you’ve tried asking me about your memories.”

Rem: “Where are we, who are you, who am I, what will you do, how dare you... I think I have asked a number of questions up until now.”

Subaru: “I’m not talking about that kind of negative stuff. Also, I thought you hadn’t yet said how dare you...”

He gave a strained grin to Rem’s prickly objection, however, it provided meager relief.

As he had told Rem, this was the first time she had asked him anything in a positive sense. Subaru perceived that as progress in their relationship.

Frankly, since their departure from the Shudraq village, all through their journey up till now, Subaru had been continuously uneasy.

After all, Rem had laid bare her hostility and suspicions towards Subaru, but despite that, she had not rejected his proposal to head toward the town for a few days because of those.

To put it bluntly, he had thought the greatest obstacle to leaving the Shudraq village would be Rem’s stubborn unwillingness to listen to Subaru’s words.

Without opposing Subaru's plan, Rem had been cooperative— Rather than believing it to be a miracle, he had wondered what the heck kind of a calamity it heralded.

But not only was Rem being cooperative at present, she had not even troubled Subaru with various, excessive questions while being carried in the wooden carrier. Instead, she had chided Louis for shifting restlessly and hindering the march, and tried to lessen Subaru's burden.

Subaru: "——"

Rem: "What is it? You don't feel like talking, is that it?"

Subaru: "No, no, not at all. You're jumping to the wrong conclusion. Just, look, our relationship has been pretty strained right?"

Rem: "It still is now, though it isn't strained, it is unfriendly."

Subaru: "I thought the unfriendliness had softened a bit!"

Rem's eyes looked at him with disgust, and Subaru's heart was wounded once again. But, being careful to protect the injury he had just gotten from Rem, he scratched his cheek with his fingers.

Subaru: "I don't know everything about you either. But, I know more about you than you do now. If there's anything you want to ask, I'll answer as much as I can. But..."

Rem: "Whether or not to believe you is up to me..."

Subaru: "Mhm."

Subaru gave a short nod, and with a glance examined Rem's appearance.

She was carding her fingers through Louis's hair, and frowning as if in deep thought. After a short moment, Rem once again met Subaru's eyes and said,

Rem: "I don't know."

Subaru: "You don't know... about yourself?"

Rem: “About you... What in the world kind of person are you, I do not understand it at all. Because what I sense and what I see do not match.”

Her lips pursed tightly, Rem’s icy look was tinged with heat.

It was not that the distance between their hearts had increased, it was that the level of seriousness had risen. As Rem evaluated Subaru, the earnestness in those eyes increased.

It was evidence that at least she thought Subaru’s humanity was worthy of investigation.

Subaru: “Compared to when you treated me like an incarnation of evil without giving me a chance to explain, this feels like a Great Leap Forward.”

Rem: “I still think there is a paper-thin difference between you and evil incarnate... However, it is just that we have reached a point where it seems fine to insert one thin sheet of paper.”

Subaru: “———”

The few words she added felt like a conciliatory handshake from Rem.

With relief, Subaru reached out to grasp that invisible handshake. Rem made a distrustful face at Subaru, who shook an invisible hand in midair. In any case——

Subaru: “Well, our thin ice relationship has reached a place of having a thin sheet of paper inserted... How about it? Anything you want to ask?”

Rem: “...Please let me think a bit more.”

Unprepared to have a heart-to-heart with Subaru, Rem shook her head and requested that.

Rem’s way of preparation—— More accurately, Rem had yet to prepare herself to believe Subaru.

Right now, it was possible she was worried about listening to his story, in a situation where she was unable to completely trust Subaru, and the information being too much to handle.

Honestly, he would be lying if he said that he did not feel impatient about Rem worrying like that but,

Subaru: “——Gotcha. I’ll wait for you to be ready.”

Rem: "...Please do not say it like that, like it is someone else's problem. Since you could say that it also depends on your daily behavior, I think."

Subaru: "I see... In other words, the only way to gain early access to that route is if I earn Rem likeability and credibility points like crazy?"

Rem: "I do not understand the meaning, but I understand what you said is unpleasant."

Putting his hand on his chin, Subaru could see that Rem's displeasure was accumulating once again.

As that conversation unfolded, from below the two of them—

Holly: "Sorry to keep you *waiting*-. We had fun taking apart the black deer and we're *done*-."

Like that, Holly returned with a face-splitting grin.

She took great delight in the dismembered black deer, hung from a branch she carried on her shoulder. Behind the chipper Holly was the tired face of Kuna, who seemed to have worked hard at the job of dismemberment.

Kuna: "Why did I have to do everything *myself*..."

Holly: "Because, Kuna can do it *better*-. If the meat got ruined, even if I eat and eat my tummy'd still end up especially *empty*-"

Kuna: "Why?! If you eat *something*, seriously keep it in your stomach, you *weirdo*!"

Kuna yelled at the easy-going Holly, but the latter laughed it off.

Holly then set her eyes on the bundle of dried branches Subaru had collected.

Holly: "Ohh, you properly gathered *them*-. I'm impressed, I'm *impressed*-."

Subaru: "I can't do any hunting. I'll at least do this much... Can you instruct me on how to start a fire?"

Holly: "*Instruct*? Never heard of that word *before*-."

Kuna: "Obviously it means to *teach*..."

Holly tilted her head in contemplation, replying to Kuna with a giggle and a “Does *it*-?”.

Next, Holly brought out a small, black stone from her luggage. Allowing Subaru to witness it, she struck the stone quickly and used the sparks produced to easily light the branches on fire.

Subaru: “Woa, woahhhhhh, awesome. That’s some artisanship.”

Holly: “It’s a fire starter *stone*-. It’s easy-peasy once you get the hang of *it*-. Subaru, you try *too*-.”

Subaru: “You’re letting me try? Okay, I’ll just borrow this...”

Holly casually threw the fire starter stone to Subaru. He attempted to imitate Holly’s actions from earlier, and as a result, he failed three times, but on his fourth try, he finally was able to produce sparks.

All he had to do now was to do the same thing over the dried branches—

Subaru: “It lit up!”

Holly: “Well *done*-! Now if any meat pops out, it can be cooked and eaten *anytime*-!”

Kuna: “The meat she’s talking about are the animals before becoming *meat*, so don’t take her for her *word*.”

Towards Subaru, who had gained a small sense of accomplishment, Holly and Kuna appraised him from opposite extremes.

Accepting both of those in his heart, Subaru gazed at the black deer’s meat roasting over the campfire. He brought up a new topic, saying “By the way,”

Subaru: “Back when we found the herd of deers, Holly’s speed was amazing. By the time I realised, you had already shot an arrow.”

Holly: “It’s because Kuna found the *herd*-. Because of her we could get fresh *meat*-.”

Kuna: “The only thing I did was say that the herd was *there*... Leaving aside firing quickly, anyone in Shudraq can shoot a bow and *arrow*.”

Holly: “Except Kuna, you *know*-.”

Kuna: “Uguh.”

Having been prodded on a sensitive topic, Kuna’s expression turned into a scowl.

Rem widened her eyes in surprise to Kuna’s reaction.

Rem: “Really? That is unexpected. Kuna’s eyes are good, is what I heard from Mizelda so...”

Kuna: “...Even if my eyes are *good*, if my arms are bad then there’s no *point*.”

Holly: “Kuna, who loses even to Utakata in *archery*. It’s *cute*-.”

Kuna: “*Shudduuup!*”

Having been rated as below Utakata, Kuna used her hand to strike Holly in the stomach as if using a dagger. However, Holly’s plump body simply bounced the strike back.

Rem watched the seemingly practiced interaction between the two with a smile, but hearing about Utakata’s archery put Subaru in a conflicted state of mind.

Because, Subaru was someone who had once lost his life to Utakata’s poisoned arrow.

In terms of strength, Utakata was not strong enough to kill Subaru. Even so, if poison were to be used, for example, on an arrowhead, there would not be a great handicap in killing power.

When it came to hunting and prey though, the use of poison was probably not highly regarded.

Subaru: “And also...”

Putting his fingers on his lips, Subaru pondered about the wielder of a heavily drawn bow.

This was about the Hunter who had attacked Subaru and Rem in the jungle, before being caught by the Imperial Soldier’s camp. The bow master who had protected Subaru and Rem from the Witchbeast once, and murdered Subaru the other.

The true identity of the Hunter had yet to be discovered.

That was why, when Holly had shot the black deer, Subaru went pale.

Except, after hearing the talk about the People of Shudraq's archery skills—

Subaru: “—It's someone from Shudraq? Is doubting anyone else wasted thinking?”

At that time, Subaru's group was a suspicious disturbance that had entered the jungle.

Subaru was shouting while searching for Rem. So it was not impossible to think that someone had concluded that Subaru was a suspicious enemy seeking to bring harm, and as a result, decided to eliminate him as a threat. It was most likely the same for the confrontation with the Witchbeast afterwards.

Actually, the Hunter had in fact protected Subaru's group from the Witchbeast— The reasoning to declare that the Hunter was definitely an enemy was weak.

Rem: “Holly-san and Kuna-san are good friends, aren't they.”

While Subaru was sunken in thought, Rem had struck up a conversation with Holly and Kuna.

Rem was talking about Holly and Kuna—the ones who were accompanying Subaru's group, the young duo from the People of Shudraq.

However, the only one who laughed upon being told they were good friends was Holly. Kuna, on the other hand, scrunched up her face in disgust and stuck her tongue out with an unflattering sound.

Subaru: “What's with that reaction and face? Pretty girls aren't supposed to do both of those, you know?”

Kuna: “I just remembered that as much as I hate it, we can't be *separated*. I've been left to suffer over and over...”

Holly: “Ahahaha, Kuna's a *worrier*.”

Kuna: “Who's. Fault. Is. *That!*”

A furious Kuna grabbed Holly's shoulder and harshly shook her. However, the difference in physique between the two was too great, and Holly, who had about double the mass of Kuna and her slender physique, did not budge an inch.

In the end, Kuna realized she would only tire herself out and drooped her shoulders. She ground her teeth, frustratedly saying “*Dammit*”.

Holly: “Me and Kuna were born on the same *day*-. We’re neighbors and kinda like *sisters*-.”

Kuna: “Someone like you, I’d refuse as a *sister*. Older or *younger*.”

Holly: “Ah, the roast’s starting to become a nice *color*-.”

Kuna: “Listen to *me*!”

Towards Holly, who entirely directed her own pace, Kuna’s one-way resistance reverberated emptily and in vain.

Witnessing this scene, Subaru thought that the sight of Kuna being at the mercy of Holly somewhat resembled a certain fussy, violent internal affairs officer.

Subaru: “Kuna’s dyed her hair green, so the color theme overlaps... Even in situations he’s missing in, that guy asserts himself quite strongly.”

If that person were listening, he would say something like “That false accusation is a positive trait, you know!?” However, since he wasn’t present, Subaru disposed of that thought as an auditory hallucination.

Rem looked at Holly and Kuna, who were arguing about the roasted meat’s color with a small smile. Subaru heard her mutter “I’m jealous.”

Rem: “Someone you can honestly talk with just like that...”

Subaru: “...Ahhhh, Rem, can I just say one thing?”

There was a certain and earnest envy packed into Rem’s utterance.

For the amnesiac Rem, the environment around her, including Subaru, must feel like an invader from the darkness. She could not feel truly at ease at any moment.

He did not know whether he had the skill to soothe her strained heart but—

Rem: “What is it?”

Subaru: “I said I was going to keep my mouth shut until you wanted to ask about it but, I’ll spill about one thing.”

Rem: “———”

Subaru: “You have an older sister. Your older twin, who holds you dear from the bottom of her heart... So, no matter where you are, you’ll never be alone.”

Hearing Subaru’s words, Rem’s already wide eyes, opened further in surprise.

After saying that, Subaru wondered if he should have been more patient, but he immediately told himself that this was the correct decision.

Rem had just said that she would wait until she could trust Subaru. It could not be helped if she disparaged him next.

Subaru understood Rem’s anxiety, but, nevertheless, he was at his limit too.

At the very least, he could let her know about Ram’s existence.

Ram, who was probably, even now, worried about her younger sister, all the way from the far lands of Lugunica— The Ram who was feeling Rem through Synesthesia.

Subaru: “I don’t understand it but, if you close your eyes and try to imagine it, you might be able to feel it. That’s what’s called a twin’s Synesthesia.”

Rem: “Synesthesia...”

Somewhat hesitating, Rem timidly placed her hand on her chest and closed her eyes.

Staying still, seeking her other half, born on the same day and from the same mother—seeking the existence of her older twin, Rem’s consciousness started to extend its hand through a sea of black night.

However—

Rem: “...I cannot feel anything.”

Subaru: “Is that, so... I guess it’s pretty difficult if you can’t visualize it.”

Shaking her head slowly, Rem reported on the failure of her Synesthesia.

For a moment, he worried something had happened to Ram that made it unable to connect with her. However, he judged that the distance— both physical and mental, was the bigger problem.

Frankly, in a situation where the Synesthesia had indeed connected, a lot of things would turn for the better at once. It was pretty disappointing, but he could not let that show on the outside.

The most frustrated one here was Rem.

For now, he had to console Rem's feelings of frustration and—

Rem: “—Ah.”

Louis: “Uu—?”

However, while Subaru was choosing his words of comfort, a slight sigh escaped from Rem's lips.

The reason for that was Louis's hand, which was placed on top of Rem's resting hand. Louis, while resting her head on Rem's lap, was concerned about Rem, overlapping her hands with her own from underneath.

Rem softly curled her lips up at Louis's actions.

Rem: “Thank you. I'm okay.”

Louis: “Ahh-.”

Rem put on a brave smile, and Louis cheerfully laughed upon seeing it.

Looking at their heartwarming scene, Subaru grit his teeth. He realized he was too late and his role had been snatched from him.

Subaru: “Dammit... I knew it! You're still my enemy aren't you!?”

Rem: “Again, why does it end up that way? Do you not think it is childish?”

Looking at Subaru, who was glaring at Louis, Rem again lost faith in Subaru.

Ignorant to the situation, Louis, the recipient of Subaru's glare, gleefully flailed her arms and legs up and down.

And then, the ones who took no notice of the stiff atmosphere between Subaru's group—

Holly: "It's *done*-!"

Kuna: "It's still *raw*!!"

The duo who had an already established relationship raised their voices.



—Subaru's group had arrived safely at Guaral, having taken four days in total,

Subaru: "So that's Guaral... It's protected by fine-looking walls."

A fortified city, surrounded by towering walls, that could be seen from a distance.

He was astonished that his prediction had missed its mark, and felt like he had been hit by a stroke of luck. Subaru was experiencing two sensations, as there was a disparity between the sight of the city and what he had imagined after hearing that it was the "nearest town".

Subaru: "The city feels pretty rugged... Is a giant gonna come over or what⁴?"

Kuna: "*Giants*? I heard they were nearly wiped out, quite a while *ago*."

Subaru: "Really? I wonder if the old fart I know is the last giant, then..."

Subaru muttered out a purposeless comment in response to Kuna's serious-minded reply.

⁴ Translation note by Witch Cult Translations: "This is a reference to Attack on Titan. The Giant tribe in Re: Zero, and the titular Titans from Attack on Titan, use the same Japanese, "巨人".)"

It was surprising to know that Rom-jii, the only giant that Subaru knew, was in such a rare position. Although, he had heard of the oni race being extremely scarce in numbers from Rem, so perhaps the struggle for survival between races was unforgiving, even in this world.

Subaru: "Thinking about it calmly, I've never met anyone related to elves aside from Emilia-tan, so maybe there aren't many elves out there, either."

As a cliché of the fantasy genre, it was common for long-lived species to have low fertility in exchange for a long lifespan, therefore being unable to increase their numbers easily.

In addition to that, because of the fear directed towards the Witch of Envy, half-elves were a target of hatred, in this world. That was the real state of things. Naturally, Subaru could think of the possibility that pure-blooded elves were also pressured by those conventions, as they were the foundation of the births of half-elves.

Subaru: "I think about Emilia-tan in a place where she's absent. Dammit, I haven't been able to meet Beako for a while as well. I feel like my Emiliase and Beatromin deficiency is becoming severe."

The prescribed medicine for both cases of malnutrition would be coming into contact with Emilia and Beatrice.

In all seriousness, the mental fatigue that resulted from being continuously worried or tense was substantial, so just hearing the voices of Emilia and Beatrice, who both contributed to Subaru's peace of mind, would make him feel more relaxed.

Subaru: "I miss Ram, Petra, Frederica, and the others' voices... Hell, in a situation like this, I'm fine with even Roswaal's voice."

Rem: "Excuse me, can you give me a break with your meaningless emotional conflict?"

Subaru: "Ah, my bad."

Rem chided him for his overflowing soliloquy while remaining on his back.

Subaru had splendidly managed to carry Rem on the wooden rack for the duration of the journey, without entrusting her to anyone else. He had not learned the ropes on how to carry things during the first and

second day, and his waste of stamina had been quite prominent. However, he had gotten the hang of his pacing and sense of balance from the third day onwards, so he had been able to make a lot of progress while walking.

Subaru: “When it comes to carrying Rem on one’s back, I’m second to none by now.”

Rem: “Don’t try to compete over such an undignified thing. Also, those two are...”

Subaru and Rem were positioned back-to-back, so Rem would be pointing towards somewhere behind him. As he turned around, obeying her words, there were Holly and Kuna.

And then, next to Kuna, who was lazily scratching her head, Holly took one step towards Subaru and Rem,

Holly: “Well, I guess this is goodbye since you arrived *safely*~.”

Subaru: “Ah... You two won’t enter the city...?”

Kuna: “It’s meaningless for us to *enter*. Our role is to escort you *two*.”

Subaru: “I see... You two really helped us out a lot.”

With the abrupt farewell, Subaru admonished himself, thinking this would obviously happen.

Kuna and Holly had only followed them out of the kindness of the People of Shudraq. He felt that he was dependent on them, because they had saved him multiple times during his travels.

Holly, who had cleared the atmosphere with her hunting skills and cheery personality.

Kuna, who possessed unexpectedly extensive knowledge and an earnest will to provide answers to Subaru’s questions, had been reliable.

Parting ways with the two of them, Subaru would be traveling with Rem, this time for sure — no, it would be a three-person-journey with Rem and Louis.

There had been someone else at the Empire’s encampment, as well as the Shudraqian village, but this time, it was different.

Kuna: "...Jeez, stop making such a miserable *face*."

Subaru: "My bad. By <miserable face>, do you mean... woah!?"

Gazing at Subaru's black eyes that had previously wavered with uneasiness, Kuna shoved something towards him.

Subaru instinctively caught the item in his hand, and teetered forward from its unexpected weight. A long and thin white wrapping was given to him. It was the object which Holly had been carrying on her back, for the whole duration of the journey.

During the trip, he had assumed that it was an item essential to Holly and Kuna.

Subaru: "Now that I think about it, I feel like you never opened this... What's this?"

Holly: "It's *yours*-. The Chieftain told us to give it to *you*, once you arrived properly at the *town*-."

Subaru: "It's mine, and once I arrived at the town...?"

Unable to grasp the true meaning behind Holly's words, Subaru knitted his brows out of uncertainty. However, Kuna had prompted him roughly with a, "Just open *it*."

Receiving her words, Subaru lowered the wooden rack on his back to the ground, and opened the white wrapping.

Inside, there was—

Subaru: "Ah..."

Rem: "Is this... a horn?"

A white lump laid in Subaru's arms, as large as his arms could hold. What Rem had murmured after looking at it had told him it was a horn — a Witchbeast's horn at that.

Subaru recognized it. He had seen it twice, and he had taken a good look at it during the Lifeblood Ritual.

Subaru: "Is this the Elgina's horn, by any chance?"

Holly: “Yep-. You were the one who broke it off, so it’s *yours-*.”

Kuna: “It’s a valuable *item*. With that size, it’ll fetch a high *price*.”

Subaru: “—Hk!”

Having been told that the horn would fetch a high price, Subaru held his breath at Holly and Kuna’s thoughtful arrangements.

In other words, they were telling him to exchange the Witchbeast’s horn for traveling expenses, so that Subaru’s group could go back to the Kingdom of Lugunica.

The two had carried the baggage for that purpose, without specifying said purpose.

Subaru: “It must’ve been pretty heavy...”

Kuna: “You were carrying Rem on your back for the whole *time*.”

Holly: “Besides, *besides*! I’m very *strong-*. So, it was no problem at *all-*.”

Both Kuna and Holly had faces looking like they had only done something trivial, while Subaru’s voice was trembling because of the two’s ulterior motives.

Their thoughtfulness had rendered him completely speechless, word for word.

Subaru: “———”

They had helped him on the way to Guaral, and even secured traveling expenses for Subaru’s group.

Despite all that, Subaru would part ways with them, and go back to his country— Holly and Kuna would reunite with their Shudraqian allies, and join the battle to retake the Imperial Capital alongside Abel.

Whilst yielding the life or death of many along the way——

Subaru: “I...”

Kuna: “——Don’t think anything *stupid*.”

Subaru: “———”

Kuna: “You gotta fight to protect the ones you wanna *protect*. It’s the same for *us*.”

Although impulsive words nearly found their way out of Subaru’s mouth, Kuna had sharply put a stop to those.

Kuna directed an annoyed glare at Subaru, all while emanating her usual feeling of listlessness.

She had a lot of complaints, and always seemed irritated towards Holly. However, she had never separated herself from the Shudraquians, nor had she ever given any indication that she disliked Holly.

As a member of the Shudraquians, she thought it was only natural for her to fight together with Abel.

—That must be proof that she had already chosen the “ones she wanted to protect” in her words.

Kuna: “Don’t keep idling *around*. I have good *eyesight*. If you do something stupid, then I can see it straight *away*.”

Holly: “And if Kuna tells me about it, then I can go kaboom with my bow and *arrow*-!”

Subaru: “...Yeah, that’s scary.”

From their words, Subaru understood that he had been gently pushed away.

If he acted out of impulse here, then he would disregard their — no, the People of Shudraq’s kindness. He could not do such a thing for the women who had referred to him as their comrade.

Subaru: “I’ll gratefully make good use of it for our journey. Thanks for taking care of us, you two!”

Comprehending Kuna and Holly’s intentions, Subaru swallowed the thoughts that surged forward.

Receiving it, albeit their respective attitudes, they nodded.

Rem: “Thank you for accompanying us, Holly-san and Kuna-san. I won’t forget my gratitude towards you two, as well as to every person of the People of Shudraq.”

Kuna: “Please do *that*. You’ve apparently forgotten a lot of things, *so...*”

Holly: "I think you're going too far with *that-*."

Wanting to at least bid them farewell, Rem had climbed down the wooden frame and seemed to be reluctant to part ways with them.

Louis also showing her unwillingness to leave Holly and Kuna was something unexpected. She had gotten close to Holly in particular, who was outspoken and unreserved with her interactions. Louis clung on to Holly's stomach for a while, refusing to separate herself from her.

Kuna: "Bye, *Subaru*. Don't forget, I'll be *watching*."

Holly: "Yep-!"

Subaru: "Yeah! Thank you so much! Thank you!"

Turning their backs towards the two waving their hands in an exaggerated manner, Subaru's group resumed their three-person-journey.

Subaru had placed back the horn he was given into its wrapping, and left it in Louis's care by making her carry it on her back. Subaru had made that agonizing decision because his hands were occupied, but perhaps Holly and Kuna's words had been effective, as Louis was trying to ensure the wrapping would not drop, following Subaru and Rem quietly.

Rem: "It means she also pays attention to a lot of things."

Subaru: "...I know she's a ball of curiosity."

Rem pointed it out while on his back, with Subaru replying to her with a bitter feeling.

The Sin Archbishop of Gluttony, Louis Arneb, had devoured myriad lives, in an attempt to find the life most suited for herself. She would be an inquirer if framed in a positive light, or an omnivore if framed negatively.

That was why, even if Louis had shown a slightly admirable side of herself, Subaru's impression of her would not change.

It would not change.

Subaru: “Let’s go.”

Hearing Rem’s sigh behind him, Subaru began walking.

He also heard Louis’s footsteps as if she were following him.

There were only three of them, just as how it had been back then, when they had been first plunged into the Vollachian Empire.

Finally seeming as if they were all facing the same direction, they moved on.

And then, they passed through the gates of the Fortress City— Guaral.

Arc 7 Chapter 16 - The Situation in the Empire

Light Novel Adaptation found in Volume 27, Chapter 2 “Looming Evil”, Parts 1-3 (near start)

Original Web Novel Chapter — [Complete](#)

Original Translation by Witch Cult Translations (Negi, [Kobosuhito](#), [Taurace](#), [Polaris](#), [Ice/Ice Occultism](#),
[Fried Hedgehog](#)) — [Complete](#)

—The Fortress City of Guaral.

That was the name of the first civilized town in the Empire that Subaru’s party had reached.

Because they had constantly been sleeping under the stars at the Imperial Soldiers’ encampment and the Shudraquian village until now, catching sight of civilization was especially exciting.

That said, it was not as though they could just let go and enjoy the wonders of civilization.

The reason being—

???: “—Inspection.”

Before their eyes, at the entrance to the city, they saw an inspection taking place, and Subaru wet his lips with his tongue.

Guaral was surrounded on all four sides by a protective wall, and entering or exiting from the east and west was limited by large gates. There were permanent inspection posts at the gates, and even from a distance the gate guards’ grim faces as they kept a stern, watchful eye, could be confirmed.

Kuna: “They’ll be able to tell we’re Shudraquian with one look. So we can’t come with you friends, but as long as you’re not carrying anything shady you’ll be fine.”

Holly: “It’ll work out if you’re not timid and walk in boldly~. Take care of Rem and Louis-chan okay~?”

Before they arrived at the city, those were the parting words of Kuna and Holly.

Both had advised him not to get more worked up than necessary, but to forget his nervousness and anxiety so easily was a suggestion impossible to follow.

Since, at any rate, in the Empire they were foreigners with unknown affiliations and no identification either.

Subaru: “Anyways, even a foreigner with no common sense like me can tell Lugunican people aren’t welcome to wander around in Vollachia these days.”

It seemed that if he foolishly revealed his true identity, he would without a doubt incur the displeasure of the gate guards.

It was not just that they could literally be turned away at the gate, to be inadvertently arrested or something of the sort would be a terrible event if it came to pass. He had already gone through that back at the Imperial encampment.

—Subaru absolutely could not permit an end such as that, where many would burn as a result of his own mishaps, to occur again.

Subaru: “———”

???: “...People around you are going to get suspicious if you look too grim.”

Subaru had furrowed his brows, in reflection of how torn he was within; upon hearing her voice, his eyes widened in surprise.

The voice had come from his back— And had belonged to Rem, who was riding along in the wooden backpack.

Because of the way the pack was structured, Rem should not be able to see Subaru’s face since their backs were up against each other.

Subaru: “And yet, how did you know I was wrinkling my brows?”

Rem: “Even if I can’t see it, I can hear your breathing. Your heartbeat too, since our backs are touching, although it is through the backpack... I can feel the tension from here.”

Subaru: “Oof... Sorry ‘bout that. For my wrinkled brow, and for my loud heartbeat too.”

Rem: “Yes. Allow me some quiet, please.”

Subaru: “By that, you mean «calm down», not «stop breathing» right?”

In response to Subaru seeking confirmation just in case, Rem remained silent, sighing.

Rem’s long sigh felt like it was somewhere between being fed up with Subaru and being apathetic towards him. Since it was not born out of clear disgust or hostility, Subaru was a tiny bit relieved.

If one were to tell him his aspirations were low, there would be nothing he could reply back with.

Louis: “Ohhh, ohhh?”

Subaru: “...I get it, so hurry up. You’re also one cause of my worries you know!”

Pulling vigorously on Subaru’s sleeve and pointing at the line was the long-haired Louis.

The Witchbeast’s horn which Kuna had bequeathed to them— Louis was shouldering it in a white bundle, currently wondering why Subaru was not lining up.

However, he could not act thoughtlessly like Louis and recklessly line up in the queue.

Subaru: “Right now, we don’t have any way to give identification or bribes to the gate guards. So, it’s impossible to approach from the front.”

Rem: “Isn’t it possible to line up and talk it out with the gate guards?”

Subaru: “Being honest and talking it out is an option, but a situation in which it fails and we can’t recover from is scary... Cause, we don’t have anyone that we can rely on right now.”

Listening to Subaru’s concerns, Rem made a small noise and went silent.

It may have been difficult to imagine for the amnesiac Rem, but for every place to place, and culture to culture, there was no overdoing cautiousness.

—Surprisingly, ten days were about to pass, since the time the trio had been blown off into the Empire from the Pleiades Watchtower.

The initial chaos had subsided quite a bit, and the heated relationship between Subaru, Rem and Louis had been shelved away for the time being. Nevertheless, it was still difficult to say that everything was looking up.

In any case, the only time when Subaru and Rem — and also Louis — were acting together and by themselves, had occurred when they were running from the Hunter and Elgina. It lasted merely a moment after they had been blown off here.

Any other time, whether at the Imperial Soldiers' camp, the Shudraqian settlement or during the journey to Guaral, there was always someone familiar with the Empire alongside them.

They were not on friendly terms with everyone there, but at least they were not lonely.

Subaru: "But, it's different now."

Antagonizing Todd and his crew, splitting off from Abel's path and even separating from the People of Shudraq.

From here on out, the trio would need to traverse the untrodden lands of the Empire without any crutches. Like it or not, taking care in their decisions would be the name of the game.

Rem: "So, what shall we do? No matter how troubled or hesitant, our goal is still the same, right? There's no way we can just pass by through this city, I reckon..."

Subaru: "Even if we call it quits here because of this inspection, they might be doing the same thing in other cities. If only this were Lugunica, they wouldn't be on such high alert... No."

Subaru shook his head, taking into account the situation in the Empire.

Though they had since parted from him, Abel had conveyed to them his own situation, and how he had been ousted from his seat as Emperor. If that were true, then, currently, the Empire was in the midst of internal strife, one could say.

Though Abel had said that the matter of the Emperor's absence was being kept from the populace, putting a lid on people's mouths was pretty difficult, and the mood would be surreptitiously contagious.

On that, even Todd had looked like he had been holding misgivings at their dispatchment back at the encampment.

Subaru: "If that's the case, then I guess it's because of Abel that the inspections are so strict...? Shit, screw that guy."

Though Abel had been of some help to them, he would rather place him as more of a negative, given the problems when you evened it all out, and mood-related ones.

Given his personality and attitude, it was easy to imagine a Nobunaga-esque reason as to why the people beneath him had rebelled⁵.

Subaru: "He seemed like a guy who would carry out the phrase, «The King does not understand human feelings»⁶, for real."

Rem: "...Are you perhaps wasting time by thinking about worthless things, instead of being worried in earnest?"

Rem's voice hardened into ice as Subaru muttered that out while rubbing his chin.

Her tone harbored genuine anger, stretching beyond exasperation or indifference, causing Subaru to try and explain his previous remark in a hurry.

Subaru: "Nonono, wait a moment, relax. My Round Table-like⁷ comment was definitely worse than some idle chatter, but it's not like I'm just absent-mindedly staring at the line without a plan. I do have an idea."

Rem: "Don't you feel embarrassed as a person, lying with such nonchalance?"

⁵ Translation note by Witch Cult Translations: "Read more about Nobunaga [here](#)".

⁶ Translation note by Witch Cult Translations: "«The King does not understand human feelings» is a reference to Fate/Stay Night.

⁷ Translation note by Witch Cult Translations: "«Round Table» is a reference to Fate/Stay Night".

Subaru: “At least please show that you’re willing to trust me, even if it’s just a little bit! You’re being too hasty by deciding that I lied in a snap!”

Rem’s impression of him continued to decrease without ever reaching rock-bottom, and Subaru was desperate to restore her trust.

Truthfully, he did not make up lie after lie, since he did have an alternative plan to pass through the inspection process. If it were just Subaru and Rem, it would be impossible to bypass the gate guards’ check-up the proper way.

If so, it did not just have to be Subaru and Rem.

Rem: “That means...”

Subaru: “It’s time to demonstrate Natsuki Subaru’s hundred-and-eighth special skill— «Relying On Other People»⁸.”

Subaru answered with a smile that showed his gleaming teeth, while holding a thumbs up.

For some reason, behind himself, he felt as if Rem had frowned at his response, even if he should not have been able to see her face.



Passing through the inspection, which had been packed with a unique sort of tension, they went through the towering main gate.

Like that, Subaru’s field of vision opened up. As he faced the stone-crafted cityscape that overflowed with exoticness, he thrust both of his hands into the air out of a sense of accomplishment.

Subaru: “We passed through!”

⁸ Translation note by Witch Cult Translations: “«Hundred-and-eighth-skill» is probably a reference to My Teen Romantic Comedy SNAFU”.

Louis: “Auu!”

Listening to Subaru’s zesty voice, Louis raised her hands up as well right beside him.

Subaru had some personal opinions regarding her, acting as if they were companions; but for now, the joy he felt at overcoming the first hurdle to enter the city washed those away.

Although he was immensely vexed about it, there was the truth that Louis’s existence had been useful in passing the inspection.

Subaru: “Speaking of which, this place really is completely different from Lugunica. Although there were tiny differences between the Royal Capital and Pristella as well.....”

While taking in the ambiance of the streets, in his mind Subaru compared it to the townscapes in the Kingdom of Lugunica.

To Subaru the most striking were the streets of Costuul near the new Roswaal mansion, but as expected, the variance was great when compared to a different country.

Each had their own idiosyncrasies, the Royal Capital, Costuul, and Pristella too, but they had something of a commonality in atmosphere, something characteristic of the Kingdom. That he could not sense in Guaral.

So to speak, compared to the parallel fantasy world noble-like feel of the Kingdom, the stores and houses in the streets of the Empire seemed more rustic and devoid of color. It gave an impression of valuing utility over showiness.

The entire street was unified in a sense, as they evoked a sense of power and refinement rather than splendor, and it felt like the leveled ground encouraged that impression.

Subaru: “If it were Lugunica this would be stone pavement, but here it’s kinda basic, huh?”

Considering the size of the streets and population, Guaral could be thought of as an above average city in the Empire.

On the whole, it was a pretty good measuring stick, to compare various places in the Empire.

Subaru: “Well, we don’t wanna stay too long, so I better not waste time using measuring sticks either.”

Rem: “—Um, could you let me down before long?”

Subaru: “Ah, my bad.”

Behind Subaru, strong feelings being evoked in him, Rem requested to be let down from her ride on the wooden rack, and Subaru apologized as he slowly got down on his knees on the spot.

She undid the fasten across her shoulders and got out of the carrier, and clutching her cane Rem stood on the ground.

While on the long journey, she had been carried in the wooden rack, but if they were going to walk through a street, she wanted to walk on her own two legs. There was no reason to hurry either, so there was no reason not to grant Rem’s request.

Rem: “This is...”

Using her cane, Rem turned around and finally gazed upon the same view as Subaru and Louis.

Eyebrows raised slightly, Rem’s pale blue eyes held an indistinct sense of wonder and excitement, and seeing Rem’s positive reaction Subaru’s face relaxed a little.

Subaru: “How ‘bout it, you surprised?”

Rem: “That is... Yes, I am. The queue was similar but... It’s because this is my first time seeing people like this, and a proper street too.”

Subaru: “Ah, it is, isn’t it? This is your first time in a normal human town, huh.”

As mentioned above, up until now, Rem’s experiences had been limited to exceptional places and treatment.

And as long as she remained without Memories, Rem would possess no recollection of living with anyone either. Life with Subaru, Louis, and the Shudraquians amounted to the entirety of the experience Rem had.

Subaru: “———”

Rem looked deeply moved, smiling with her whole face, and Subaru closed one eye.

For now, he folded up the wooden rack Rem had gotten out of and waited for her excitement to subside.

—It was hard to say Guaral was brimming with life for a city.

The queued checkpoints, and the boorish dark colors of the streets stood out. Altogether, the place’s impression was a far cry from gorgeous. The size of the city too, appeared to be in the thousands.

And yet, that did not detract value from the excitement in Rem’s eyes it seemed.

Subaru: “So then, shall we look around a bit?”

Rem: “—No, it’s fine. I don’t want to take up too much time.”

Subaru: “If it’s for you, I wouldn’t say it’s too much...”

Rem shook her head, and Subaru scratched his cheek as he answered.

Really, if it served as a promising sign regarding Rem’s inner feelings, sightseeing around town wouldn’t be a problem. If a pressing matter arose, he would want her to hold back, but for now the outlook was positive.

After all, it was because of Rem’s quick-wittedness that they were so fortunate.

Subaru: “If it weren’t for Rem, I wouldn’t have managed successfully with Flop-san and his sister. It’s okay for you to be a little selfish, y’know.”

Rem: “...What I am saying is that it’s not good to keep them waiting. Even though you’re already relying on their kindness, are you going to incur more debt beyond that?”

Subaru: “Ohh... When you put it like that, yeah, sorry...”

Turning away from the buildings, Rem’s sharp gaze pressed down on Subaru’s heart.

Behind Subaru's group, slowly with the sound of heavy wheels, came an oxcart — a Fallo cart, pulled by a Brave Oxen Fallo, came along.

Fallos, like ground dragons and the large canine ligers, were a type of animal used for labor.

Like ground dragons and ligers, many pulled carts, and many were used for things like transporting cargo. Their pace was slow, and they did not have the Divine Protection of Wind Evasion like ground dragons either, and he'd heard they were generally utilized in cities.

And then—

???: "Hey hey hey, kept you waiting, huh? They took their sweet time checking the cargo. Honestly, those officials' task is such a pain."

Speaking with a shrug from the coachman's seat of the Fallo cart was a young man with long bangs.

A character with dazzling golden hair and a fair-skinned complexion, his slender form wrapped in wide sleeved clothing, it was the person who had assisted Subaru's group with entering the city.

At the appearance of the young man on the Fallo cart, Subaru gave a "Glad you made it", and bowed his head.

Subaru: "I'm sorry, Flop-san. Next time I'll get them to let you through ahead of us."

Flop: "Nah, I don't mind really. Things like cargo inspection are tedious work. So it's not especially worth coming along to see, I must say."

In response to Subaru's words of apology, the youth in the coachman's seat— Flop gently shook his head.

With his flowy gesture his long bangs swayed like the mane of a lion, and Subaru felt like he could envision a sparkling effect there. He was a quirky guy, but since his responses were relatively forthright, the gap was large.

That sort of mental image before Subaru, he once again smoothed down his own bangs,

Flop: “Yeah, it’s a boring task. In the future, travelers like you should leave that sort of thing to me... Actually, I’m sure my sister can handle it.”

???: “Big bro, big bro, I can hear you though!”

Flop: “Hahaha, it’s not as if you weren’t supposed to hear what I said, dear sister. Don’t underestimate an older brother’s volume.”

Walking alongside the slowly advancing cart, was the woman whom Flop had let overhear his slightly out-of-focus response.

She was a woman of high stature with hair the same color as Flop’s, her features very much resembling his. Her shoulders and legs were exposed by a daring attire, and her voluminous hair was parted into many segments in an avant-garde style.

Even with that kind of peculiar outward appearance, the two barbarian swords attached to opposite sides of her waist were probably what stood out the most.

It was clear these were not weapons for mere show or vain threats, since their condition was that of having been well-used.

This woman was called Medium, and along with her older brother Flop, the two traveled together as the friendly O’Connell siblings.

They had made their acquaintance in the inspection line, and they had helped Subaru’s group, for whom providing identification or bribes would have been difficult, pass through inspection. So they were partners that ought to be called benefactors.

Of course, it wasn’t just out of kindness that they had cooperated with Subaru’s party. To begin with, it had been Subaru who had laid his eyes on the O’Connells with the objective of passing the inspection.

As they were without money or connections, cooperating with another party was a requirement to get through the checkpoint.

So when Subaru saw them, he thought there might be room for negotiations.

The reason he thought so was—

Medium: “Wowie, big bro! So, you saw through everything I was thinking!”

Flop: “Of course, naturally. You can’t win in business if you can’t predict someone’s thoughts. Our O’Connell company is viable because of my brains and your brawn, y’know!”

Medium: “That’s my bro! Though I don’t really get what you’re saying!”

Flop: “Hahahaha, it’s great that you seem to be enjoying life dear sister!”

Both their chests puffed up with pride, the O’Connell siblings laughed together uproariously. Their trade was peddling.

To be precise, Flop was responsible for the business of peddling, and Medium was the one in charge of guarding her brother and their goods while on the road and inside towns.

—Merchants.

Well, actually, for Subaru to pass the inspection, that was the selection criteria for companions to depend on.

Subaru: “The experience of talking about this and that with Otto and Anastasia-san came in handy...”

His close friend Otto, and Anastasia, with whom he had embarked on a long journey— The latter was not really the person herself, but Echidna who had been acting as her, although the knowledge she showed ought to be the same as the person in question.

He had mainly received instruction from those two, and that was the seed of Subaru’s faith in merchants.

Even across national borders, if someone were a merchant, they would be willing to listen to a partner who presented benefits.

Literally ready to take a chance on a strong offensive gambit, after they’d struck out on four groups of merchants, Subaru’s party encountered the O’Connell siblings.

And then, they won over that somewhat quirky pair, and successfully earned their cooperation in crossing the checkpoint.

As the leverage for negotiation, the item that captured their interest was—

Subaru: “By the way, is this wooden rack really enough as compensation? Though I did put effort into making it, the crudeness of its craftsmanship still makes it very obvious that it’s handmade?”

Flop: “I can’t deny that it’s very minimalistic. However, the fact it can be assembled from parts, as well as the way it’s designed and made for carrying were what piqued my interest. It’d be useful even for transporting heavy baggage, no?”

Subaru: “...Well, as long as Flop-san’s fine with that.”

Feeling somewhat unassured, Subaru handed the folded wooden rack over to Medium.

After receiving it, Medium let out a “Woah~” as she checked it out, then turned around and shoved it inside the cargo bed of the Falo cart. It seemed like she had not seen much value in the rack.

In truth, even Subaru himself didn’t know what exactly Flop had seen in it.

The handover of the wooden rack made by Subaru had been the condition for the O’Connell siblings’ assistance.

After seeing Rem being carried by use of the wooden rack, Flop had felt it was a unique and fascinating creation, and promised to help break through the inspection with the object in exchange.

Honestly, as far as Subaru was concerned, who had been prepared for something like a Witchbeast’s horn to be brought up to the negotiation table, he could say this had been a rather unexpected proposal.

Subaru: “I was thinking about remaking it with better materials after arriving in town anyways, worst case scenario, it was possible that Rem wouldn’t want to ride on it anymore.”

Rem: “It’s true that I want to walk with my own feet whenever possible. Because if I ride on the wooden rack, your stench will come drifting along with the wind.”

Subaru: “*Gomen*⁹...”

⁹ English flip. Means “sorry” (ごめん), originally “ソーリー” (sorry).

While leaning on the cane, Rem dished out a jab on the matter of the Witch's Scent in a low voice.

Nonetheless, enduring this whole time during their travels and only saying so after reaching their destination was considerate of her, or so Subaru told himself.

Watching this back-and-forth between Subaru and Rem, Flop shrugged his shoulders as if saying "This won't do". Although he displayed a completely rueful reaction, there was a reason behind that attitude.

Flop: "Try to get along better, you guys. To be husband and wife means to be each other's support. The way you relied on each other earlier was absolutely beautiful."

Medium: "Well, the one who took away their wooden rack was big bro though."

Flop: "Exactly! What right do I have for saying that, silly me!"

One held his palm against his forehead, and the other holding her stomach, Flop and Medium burst out in laughter.

Affected by the sibling's guffaws, Subaru's tensed face eased while taking a quick peek at Rem. Without a hint of laughter on her face, was Rem, to whom Louis was holding on to with one arm.

Directed at the girl's profile, Subaru voiced a "Umm~" timidly.

Subaru: "You know, erm, Rem-san? Are you perhaps upset right now?"

Rem: "Huh? Why would I be upset? Do you have a clue as to why or something?"

Subaru: "Ohh no, I was just wondering if it was against your wishes to play husband and wife with me, even if it's just made up for the sake of our disguise..."

While poking his index fingers against each other, Subaru tries to tend to Rem's mood in trepidation.

From Flop and Medium's perspectives, the relationship between Subaru and Rem was that of husband and wife.

That had been the result of Subaru's sudden speechlessness at the abrupt demand for an answer regarding their relationship the siblings had put out, while having a discussion for passing the inspection— No, it was not because of speechlessness.

They did have an answer prepared beforehand, however the credibility of that answer was doubted, so there was nothing that could be done about it.

Subaru: "To think that the story of traveling siblings was not believable enough..."

Rem: "Flop-san and Medium-san are not only under the same situation, but the two of them are also very similar in terms of appearance, that's why. It's an impossible feat to pull off for me, you, and this child."

On the matter of deceiving them, as merchants living in a world filled with deception and honesty, there was no other choice but to say that Subaru was simply too inexperienced to succeed.

In the first place, the one who had seen through their lie had been Medium, who had blurted out "they look nothing alike, right big bro?" in a loud voice.

Anywho, after being defeated by those keen eyes, the spectacular story (derived from the brother-sister setting Subaru had prepared beforehand) of how they had traveled far from their hometown with the goal of throwing away a cursed ring in a far-off mountain had been rendered useless.¹⁰

The shock received from that was another reason as to why Subaru had entered a state of stupefaction when the time came to supposedly answer their question. The one that had saved him from that predicament had been Rem, who made use of her quick-wittedness and explained, "I'm his wife".

Subaru: "So the story is that Rem and I are husband and wife, and this kid is the child of Rem's elder sister, who left her in our care..."

Rem: "Wasn't it you who told me I had an older sister? Although, since we're supposed to be twins, I don't think she'll have such a grown kid... but I'll turn a blind eye to that."

Louis: "Hmm-?"

¹⁰ Translation note by Witch Cult Translations: "This anecdote is most likely a reference to the Lord of the Rings saga".

Having been stroked on the head by Rem, Louis let out a tiny groan with a content look.

Louis's harmless presence and mannerism had been one of the reasons why Flop and Medium had not become cautious around Subaru's group, apparently.

Leaving aside Subaru and his nasty-looking eyes, there was the debilitated Rem and the vulnerable Louis. This trio did not seem like bad people who would commit crimes in the city to Flop and Medium.

Rem: "Why..."

Subaru: "Hm?"

Rem: "Why did you fumble your words in that situation? It's not like you're incapable considering how you normally chatter on and on."

Subaru: "That feels like a complaint disguised as praise..."

Nevertheless, it was true that Subaru's incompetence had almost caused trouble for Rem.

If it hadn't been for Rem's quick response, the three of them would most likely still be stuck outside the gate, gawking at the line helplessly.

Subaru: "-----"

There was a limit to how far he could get by just fooling around.

Subaru, wanting to avoid damaging his trust with Rem any further, let out a faint "Ah" when Rem casted her eyes towards him.

Subaru: "I was surprised myself but, the moment they saw through the lie, my body tensed up like crazy. Maybe it was because I was traumatized by the campground from before."

Rem: "Ah..."

Subaru: "I thought that if we gave a sloppy answer, Flop and Medium might've changed their attitude or something. I'm ashamed to say but, that was why my train of thought suddenly stopped. My bad."

After conveying the self-analysis of his incompetent self, Subaru lowered his head towards Rem sincerely.

A brain full of smart little tricks coupled with an articulate tongue, that was one of the few weapons Natsuki Subaru possessed. That was why, once both of those stopped working, Subaru would be reduced to nothing but a mere nuisance.

He was responsible for Rem's well-being— Careless failures could not be afforded.

Rem: “—I understand now. I guess it is what it is.”

Subaru: “...Really? Even though I messed up like that?”

Rem: “Anyone would freeze up after having experienced something unpleasant. That's what I think, at least.”

Subaru, who had thought he was totally going to be yelled at mercilessly, was surprised by Rem's response.

Of course, it was because Rem's very core was kind, so he was already aware that she would spare her consideration for other people. The fact that Subaru was among those who she directed her consideration towards, however, was a surprise.

Subaru: “...So you're not mad?”

Rem: “I'm not angry. But, just discuss with me beforehand next time. Because I don't think I'll be able to spin up believable excuses every time.”

Subaru: “Ohhh, okay, understood. You sure you aren't mad though, right?”

Rem: “I'm not mad.”

Subaru: “For sure for sure?”

Rem: “Haven't I been saying I wasn't mad...!”

Out of excess worry, Subaru had fueled Rem's anger instead.

Hugging his head from Rem's sharp gaze, Subaru cowered and begged for forgiveness in the end.

With that interlude, Subaru's group finally entered the stage called Guaral.



Subaru: “—I can finally relax!”

Said Subaru who threw himself onto the bed at the inn, stretching his arms and legs, enjoying the freedom.

The bed and sheets which possessed decent quality, and the ambiance of the room let off a decent sense of cleanliness; both these aspects indicated the quality of the inn was above average.

Given their situation, although it was not like they should indulge in too much luxury, this was a necessary expense to ensure safety.

Otto: “If we are to stay somewhere, I believe it is best that we eliminate the options of cheap inns and camping. Leaving people who have the power to protect themselves aside such as Emilia-sama and Garfiel, people like me or Natsuki-san would be easy pickings for those harboring ill intents.”

Such was one of the topics brought up in conversations over alcohol, which used to take place in Otto’s room.

Thinking hard about it, being that cautious was necessary, but in the case that the traveling budget wasn’t very high, safety would be something that would slip out of mind easily.

However, considering the situation that Subaru and the rest were in at the moment, it was a needed expense.

Although, speaking of which—

Subaru: “We sure spent a considerable time fighting over who gets which room...”

While saying so, Subaru rolled over on his bed, and began staring at the wall.

Beyond that wall, in the adjacent room were Rem and Louis— They had decided to rent an inn in Guaral and divided the rooms based on gender, but Subaru felt disappointed with the results.

Albeit a while had passed, Subaru had yet to fully shed his suspicions of her. He was still opposed to them being together outside of his personal supervision.

That said, Rem had refused his proposal for all of them to share one room. Thus at present, he had no choice but to settle in with the current state of affairs but—

???: “My oh my, Husband-kun, feeling quite sullen today aren’t we. Wonderful, simply wonderful!”

So spoke Flop as he entered the room quite belayed.

Inside, he tossed his luggage onto the bed Subaru was not mulling on, then winked at him as he caressed his own long bangs.

While Flop was indeed being Flop, he did have an actual reason to be present.

This room had been rented with the intention that Subaru and Flop occupy it, and Flop’s sister, Medium, would occupy the other room with Rem.

Subaru: “Ahhh, I’m sorry. For leaving everything to you...”

Flop: “It’s all fine and dandy. You protected yourself with wit. The saying that «the people of the Empire must be strong» does not refer exclusively to the art of war.”

Subaru: “...That makes me feel a bit better, thank you.”

Sitting cross-legged on the bed, Subaru smiled at him bitterly.

Even after overcoming the checkpoint at the gates, the siblings Flop and Medium had continued to help Subaru and his friends in various other ways.

They had helped in finding an inn where they could procure safety as well, but the biggest help Subaru had received regarded the Witchbeast’s horn.

Subaru: “Who knows how we’d have been taken advantage of if we were on our own.”

The horn of the Witchbeast that Louis had carried was already no longer in their possession.

This was because, following Kuna's, along with many others' advice, they had liquidated the horn into currency. For some reason, Flop had come along and helped in the selling price negotiations for it.

All they could do was witness the unfolding of a fierce battle between Flop and the shop owner, like people watching a court trial in progress while being ignorant of the law.

Regardless, they had managed to convert the Witchbeast's horn into Imperial Gold Coins.

That adequately heavy bag of coins would provide funds for Subaru's 'campaign' in the Empire. It would have to cover their future traveling expenses, so they had to be careful about it.

Subaru: "I can't afford to get swallowed whole again like before after all."

Flop: "Hahaha! The first move should always be an attempt to be imposing. Straighten your back and stand tall, and you'll see your opposition won't come to make their move so easily. Your baseless confidence may just become the only truth in the meantime. Doesn't profit only exist beyond that!"

Subaru: "Yeah, when you put it like that, it definitely sounds really convincing..."

For better or worse, Flop was full of confidence.

Subaru could imagine circumstances where his unreserved way of speaking would bring about unnecessary arguments, but seeing as he had made his way in the world to date, his way of life was evidently correct.

In fact, Subaru had been saved by those very mannerisms of his, so he was quite honestly impressed.

Flop: "That said, it was quite the long trip with the Wife-san, correct? Would you prefer to continue that conversation of ours tomorrow?"

Subaru: "It... It's a pretty tempting suggestion, but I'm good. We need to get to our destination as soon as possible. We can't afford to waste even a single day."

Tempted as he were by the softness of the bed, Subaru managed to tear himself away from it.

As Subaru got off the bed, Flop exclaimed "Truly fantastic", with his hands thrown out,

Flop: “There are times when dragging along one’s feet for the sake of one’s loved ones, even if they are heavy as iron, is truly a necessity. For me, that’s my sister. For you, Husband-kun, it’s the Wife-san.”

Subaru: “Don’t put it like that, it makes me feel awkward...! So, may I ask you to show us the way?”

Flop: “By all means. I was the one who proposed the idea in the first place!”

He smacked his fist on his chest as he willingly accepted.

Having received his answer, Subaru pulled his will to lie down back into him with renewed vigor, and headed off to the next room with Flop in tow.

He knocked on the door and called out to Rem.

Subaru: “Is everything good on your end, Rem?”

Rem: “Yes, everything’s fine. Medium-san and I were just having a discussion on whose bed Louis-san should sleep...”

Subaru: “...I see.”

Rem: “You thought that we should put her to sleep on the floor just now, didn’t you?”

Subaru: “I didn’t say anything because you’d get mad at me...”

Considering how dangerous Louis was, he could not suggest letting her sleep on the same bed as Medium.

If he were allowed to speak his mind, Subaru would’ve opted to stay up all night to keep an eye on her, but given his current physical condition, he’d end up falling asleep within the first few hours after starting.

He had no choice but to put faith in her, seeing as she had done nothing worth being on guard for in the last ten days.

—Trusting an Archbishop would be just a stupid idea all around, though.

Subaru: “Remember that talk we had earlier? Yeah, I’m heading out for a bit with Flop-san. I’ll buy dinner on the way back, so let’s eat together.”

Rem: “I understand... Well, now that I think about it, there are lots of people around here now, so I don’t really have to rely on just you anymore.”

Subaru: “Why, of all times, did you have to say something like that now!? That just makes it harder for me to go out!”

Rem: “...Why indeed. I just said whatever came to mind.”

Even though Rem had just filled him with incredible reluctance, Subaru strived to prioritize his original goal.

He waved his hand to Medium, who was playing around with Louis, letting her pull on her hair,

Subaru: “Medium-san, please look after these two for me. If she bothers you too much, just hit her with everything you got.”

Medium: “Reallyyy~? My punches hurt lots and lots, y’know?”

Subaru: “Exactly. Sometimes pain’s a great teacher.”

That said, Rem would definitely step in should something go wrong.

Vexing as it were, Louis was helping Rem gain mental stability. He was thankful for that. Were she present with no purpose, he would surely be unable to find even a shred of justification to carry her around with them.

Flop: “What a tumultuous journey it must have been, Husband-kun.”

Once he had left Rem and Louis behind at the inn and stepped out onto the streets, Flop tapped his shoulder.

Being offered consolation like that had given rise to an urge to begin spewing complaints inside Subaru, but even if he had given in to it, it would only put Flop in a difficult position.

Especially with how he was indebted to him and Medium.

He wished to not pile anything else on top of them.

Subaru: “Relying on others might be one of my hundred-and-eight special moves, but even that has a limit.”

Flop: “Certainly, so long as you do not put your full weight on them, relying on others is not at all a bad thing. My sister and I are traveling together, so we make up for each other’s shortcomings. Otherwise, both of us would surely have perished long before. That too is the Imperial Way.”

Subaru: “The Imperial Way...”

As Flop waved around his hands, patting his own bangs once more, Subaru thought about the words he spoke of. The Imperial Way. They lay heavy on his chest.

Perhaps, that was the source of Subaru’s intangible fear— The difference in values of life.

In that sense, Flop’s trains of thought were easy to digest as they hit closer to home. His manner of being was definitely different from what Subaru had experienced so far in the Vollachian Empire, however.

Flop: “Not everyone can adopt a martial way of life. What is important is to come to terms with oneself within our own outlines of life.”

Subaru: “Come to terms with oneself, huh.”

Flop: “As I said a moment ago, if we were to look at Medium and myself as individuals on their own, our numerous weaknesses would be quite apparent. However, should we come together, we can cover up each other’s flaws, and they become quite trifling. In fact, one could say my sister and I have made it alive to the present day because of this, and that’d indeed be the whole truth.”

Subaru: “———”

Flop: “Always keep this in mind, Husband-kun. We, my sister and I, you and your Wife-san, we have all won all of life’s challenges so far only because we went at them head on— Do I seem like a man of the Empire more now?”

His cheeks loosened, Flop waited for praise.

Subaru stared hard at him, when he was hit with an epiphany. To make up for what one was lacking with the help of others; that was no different from his own values.

He had thought there would be none in the Empire with whom his ideals would be shared.

Subaru: “Not everything’s that hopeless, huh.”

Flop: “That said, when most of the Empire’s residents speak of the Imperial Way, they do indeed refer to brute strength! My ideals are laughed at. The flapping of a chicken’s wings, they call it! My way of thinking is by no means common.”

As Subaru came to his own conclusions, Flop once more reminded him to not be too trusting. However,

Flop: “That’s precisely why, putting a price on that skill also holds true. Like how I’m referring you to someone.”

Subaru: “Yup, thanks a bunch.”

Nodding, Subaru reaffirmed his gratitude for Flop’s referral.

On top of Flop’s help on getting past the security check and finding them an inn, he was thankful to Flop for the reason of this outing— A meeting with a referral that could help smooth out Subaru’s group’s journey by securing them a mode of transport and an escort.

Just like how Kuna and Holly had escorted them on their way to Guaral, they required a skilled bodyguard to protect them from the dangers of the road. Otherwise the journey would be difficult.

There was a limit to how much Subaru could travel by foot while carrying Rem on his back. Ideally he’d opt to acquire an ground dragon, but if that proved to be a difficult task, a Brave Ox or Large Canine would do. In any case, a riding beast was necessary for transport.

And for both of those, they had to get by with their limited funds.

Subaru: “That’s why, we’ve been seriously saved because Flop has someone in mind.”

Flop: “You say someone in mind, but I just know about the bar where someone with that occupation regularly visits. Now, if you’re talking about riding beasts, then we’ve got something to talk about— That’s right, like a Fallo cart!”

Subaru: “You’re really pushing Falos, aren’t you?”

Flop: "I'm not kidding when I say I grew up on Falo milk, 'cause I'm a Falo fan."

Laughing loudly, Flop strongly recommended Falos in a passionate tone.

Subaru did not know about the circumstances of travel for those who had large amounts of cargo, but at least for Subaru's group, who wanted to travel long distances, Falos were not a good match for them. Their speed was rather slow, and so, Falos would be their last resort.

Flop: "Anyhow, you should take any little precaution you can when on the road... Just between us, things at the Imperial Capital seem to be pretty rowdy at the moment. It's not guaranteed that those sparks won't spread."

Subaru: "—The Imperial Capital is rowdy."

Subaru's eyebrows twitched. However, Flop did not seem to notice his reaction and crossed his arms, replying with "That's right".

Flop: "The Empire's known to constantly have spots of smoldering embers somewhere all year round, but the possibility of an ember sparking and spreading is being feared right now. I didn't want to worry your wife, so I'm telling this only to you."

Subaru: "Thank you for the consideration... By the way, is that related to the Emperor or something in any way?"

Flop: "To the Emperor, Vincent Vollachia?"

Flop widened his eyes in surprise, as if he had heard something that one would never dream of. He then immediately shook his head saying "Nonono,"

Flop: "Something happening to His Excellency the Emperor is unheard of. Besides, His Excellency the Emperor has managed to settle the country's affairs so far, superbly so."

Subaru: "But you said those embers are still smoldering, didn't you?"

Flop: "The reason they stay as embers is due to the prowess of His Excellency the Emperor. His Excellency rose to the throne of the Emperor about seven or eight years ago. Before then, the Empire was in a much more chaotic state."

Subaru: “———”

Flop: “The Emperor himself is taking control of the situation regarding these current quarrels. I’m sure our homeland will return to its smoldering state very soon.”

Subaru: “Eh?”

Their homeland smoldering with embers, boasted Flop.

However, something Flop had asserted caught Subaru’s ears— How he said, that the Emperor himself was taking direct control of the situation.

Subaru: “The Emperor is trying to do something about the Imperial Capital’s troubles?”

Flop: “His own turf... Well, I guess if something happens very close to home, even the Emperor’d start taking action. Anyone who takes advantage of the situation will be spared no quarter, that kind of statement was issued.”

Subaru: “A statement from the Emperor...”

There did not seem to be any indication of a lie from Flop’s matter-of-fact explanation.

In any case, Flop would have absolutely no reason to try and deceive Subaru on the troubles going on inside the Imperial Capital. So at the very least, he spoke what was the truth for him.

Nevertheless, that was why Subaru’s ears had gotten hung up on it.

Subaru: “If Abel really is the Emperor, then he was the one that gave out that statement...?”

—No, it was strange considering the timing.

Of course, giving out an official statement did not necessitate the Emperor themselves to be present. A minister could have easily ghost written it, and deflect blame by saying “The secretary did it.” First and foremost, if he were to believe Abel’s words, the people remaining at the Emperor’s Palace were none other than the people who chased him out.

They would stomp on their respect towards the Emperor and would use his name and anything else for their under-handed tactics. Except—

Subaru: “Abel could just be a crazy dude. I’ll keep that in mind, just in case.”

To see and believe something as presented was a sure-fire way to a quick death on the stormy oceans.

Even if this place were the ocean, that did not mean it would always be stormy. Subaru just wanted to assert his conviction that he needed at least this kind of mindset to face the Empire.

Most of all, as a person who had confronted and talked to Abel himself, there was a part of him that thought that his intensity was not something a self-proclaimed Emperor could give out but—

Flop: “—Husband-kun, it’s no good to have a scowl on your face.”

Flop spoke as he circled in front of Subaru, mulling over his expression.

Pointing to his own forehead, Flop directed words at Subaru, who unconsciously stopped moving,

Flop: “Good fortune won’t come to anyone who doesn’t have the time to smile. You’re going to try and find companions for your journey now, aren’t you? Then, you need to find someone good.”

Subaru: “That’s...”

Flop: “If that’s the case, then erase those wrinkles on your brow and warm those cheeks up. That’s what we call the merits of a successful man.”

Flop rubbed his fingers in between his eyebrows and then proceeded to warm his face up with his hands.

Seeing Flop’s act, Subaru caught his breath. Next, he slowly loosened his brow and cheeks with his fingers as he was told.

Subaru: “Yeah, I forgot. The look on my face is already nasty so I should at least carry with me a light and gentle atmosphere, shouldn’t I?”

Flop: “Sorry! My ability can’t do anything about your looks!”

Subaru: “You don’t have to take it that seriously! It’s something I got from my parents so I actually don’t mind it as much as I say it!”

Flop’s lament was overdramatic, and so he responded in an overdramatic fashion as well. Maybe that was part of Flop’s concern for him and he was just trying to relax Subaru’s stiff nervousness.

Exchanging quips like that, Subaru and Flop approached the street to their destination.

What Flop pointed toward, was a hideout-like bar at the end of the alleyway.

Flop: “Were it a lot of people, you’d normally hire a bunch of guards, but since Husband-kun, the Wife-san and the Niece-chan only amount to three people, it’s not like you can say you’re a large family. After all, me and my sister can’t follow you out of Guaral!”

Subaru: “But, I got the feeling Medium-san’d stick with us if we played our cards right...”

Flop: “If my sister’s taken away, I can’t cover for my weaknesses, so I guess I’ll die!”

If one were to weigh trustworthiness and security on a scale, Flop and Medium were genuinely not a bad option. However, Subaru could not burden them more than he already had.

Subaru: “Hang on, worst-case scenario, we escape the country to Lugunica with the two of them in tow. And then, we could grant them the successful merchant life that Otto couldn’t achieve. That’s also a possibility...”

Flop: “Heyyy, Husband-kun? Are you alright?”

Flop waved his hand in front of the deep-in-thought Subaru, checking on his well-being.

Subaru scratched his head, replying to Flop with a “My bad”. It was just a thought, but he felt that it was not a bad proposal.

He felt bad that Flop had gone out of his way to show him the way here but—

Subaru: “Hey, Flop-san? Medium-san and you, there’s a favor I—”

It was at the moment he tried to say “want to ask of you two”.

???: “———”

—Somewhere, something faintly hard-sounding reverberated.



Flop: “—Husband-kun, it’s no good to have a scowl on your face.”

Subaru: “...Huh?”

Abruptly, his field of view shifted in a blink and Subaru’s mind went blank.

In front of Subaru, Flop was pointing at his own forehead. He was loosening the space in between his eyebrows by rubbing it with his fingers, and as if he were lecturing the frozen Subaru.

Flop: “Good fortune won’t come to anyone who doesn’t have the time to smile. You’re going to try and find companions for your journey now, aren’t you? Then, you need to find someone good.”

Subaru: “———”

Flop: “If that’s the case, then erase those wrinkles on your brow and warm those cheeks up. That’s what we call the merits of a successful man.”

Continuing on, Flop started warming his cheeks up with his hands.

That action was something Subaru recognized as one he had seen before. Of course he recognized it. Because, it had occurred a sparse few minutes ago.

It was an exchange that had happened a mere few minutes ago, and the same conversation was repeating.

Subaru: “Oi, hang on, wait a second...”

Subaru was suddenly assaulted by cold sweat and covered his face with his hands.

Seeing that, Flop loudly exclaimed “Don’t hide it, relax it!”. However, Subaru’s ability to reply to his words had vanished.

Looking around, he recognized the surrounding street too.

This was his first foray into this town's streets, and he was not well-acquainted with Guaral. Yet, his memory was not as faulty as to forget the scenery he had just witnessed.

Meaning—

Subaru: “—Did I Return by Death?”

In an inconspicuous situation, in which he did not know what exactly had happened to him, Subaru hardened his cheeks for a completely different reason from before, with that mutter escaping his lips.



Illustration from Volume 27, coloring by Floating ([source](#))

Arc 7 Chapter 17 - Looming Evil

Light Novel Adaptation found in Volume 27, Chapter 2 “Looming Evil”, Parts 3 (near start)-6

Original Web Novel Chapter — [Complete](#)

Original Translation by Witch Cult Translations (Negi, [Kobosuhito](#), [Taurace](#), [Polaris](#)) — [Complete](#)

Subaru: “———”

Reflecting upon the unbelievable truth, Subaru could feel his entire body awash with cold sweat.

As far as Subaru knew, this was one of the most terrifying situations he could be in.

A scenery he remembered, a conversation he had already heard before. This was not something like déjà vu.

This was not an event that he thought had happened before, it was an event he was actually reliving. The reason for that was only one—— He had Returned by Death.

Subaru: “But, why...?”

There was absolutely zero warning.

Particularly for Subaru, it felt like the world had switched out in a blink of an eye.

It felt so unreal to the point that it was enough to question whether the Authority he carried had activated by mistake. And that for some reason, the “Death” part of Return by Death had been dropped and only the “Return” part had activated.

Subaru: “Am I an idiot? No, I am definitely an idiot.”

Subaru disciplined himself as he attempted to look at this situation optimistically.

It was a stupid statement, but he had to trust Return by Death. The power to reverse time that Subaru held had never once been activated without death as a trigger.

By losing his life, Subaru would go back in time. That was a certainty.

Subaru: “—*Hai*¹¹, I’ll accept it. I’ve accepted it. Now, me, what do I do.”

Pushing his fist into his forehead, Subaru told his panicked self to be calm. Now that he accepted that he had Returned by Death, the next point to focus on was his cause of death. He thought back to the events that had occurred only a few dozen seconds ago.

Subaru: “...I can’t think of anything.”

However, even when reflecting back on the time he had met his demise, he could not recall anything.

He searched for the tiniest of clues in his memory, but turned up empty-handed.

The bar which was their destination; a talking Flop; the hustle and bustle of the main road getting quieter; the slight, unique smell of the shade in the alleyway; a faint, hard sound— that was all he could scrounge up.

None of them were linked to the reason as to why Subaru’s life was in danger.

Subaru: “Fuck, why am I always like this...!”

If Subaru had been watchful regarding changes in his surroundings, he would not be exposed to this misery. He detested and cursed his own carelessness.

However, the logical part of him understood that that was an impossible demand and turned an unamused eye towards himself.

He was not a security camera. It was impossible to stay alert of his surroundings twenty-four-seven. He was not a genius that could take in the small changes in his environment and be able to form a plan to deal with them immediately.

¹¹ English flip. Basically the Japanese way of saying “okay/alright”, the original was quite literally “OK”.

Natsuki Subaru was undoubtedly an ordinary person.

That was the unchanging assessment he had given himself, even after experiencing his memories vicariously from the eyes of an outsider and seeing himself in a new light.

That was why he could not stop thinking and moving forward.

Subaru: “—The situation is similar to when Shaula first killed me.”

Along the path to Pleiades Watchtower, Subaru’s group, who was challenging the sand wind at the Augria Sand Dunes, had been annihilated by Shaula, who was guarding the area from the Watchtower to the sand sea.

The sand sea’s rite of passage had begun with a white light that could not be reacted to. It was that first strike which blew Subaru away and started the infernal fight afterwards.

What had occurred, what was the cause of death. The situation where it was uncertain if he had died or not could be said to be a mercy bestowed by his first death at the sand sea.

However, unlike then, he was currently in the middle of a town.

The environment was fundamentally different from the sand sea where he had the conviction to face the various dangers to his life.

Subaru: “What’s going to take my life in this situation...?”

A death with no forewarning. The only thing he could think of that fit the bill was still Shaula’s snipe, as it left a strong impression.

That was why he may have been shot this time too. Subaru had died inside the alleyway— although they were not tall, the surrounding buildings sandwiched them and created a space with poor visibility.

If one were to shoot here, they could only do it from the front or back, but this was not the most ideal place for shooting, was what he thought. Of course, since Subaru did not know how accurate his memory was, the possibility that this position actually allowed an ideal line of sight was—

Flop: “—Husband-kun? Why is your brow more wrinkled than before?”

Subaru: “Ah...”

Flop: “Weren’t you listening to my advice? Your fortune will run away if you don’t erase those wrinkles! To chase something that’s run away is an arduous task! ‘Cause I’m usually on an ox cart!”

Hitting his hand on his chest, Flop exaggeratedly gestured in front of Subaru.

Sensing that this overaction of his had the purpose of cheering up Subaru’s grimacing face, Subaru could not help but freeze up at his actions.

To find his cause of death, he would have to investigate the suspect that was travelling with him at the time too.

In the case that Subaru’s cause of death was not by shooting, the most likely culprit was Flop—the person who was travelling with him, and the person that was nearest to him.

However, at Subaru’s time of death, Flop had been within his field of vision and there was no sign that Flop had taken action to attack him.

Needless to say, Subaru knew that in this world, there was a plethora of attacks that could reap his life in a single strike without him noticing at all. Nevertheless, Flop did not seem like someone who could do that. First of all—

Subaru: “Does Flop-san have a reason to kill me?”

The most likely possibility was that he had faked goodwill and was trying to mug Subaru. However, Subaru thought that doing so, purposefully, in the middle of a town, was a poor decision.

They had met the O’Connell siblings for the first time at the queue outside the gate.

If they wanted to do their deed without detection, all they had to do was to deceive and invite them somewhere outside the gate. All could be done before entering Guaral, a place with guards. Even if their objective was the money they could get by selling the Witchbeast’s horn, in the end, the reason Subaru had not been cheated out when selling it had been due to none other than Flop’s help— There was no reason to trap Subaru.

All they needed was to trick Subaru outside and steal the horn, and sell it once they got inside the city.

There was no logical explanation for their motive.

Quite a lot of people had killed Subaru until now, but they all possessed a rational explanation for doing so. Excluding Witchbeasts where communication was non-existent, that was a solid rule.

That was why—

Subaru: “Flop-san? Why are you so nice to us?”

Flop: “Hm? That’s a sudden question.”

Subaru: “Yeah, sorry about that. Just, I got a bit worried.”

Flop raised his nicely-shaped eyebrows in surprise at Subaru’s abrupt question.

Faking a chuckle at this reaction, Subaru held his breath, waiting for Flop’s response— Logically, he did not doubt Flop. All that was left was whether he could believe him or not.

Flop, who acted cordially and had performed various deeds to help them out.

Subaru sought peace of mind, to believe that Flop and his sister Medium were not two-faced and that they could be trusted.

Flop: “—Hmm.”

Subaru did not know if his eyes betrayed his true feelings, but Flop narrowed his handsome eyes as if he could see those emotions.

The expression he told Subaru to adopt before, a look overflowing with confidence and carefreeness yet devoid of any grounds for that, disappeared from his face, and was instead replaced with the face of an intellectual gentleman.

And then he shook his head at the frozen Subaru,

Flop: “It’s not a complex thing. It’s simple. What my sister and I are doing by being good to Husband-kun and Wife-san and Niece-chan is...”

Subaru: “Is?”

Flop: “—Is revenge!”

Subaru: “...Eh?”

Raising his hands, Flop proclaimed that out loud.

The strong and merry tone used, and the disturbing contents of the proclamation clashed with each other so much that, for one moment, Subaru could not take it in. Shocked, his eyes went wide.

In front of the stiff Subaru, Flop brushed his fringe, and said “Listen, okay?”,

Flop: “Long ago, my sister and I were living on the edge of life and death! Thrown away by our parents, we grew up in a home that adopts orphans... That place was pretty terrible!”

Subaru: “A home for orphans...”

At the back of Subaru’s mind, an image of a home vaguely resembling an orphanage came up.

However, it was not difficult to imagine that the facilities and equipment of this world’s orphanages were much different than the modern buildings Subaru was thinking of.

That terrible environment was probably something far worse than he could imagine.

While revealing to Subaru the kind of environment he had grown up in, Flop gestured.

Flop: “Every night, huddling with the other kids in the same boat as us, I decided in my heart to escape from that situation. And then, my sister and I got the chance, and were able to escape from there. For the first time ever, living through a night without being beat up, I vowed— Revenge, that is.”

Subaru: “Revenge as in... against the people at the home for orphans?”

Flop: “No, not them— At the world.”

Having the same expression as before when proclaiming revenge, Flop hardened his fists.

Towards the intimidated Subaru, Flop put his passionate face upfront and,

Flop: “My sister and I grew up being beaten by the adults at that place. But, were the adults that punched us happy while they were punching me? No, they weren’t. They were unhappy too. Unhappy adults were beating unhappy children. Is this kind of hopeless situation even real?”

Subaru: “———”

Flop: “Even adults who choose violence are unhappy. So I became a merchant to lift me and my sister out of misfortune. And as much as I could, we would bring others out of unhappiness as well. Just like how on that night, those people brought us out of it.”

Subaru: “That’s your revenge against the world?”

Flop: “That’s right. Me and my sister are resisting against the world which pushes misfortune onto us for revenge. Helping you and your Wife-san is also a part of that.”

After declaring that, Flop scratched his nose in slight embarrassment.

Receiving the fire in his words and actions, Subaru lost the ability to speak. The heat from that fire slowly seeped into his brain, and there, he came to a snap decision.

Subaru: “Thank you, Flop-san. I’m glad I met you siblings, Flop-san and Medium-san, at the queue.”

Whether he could believe them or not, he wished for a response that would point to the answer of that question.

And, the response he had received was far more than he expected. And so it was decided.

Subaru would not doubt Flop O’Connell’s goodwill.

He decided he would trust it to the end, his noble, vengeful heart which had decided to resist against the unfairness of the world.

Meaning, all that was left was to——

Subaru: “Flop-san, this street isn’t really giving off a good Keh¹² in the Feng Shui way. So is it alright if we could use a different path?”

Flop: “Keh? What is Keh? Actually, is that the reason for the wrinkles in your brow and your eyes?”

Subaru: “It’s more like a fortune-telling *mono*¹³ for good omens. It’s got nothing to do with my eyes! I think! But yeah, this street’s no good. I don’t mind if we go the long way, so please?”

Depending on Flop’s goodwill, Subaru forcefully advanced the conversation.

Deciding that Flop was not the culprit, the next thing to do was to avoid the incoming death. Whether it was a ranged snipe or not, it was no mistake that this was an attack.

If he were able to avoid the attack’s condition for occurrence, that would result in him being able to avoid this death.

To do that, first, it was crucial that he did not follow the same actions as he did before.

Changing paths, delaying the timings, he would avoid the disaster that would occur to him before it happened.

If he could do that, he should be able to dodge the unwanted death.

Subaru: “Well to begin with, I’ve never wanted to die in the first... Well, only once or twice.”

And in addition to that, it was an unavoidable option due to the imminent state of affairs.

When cornered in a situation where the only way to save someone was to die, in those times Subaru had chosen death. Yes, Subaru also desired revenge on the world.

Flop: “I don’t know about that Keh thing but I like your earnest expression. It’ll be a bit of a detour, but why don’t we take a different path?”

¹² Translation Note by Witch Cult Translations: “卦 (read Keh, like the start of Ketchup) is an ancient Chinese hexagram used for divination. So, Subaru is saying the street is not giving off good omens/fortune after using Keh. For more information, see [here](#), [here](#), and [here](#).”

¹³ English flip. Means “object/item” (物), originally “アイテム” (item).

Subaru: “That’d be a great help! Let’s go to a main street with as many people as possible.”

Flop: “Gotcha.”

Fortunately, Flop listened to Subaru’s unnatural suggestion without opposition.

Following his lead, the plan for which way to go to the bar was changed. They turned back from the path they would have continued on and took a route to the tavern that would go through the main street, with minimal alleys.

Ultimately, if they passed through the line of fire before the tavern, it was possible that it still would not change the fact someone was after Subaru. However, if he knew the attack were to happen in the alleys in front of the tavern, there would be many ways to deal with it.

In the worst case, there was also the possibility his opponent might withdraw upon witnessing Subaru’s vigilant look—

Flop: “Well then Husband-kun, this way—”

Passing by Subaru’s side, Flop began leading him down a different road.

It was in that instant— By accident Flop looked over Subaru’s shoulder, and his eyes widened as if he had just noticed something.

Subaru: “—Ohh.”

What, he attempted to ascertain from Flop’s response, but that was not realized.

The reason being that, instead of a question coming from Subaru’s mouth, his mouth had opened fully to spit out the blood it was teeming with.

Subaru: “Ah, uh!?”

It was a feat of a single moment.

Subaru felt something seize the back of his head, forcing him to look up. Then, a hot sensation passed over his bare throat, and blood burst forth.

Drowning in the overflowing blood and pain, Subaru understood his throat had been cut open.

Subaru: “Guh... Uh.”

Both hands pressed to the wound on his neck, amidst the intense pain and blood loss, Subaru sought for a breakthrough solution.

The wound was deep and wide, cutting through major blood vessels, blood gushing out. He would take off his outer garment and wrap it around his neck to halt the bleeding— No, the first priority here had to be to get away from the enemy behind him.

Moreover, Flop was right there. He was wrong to have doubted him. Afterwards he would have faith in him, he might not be forgiven, but right here, was Flop.

Subaru: “Ah, nghh...”

Rem was at the inn. One way or another, even with blood flowing from his neck, he had to make it back to her.

Go back, take her away, it's not safe, withdraw. Even if she hated him, drag her away. For Rem to live. She had to live. For that, the neck's bleeding, stop it.

The blood, the blood, bloodbloodbloodbloodblood, the blood, stop, stop it, stopstopstopstoouooo—

Subaru: “—Uh.”

op.



Flop: “—Husband-kun, it’s no good to have a scowl on your face.”

Subaru: “_____”

Flop: “Good fortune won’t come to anyone who doesn’t have the time to smile. You’re going to try and find companions for your journey now, aren’t you? Then, you need to find someone good.”

In front, Flop emphasized his point while grinding his finger against his own brow.

While watching that man's gesture, Subaru promptly put both his hands to his own neck. He did not feel that hot sensation or the heat of life flowing out. The feeling of blood gushing forth with every heartbeat.

Of his own life pouring out, the pulsation of despair approaching Death.

Flop: "If that's the case, then erase those wrinkles on your brow... What's the matter, Husband-kun, your face's gone pale."

Seeing Subaru keep silent, Flop looked surprised and became concerned.

Despite that earnest gaze of his, just before Subaru, he was reminded of the moment his throat had been slashed open.

Right, his throat had been cut.

His throat was cut, blood spurted out, his instincts sounded the alarm that he had to get away, however, even if he could not hear those alarm bells, he came back to that moment.

In other words, he had died. He had once again Returned by Death.

In addition to that, this time was different with instant death from the outset. More explicit, in the form of hostility.

Subaru: "...Bwahh."

With his hands on his throat, Subaru had forgotten to breathe, which he remembered in a hurry. Subaru raised his shoulders up and down with deep breaths, Flop touched his shoulder and asked if he was alright, but Subaru had no room to respond.

However, he could not stay here either.

Subaru: "Haa, Flop-san, today, it's, a terrible day for Feng Shui. Let's return at once...!"

Flop: "*Fuusooley*? Although, considering that pallor to rest a bit would be..."

Subaru: "No, resting would be a waste of time! This is a fit that won't stop until Rem holds my hand!"

Flop: “I-is that right... What an affliction that is!”

With a sense of uneasiness and urgency burning in his heart, he had blurted out nonsense, but the good-natured Flop gave more importance to the atmosphere than the content of words.

The hand that had grasped his shoulder was grabbed in turn, and Flop nodded in surprise. Pulling on that hand of Flop’s, Subaru hesitated as to whether to head forward or back.

If they went forward they would be on route, but if they went back they would go by the place in which he’d had his throat slit.

He felt he was at an impasse where whichever way they went his life would be in danger, so rather than forward or backward, he would return to the main street via some other alleyway.

He had failed before, but his opponent would try not to kill them— No, kill Subaru, somewhere in the public eye. If he was going to alert his opponent, getting to the main road was imperative.

Flop: “Husband-kun! Your hand is super cold! We should get your wife to warm them up soon!”

Subaru: “Ahh, as soon as possible, I want to see Rem’s face.”

As a result, he did not care about the abuse he would face for returning without accomplishing his goal.

At any rate, to that place with Rem—

Subaru: “—No.”

Can I go back? The question swirled in Subaru’s mind.

In a situation where he had not yet grasped his enemy’s true nature, he thought about the danger of going back to Rem. He was unaware of when his opponent had begun targeting him, but if they returned to the inn, he may be kindly revealing the location to his foe.

Subaru: “———”

Cursing his lack of thought, Subaru bit his lip and at the same time, his field of vision opened.

Exiting the alleyway, Subaru and Flop had made it to the main streets of the city. On the right and the left, the number of people coming and going could not be compared to a metropolis, but it was a hell of a lot better than the alleyways with their hideout-like taverns.

Nonetheless, it would take some nerve to dive into the crowd of people. To avoid that, he would have to decide on a guideline for their next course of action.

Flop: "If we're on this street here, that means the inn should be over there. So then, this way..."

Subaru: "That's no good, Flop-san! We can't go back to the inn. To see Rem, such a thing would be inexcusable!"

Flop: "Isn't that different from what you just said?!"

His conduct ended up being that of an emotionally unstable person, but his anxiety from before made it so he was incapable of returning to Rem's side. That being said, it was also ungrateful to keep manipulating Flop without giving him any information.

But, what could he say to make him understand?

He was not an associate of the Emilia Camp, nor a long-time traveling companion like Anastasia or Julius. He had no powers of persuasion or grounds to make him take Subaru's opinion seriously.

Even for this, it would be asking too much to pin his hopes on Flop's innate goodness.

Subaru: "Damnit...!"

To break the deadlock of the situation, currently Subaru's hand was sorely lacking.

He was separated from his precious Rem, and was being hunted down in a strange town. He was with the virtuous Flop, but he lacked fighting strength. Subaru himself had no strong point to show.

Without knowing who was attacking him, he did not know who to be wary of.

Subaru: "No way, the hunter...!?"

When he defined his opponent as an invisible assassin, the first possibility that came to Subaru's mind was the Hunter.

They were a dangerous person who had killed Subaru once in the Buddheim Jungle, and after that as well, they had aimed at him while he was with Rem on one occasion. Ultimately, he had not run into them even once since then, but what if they were still meticulously continuing to hunt Subaru?

In the Buddheim Jungle, the military encampment, and the Shudraqian village, there had always been someone acting with Subaru. To avoid a set up with combat-ready opponents, they may have changed their timing until Subaru was with the powerless Flop.

Subaru: "If that's how it is, it's like you have the tenacity of a bear robbed of its prey. Why go this far to aim at me? What about me is the reason for..."

Flop: "Husband-kun? You alright? What are you so worried about? If there's something I can help you with, you can try talking to me first. You're acting strange."

Subaru: "Flop-san..."

While Subaru was looking left and right down the street and losing his nerve, Flop called out to him in that voice.

Directly across from him Flop seized both his shoulders, his earnest gaze and offer made Subaru want to depend on him, and Subaru seriously considered if he should try gambling on his innate goodness.

If it was Flop, he might have the faith to believe in Subaru and lend him a hand.

Subaru: "Flop-san, sorry to keep relying on you, but can I ask you something?"

Flop: "Ah, of course, certainly! Whatever it is, even if I can't help, my sister might be able to. After all, my sister and I have the kind of bond where we can cover for each other's weak points, you know."

Subaru: "In truth, between the two of you this might be a matter for Medium-san though..."

If his opponent violently struck without mercy, there may be no choice but to respond with greater force. Medium's strength was much greater than Subaru's or Flop's.

With that in mind, Subaru would try to explain the situation to Flop. Firstly, he would have to hide the matter of Return by Death, and explain that someone was relentlessly targeting him.

Subaru: “Actually, someone is presently...”

Flop: “—What the?”

Subaru: “Huh?”

His mind made up, while being careful not to trigger the penalty of mentioning Return by Death, Subaru was going to try to explain the circumstances to Flop.

However, just as he was about to speak, Flop’s gaze turned toward the wrong direction. He raised his well-shaped brows and squinted in the direction of the street.

By his reaction he seemed to have noticed something, and Subaru belatedly became aware of the same thing.

Subaru: “—Hk.”

A long way off, someone was screaming.

And it was not just one person, several people shouted in shrieks and angry roars. Then the voices gradually increased in urgency, and sounds that differed from screams multiplied—

Flop: “Wha—!?”

Eyes wide, Flop’s throat closed, and Subaru also turned in the same direction.

Immediately, witnessing what Flop had, the same scene before his eyes also left Subaru at a loss for words.

—A giant wheel was headed right for Flop and Subaru.

Flop: “Husband-kun, watch ou—”

Flop’s voice was cut off too early, the impact engulfed Subaru’s entire body with its intensity. His body was totally blown away, it hit the hard ground and tumbled many times.

The momentum did not stop, and he crashed into a wall. But that was not the end— Back-to-back, another successive impact hit the collapsed Subaru, and once more his body was blown away.

Subaru: “—Ah, guh.”

Having been sent somersaulting and tumbling, Subaru’s field of vision was dyed black as his body hit the ground.

It was not as if the sky had suddenly been covered in clouds. It was something else, his field of view had been destroyed for a different reason. The cause he did not know, and even if he found out what it was, nothing good would come out of it.

However, if there was something he could say—

Subaru: “D-dea...”

Death, that was something every cell in his whole body had been proclaiming towards Subaru’s instinct.

Up until this point, as someone who had experienced Death over thirty times, Subaru was somewhat conscious of just how much damage his body was able to withstand before he lost his life.

This time, it was clearly over the limit it could endure.

Subaru: “———”

A festering pain.

Yet, that was something on a whole other level compared to merely localized pain. This aching assaulted his entire body. The existence named Subaru was synchronized with the phenomenon called pain.

This was not mere localized pain. Natsuki Subaru was precisely Pain itself. Pain was what he was, and therefore it was only natural to be in pain. Anywhere and everywhere hurt. The pain did not disappear.

From a distance rang a sound like that of tinnitus or similar to the whistle of a train, reverberating inside his head.

Amidst that, the sounds which can be heard were, the joys and sorrows of the people hurled into a maelstrom— Nay, there wasn't any joy. It was more fitting to call it a pandemonium. Pandemonium, hah. What a word.

Contrary to the echo of sounds, the events that unfolded were overwhelmingly grave.

Subaru: "Ahii, ouh, ah..."

He could not produce any syllables.

The mouth that attempted to enunciate words was in tatters. Without any teeth remaining, it had decent ventilation. Somewhere had been ripped apart and air was leaking through it. There was blood, sound, and pain.

Something, something, something—

Subaru: "Ohh, ah."

Something had murdered Natsuki Subaru again.



Flop: "—Husband-kun, it's no good to have a scowl on your face."

Subaru: "———"

Flop: "Good fortune won't come to anyone who doesn't have the time to smile. You're going to try and find companions for your journey now, aren't you? Then, you need to find someone good."

Putting his finger in between his eyebrows, Flop rubbed the skin and flesh to relax them.

Watching the man's performance unfold in front of his eyes, Subaru hugged his own two shoulders. Then, he recalled his mouth which air no longer escaped from, as well as the pain that had vanished.

—It can't be, I died again.

Subaru: “Moreover... this time, it was... a dragon carriage, was it...?”

Pulverized by the impact, sent flying and rendered immobile, the candle of life thinned and vanished.

While dominated by the pain proclaimed by every inch of his body, Subaru had been killed. He had lost his life.

Subaru: “———”

Clattering, the shoulders in his own grip trembled, and his knees began to shudder.

Even if his body did not recall the disaster that had befallen it, his soul remembered. The impact and pain inflicted upon his whole body as if tearing it to pieces, even if it no longer remained, still gnawed at his soul.

At last, Subaru could not conceal his fear towards the looming evil that befell upon him.

First time was instant-death, the second was being beheaded, the third was being run over by a dragon carriage— It could no longer be just a mere coincidence. No doubt, the aim was to kill Natsuki Subaru.

It had killed Subaru mercilessly. The most frightening thing of it all was that, despite Return by Death having been triggered thrice, Subaru had obtained no further information other than the fact an enemy existed.

The opponent would not leave behind any information for the lifeless Subaru.

Flop: “If that’s the case, then erase those wrinkles on your brow... What’s wrong, Husband-kun? You don’t look so well.”

Subaru: “Flop, -san...”

Once again, Flop had shown concern towards Subaru, the latter’s facial expression having changed.

Earlier, the chaos on the main street was most likely the result of the dragon carriage going berserk. Then, in the instant before the collision, Flop had extended his hand in an attempt to save Subaru.

Not making it on time, Subaru had received the deadly impact head on, and it was unthinkable that Flop, nearby as he was, would have gotten off scratch free—— He would have been dragged into the collateral damages as well.

Subaru: “In the first place, up until now...”

The enemy would not necessarily retreat in content after killing Subaru.

Flop had been there at the scene, and had witnessed the occurrences on both the first and second time. If the opponent was someone of caution, it would be natural for them to seal Flop’s mouth, as he was a witness.

Would it not mean that, up until now, Subaru’s death would be accompanied by Flop’s murder?

Would it not mean that Flop had already been dragged into the situation Subaru was put in?

“I won’t allow that”, thought Subaru as he gritted the back of his teeth.

Subaru: “——Hk! Flop-san!”

Flop: “W-what!?”

Killing any cowardice by gritting the back of his teeth, Subaru faced forward courageously.

Next, with that enthusiasm Subaru grabbed Flop by the hand, catching him by surprise. However, he did not have the leisure to take Flop’s bewilderment into account.

Considering what had happened so far, the countdown to death had already begun.

A situation of dead-end times three, where moving forward meant hell, heading back meant hell, going around still meant hell.

Even then, he must search for the path towards survival—— not just for Subaru and Rem, but also for the kind older brother who had helped them and return him to his sister’s side. That was why——

Subaru: “Flop-san, let’s run!”

Flop: “That’s sudden!? What happened!?”

Subaru: “There’s no hows or whats, life is finite! We can’t waste even a second, right?!”

It would be a bad move to stop here and earnestly try to persuade the other.

Subaru made such a judgement, same as previous times, he would use forceful reasoning to destroy Flop’s resistance. Sure enough, swallowed up by the momentum, Flop just nodded in agreement and voiced, “That’s true!”.

Flop: “Life is short. For the sake of achieving my sister and I’s goal, although time should indeed be treasured...”

Subaru: “Let’s run! Run towards the bar immediately! The trivial matters can be discussed later!”

Flop: “U-understood! I understand already, so stop dragging me! My bangs will get messed up!”

Forcefully dragged away by his arm, Flop cried out as he stumbled over his feet.

Listening to Flop’s shriek-like voice, Subaru advanced toward the road he once took—with the same goal of getting a bodyguard, he hurried toward the bar.

However, the goal was not to get a bodyguard for the sake of their travels.

For the salvation from this series of unavoidable Deaths, for the sake of obtaining the necessary help as soon as possible, they ran.



???: “—You wanna hire the strongest one here?”

The barkeep they finally found raised his eyebrows in response to Subaru’s ragged breath inquiry.

The middle-aged barkeep, whose hair had started to gray, stared at the panting Subaru from top to bottom with somewhat skeptical eyes.

With his demeanor and his age, Subaru too realized that he was lacking in persuasiveness. Moreover, he had barged into the bar, and suddenly brought up a question like that.

You could even say he had been generous enough to not immediately jump to the conclusion that Subaru was messing with him.

Currently, Subaru and Flop are inside the bar which was their original destination.

At first Subaru had been killed instantly by some unknown method in the alleyway within the immediate vicinity of the bar. That in of itself had been unsettling, but perhaps because rushing things turned out to be effective, the clutches of the devil that would have stopped Subaru and Flop who instead hurriedly hastened toward the bar had not made their appearance.

However, it would be premature to assume that they had escaped from danger on the basis of that argument.

Subaru: "That's why, I have to borrow the strength of the strongest one here."

Barkeeper: "...If we're talking about the strongest one here, that'd probably be Rowan."

The barkeep shrugged his shoulders at Subaru, who had asked again while gathering his breath. Then, he proceeded to look at the other person besides Subaru, Flop, who was also out of breath.

Barkeeper: "Flop, here I thought you haven't shown your face around in a while, and here you are helping someone again huh. Even though you won't get a single penny out of it anyways."

Flop: "Hey now, I'm just doing whatever kind of deals I want to partake in. Those whom I partake in deals with aren't limited to just people. At times, I take on unfavorable deals against the world itself."

Barkeeper: "I'm saying there's no profit in doing that, you softy."

Perhaps because the barkeeper had been on quite familiar terms with him, he commented on Flop's actions with a speechless tone.

Despite hearing directly from Flop why he had helped Subaru's group, it seemed his kind nature was a well-known fact to someone who knew him beforehand.

While the barkeeper polished a glass cup, he shot a sharp glance towards Subaru,

Barkeeper: “He’s a real softy like you’ve heard. But, don’t you get the wrong idea here. This dumbass and his sister are softies that will help anyone regardless of who they might be, in turn, there are a lot of people that are indebted to them.”

Subaru: “...I don’t have any intention of being an ungrateful bastard either, I’ll pamper him back just as much as I have been pampered.”

Flop: “Hahaha, I shall look forward to that! The day I’m going to be pampered that is!”

While fixing his bangs with a comb he took out of his pocket, Flop returned a candid response.

Feeling saved by Flop’s kindness and magnanimity, Subaru turned towards the inside of the bar, and asked “Which one is Rowan?”.

Barkeeper: “Ahh, Rowan’s passed out over there at the uh, corner over there.”

Subaru: “Passed out at a corner...? That doesn’t sound like good news.”

While saying so, Subaru looked nervously at the direction the barkeeper pointed at. Upon which, within the dim bar, and amongst several men that chattered drunkenly, he found a man who was slumped over at a table in the corner.

It was a man in his fifties, his long and disheveled hair tied up sloppily, along with his weapon of choice—a katana sheathed by the waist.

The table he had slumped over on was lined with several empty glasses; one can tell he really knocked himself out in every sense of the word before the sun had even set.

Subaru: “...That’s the strongest, you say?”

Barkeeper: “There’s no doubt he’s got a terrible drinking habit but, he’s a master of his trade. Though he’s got a terrible drinking habit.”

Subaru: “You mentioning that about him twice only makes me even more worried.”

Subaru received the barkeeper’s warning about him having a bad drinking habit, two times consecutively.

Though he had been considered as quite the drunkard, beggars couldn't be choosers. Right now, what was most important was not his personal conduct or the toughness of his liver, but his prowess in combat.

That of the person who possessed the ability to save the desperate Subaru from his impending doom.

Subaru: "Hey, Rowan-san, could you hear me out for a bit?"

Rowen: "Ngah?"

Subaru steeled his resolve and headed towards the table Rowan passed out on along with Flop. As he spoke to the collapsed man while shaking him by his shoulders, Rowan responded in a stupefied voice and raised his head.

Face flushed completely red paired with a sleepy gaze, as well as facial features that would have been rather discernable if it weren't ruined by a reddened nose.

Rowan: "What's up, bro. Whaddya want from me...?"

Subaru: "This dude's wasted... Anyways, listen to me. I have a job for... You reek!!"

Rowan: "Oioi, ain't'cha a rude one..."

After getting up wobbly, Rowan exhaled a drawn-out breath which Subaru had to turn his face away from.

As the dreadful stench of alcohol wafted, it even created an illusion that his vision had somehow been warped. It was not something as simple as drinking during the day. There should be a limit to how heavy of an alcoholic a person was.

Subaru: "Come to think of it, because there isn't anyone I already know to be a heavy drinker, this is my first time dealing with this type... Roswaal and Otto too would only drink in moderation..."

The people in the Emilia Camp who habitually drank alcohol were Roswaal and Otto. Ram and Frederica would drink too, but only if invited. Besides them, nobody else drank.

Subaru was also apparently of drinking age in this other world, but he had more or less gone until now without feeling the need to drink.



Illustration from Volume 27, coloring by goatmanfatsuki ([source](#))

Subaru: “So honestly, I don’t really have a good impression of drunks but... Hey, this guy’s really the best one here right!? I’m not playing around here.”

Barkeeper: “What a coincidence. I don’t have this place open to play around either. There’s no mistake, it’s him.”

Subaru: “Shit, you’re serious...”

Receiving the barkeeper’s reassurance, Subaru turned back to Rowan with a bitter look.

Rowan was sitting sloppily in his chair and shaking an empty glass upside-down above his head, desperately trying to taste any droplets of alcohol left with his tongue.

Rowan: “Tsk, ain’t enough booze. Oi, ya bros, treat me to a drink why don’t’cha.”

Flop: “Hm, you want a drink? Okay. Barkeep, A drink for him...”

Subaru: “Wait a sec, wait a sec, Flop-san! I really shouldn’t be saying this since I’ve been saved by your kindness but just for a little bit, keep your good will in your wallet!”

Shutting down Flop, who was about to treat someone just because they requested it, Subaru positioned himself in front of a displeased-looking Rowan. Then, he placed his hands on the table with force,

Subaru: “Rowan-san, let’s get straight to the point. We won’t be treating you to a drink. But, I can pay you the money you need to buy drinks. I want you to take a job.”

Rowan: “Ahhn, a job...?”

Subaru: “That’s right. I’d like you to be an escort. And also, starting right this very second.”

Getting close to the stink of alcohol, Subaru boldly laid out those conditions.

Hearing his talk, Rowan stared back at Subaru with sleepy eyes.

Rowan: “...Yer tone’s pretty panicked. Ya bros are in quite a dangerous situation, aren’t’cha?”

Subaru: “Yeah, it’s no laughing matter. What do you think? The amount I can pay, this is my limit.”

Flop: “Husband-kun, that’s...”

Widening his eyes in surprise, Flop attempted to stop Subaru’s action. However, Subaru halted Flop, who was trying to restrain him, instead and assertively put on the table a bag—the bag which contained all of the money he got after selling the Witchbeast’s horn.

As a precaution, he had not split and pass some amount to Rem.

This was genuinely everything Subaru’s group had on hand. There was no more money that he could pay beyond this.

Rowan: “Woah, woah, this is...”

Subaru: “This is everything I can pay with. What do you think? Will you take it?”

Rowan: “———”

Opening the mouth of the bag, Rowan went silent as he confirmed the contents with a quick glance. His face was still red but the drunken look in his eyes from before was now gone, a look of serious scrutiny replacing it.

Of course, an escort that could be hired at a bar—to show someone like Rowan, who worked as a knock-off mercenary, all of the funds that Subaru walked around with was a fairly large gamble.

Having crossed national borders, Subaru was not well-informed on the value of goods in the Empire. However, he felt that the value of currency was not so different from the Kingdom of Lugunica.

With the money Subaru had offered up, one could easily live a year just monkeying around.

Rowan: “My skills are first rate... I thought of saying that but, this amount upfront...”¹⁴

Subaru: “I’ll say this now, but I can’t negotiate any increase in payment.”

¹⁴ Translation note by Witch Cult Translations: “Rowan refers to himself using 某 (read «soregashi» or «nanigashi»), which is an archaic pronoun samurais used to refer to themselves. It’s difficult to preserve that in English because of the lack of variety in pronouns in English compared to Japanese so hopefully this explanation will do. As an example, «某の腕は高い» becomes «My skills are first rate.».

Rowan: “I ain’t doubting ya. Ya’ve said y’ain’t playing around, it seems you’re serious about it.”

Scratching his scarlet-turned nose with his finger, Rowan slowly stood up on the spot. He picked up the money bag Subaru had handed out and carefully kept it in his pocket.

Rowan: “I ain’t givin’ this back even if ya tell me to give it back.”

Subaru: “It’s a shame, but I won’t tell you to return it. If you do your job right.”

Rowan: “Puhah.”

A breath reeking of alcohol being let out by his laugh, Rowan accepted Subaru’s job.

Hearing his answer, the tension in Subaru’s shoulders, present for all this time, faded away. His nervousness would not go away and uncertainty endlessly circled his insides but—

Flop: “Husband-kun, was that alright? That money was...”

Subaru: “It’s fine. It’s nothing if it means we’re safe now. I’m sorry for scaring Flop like that, and also thank you for introducing me to this place.”

Flop: “—If you say it’s okay then I’m okay too. Thankfully, we paid for the inn in advance!”

In terms of the accommodation bill, Subaru had already paid for it, including Flop and Medium’s part, who they shared rooms with, under Subaru’s group’s name.

It seemed like he avoided the dishonor of passing the bill off to them by not thinking ahead when hiring Rowan.

Rowan: “So, employer. How shall I address ya?”

Subaru: “Ohh, right. My bad. I was in a rush. My name is—”

Rowan: “—Wait.”

Asked about his name, Subaru panicked as he thought he disrespected Rowan. And as he was about to name himself, Rowan stopped him.

He thrust his hand in front of Subaru's face and directed his sharp gaze behind Subaru— towards the bar's windows.

Subaru: "Ro...wan?"

Rowan: "...It's a weird feeling. Say bro, you were tailed weren't'cha?"

Subaru: "—Uh."

Rowan's low and quiet voice made Subaru swallow his breath.

Beside him, Flop, confused, said "What does that mean?", but Subaru had a general idea on the presence Rowan had detected.

It was not a what-if scenario, it was definite. The weird feeling Rowan had gotten was the being that tailed Subaru; the enemy that had attacked Subaru in the alleyway.

The enemy who had killed Subaru three times had not given up on Subaru this time as well.

Flop: "Just who are you being chased by?"

Subaru: "...I'm not kidding when I say this, but I don't know. I just thought that if we stayed outside, they would come after us. That's why I hired you."

Rowan: "I see. They shoulda picked a better fight."

It was a situation where they had nothing to work with, yet Rowan said that in a joking manner.

However, even if Rowan's tone had a hint of nervousness and seriousness, there was no worry in his voice. That probably meant he had reasonable confidence in his skill.

In reality, the drunkenness had disappeared from Rowan's eyes and the atmosphere he gave off was now that of a strong individual.

Rowan: "——"

Rowan's specialized weapon was a singular katana sheathed on the left side of his waist.

It was late saying this now, but to see a katana as a sword-of-choice was rare in this other world. Rowan's weapon was a distinct irregularity against the western-style swords that were the norm.

Looking closely, together with the atmosphere emanating from his disheveled hair, Rowan's appearance somewhat resembled that of a samurai. However, he lacked a certain intensity, so maybe a ronin¹⁵ was a better description for him.

Subaru: "Rowan-san, they are..."

Rowan: "There's no need to be a scaredy-cat. No matter who they are, if they're gonna stand in front of me, all that's needed is to cut them in two. There's alcohol in my belly and my sword's in top shape."

Subaru: "So this isn't drunken fist but drunken sword¹⁶? Can't say I've heard of that."

Nevertheless, it did not sound like a lie and Subaru put his faith in Rowan's self-confidence.

Moving around to the opposite side of where Rowan was glaring at the window, Subaru pulled on the sleeve of the Flop, who had still not fully taken in the situation.

Subaru: "Flop-san, let's have Rowan-san handle this."

Flop: "Handling things and whatnot, I still don't quite understand the situation! What are Husband-kun and Bodyguard-kun fighting with exactly?"

Subaru: "That's something I still—"

"Don't know yet". Faster than Subaru could reply with a statement which would only arouse Flop's worry, the situation changed.

However, the situation did not develop in a manner in which the enemy had charged in from the front and Rowan had burst out for a counterattack.

¹⁵ Translation note by Witch Cult Translations: "Ronin means wanderer or Samurai without a master, for more information, see [here](#)".

¹⁶ A reference to the drunken fist style, Chinese martial arts that imitate the movement of a drunk person. For more information, see [here](#).

???: “Bweh...”

Spilling those cries of pain, a man with a large build fell at the entrance of the bar.

With that sudden occurrence, Subaru literally jumped up in surprise. However, the other customers in the bar who saw the man had a shallow reaction, as if they were used to the sight.

The drunken customers besides Rowan— They probably worked doing mercenary-like activities as well. Those people simply stared at the fallen man with little reaction.

The only people who rushed to the fallen man’s side were Flop and the barkeeper.

Only, the one who was actually worried about the man was Flop, and it was obvious on the face of the barkeeper that he just did not want his floor to be dirtied.

Flop: “Hey, you! Are you alright? Get a hold of yourself!”

Large Man: “*Fu, fuga, fuga...*”

Flop: “Fugafuga!? Is that your name? Get a hold of yourself Fugafuga-kun!”

Subaru: “Er, no, Flop-san, that person’s...”

Flop tried to get the fallen man up, but the man responded with a groan. It was not like the man was courteously introducing himself to a person he met for the first time.

Adding on to that, a man entering this bar in this situation meant that—

Large Man: “*Fuga...*”

Subaru: “—Hm! Flop-san! Get away!”

Flop was leaning down, endeavoring to get the face-down man up by pulling on his arm.

Having gotten a terrible feeling, Subaru immediately pulled Flop back down onto the ground and got him away from the man.

—On the very next moment.

Large Man: “—!!”

The body of the man who was groaning and saying “Fugafuga” expanded, and for a brief flash, shone bright scarlet.

Then, the expanded body of the man ruptured and a great explosion threw the inside of the bar into chaos.

Customers: “Guaaaahh!?”

Screams echoed inside the bar and red flecks of light scattered around the area. Right after, they became flames that burned and spread. Subaru came to the realization that the man who had blown up had been used as a human bomb.

Subaru: “Flop-san!”

Flop: “I-I’m fine Husband-kun! But, this is...”

Subaru and Flop, who had been juggled around by the blast wave, stared in shock at the state of pandemonium inside the bar.

The reason the man’s body had exploded was most likely because he had been forced to hold onto Fire Magic Stones— Looking at his anguished face, the Fire Magic Stones may have been inside his body.

Those detonated, and fire scattered about. Additionally, that was not all—

Customer: “Cough! Wha-what the hell!? My eyes, my eyeeeeessss!”

Inside the overflowing inferno, one of the drunken customers who had gotten caught up in the mess covered his face and screamed out. Looking around, that man was not the only one who was screaming, the other men were doing the same too.

Having been blown away, the men who were engulfed in the lingering smoke from the explosion at the center of the bar covered their eyes and nose, shouting in great pain. And then—

???: “It’s no good if we stay in the bar! Everyone, hurry up and get out!”

Subaru: “Wai—”

A man shouted while tears poured down his face, and several men, with their faces covered, rushed for the entrance all at once. Looking at the men jostling against each other, Subaru tried to raise his voice in an effort to tell them to stop.

The man who had exploded, and the smoke accompanied with pain after that. Subaru felt like both of those had contributed to the disorder within the bar, and were attempting to guide people into escaping outside.

However, even if Subaru were to raise his voice out of desperation, it would not halt the footsteps of those men driven by pain. As a result—

Subaru: “—Hk!?”

A second explosion occurred, blowing away the men flooding the entrance altogether.

The second one was larger than the first, and the men caught in its radius were unable to even protect each other as they were charred black, scorched from the front by the bursting flames.

The explosive heat and the blast wave surged towards them, and Subaru was petrified by the gruesome scene.

Nightmarish sights taking place one after another— it all seemed unreal.

Subaru: “Th...is...”

Rowan: “Get a hold of yourself, client! It’s gonna be troublesome for me if ya collapse right here!”

Subaru: “—Ah.”

Whilst Subaru remained petrified and dumbfounded, he was seized by the back of his collar and was forcefully dragged to his feet. The person responsible for it was Rowan, who had his face covered with the sleeve of his clothes.

He gestured for Subaru to keep a low posture, ensuring he would not inhale the same smoke that had tormented the other men, and,

Rowan: “Barkeep! We’ll head out the back! Front side’s under watch!”

Barkeeper: “G-got it! It’s this way...!”

Listening to Rowan’s instructions, the manager nodded obediently as blood flowed down his forehead.

Like that, Rowan made a sign with his hand behind the bartender, who was moving as if he were crawling across the floor, and slapped Subaru’s back, shouting, “Go!”

Rowan: “Client, and the young man over there! Get moving right now if ya don’t wanna die!”

Flop: “O-of course, I can’t afford to die! Both my little sister and I are still in the middle of our journey...!”

Subaru: “Fuck...!”

Receiving Rowan’s encouragement, Subaru and Flop pursued the manager ahead of them. While chasing after him, Subaru’s mind was filled with confusion and rage directed at both himself and the enemy.

Of course, there was anger towards the enemy who had committed such atrocious deeds. However, he was also angry with himself, as he had failed to recognize the threat level of the enemy, even though he had known the enemy was present.

To begin with, the enemy had done something to cause a dragon carriage to go out of control in the main street.

A considerable number of people must have been caught up in that. If that was so, Subaru should have been more earnest with his thoughts. He should have acknowledged the fellow as someone who did not pay any heed to the damage to their surroundings.

Because of that, the men, who had only been at the bar, had gotten entangled in—

Barkeeper: “—! The backdoor won’t open!”

Having arrived first at the backdoor, the manager cried out in front of the self-reproaching Subaru.

He was desperately trying to open the door, but it would not answer his panicked calls. Perhaps the damage from the explosion had bent the door out of shape, or—

Flop: “This is bad! The front entrance is already demolished! If this goes on...”

Rowan: “Argh, outta the way! A door like this is—”

In the bar, the vermillion flames were growing intense, and in a situation in which the black smoke was about to swallow them, Rowan had leapt out, almost as if he were thrashing out Flop’s shout. And then, upon placing a hand on the katana by his waist, he drew and slashed it at the unopening door with great force, with nary a single flash of his blade—

Subaru: “—Ohh.”

The silver gleam shot forward, cutting away the closed door with a slash.

It was a sword skill similar to *lai*¹⁷, one which Subaru knew. Despite performing a slash that caused Subaru to be mesmerized involuntarily, Rowan did not show his pride for it, and kicked down the remainder of the door.

Rowan: “Aight! It opened! Everyone, keep low!”

Freeing the backdoor that had previously been sealed, Rowan called out to Subaru and the others behind himself.

An enormous amount of confusion was spreading far and wide, but it looked like they would be able to get away from the inescapable situation that was the bar in flames, at least.

Subaru had also understood that Rowan’s judgement in battle, as well as his skills, were trustworthy. All they needed to do was to distance themselves from this place, and for their evil opponent—

Subaru: “———”

Suddenly, Subaru held his breath.

Something was nagging at the back of his mind— He attempted to predict the thoughts of his scrupulous, ruthless enemy.

¹⁷ Translation note by Witch Cult Translations: “*lai* (or *laijutsu*) is a Japanese sword technique; for more information, see [here](#)”.

They had thrown a man-turned-human-bomb into the bar, lured out the people inside using smoke containing stimulants, and blew them away at once with the Mana Stones they had set up at the entrance.

And then, they had obstructed the entrance, and utilized some method to seal off the backdoor as well. Subaru and his group had broken through that blockade, and were able to escape through the backdoor, but—

Subaru: “Rowan-sa—”

“Something’s wrong”, Subaru attempted to put his minuscule feeling of discomfort into words.

If his opponent were a thorough one, then it would be impossible to think they would let up their offensive. In order to convey that eeriness, Subaru called for Rowan. There was no reply.

Rowan: “———”

Leaning forward from the backdoor, Rowan’s body teetered backwards, then fell.

Subaru, Flop, and the barkeeper stared at the fallen Rowan, shocked. His head, specifically the area starting from his forehead and above, had been destroyed, and his eyes were hanging out, having been extruded.

No matter who looked at it, Rowan had died, his head pulverized.

Barkeeper: “Ah.”

Gazing at Rowan’s appalling state of death, the bartender widened his eyes, attempting to scream.

However, he could not even do that. A single blow was swung with the other side of the flames, piercing through the chest of the manager who had taken a deep breath, viciously tearing apart the upper half of his body. Scattering the bones and organs from inside his body, the barkeeper rolled straight into the fire.

The scent of burning flesh immediately reached Subaru’s nose, but the barkeeper did not scream. He had been killed instantly.

???: “———”

Beyond the flames and the smoke that filled the area, something gradually made its appearance.

Stepping over the slashed, torn down door, the silhouette of a man with damp cloth wrapped around his face had appeared.

He had a firm grip on the long-handled axe in his hands, and Subaru understood that it was the weapon that had crushed Rowan's head and given the bartender an instant death. However, his understanding ended there.

Flop: "Wh-who in the world, are you? Why are you doing this?"

Having watched the deaths of Rowan and the barkeeper just like Subaru, who was unable to move out of dismay, Flop spoke with a trembling voice beside him. Although he was swamped by fear, he was glaring at the silhouette among the flames with a solemn gaze.

As if he were directing his animosity towards the villainous man, who had massacred the people in the bar one after another with such viciousness.

However---

Flop: "Don't think you can get away with thi--"

???: "-----"

Flop, while attempting to condemn the man's wrongdoings with a firm attitude, received a direct strike to his head from the man's axe.

The man would not do anything meaningless, such as bashing him with the back of his axe without aligning the edge of the blade. He adjusted the angle of the blade, slamming it into Flop's forehead where his long bangs were draped over, and spilled the contents outside.

Brain matter flew about, and Flop died as the crimson hue of his blood blended together with the red flames.

His body crumpled into a heap while making a loud splash. Blood slowly flowed out, staining Subaru's bottom as he sank down onto the floor--- No, Subaru's pants were already soiled by something vastly different. Out of fear, he had been unable to control his bladder.

Subaru was frightened by the terrifying appearance of the man that held a bloodstained axe amidst the inferno.

His soul quivered at his vindictiveness, his persistence, his dreadfulness.

Subaru: “W-why...”

It was an awfully foolish question.

Flop had been killed unsparingly after asking a similar question. Of course, there was no reason for the man to be merciful only towards Subaru. He would likewise perish. He would be killed.

Subaru did not possess the strength to draw back, nor the courage to crawl away. Right now, he was unable to take his eyes off the man.

Even if gazing at the man filled his being with terror, he could not look away because that was equally as horrifying.

Subaru: “Why... Why!”

Just like an idiot who only ever repeated what he knew, Subaru yelled out with desperation.

The man did not respond despite hearing him shout. He slowly lifted up his axe, his face remaining hidden, and positioned it straight above the sitting Subaru’s head.

And then—

Subaru: “WHY!?”

???: “—I won’t tell you anything. Won’t it be troublesome if you run away again?”

As Subaru shouted out with a bleeding heart, the man at last gave a reply.

Listening to the man’s tone and voice, which sounded as if he was only stating the obvious, Subaru’s breath caught in his throat.

He attempted to match the voice with a voice he had heard somewhere, and,

Subaru: “Buh.”

The axe swung down faster than he could do so, splitting his skull in a single blow.

There was a small, hard sound.

There was.



Arc 7 Chapter 18 - Battle in the Fortress City of Guaral

Light Novel Adaptation found in Volume 27, Chapter 3 “Battle in the Fortress City of Guaral”, Parts 1-3

Original Web Novel Chapter — [Complete](#)

Original Translation by Witch Cult Translations (Negi, [Kobosuhito](#), [Taurace](#), [Polaris](#)) — [Complete](#)

—If he closed his eyes, Subaru could recall the scene in his mind.

The middle of the dense jungle where an abundance of trees grew thickly, the muddy soil, and the atmosphere of the imposing men.

The Witchbeast’s roar that reverberated across as if to split that atmosphere apart. The fighting spirit that would rise and excite alongside the start of battle. And, the intense malice that would be directed towards Natsuki Subaru due to his involvement in inviting the Witchbeast—

That was an action Subaru himself had acknowledged and consciously decided to carry out, and had put it into practice.

He had acted after placing a scale within himself, comparing what was important to him and what was not.

It was an action done with the full determination and intention to cause harm.

What would happen to people inexperienced with fighting Witchbeasts if they actually fought one? He did not know.

They could have subdued it instantly. There was also the possibility that they could have become seriously wounded.

He did not want to think about it much, but instead of ending there, there could have been those who lost their lives.

—No, he should assume there were.

After justifying his own deed, he should at least acknowledge that fact. After all, he was the one who had decided and acted on such an action.

Natsuki Subaru chose the side of the scale he desired, and put a plan into practice, where others may die.

These other people were not Witch Cultists or Sin Archbishops, nor were they wicked people who would cause harm to others for bad intentions.

He had attacked individuals who chose to take up arms just to make ends meet. They were merely following orders from their superiors. These were people who, under the right circumstances, he could have formed positive relations with.

Therefore, this occurrence was justified, inevitable and natural.

The consequences of Natsuki Subaru's actions must be paid for by Natsuki Subaru.



Flop: “—Husband-kun, it's no good to have a scowl on your face.”

Subaru: “———”

Flop: “Good fortune won't come to anyone who doesn't have the time to smi— M-Husband-kun!?”

The instant after the bladed edge of the axe sunk into his skull, Subaru's field of vision became clear with a ring of a hard sound.

What jumped out in his unclouded vision was the figure of Flop, prodding his brow with his finger.

The pretty boy with his long bangs and slender face. Recalling the event that had come to pass a few dozen seconds ago, his head being split open; Subaru quickly covered his mouth and fell to his knees.

The rising need to vomit. The link between all the malicious acts that had occurred to him— his heart beat felt like it was about to explode, his organs felt like they were being strangled. That, and the deafening ringing in his ears, tormented Subaru.

The voice of Flop worrying for Subaru sounded far off. No sound properly registered in his brain.

Subaru: “—Todd.”

Listening to the intense ringing in his ears and the screaming of his organs, Subaru’s lips produced a short sound.

That sound was the name of someone he became acquainted with in the Vollachian Empire. He was someone towards whom Natsuki Subaru had for the first time acted with purely antagonistic intent and—

And he was the malicious assailant that had caused the great tragedy that occurred moments ago.

Subaru: “———”

The flaming bar and the stifling black smoke.

The reason the drunken customers had fallen victim to the axe one after another was because of an irritant in the smoke. It was probably a simplified tear gas of sorts with strong irritative spices mixed in. However, despite it being pseudo-tear gas, its effects were immediate.

Using magic stones to cause a fire and sealing the entrance to lead the survivors to the back exit. Barring the back door and using the moment of relief after they broke through, an ambush was performed on the strongest survivor, and they were executed.

Then, using a soaked cloth to protect himself from the smoke, he directly, with certainty, killed Subaru.

His last words and voice, and above all else, the eyes he saw of the masked man indicated his true identity.

That was Todd— The man that was supposed to have died in the Buddheim Jungle.

Subaru: “No...”

That was simply unconfirmed information.

The Imperial Army's camp fell into a state of ruin after the People of Shudraq's attack, under Abel's command. After hearing that there had been many casualties, over a hundred casualties, fearing that more pain would be compounded upon him upon further words, he shut out any other information beyond that.

After that, he had quickly taken Rem along, and decided to leave Abel and the rest.

That was why he had not even tried to think about any survivors from the attack on the encampment.

That included the attack Subaru chose to do himself against Todd's group, which was unrelated to the attack by the People of Shudraq—

Subaru: "If this is the nearest city to the Jungle, of course any survivors would run away here."

Having had their camp attacked, any Imperial Soldiers who had escaped by the skin of their teeth would inevitably head to Guaral.

Yet, that thought did not cross Subaru's mind; and so, he had nonchalantly stepped his foot into the city where enemies would be waiting. Plus, with Rem in tow.

Subaru: "...Enemy."

That word that popped in his mind, he once again tasted the bitterness of that word on his tongue.

Back when he was living in his original world, the term "enemy" was something that would only appear in manga or games. Even after being transported to another world, the target for that term only extended itself to adversaries like the Witch Cult and Witchbeasts.

Meaning, this was his first time to call someone who was not one of those, an "enemy".

This "enemy", was one created by none other than Natsuki Subaru's own actions.

Subaru: "—Hk."

Making a harsh sound, Subaru strongly grit his teeth.

Biting on his cheek meat, utilizing the searing pain and taste of blood to grab his consciousness by the collar, he forcibly pulled himself back to reality. If that were not enough, he did not mind biting off all the meat inside his mouth.

He had no use for constricted organs, loud-ringing ears, trembling hands and feet, nor for a paralyzed brain.

He could not be beaten down by malice and fear right now.

Even if he was just putting on a bold front, until the situation changed, he could not take it off.

Flop: “Husband-kun, get a hold of yourself! Husband-kun! Want to drink some water?”

Subaru: “—Hm, I’m fine. My bad, I worried Flop-san...!”

The color of his face and the tone of his voice probably did not signal that he was fine at all, but Subaru told himself he was fine while slowly standing up.

The shaking in his knees and the discomfort from his paralyzed organs still remained. However, he could not stay crouching forever. While Subaru was being spoiled by weakness, time was still marching forward.

Waiting for the right moment to strike, Todd’s plan of attack should still be in motion right now.

Subaru: “Hey Flop-san, can I ask you to do me a favor? Can you go back to the inn and get the medicine for my chronic illness from Rem?”

Flop: “Medicine? Are you under some bad sickness Husband-kun?”

Subaru: “Yeah, my glossy ankle disease¹⁸ is getting pretty bad.”

Flop: “Ohh my! Haven’t heard of that before!”

Being told a random disease name, Flop widened his eyes in surprise.

¹⁸ Translation note from Witch Cult Translations: “Glossy Ankle Disease (くるぶしツツヤ病) is a reference to one of Brokeena’s many fake chronic diseases in the manga series Dai no Daibouken/Dragon Quest: The Adventure of Dai.”

Taking advantage of Flop's goodwill left a bad taste in Subaru's mouth but he turned a blind eye to it, convincing himself that he had no choice. For now, Subaru had to prioritize getting Flop as far as he could from himself, as soon as possible.

If Todd's aim was revenge and if Flop and Subaru were to split up, he would have no choice but to go after Subaru.

Once Flop's safety was guaranteed, Subaru could focus on protecting himself.

He had still not decided on what was the correct option to take though—

Subaru: "I can meet up with Rowan at the bar, leave it to escape the surprise attack. Then..."

He had no other choice but to perform a rather haphazard plan.

Given that he did not have the time to stop his legs and think things through slowly, he could only put into actuality the best action he could think of at this very moment, and hope to pick up a miracle as he went.

Subaru: "Rem should..."

When Flop returned to the inn to retrieve the medicine for the unheard-of disease, Rem should figure out that something abnormal had happened to Subaru. She should, he hoped.

Once she figured that out, she would stop Flop from returning to this area, he believed.

It was all a lot of wishful thinking but that was the limit of Subaru's thought process at the moment.

Subaru: "Flop-san, please!"

Flop: "O-okay! Wait here! Keep your chin up Husband-kun!"

Hit with Subaru's genuine seriousness, Flop treaded the path back to the inn. Sending Flop off, Subaru decided instead to hurry to the inn.

Getting the drunk Rowan sober as fast as he could, he would smack him with money and hire him once more. Rowan had fallen prey to the ambush, but in a straight fight, he would have enough strength to win. Subaru hoped for that too.

He was depending on luck a lot, but he put his hopes on Rowan. Pleading for him to be the strongest in Vollachia—

???: “—Ah?”

About to start running with a praying heart, Subaru abruptly heard a hoarse voice from behind him.

Seeing as this was an unpopular alleyway, the voice he heard could only belong to one person. The problem was, what emotions did the owner of that voice experience to produce such sounds and what that consequently meant.

He quickly realized that those sounds would by no means be leading to a good conclusion.

Flop: “Uu, uuuaahhhhhh—!!”

What followed the hoarse voice was the scream of Flop, who had gone the other way.

Turning his head around immediately, Subaru found Flop flipped upside down at the street ahead. Fallen face-up, Flop was clutching his right leg. A small knife had pierced through his thigh.

The knife which was buried deeply to the heel, took away the ability to run from Flop.

Subaru: “Flop-san!”

Hurriedly turning back from his running position, Subaru bit his lips as his feet skid on the ground. Then, without pause, he kicked off the ground and ran over to Flop, his leg injured.

Again, his expectations had been suddenly subverted.

He thought that if they were to split up, Todd would definitely prioritize Subaru and go after him. Yet, contrary to his calculations, Flop had suddenly been attacked.

Furthermore, getting attacked at this place and at this very moment, was beyond his expectations as well.

Subaru: “Flop-san! I’ll bring you somewhere to treat that straight away!”

Holding various regrets and remorse, Subaru rushed to Flop’s side. Flop was writhing in agony from the pain in his leg but Subaru did not have the time to treat him right now.

He had to lend his shoulder and take him to someplace with people— No, he could not let the situation develop like it had before, at the time he had perished after being run over at the main road. Even if he had to be forceful, he had to drag him to the bar. That was the best option.

The fact that the knife had struck his leg was a silver lining. Because, as long as a major artery had not been pierced, there would be no real danger to his life—

Subaru: “———”

His thought process leading him here, a question abruptly appeared in Subaru’s mind.

It was good news that Flop’s life was not in danger. Yet, how was that so? Seeing the method in which the massacre at the bar was conducted, the enemy’s skill in killing was first-rate.

In spite of that, the attack against Flop ended at his legs. Why was that?

This was knowledge from manga but, this information was about a technique used by snipers in battle.

Snipers, who would hide themselves to perform one-sided attacks against faraway opponents, when faced with a group of enemies, would purposely not kill their opponent and instead stay their hand after majorly injuring them. Then, they would lure out the ones who would try to rescue their injured comrades and strive to extend their hands of death towards them.

It was a nightmarish method that took advantage of those who had a sense of fellowship, of those who could leave no man behind.

Why did he remember something like this at this moment? That was because—

Subaru: “Shi——”

The instant that he felt something was wrong, a dark light flashed in the alley next to the fallen Flop.

Immediately after, a sharp, frontal strike smacked and blew Subaru away, who preemptively threw his hands up in an effort to protect his head.

Subaru: “Gahhh!?”

Eating the hard strike completely, the blown-away Subaru hit the back of his head hard on the ground. His vision went white and the ringing in his ears became loud again. While that was happening, he was pushed further back with momentum, rolling over once.

Subaru tried to discern the true form of the strike, and the distance from which it was launched. Unable to completely block the strike, he stretched his hand to his forehead, where he felt a warm sensation. It was likely that his forehead was cut from the hard strike and—

Subaru: “—Ah?”

His right hand, which he attempted to use to touch his forehead had been blown off at the forearm onwards, between wrist and elbow.

Subaru: “G-gyaaaaahhhhh!”

His right arm, which showed its jagged crosscut with white bone and pink muscle fibers, pumped blood out energetically in sync with his heartbeat. Panicked, he tried to stop the flowing blood by putting pressure on the wound, but the palm of his left hand was also cut down the middle, his crushed fingers each all facing a different direction.

It was proof that he had unfashionably suffered an attack from the opponent.

First of all, if he were to say that, running to Flop’s side without any precaution had been a mistake.

Mistake, mistake, mistakemistakemistakemistakemissmissmissmissmiss—

???: “—Ahem.”

Holding the overflowing blood, Subaru fell into panic, triggered by pain and a sense of loss.

A man holding an axe in one hand cleared his throat in front of that Subaru— He was a figure that appeared from the alley. A young adult who tied up his orange hair with a bandana. It was Todd.

He was not hiding his face this time.

The malicious eyes Subaru had personally seen at the bar. Subaru had not mistaken the true identity behind them for someone else or another.

As expected, Todd had set an attack with the full intention to kill Subaru.

Subaru: “Ugi-giiiiiiiiiiiiiii...!”

The molars he was biting down on cracked and Subaru glared at Todd with bloodshot eyes.

He did not know himself if the meaning behind that glare was anger, hate, or more shamefully, just a plea for his life. Nevertheless, Todd’s response was cold.

He, showing a face that did not present much emotion, traced the bladed edge of the axe which destroyed Subaru’s arms.

Todd: “I need to make sure to properly sharpen this or it’s no good, my bad my bad.”

He said that lightly while reflecting on his actions.

Subaru: “Kah...”

Todd: “Alright.”

Opening his eyes wide, Subaru attempted to form words with his trembling tongue. However, Todd was indifferent to Subaru’s words, and nonchalantly swung his axe upwards.

It was as if he had no interest in Subaru’s words or identity—

???: “Uwaaahhhhhhhh—!!”

Todd: “Woah.”

However, before Todd could swing the axe he raised up, someone jumped on his body.

It was not Subaru, groaning in pain due to his destroyed arms. With this situation of Subaru having been rendered useless in a single strike, in order to protect him, a person jumped Todd. Flop.

Taking a knife to his right leg, the good-willed merchant who should have been fighting against intense pain was grabbing onto Todd's back as if he were going to sink his teeth into him. He looked at Subaru over Todd's shoulder.

Flop: "Husband-kun! Run away! Run away right no—"

Putting urgency on his slender face, Flop's strong-willed expression jerked up as he was struck on the chin.

The grappled Todd used his elbow to forcefully hit Flop. The young adult, being far divorced from violence, was easily peeled off.

Then, facing the fallen Flop, Todd raised his axe.

Subaru: "Sto..."

Todd: "One, two aaand three!"

Subaru was not given the chance to stop him. Todd lightly exclaimed and next, an intense, sharp sound of water splashing reverberated.

Hit by Todd's elbow, Flop, facing upwards, received the blade of an axe to the face. The young man, having his entire face and head split in two, swiftly became a corpse. Blood flowing, brain matter spilling, his arms and legs twitching.

Witnessing the alleyway steadily becoming soaked with blood, Subaru's mouth fell open in disbelief.

Pain, confusion and rejuvenated fear. Subaru's normal thought process was stolen by nothing but those emotions.

Just, what was the man in front of him?

Subaru: "I get..."

Todd: “Hm?”

Subaru: “I get, I get that you resent me. I get it...”

Avoiding the blood from the dead Flop, Todd turned to face Subaru as he spoke to him.

Subaru’s tears and mucus actively gushed out in thick drops. Blood flowed from his broken molars and additionally, he was covered in the blood spurting from his right arm. Subaru was in quite a horrible state.

He had not wet himself this time, but that was no comfort of any sort.

He had yet again let Flop die.

He had devised a method in which he thought he could save him, but because of Subaru’s inadequacy, Flop had died. He had let him die with a face unpresentable to his sister, Medium.

Subaru: “But everyone else... everyone else! Don’t... bring them into... it!”

There was a reason to resent him.

It was hard to admit that it was justified, but it was a natural from what had transpired between Subaru and Todd.

That was why it was inevitable that he would come after Subaru. But, to involve other people for that was against the rules. It was a cowardly act. It was far from just and fair. That was evil. Was that not evil?

Subaru was at long last even starting to lose the mental faculties to verbally assault his opponent.

Listening to his statement, Todd hummed “Ahhh” in a small voice,

Todd: “You, what do you mean by resent?”

He spoke, standing in the bloody alleyway, as he craned his head in question, wiping the blood that had reached his cheeks.

Taking in that naive-sounding attitude and answer, Subaru held his breath for a moment, but quickly a violent emotion he could not control burst out. With spit flying, he said “Don’t you dare play dumb!”,

Subaru: “Ambushing us, setting traps... relentlessly pursuing me...!”

Relentlessly, he had relentlessly been pursued and cornered.

No matter what action Subaru would take, he would anticipate and stay one step ahead to kill him with certainty. Meticulously preparing and laying out traps.

Going through that much effort to target Subaru. There was no point in feigning ignorance now. That was just being unreasonably stubborn.

It was a desecration of Flop’s death. Embarrassing Subaru, was this his way to vent his anger?

Subaru: “Are you...”

Todd: “I don’t know what you’re misunderstanding, but killing you isn’t because of resentment or anything, obviously. I found a dangerous-looking guy in town. Naturally I’d kill you, no questions asked.”

Subaru: “-----”

Todd: “You kill a poisonous snake not because you resent it, but because you fear it. For that, you’d use anything at your disposal to kill it.”

Saying that it was nothing more and nothing less than that, Todd neatly picked off the bits of hair and skin that was stuck to his axe. Were those the fragments of Flop’s destroyed head? Subaru could only stay still in shock.

There was no lie in Todd’s composed response and attitude. He even responded with a smile.

Since the beginning till now, Todd’s attacks against Subaru proved that he was serious about his words.

Todd regarded Subaru as dangerous and could not help but kill him.

That was why he would not listen to him, not let him do anything, and nor would he try to interrogate Subaru for any information.



Illustration from Volume 27, coloring by goatmanfatsuki ([source](#))

Also, he did not hate him for the deed done in the jungle. The only impression that Todd had gotten out of that, was that Subaru was a dangerous being.

As a consequence, Todd would unemotionally and dispassionately try to kill Subaru.

Todd: “You are the same as me—— I will not give you time.”

Saying that, Todd put his foot on Subaru’s chest and kicked him. Unable to resist, Subaru fell down backwards, facing upwards. Todd straddled the fallen Subaru and raised his axe.

Subaru widened his eyes. He looked for the correct words.

With Return by Death, he would find the throughline behind various events. That was how Subaru seized victory. However, this strategy that worked even on Sin Archbishops had moments in which it did not work.

That was when——

Subaru: “——Wait.”

Todd: “I won’t wait.”

——That was when the opponent was a coldhearted cutthroat.



Flop: “——Husband-kun, it’s no good to have a scowl on your face.”

Subaru: “——Hk.”

Flop: “Good fortune won’t come to anyone who doesn’t have the time to... Wha-what’s the matter? Your face has suddenly gone pale?”

Upon seeing an axe coming down right on their head, surely most people’s faces would be drained of blood.

Without thinking, Subaru put his hands to his own face, cold from the lack of blood. Relief and fear churned within him, as the hands that felt that coldness confirmed the truth that he was alive and well.

Subaru: “Damn it, again...”

What should he do? Subaru did not possess even the slightest idea.

In regards to time, all the events that had happened to Subaru had transpired in only twenty minutes. Within those twenty minutes, Subaru had already lost his life five times.

Even during the last round at Pleiades Watchtower, he had piled up over fifteen experiences of Deaths in search of victory, but then, there was confidence that progress was being made step-by-step.

But this time, he had nothing.

The corpses of Natsuki Subaru had accumulated, but he did not really feel they were contributing to his victory.

If there was one thing that could be said, it was——

Subaru: “——Even now, I’m being watched.”

Already, Todd was observing Subaru with Flop.

Consequently, the moment he separated from Flop, Todd would mercilessly use Flop as bait.

It would be a different story if Subaru had the ruthlessness to be able to use Flop as a decoy, but since he could not do that, if Flop were assaulted, Subaru would put forth every effort to save him.

This was different from the time he had weighed the safety of Rem against the welfare of Todd and company.

Flop had been kind to utter strangers, or rather, to Subaru’s group. Subaru did not have it in him to choose an option that would leave him for dead.

So, carrying out a strategy on his own apart from Flop was impossible.

Simultaneously, the option for Subaru to return to the inn had also been snatched away.

It was not clear at what point in time Todd had noticed Subaru's presence, but if he had been discovered on the way to the tavern, the location of the inn, Rem's whereabouts, had not been exposed.

Yes, Rem's location had not been found out. That was quite believable.

Supposing Rem's whereabouts had been found out, Todd would be sure to make use of Rem, and utilize her in order to kill Subaru more systematically. It was ironic that his faith in Todd's cunning conversely became proof that Rem had not fallen into his hands.

Subaru: "Anyway..."

While biting his lip and covering his face with his hand, Subaru desperately turned his head.

Time, somehow there was not enough time.

If he parted ways with Flop, Todd would begin his offensive immediately.

On the contrary, waiting for his offensive and counter attacking— Well, he was not the sort of opponent that could be beaten even if his first attack were avoided. Since Subaru had no weapons, he would have to eliminate his opponent's fighting strength in a single strike. No way.

If they escaped to the main street, Todd would recklessly drive a dragon carriage and kill by running them over.

Even if they avoided the rampaging dragon carriage, the chances that he would then take advantage of the chaos in the street were high. On top of that, the rampaging dragon carriage would drag in uninvolved bystanders. No way.

If they chose some other route, each and every alley would be his hunting ground.

North, east, south, and west, keeping an eye out in all directions was impossible. Even if they dealt with his first attack, in the end the plan to counterattack would be the same, and their lack of fighting power lay ahead. No way.

Would the best thing to do after all be rush to the tavern with Flop, and before Todd could get ready to attack the tavern, prepare fighting forces to intercept him?

The obstacle would be how seriously he could take the drunk Rowan, but right now this should be the plan with the highest chance of victory that he could think of. No other move came to mind.

Subaru: “Fuck, fuck...”

What a troublesome opponent to have made an enemy of.

In the case of Sin Archbishops, they had the nice point of their reliance on their Authority turning their strengths into weakness. Since by working out the mechanism of their Authority, conversely the weak points of those guys would become evident.

However, Todd did not have that. He would use anything he can. He had stated so himself.

He did not rely on anything, and he did not take damage to the surroundings into consideration either.

After killing Subaru, how on earth he planned to explain that to the people around him, even that was a complete unknown. No consideration had been given to what would come afterward whatsoever.

In order to kill what must be killed, there was a fear of superfluous thoughts interrupting.

Flop: “Husband-kun? You alright? If something’s wrong, going back to the inn would be...”

Subaru: “N-no! Hell no! That’s a bad idea.”

He responded with great force, and Flop stared in wonder at that voice of Subaru’s.

Having done that, Subaru seriously cursed his own mental fragility. If he displayed such odd behavior, Todd would end up becoming suspicious.

If that happened, the valuable advantage of Return by Death would disappear.

Beyond what he had already grasped, the only way Subaru could take advantage of Todd was his preconception that his presence was not known to Subaru.

Ambush and trap, escape and counterattack, whichever means he utilized Todd could not be made aware of what Subaru was aware of. Well, actually—

Subaru: “—Wait.”

Suddenly, as Subaru was desperately thinking of countermeasures against Todd, a thought crossed his mind.

Todd did not stick to any one way of doing things, or even take damage to the surrounding into consideration— Still, he paid no mind to damage to the surroundings. That was not damage to himself.

Rather, this surprise attack was because he wished to drastically diminish the damage to himself.

Todd had stated it himself, with his own mouth.

You kill a poisonous snake not because you resent it, but because you fear it, he had said.

So he had said, then—

Subaru: “—TODD! I know you’re here!”

Flop: “Wha-wha-wha!?”

Abiding by a thought that flashed through his mind, Subaru shouted at the top of his lungs.

Startled, Flop jumped at the sudden occurrence. However, it was more than likely that Flop had not been the only one.

Todd, who had been tailing and keeping a close eye on Subaru and Flop, should have been startled as well.

Counting on Todd’s moment of bewilderment, Subaru sharpened his glare, contorted his expression menacingly. While holding up the nastiest, most evil-looking demeanor possible, he swept his gaze around,

Subaru: “What a persistent bastard! Here I thought you had perished for good after all that went down, but it seems you managed to survive by some devil’s luck! However, don’t think I’ll let you get away this time! I’ll fucking kill you!”

Using the most threatening voice he could muster, Subaru spewed curses imbued with malice and hostility.

In a way his voice would definitely reach Todd no matter where in the alleyway he was hiding, and so that the message “Natsuki Subaru has caught on to your presence” would be conveyed.

Subaru: “Do you seriously think you can win in a fight against me? That’s beyond hilarious! You make me laugh, hahahahaha! Can’t wait to see it again, the pathetic way you look running away, that is!”

Revealing his two trump cards of provocation and mockery, Subaru burst out in laughter at the middle of the alleyway.

“Thank god I don’t have stage fright”, thought Subaru as this was the only time he was sincerely thankful for his shameless personality. If it were not for that, the tremble in his voice, the fear on his face, and the terror in his eyes would have been exposed.

It was thanks to Natsuki Subaru’s lousy personality that he was able to conceal those emotions.

Flop: “M-Husband-kun?”

Subaru: “Shush. Flop-san, be quiet.”

Shutting up Flop who had been completely dumbfounded by Subaru’s sudden change, Subaru pulled him by the arm and began walking brazenly.

Returning via the way they came was not possible. For starters, it had been confirmed Todd’s hiding laid somewhere over there, probably.

Hence, he stopped in the middle of his tracks, and while turning his head toward the depth of the alleyway,

Subaru: “Ohh yeah, you’re welcome to come at me any time. I shall rip you to shreds, as you wish.”

He was not sure whether Todd would get it, but he added his middle finger as his last provocation.

Doing so, Subaru was able to hide the pounding of his heartbeat while heading towards the end of the alleyway wearing an audacious smile.

Subaru: “———”

Honestly, that was a complete gamble.

There was a chance that Todd would become enraged from Subaru's provocations, and jump into the alleyway whilst swinging his axe, which would not have been a completely unlikely scenario at all— However, Subaru trusted that it would not come to pass.

Todd would not go into a fit of rage. That man was the type that would gradually search for the best move in a composed manner and carry it out.

That was why, the bluffs Subaru had been dishing out should be able to work on Todd.

Having spotted Subaru in the street and developed an intent to kill, if Todd's train of thought were followed, he would have most likely come to the conclusion that Subaru must be eliminated because, to him, Subaru seemed like a ticking time bomb. Choosing a surprise attack as the method to rope in and grasp victory in his hands was just a means to the end, as long as it worked, then all would be well. If that was no longer suitable for execution, he would just move onto the next best option.

Todd had not been particular with his methods.

That was the difference between him and the Sin Archbishops. Subaru would use that adaptability of Todd to his advantage.

Subaru: "Next up is..."

He carried out the strategy that had popped in his head in the heat of the moment, but the next steps had yet to be decided.

If Todd's caution toward Subaru grew stronger, that would mean spare time until the next wave of attack existed. While the chance was in his hands, Subaru must make a decision between "Fight" or "Flight".

Choose "Fight", then it would be necessary to get Rowan from the bar involved. As long as no better alternative showed up, borrowing his strength would be the best bet.

Choose "Flight", Subaru would have to go to the inn and grab Rem, then escape from the city. He felt bad, but he would have to ask Flop and Medium to come along as their safety were most likely in jeopardy.

Then, in the case that they decide to escape from the city, the place Subaru can go to was——

Subaru: “——So that was why.”

Flop: “Husband-kun?”

Though he stayed on guard of the alleyway behind, but, in that instant, Subaru’s eyes had become bloodshot.

The fear toward Todd, remorse toward Flop, concern toward Rem, affection toward Emilia, longing toward Beatrice, all of those had, more or less, been forgotten in that instant.

Forgotten, having grasped the feeling that had surfaced, Subaru firmly closed his eyes. Then——

Subaru: “——We need to get out of Guaral as fast as possible, before my bluffs are seen through.”



After deciding the next course of action, Subaru wasted no time.

Even after he got out of the alleyway with his plan in motion, Todd did not make any moves. It must have been because he had become extra cautious due to Subaru’s provocations, which proved to be effective.

However, the effects of those bluffs could only last so long.

Subaru: “He’ll definitely catch on soon. We have to get out of here as fast as we can...”

Their only option was to run away.

Making up his mind, Subaru gave Flop a brief explanation and took him along, towards the place they had just left—— returning to the inn which they departed from before he had met his demise five times, they dashed up the stairs.

Then, after pounding on the door to the room occupied by Rem and the others, they rushed inside hurriedly.

Subaru: “Rem! Are you oka... whoa!?”

Medium: “Uwah! What, so it was you guys! Had almost killed you there!”

The door left wide open, Subaru’s neck was against the icy blade of a halted machete. Its welder Medium gave a “Sowwy sowwy” apologetically as she sheathed her weapon.

Behind Medium, further inside the room, was Rem who watched that whole exchange as she widened her eyes,

Rem: “Wh-what is this about all of a sudden. I thought you had left yet you came back so soon...”

Subaru: “Rem!”

Rem: “—Hk.”

Surprised by his sudden return, Rem began berating Subaru as the color of his face changed. But instead of stopping to hear everything she had to say, he rushed to her side and threw his arms around her.

Her breath caught in her throat, and her shoulders shrunk in, with her slender body being embraced so suddenly.

And then,

Rem: “...Please let go of me.”

Subaru: “...Ah, yeah, that was my bad. Got a little bit too carried away there...”

Rem: “I-I understand that. From the looks of it, something serious must have happened.”

She calmly pulled him off herself once he had made sure she was truly safe.

Subaru steeled himself for the rebuking that never came. Rem instead sighed for a good moment, let slide his behavior and then continued,

Rem: “Well then. What happened?”

Subaru: "...I got spotted by a really bad guy. I managed to give him the slip, but that won't really help us for long. We can't stay here anymore. I know we just got here, so I'm really sorry, but."

Rem: "So we need to leave the city, right? I understand. Louis-chan, could you please get our luggage?"

She had caught onto the fact that there was no time for an in-depth explanation. So she quietly accepted the current state of affairs.

Of all things that could've happened, Louis really did as Rem told and heaved the luggage onto her back— Wait, something's off here.

Subaru: "Why... Why haven't you unpacked? Even though we settled down at the inn..."

Rem: "——"

Subaru: "Wait, Rem, by some chance, did you..."

She remained silent under his inquisitive gaze. However, her silence was as good as affirming his exact suspicions out loud.

Subaru: "So that's why... No wonder you accepted my proposal to come here so easily..."

Flop: "—I'm sure you have a lot to mull over, Husband-kun, but now isn't the time, is it?"

Subaru: "Flop-san."

Digesting the incomprehensible feeling of Rem's attitude, Subaru covered his forehead and Flop tapped him on the shoulder. The earnest countenance of Flop urged Subaru to action.

He must not waste the time created by the precious once-in-a-lifetime great charade.

Flop: "My sister, we're leaving town with these three. I'm told there's a dangerous paramour after the Husband-kun! We gotta let Wife-san and Niece-chan get away!"

Medium: "Woah, okay big bro! But, like, I already took off my boots!?"

Flop: "So put them back on, my sister! Shoes can be worn any number of times! That's their strength!"

Medium: “Ohhhh! Amazing, big bro! You’re a shoe genius!”

After hearing Flop’s determined persuasion, Medium assented and rushed to put on her boots.

Since it was an exchange between siblings, the outsiders did not interfere, but Subaru found that back-and-forth to be highly dubious, as he lifted Rem’s body and held her.

Rem: “Wait! At least put me on your back...”

Subaru: “It’s an emergency evacuation! And the wooden rack is in their oxcart... Flop-san! Where’s the cart!?”

Flop: “At the inn’s stable! And let me tell you, it’s no exaggeration to say Botecliffe is our third sibling! A cute little brother that we can’t leave behind!”

Medium: “Big bro! Bote-chin is a girl!”

Flop: “A cute little sister!”

Louis: “Ohhh! Ohhh!”

In spite of the pressing situation, every person coming along was incredibly boisterous, and Subaru hurriedly ran down stairs with Rem in his arms.

Subaru: “Sorry about the noise! Please accept the fee for the room!”

Passing by the inn’s reception desk, Subaru and company flew out the door without requesting a refund for not staying.

They went straight to the stables, and found the oxcart tethered with their things inside it.

Subaru: “How’s the speed of a Falo if running at full power!?”

Flop: “Hahaha, I haven’t let her run at full speed even once. Well my sister, how fast do you think?”

Medium: “I dunno, but probably faster than big bro!”

Hearing that unreliable answer, Subaru gave Rem a boost up to the back of the oxcart. Immediately Louis rushed in, and he tossed her up next to Rem, and opened the entrance to the stable.

Flop and Medium got into the coachman's seat, and the preparation to escape was complete. And then---

Rem: "Um, what is a paramour? What sort of explanation did you give Flop-san?"

Subaru: "Now's not the time! Flop-san, get Botecliffe running at full speed!"

Flop: "Ahhh! I know what I'm doing! Run, Botecliffe!!"

Subaru climbed into the back of the cart and Rem pulled on his sleeve with reproachful eyes, but without answering her question Subaru called out to Flop's back.

Hearing that, Flop wielded the reins and struck the tough Brave Ox--- Botecliffe, on the back.

And so, the oxcart broke into a run. Slowly.

Subaru: "This is super slow! She's walking!"

Flop: "Botecliffe! Run for me! Listen to your older brother, Botecliffe!"

Rem: "It would appear she does not consider you her brother..."

Rem's words felt like the truth, but Botecliffe's running speed--- No, its walking speed did not change. At this rate, it would honestly be much better if Subaru carried Rem on his back and everyone ran for it.

And, just as Subaru's sense of urgency was growing in intensity---

Medium: "BOTE-CHIN! RUUUN! Or else, I'm gonna make you dinner!"

Botecliffe: "---Moo!!"

She pulled out her barbarian swords and hoisted them overhead, and Medium shouted while rubbing them together to make sound.

Her smile encompassed her whole face, and perhaps sensing the truth in her words from Medium's behavior, the next second, Botecliffe let out a loud, deep sound and began ferociously running down the street.

Subaru: "UWOOAAHHH!!"

The intense acceleration and shaking caused swaying, and from the back of the cart Subaru let out a scream.

Flying out of the stable, Botecliffe rushed onto the main street, and the feeling of drifting from the sudden change of direction caused Subaru to nearly be thrown from the back of the cart, but Rem had promptly grabbed his hand.

Subaru: "Ah, that was close! You saved me, Rem! Your hand is so smooth—"

Rem: "Haa?"

Subaru: "Don't let go so quickly!"

Naturally a superfluous thought leaked out, and with his hand released Subaru's head hit the cart. But fortunately, he settled without getting thrown off, and everyone remained on board the running Falo cart.

Continuing on, the Falo cart speedily raced down the road as it headed for the city gate. It drew eyes as it moved left and right, dodging other dragon carriages, ox carts and canine carts.

Subaru: "Once we pass the main road, we should reach the main gate where the inspection was..."

Rem: "It does not seem like things will go that smoothly."

Subaru: "What? Wait, oi oi oi oi!"

Subaru widened his eyes on gazing at what Rem was pointing towards, up ahead of the speeding Falo cart.

In their path stood men clad in armor, engraved with the national seal of the Sword Wolf. They were deployed in a way to block the main road. Imperial Soldiers were attempting to obstruct their path.

Subaru: “It’s Todd, isn’t it!? He changed plans and called for his friends!”

There was no sign of Todd among the Imperial Soldiers that awaited them, but the reason they were obstructing Subaru’s group right now was no doubt because of Todd’s influence.

Receiving Subaru’s taunt at the alleyway, Todd figured he would be at a disadvantage by himself, and so he gathered his comrades. It was definitely a very logical and necessary decision on his part. Subaru hated how correct and appropriate his deci—

???: “—You shits! Don’t think y’all can get away!!”

In place of the absent Todd, at the head of the deployed troops, stood a familiar face.

A man whose right eye was covered by an eyepatch. His features looking as if someone had painted roughness and wildness directly onto it— It was Jamal. He accompanied Todd and, without a doubt, the man on whom Subaru set a trap on in the Jungle.

Seeing that Todd was alive, it was no surprise that he was alive as well but—

Jamal: “You’ve got some balls sending a Witchbeast at us! You’re fucking dead!”

Subaru: “...He *tanni*¹⁹ hates me. It’s kind of a relief that way.”

Watching Jamal shout in anger with bloodshot eyes, Subaru felt peace of mind, knowing that his attitude was more human.

However, having said that, that did not mean that Jamal’s existence as a threat was gone. Including Jamal, the lineup of Imperial Soldiers were a plain threat.

Just how were they going to break through?

Medium: “Big bro, hold them reins tight. I’m counting on you.”

Flop: “No worries, give it to them sis!”

¹⁹ English flip. Means “simply” (単に), originally “シンプル” (simple).

In the limited time Subaru had to make a decision, before he could choose his next action, the duo at the driver's seat, the O'Connell siblings Flop and Medium, gave their answer first.

Subaru did not have the chance to stop her. Medium positioned her legs at the tip of the driver's seat and leaned forward, falling—

Medium: “—Hup!”

Kicking the seat using her feet, her body shot forward with the speed of an arrow.

Machetes-drawn, she flew in a straight line and plunged into the enemy's formation head-on.

Medium: “Hiyaaahhh!!”

Clawing the earth with her heel, Medium forcibly stopped herself using the enemy line. She then swung her arms.

Her machetes swept forward as it ravaged the air, generating an intense shockwave. The armored Imperial Soldiers were blown back far and wide, spewing blood.

Subaru: “S-she's stroooooong!!”

Rem: “Is that how you compliment a girl?”

Subaru: “What else am I meant to say!? It is a compliment! Medium-san's strong as hell!”

Despite Rem's coldhearted comment on his honest opinion, Subaru exclaimed loudly at Medium's unexpected fighting prowess.

Hearing Subaru's voice, Flop, sitting at the driver's seat, proudly scratched his nose.

Flop: “How's that? That's my sister's true strength! I'm utterly hopeless at fighting, so my sister and I cover for each other and...”

Subaru: “Crush your weaknesses, right? I understand now!”

Flop: “You get it!”



Illustration from Volume 27, coloring by coolcollin007/SoupVEVO ([source](#))

As if Subaru's answer was to his liking, Flop's eyes shone brightly and he flashed his white teeth.

This was second-hand information from Flop himself, but Subaru could confirm it to be true with his own eyes now.

Medium rampaged on, overpowering the Imperial Soldiers that were blocking their way one after another, forcefully clearing a path for the Falo cart to get through.

Subaru: "At this rate..."

???: "—Don't get so cocky, you shitty bitch."

Medium: "Ukyan!?"

Seeing the light at the end of the tunnel, Subaru pumped his fists. It was at this moment.

At that moment, a flash of a drawn sword assaulted Medium. She blocked the attack with her machetes but was sent flying as if she were paper.

Medium was shocked by the attack. The man who sent her flying also wielded blades in both hands— It was Jamal.

Jamal: "We've already had our numbers reduced, I ain't gonna lose any more just from this scuffle! Y'all hurry up and prostrate yourselves under my foot!!"

Medium: "Kyahh! Wahh! Big bro, this guy's strong!"

Subaru: "For real!?"

Angrily showering them with words of abuse, Jamal swung his dual blades and attacked Medium. She blocked the strikes, but Subaru could tell, even from an outsider perspective, that she was inferior in fighting strength.

It was his first time seeing Jamal fight properly, but his skill was far higher than the impression Subaru had got of him before— it made Subaru think that perhaps, the Elgina he had set on Todd's group to beat them in the jungle had been beaten back by none other than Jamal himself.

Subaru: “This is bad, there’s not enough distance!”

Thanks to Medium’s hard fighting, the number of Imperial Soldiers blocking their path had decreased.

It seemed possible to break through by relying on the Falo cart’s momentum and charging in, but that was only if Jamal, who was standing imposingly in the middle of the street, was not there.

As long as Jamal was there, they could not hope to get away.

Flop: “—Sis!”

At that moment, Flop called out.

The cornered Medium glanced in the direction of her brother’s loud voice. Perhaps, he was about to yell out words of advice that would help turn around this impossible situation. Subaru hoped, but alas—

Flop: “—You can do it!!”

The advice Flop shouted out, was unmistakably just telling her to believe in herself more.

Hearing those words, Subaru’s mind went blank. Even Jamal was dumbfounded.

However, for Medium O’Connell, for a person with who was bonded through blood, the reaction was different.

Medium: “I can do it—!!”

Receiving her brother’s encouragement, Medium roared. Her machetes screeching loudly alongside.

From her stance focusing solely on defense, she switched to a ferocious offense. A flurry of blades assaulted Jamal’s entire body.

Jamal: “You think a desperate attack like that will work on an Imperial Soldier?!”

Medium: “Ugii!”

However, Jamal parried her ferocious blows with his dual swords, striking her with his own counterattacks.

Medium grimaced from the pain, blood trickling out of the lacerations she had sustained on her arms and legs. Despite that, she continued to stay on the offensive by putting in the effort she could have used to defend herself instead, pressing ahead with preventing Jamal from moving away.

Thinking of the possibility that Medium would stay there to pin Jamal to his spot, Subaru attempted to let out a desperate shout, “No, don’t!”, and then—

Rem: “Take this.”

Subaru: “Woah!? Rem, what are you... Rope?”

Right as he was about to shout, Rem had shoved the rope on the platform into his chest.

It appeared to be quite long, also thick and sturdy, something worthy of being used to secure cargo to the cart. However, in front of the puzzled Subaru, who was unsure of what to do with the rope,

Rem: “—Person with the eyepatch!”

Rem called out as she stood up, carrying a crate that had been stacked on the platform, and then flung it towards Jamal with a gallant throw.

Jamal whirled around, responding to the call with an “Ah?”. Once he saw the crate heading his way before his very eyes, he easily sliced the wooden box in half with an annoyed swing of his arm.

And then, his whole body was showered with the spices that had been packed inside the crate.

Jamal: “Guh, whoa!? Wha... this is...”

Jamal waved his arm around from the discomfort, his vision obstructed by the scattering powder. At that moment, Medium tried to take advantage of the opening that had been created, aiming for his back with her machete, but—

Rem: “Medium-san!”

The Falo cart had arrived at Medium and Jamal’s battlefield, quicker she could do so. And then, Subaru held the rope Rem had given him high above his head, throwing it towards Medium.

Looking at it, Medium prioritized grabbing the rope over attacking Jamal.

Medium: “I got it!”

Subaru: “I gotcha!”

The moment he heard Medium’s voice, Subaru endured the added weight to the rope with his entire being. He thrust his feet into the loading platform, supported Medium’s weight, and helped her return.

Seeking to jump back onto the Falo cart, Medium took a step forward, about to make a jump with the aid of the rope.

Subaru and Rem would retrieve her, and then they would break through the front gates, heading out—

Jamal: “I said, don’t think you can just escape!”

The next moment, a furious Jamal cut through the cloud of spices, bursting forth from it.

Like that, he set his sights on Medium’s back as she positioned herself to jump away, ruthlessly attempting to bring down his dual swords on her.

In a nick of time, Medium would be felled into a sea of blood from Jamal’s strike—

Jamal: “Buh.”

Rem: “This is payback for what happened by the river!”

Jamal’s face was smacked by the wooden rack that Rem had tossed from the platform.

The rack that had been handed out to the O’Connell siblings fell apart upon colliding with Jamal’s face, having completely finished its role.

Jamal was flipped over, and Medium returned to the Falo cart. She threw out her machetes onto the platform, and then proceeded to lie down with her arms outstretched.

Medium: “Ohh no, no, ohh no! That was close! Big bro, that was close!”

Flop: “Ohh, indeed, dear sister! You two also did very well, Husband-kun and Wife-san! You saved us!”

Medium: “Really, really! Thanks! You saved us!”

Subaru: “No... not at all. We’re the ones who were saved.”

Medium, who had made her way back onto the loading platform, and Flop, who had cheered for that fact.

However, the siblings’ gratitude was misplaced. In this city, the two had continued to save Subaru and his group, right from the beginning and to the end.

On top of that, he had gotten the siblings involved in his group’s circumstances. How could he make it up to them?

Gate Guard: “Halt—! Halt! Hal... Whoa!?”

Although a gate guard tried to stand in the way in an effort to stop the speeding Falo cart, he ended up leaping to the side in order to avoid it.

The Falo cart did not let up its momentum as it passed the guard, heading for the front gate with Subaru and his companions on board. The cart would zip out of the city at once, whilst throwing the queue for the inspection process into disarray.

What an outrageous situation. Subaru and company had only stayed at Guaral for less than three hours.

However, they managed to drive past the inspection area, and passed through the front gate. Subaru wanted Botecliffe to do her best, since she would need to keep running in order to shake off the group’s pursuer.

And then, he would have to tell Flop and Medium about—

Subaru: “———”

Amidst the uncontrollable shaking of the platform, the cart blew past the front gate and exited the city.

Subaru’s field of vision opened up, and he was able to discern the wide plains and the horizon. It was just as the cart was about to finally make its escape.

—When a silhouette plummeted towards Subaru from right above the gates, an axe raised high into the air.

???: “Orghhhh!”

A single strike was swung downwards, descending upon the crown of Subaru’s head as if it were slicing a piece of bamboo in half.

The blow was one that Rem nor Medium, as well as neither Flop nor Louis, were able to react to. It was nightmarish, something that could not be guarded against if it had not been predicted. However—

Subaru: “—I knew it.”

Subaru received the axe strike that rained down on him with the machete Medium had dropped on the platform.

Subaru had guessed that the instant he and his companions had succeeded in their escape, the moment where they would let down their guard the most, would be capitalized, and a single blow would be driven into the target— Subaru’s head.

—If it were Todd, that would be what he would do. The horrors Subaru had experienced five times over had assured him of it.

Todd: “I should’ve killed you, after all!”

Subaru: “Guhk...!”

Todd forcefully pressed his axe further with malice gleaming behind his eyes, attempting to split Subaru open.

It was a good thing for Subaru to receive the axe with the machete, but his hands had grown numb from the impact, and it was only a matter of time until he would drop the weapon.

Neither Rem nor Medium would make it in time to the lock of weapons that was placing Subaru’s life on the line.

Even though he had managed to dodge a fatal strike, if things went on like this, he would be killed by To—

???: “Ahh, uhh!!”

Subaru: “Woah!”

All of a sudden, the force behind Todd’s axe had grown weak.

When Subaru glanced over to see what was happening with a frown, he saw Louis clinging onto Todd, her arms secured around his body. She shook her blonde hair loose, struggling desperately to put an end to Todd’s act of violence.

Todd: “Don’t get in the way, kid!”

Louis: “Auh!”

Shaking off Louis’s interference, Todd mercilessly slammed his elbow into her face. Elbowed by him, Louis let out a shriek and fell over.

Subaru: “—Hk, son of a bitch!”

Witnessing that event unfold, Subaru gritted his back teeth as he exerted his strength to push back against Todd.

Todd stumbled back from the sudden action, creating distance between himself and Subaru after the brief moment where their weapons had locked together. However, this was within Todd’s range. He raised the long handle of his axe. The next blow was about to come.

Before that—

Subaru: “—You’re watching, right!? Do it, Kuna! Holly!”

Subaru shouted out with all his might before Todd could unleash his axe strike.

He was unsure of how far his voice had echoed across the plains. He was unsure, but—

Kuna: “Bye, Subaru. Don’t forget, I’ll be watching.”

Holly: “Yep-!”

The voices reverberated inside his skull, almost like a reply—in an instant, the sound of something hurtling through the wind pierced the air.

And then, it flew straight across, absorbing itself into Todd’s side—

Todd: “Kah.”

With a small cry of pain, Todd was sent flying at breakneck speed as his body jerked to the side.

Unable to keep himself boarded on the platform, he was thrown off the Falo cart as he spun sideways, tumbling to the solid ground without managing to break his fall.

He rolled twice, and then thrice, his figure growing increasingly distant.

Subaru: “Haa... haa...”

Rem: “Wh-what just...?”

Todd was now absent from the Falo cart’s platform, having been tossed off. Subaru dropped to his knees as the machete fell on the spot, and Rem was propping up Louis, who had received an elbow strike, in her arms.

Rem also had a confused expression on her face from what had just occurred, but Subaru had a sense of confidence, one which told him that they would receive assistance if they could make it past the gates.

The origin of his certainty came from—

Subaru: “That nasty fucking Emperor... I’ll make sure to punch you when I get back...”

Subaru spat out that venom as he sprawled across the Falo cart’s platform, whilst picturing the face of the villainous man who must have known everything.

Arc 7 Chapter 19 - A Vexing Reunion

Light Novel Adaptation found in Volume 27, Chapter 3 “Battle in the Fortress City of Guaral”, Part 4,
and Volume 27, Chapter 4 “Emperor / Merchant / Natsuki Subaru”, Parts 1-2

Original Web Novel Chapter — [Complete](#)

Original Translation by Witch Cult Translations (Negi, [Kobosuhito](#), [Taurace](#)) — [Complete](#)

—The man remained motionless, sprawled out on top of the stiff soil.

???: “——”

He was neither dead, nor asleep.

He simply closed his eyes, organizing his thoughts in silence as he adjusted his unsteady breaths.

Assembling them, putting them together, building them back—

???: “Oi, you alive?”

???: “—Yeah, I’m alive.”

As someone called out to him overhead, he opened his eyes to see the face of a familiar man.

He felt like the man was in possession of exceptional talent, since the boorish impression he gave off persisted even when looking at him upside-down. Anyway, that was completely unrelated to resolving the current situation.

???: “What happened to those guys?”

????: “They managed to pass through me, and ran away as fast as they could after they threw you out. You’re... you better do something about that. I can’t help but feel pain whenever I look at it.”

???: “That...? Ah, you mean this.”

He sat up while scratching his head, glancing towards the side of his body, where the other man had pointed at with a finger. Just then, he spotted the thick arrow embedded into his body.

If the arrow piercing his left side had been positioned slightly higher than where it was, then it might have pierced his heart.

Although the injury had nearly taken his life, he had few strong emotions about it. Not just about how it looked, but also about the fact that his own flesh had been pierced.

Todd: "It's not really as painful as it looks, alright? Though it'll be difficult to move for the time being..."

Jamal: "Dumbass. Who said they were worried about you? I said it's painful to look at. Hurry up and pull it out."

Todd: "You're kinda rough with wounded companions, aren't you— And."

Hearing that from his frowning partner, he reluctantly grabbed the lodged arrow. The trouble with arrow wounds was that the arrow needed to be pulled out before the flesh closed around it.

Fortunately, it had only been stuck there a short time, so he was able to pull it out in one go with some exertion.

For the flow of blood, he pressed a torn piece of clothing on the opening of the wound and forcefully compressed it to stop the bleeding.

Todd: "So, here's the arrow just as you ordered. Now what do we do, huh."

Jamal: "If it's a deep wound, you should withdraw and rest. As for those guys that got away, I'll take some people along and crush them. We'll show those bastards ourselves that they're prey..."

Todd: "—That'd be a bad move, Jamal."

Jamal: "What?"

The man dictating the course of action from here— Jamal, was reined in by his hand.

Todd understood why Jamal would want to pursue the fleeing enemies who had made fools of them to get payback. But, if they proceeded with a hasty offensive move, the ones who would be met with a painful experience would be those here.

Todd: “Think about it. Why exactly, did those guys brazenly enter Guaral? Considering what they themselves did, it’s obvious we’d be in this city.”

Jamal: “...Unless they’re brainless idiots.”

Todd: “—They deliberately marched in. They went as far as to conceal an ambush outside the city.”

With a glance, Jamal looked at the arrow that had just been extracted and cleared his throat.

Jamal, as an experienced military man, had the ability to perceive the direction from which an arrow had been fired and its accuracy, and was able to determine from how high it had been shot.

Naturally, he would reach the same conclusion as Todd himself.

Jamal: “If that’s right, their aim is...!”

Todd: “To lure out and hunt us Imperial Soldiers who’d entered Guaral. If we abruptly chased after them with our entire military strength, or rather, if we pursued them with our small force, we’d be playing in the palm of their hand— Which of us would be the prey, I wonder.”

Jamal: “———”

Gritting his teeth in frustration, Jamal scowled in the direction their opponents had fled.

On the inside, Jamal looked like he was being swayed by gut-boiling fury, but Todd knew that painful feeling all too well— that was something he wouldn’t say. Rather than fury, it was admiration that had taken hold in his heart.

Brazenly using oneself as a decoy, successfully taking advantage of unpreparedness to lure out a foolish opponent.

He was certainly a formidable enemy, a child of war.

Todd: “I seriously fucked up, failing to kill you...”

While looking the same direction as Jamal, he softly muttered that.

And then, he took a breath, “Ahh” as if he had pulled himself together,

Todd: “Seems we’ll have an opportunity for revenge— They’ll come back, no matter what.”

Jamal: “When that time comes, I’ll show absolutely no mercy.”

Todd silently nodded in approval of Jamal stifling his anger.

Then, for the time being he would confirm this battle as a loss. Moreover—

Todd: “Jamal.”

Jamal: “Ohh... What’s with those hands?”

Todd’s legs were stretched out on the ground, both hands extended in his direction, and Jamal frowned.

Todd tilted his head at the incomprehension, “Just what it looks like”, he continued,

Todd: “Piggyback ride.”

Jamal: “Die alone!”

He shrugged his shoulders, really, that was not a response of true friendship.



Stepping strongly on the hard ground, Subaru marched forward with long strides.

As he neared his destination, his restlessness increased and his ability to suppress the need to jump out from the ox cart decreased. And so, with the moment of arrival finally at hand, his body leapt forward with vigor.

He felt like he heard voices trying to stop him, but they all went in one ear and out the other.

Shaking them off, he headed straight for the target building. A wooden building, noticeably larger than the rest, located at the center of the settlement. Entering it, he drew the gazes of several people inside. And—

???: “—So, you have returned. Quicker than my expectations even.”

An arrogant man brazenly declared, sporting an oni mask.

Saying nothing towards his haughty attitude, Subaru charged straight forward. Letting the momentum carry him, he, without hesitation, peeled off the mask of the man who looked down on him.

Letting his mask be removed with little resistance, the man’s graceful features became exposed.

Grabbing the collar of that unbearable person with his demonic face, Subaru pulled him up into a standing position. Next, he brandished his fist, ready to send his fist flying into that face and—

???: “Subaru, *wait*.”

Just as Subaru was about to punch him into oblivion, his drawn right arm was forcibly stopped from behind.

A tall figure, who dyed the ends of their hair red. It was this settlement’s clan leader, Mizelda, who had stopped him. Wanting to complain about her action, he opened his mouth, about to say “*Now?* Of all times?”.

However, faster than he could object, Mizelda prefaced, saying “*Listen*,”

Mizelda: “Not the *face*. Anything else, I’ll *forgive*.”

Subaru: “ORAA—!”

Abel: “—Hk.”

Receiving her unwavering answer, Subaru, after a brief moment, delivered his fist directly into Abel’s stretched torso.

Subaru did not know if Abel had expected to be punched in the face but, having been hit in a location he was not ready to be hit in, the man let out a cry of pain and took a few steps back. Not all of Subaru's pent-up anger was released by just that but—

Subaru: "Don't think we're even now, shithead...!"

Abel: "—Hmph, what a greedy man you are."

The man picked up the oni mask that had fallen to the side and put it back on. The man who always had something to say back— Abel.

Having struck the man who was the source of his dam-level pent-up anger, Subaru harshly exhaled.

For he had travelled for three-plus days, taking the path back, just for this one strike.



Flop: "Look sis! Apparently, this is the village of the famous People of Shudraq! It's in the backwoods of the unexplored regions, just like the rumors say! What a find!"

Medium: "Woah! Amazing, big bro! Look look! Everyone's abs are ripped just like me! Ripped! Big bro, ripped!"

Flop: "Mega ripped!"

The siblings' voiced thoughts echoed throughout the settlement. They were seemingly easy-going, no matter where they were.

The duo exchanging their candid opinions were the O'Connell siblings, Flop and Medium. Caught up in the flow of things, they had been invited into the People of Shudraq's settlement.

They were in the middle of the plaza, sitting atop their ox cart, surrounded by the Shudraqians who had gathered in curiosity. Their fearless attitude appeared to be a constant even in different lands and environments. Acting like big shots, they showed not a single emotion remotely resembling trepidation, alertness or anxiety, even while drawing the eyes and attention of many.

However, they should become more aware of the dangers and harms to one's life and body when interacting with others. It would be more normal and appropriate to be scared, because currently, they were being surrounded by a pretty much unknown, wild tribe.

Abel: "You have brought back rather noisy company. Were those people required for your journey? If so, the way you and I see value is different."

Subaru: "I won't deny we value things differently. There's a big difference in how you and I see things — Saying that, that attitude of yours is really something isn't it?"

Abel: "Hoh?"

Sitting on the floor of the meeting area, Subaru and Abel faced off against each other, much like how they had done a few days prior.

Abel had received Subaru's punch of retribution earlier, but there was no inkling of repentance in the tone of his words. Never mind wanting an apology, he did not plan on giving one anyway.

However, Subaru could not ignore his comment on the siblings. That was because—

Rem: "Abel-san, we inadvertently got those people involved. They were kind to us when we were stuck standing outside the city... Just because of that."

Abel: "——"

The reason for Subaru's anger was explained instead by Rem.

Unlike last time, the meeting room had not been cleared out, and so members other than Subaru and Abel were also participating in the discourse.

Next to Subaru was Rem, seated *seiza*-style²⁰, and their fellow travelers, Kuna and Holly. Seated next to Abel were the sisters Mizelda and Taritta.

²⁰ Seiza (正座) is the Japanese term for the formal way of sitting in Japan (kneeling with the tops of the feet flat on the floor and sitting on the soles). It is literally translated as "proper sitting". For more information, see [here](#).

As a side note, on the topic of Louis, she was being looked after by the person closest to her in age, Utakata. She was currently, most likely at the ox cart in the plaza, with the Shuraqian-surrounded O'Connell siblings. In any case—

Rem: “With their assistance, we were able to return safely. In doing so, they are now being targeted by the city’s soldiers...”

Abel: “Incorrect, I shall amend that. The ones targeting us and the two outside are not the city’s soldiers. They are the Imperial Soldiers. The ones who serve this country have become your enemy.”

Rem & Subaru: “———”

From behind his oni mask, Abel’s cold words pierced through Subaru and Rem.

Hearing his dry statement, Rem could only avert her light-blue eyes tiredly. To be honest, that was the undeniable truth of the situation. Subaru understood that.

However, understanding and agreeing with the truth were two different things.

Subaru: “Drawing the bad will of the camp’s Imperial Soldiers was my mistake. Their hostility is also the result of my choices and actions.”

Abel: “That is correct. It is the fate you tied yourself to, even before you encountered the People of Shudraq.”

Subaru: “I can’t make excuses for that fate, because the one who made them an enemy is unmistakably me— But, the one who had to pay for those consequences should have just been me.”

It was true that the majority of the fault fell on Subaru, but the problem here was Abel’s attitude.

From the start, he should have known the danger Subaru’s group would be in if they entered Guaral. He should have noticed the possibility where they were attacked after coming into contact with the surviving Imperial Soldiers.

That was why—

Subaru: “You ordered Kuna and Holly to wait for us outside the city in advance. To help us if we were trying to escape the city from pursuers.”

Holly: “For real for *real*, you guys were in quite a pickle you *know*-. If me and Kuna weren’t *there*, Subaru, your head would’ve been split in two by an axe by *now*-.”

Plunking down into a cross-legged position, Holly stated casually while stuffing her mouth full of dumplings. Unlike the person sitting next to her, Kuna, who held an uneasy expression, she did not comprehend the mood of the conversation.

Of course, Subaru was thankful for Holly and Kuna’s help. If not for their assistance, the possibility of his head having been split open back then was quite high.

Subaru: “Using Kuna’s eyes to keep watch and Holly’s bow to support us... A long-range bow and arrow snipe. It’s what you’d call a combo skill with both your talents.”

Kuna: “...No one told me that the situation was that crap, *though*.”

Kuna’s spiritless comment evidently showed that she harbored a sense of guilt towards Subaru’s group.

Saying that however, the guilt that Kuna carried was invalid. That was because the words she had given Subaru before they entered Guaral that had been what had given him the hint he needed.

Had she not advised him, the help that Holly mentioned would have been unattainable. However—

Subaru: “That kind of thinking only applies to Kuna and Holly— Someone like you, who foresaw the whole thing, I’m not going to be nice to.”

This was why he had made the first thing he did after coming back to be his strike of retribution on Abel.

If Abel had shown any traces of self-reflection after receiving that, his feelings may have been different. But, mostly as expected, Abel showed no remorse or even any sign that he thought he did something bad.

With his unchanging, arrogant attitude, he toyed around with Subaru’s anger.

Even now, the sharp stare behind his oni mask showed no clouds of doubt.

It was as if he was about to say, “So what of it?”.

Subaru: “Oi, why don’t you say something instead of shutting up.”

Abel: “—So what of it?”

Subaru: “...You actually said it.”

With the aggravating response he had predicted becoming reality, Subaru grit his teeth at Abel’s words and sharpened his glare.

However, Abel coolly let Subaru’s accusatory stare slide and,

Abel: “After returning with vigor and striking me, all you can lay out are dull words of abhorrence? First off, I warned you from the start, did I not? —That it would not be an easy path.”

Subaru: “Guh...”

Abel: “Latching onto the closest peace and safety you could find, understand that this was the penalty for not using your head. Out of all the actions any of those defeated soldiers could take, going to the city nearest their burnt camp had the highest probability of occurring. It is common sense.”

Subaru: “Then... Then, you should have said that to begin with!”

Sitting with one knee raised, Abel’s words poked unsparingly at Subaru’s overhastiness.

Still, in the first place, Subaru understood his mistake and acknowledged it. He understood that it had been his lack of thinking and actions beforehand that had caused the unfortunate sequence of events to explode and unfold.

However, Abel had been aware that danger lurked, and let it slide. His actions had directly benefited the enemy— if being allies or enemies was an irrelevant detail, then what he had done was equivalent to setting Subaru up in a trap.

Subaru: “You knew everything from the start. The chances of us encountering the Imperial Army’s survivors, the chances of us having to frantically escape. How, in all that mayhem Rem would...”

Abel: “———”

Subaru: “Anyway! You knew everything. But you kept your mouth shut.”

Letting his mouth run off without thinking, words which should not be spoken almost came tumbling out. Quickly preventing himself from saying any further, Subaru concentrated his anger at Abel, avoiding to look at the face of the person sitting next to him, Rem.

Subaru was getting worked up in his flames of anger. Towards that, Abel coolly— no, coldly, gazed towards him.

Just how much of this world did this man see through with his penetrating gaze.

And, for a person able to see through so much, for what purpose did he toy with Subaru and the others.

Subaru: “Answer me, shithead. Why did you let us...”

Abel: “To save myself from extra work. Nothing more, nothing less.”

Subaru: “Extra work..?”

In response to Subaru’s angry biting look, Abel let out a sound indistinguishable from a sigh.

When Subaru blinked at his response, Abel gently rubbed the ground of the meeting room, and picked up the parched earth in the palm of his hand.

Abel: “Fellows like you value what is seen with your own foolish eyes more than the words of the wise. The intensity of falling raindrops is more eloquent than anything that could come from my mouth.”

Subaru: “———”

Abel: “Thanks to that, you must feel it keenly— That for you, there is nowhere to run to.”

As he spoke, he sprinkled the dirt from his palm and scattered it.

With just that action, Subaru felt an optical illusion of being terribly and clearly blocked in every direction was very much being thrust toward him.

As the Emperor of the Sacred Vollachian Empire, it was simple to manipulate others with skillful words.

In front of the tough sly fox of an Emperor, Subaru's complaint was no different from the cries of a caged monkey.

So, in reality, Subaru was just left at his wit's end.

Subaru: "...Ultimately, what is it you want to do?"

Abel: "I have already told you my intentions. To regain what was stolen. To that end, the current Empire is my adversary. It is your enemy as well."

Subaru: "—You're telling me to cooperate with you?"

Abel: "For the time being, I have explained I possess no reason to harm you."

For the troubled Subaru, Abel's words seeped in like poison.

Abel's art of conversation refused to allow for a clear answer to be grasped, and was endowed with cunning as if to mystify Subaru, but, on the other hand, it also felt as though he was attempting to test Subaru.

Again and again, Abel did not make any assertions to Subaru, yet he continued to speak.

Telling him to think for himself, and choose what to take from it.

This time as well, Abel was provoking him to rise to his level if he wanted to argue. Currently, Subaru could not rise to his same level of discussion.

And His Excellency the Emperor was not so kind as to wait for Subaru to obediently rise to the occasion.

Subaru: "...So, everything rests in the palm of your hand? I don't like it."

Abel: "—Unfortunately, I hold only some people in the palm of my hand. It is because of the portion I could not control, that currently, I am here, sitting upon the dirt."

Subaru: "———"

In the reply to what Subaru had spat out, Abel's self-deprecation was audible.

His facial expression was not visible, and the tone of his voice also did not change. Still, it seemed like self-deprecation. It was unusual— no, it was the first time Subaru had heard Abel mock himself.

And it was proof that he had accepted the undeniable reality.

He had allowed his own subordinates to rebel, an uncrowned Emperor, ousted from his throne.

Deep in the jungle, sitting upon the dirt of the Shudraqian meeting place, that situation in particular was evidence that he had made a foolish blunder for which there was no excuse.

Subaru: “———”

While fixing his gaze directly at Abel, Subaru deliberated quietly.

Subaru still was unaware of Abel's true intentions, as well as his own or their own plans of action hereafter. He wished not to be taken for a ride by Abel's calculations yet again, and suffer similar misfortune.

Actually, what the hell was Abel thinking?

Subaru certainly did not believe that Abel would go so far as scheming to bring Subaru over to his side. That he would detect such value in Subaru did not appear plausible.

In spite of that, if there was a reason for Abel to keep Subaru on hand, rather than Subaru's own self, it was an interest in other accessory—

???: “——Husband-kun! The people here are truly delightful and big-hearted! I'm impressed!”

Subaru: “Uwah!?”

Subaru gasped, right in the middle of his serious deliberation.

Losing his footing at the entry to the meeting place, the figure of Flop appeared, his beautiful voice resounding through. In the middle of the meeting place, while he looked out over each face lined up,

Flop: “Ohh dear, I apologize for the late greeting! Apparently, it seems the people here are representatives of this village. Ohh! Miss Kuna and Miss Holly look-alikes too!”

Kuna: “It is *us*.”

Holly: “It *is-*.”

Flop: “Ohh right! I’m being rude!”

Smoothing down his hair with his hands, Flop briskly moved to the center of the assembly, and bowed wearing a friendly smile.

Flop: “Allow me to correct myself, I’m Flop O’Connell! I do peddling with my sister Medium and Botecliffe. It seems for various reasons we ended up accompanying Husband-kun, Wife-san, and Niece-chan on an incident-filled journey to this position. From now on, everyone, I am in your care!”

Taritta: “Is he being polite or *not*...”

At Flop’s vigorous greeting, Taritta wore a vexed expression. Then with a glance she peeped at the adjacent Mizelda’s face,

Taritta: “Sister, what shall be *done*? Outsiders are ordered to stay *back*...”

Mizelda: “That’s *true*... Well, he’s a sexy *man*. I’ll keep him in my *room*.”

Taritta: “Sister...”

Folding her arms, Mizelda decided on Flop’s treatment by his face.

Mizelda’s judgement by exceedingly simple logic was easy to understand, but seemed troubling to Taritta, who supported her older sister as the chieftain. Of course, if that alone was the basis for Mizelda’s judgements, Subaru would not have been able to remain in the village, so he thought there must be more to it.

Subaru: “Right, Mizelda-san, there’s one thing I want to check. Flop-san is my guest, or perhaps I should say I decided on my own to bring him along. But, about making him undergo the Lifeblood Ritual...”

Flop: “Lifeblood Ritual? By chance, could that be some kind of traditional welcoming ceremony passed down in this village!? Certainly, I would love to have that experience too!”

Subaru: “It’s a traditional ceremony, but it’s a bit rough to be called welcoming.”

Flop was looking forward to trying the ritual, but even he would likely become reluctant if he were presented with the possibility of being pitted against a Witchbeast. Subaru was afraid that there was a possibility that Flop’s attitude would not change upon hearing that, but either way, he did not want to let it happen.

Abel: “—I knew from the moment we were partitioned by this thin wall, but they are a noisy bunch.”

And now, the one who did not welcome that attitude of Flop’s was the ruthless Emperor donning an oni mask.

It was a stark contrast between the sunny warmth of Flop and the cold blood flowing through Abel. At least, the fact that Abel seemed to have no reason to like Flop made Subaru’s blood freeze.

Flop: “Ohh my! What an unusual mask... Is he perhaps the head of the village by chance? I read somewhere that people who have special appearances have special positions!”

At the first chance meeting of the pair, Flop started by referencing Abel’s striking appearance.

Flop’s conclusion from the conspicuous oni mask was understandable, but it was difficult to deem Abel as one of the People of Shudraq. At any rate, the part about the oni mask aside, he was culturally quite far removed from the other Shudraqians. Especially from visuals, his appearance was far too irregular.

Abel: “It is not a poor way of thinking, but lacks attentiveness and prudence. A moment ago, you spoke of your occupation as being that of peddling...”

Flop: “Ohh, yeah! My sister’s Botecliffe pulls the ox cart that carries our goods, and we do trade all over the Empire... We are nomadic siblings wandering with the wind!”

With his hand pressed to his chest, Flop responded as if singing.

Outside the building, a voice could be heard saying “That’s my big bro!” from the public square. Even though separated by a thin wall, there was a deep bond between the siblings.

However, even proof of such a wholesome relationship, seemed not to be grounds to Abel to warm his utterly frozen heart.

Upon hearing Flop's reply, Abel sniffed a small "Hmph",

Abel: "—Natsuki Subaru, you say you picked these up in the city."

Subaru: "Don't go treating people like objects. To start, if I accurately express the state of affairs, a more correct representation is that we were picked up by Flop-san."

Abel: "The essence is what matters. I am not at leisure to concern myself with trifles. Nevertheless, I will first commend you for returning in this way. It was a great feat."

Subaru: "Sure doesn't feel like praise... What the hell are you scheming."

Frankly, Flop and Abel were a bad match in Subaru's view.

For that reason, he had planned to ask Flop to wait in the square and introduce him when an opportunity arose, but Abel's reaction was unforeseen by Subaru.

But then, Abel's interest was not in Flop's humanity. Naturally, it would not be the presence of Medium, who was known by the loudness of her voice alone, either. As such, the answer was clear.

Abel: "Merchant, to what degree are you acquainted with Guaral?"

Flop: "That's a good question, Village Chief-kun! I'm proud to say I'm pretty well-known in Guaral. At any rate, it's certain our lives would be over if we traveled too far. Since even peddlers have to get accustomed to travel coming and going from fixed places!"

Kuna: "Seems like a fine line between caution and cowardice, *huh...*"

Kuna let out an exasperated sigh at Flop's overflowing ever-positive self-confidence.

But, listening to Flop's answer, Abel kept silent under his oni mask— No, Subaru's ears picked up a faint sound out of the silence.

It was a small noise from Abel's throat.

Abel: “How fortuitous. Quite the find, Natsuki Subaru— A peddler intimate with the city would likely happen to know a byway or two.”

Subaru: “Oi, hold up, Abel. A byway? What are you suggesting?”

Abel: “Again you look towards another for answers? It would appear you fail to comprehend the purpose of my repeated interrogation. I lack the words to label such ignorance with.”

Subaru: “———”

Every single bit of his manner of speaking was aggravating, but he had no retort for Abel’s words.

Natsuki Subaru was too isolated and helpless to actually break off the discussion here, and turn his back and leave. Therefore, he thought carefully, even if it was annoying.

—No, even without thinking about it, he had a pretty good grasp on Abel’s intention.

Just now, it was evident from listening to the interrogation of Flop.

Subaru: “Abel, you, are you seriously...”

Abel: “Even slow minds can happen upon the answer if utilized. Ahh, as expected of your thinking.”

With trembling lips and stiff cheeks, Subaru looked back, and Abel’s penetrating gaze from behind the oni mask told of his cold-hearted plan.

Then, Abel spoke, informing everyone besides Subaru.

Abel: “—The Fortress City of Guaral shall fall. That city is necessary as our next base.”

Arc 7 Chapter 20 - Emperor / Merchant / Natsuki Subaru

Light Novel Adaptation found in Volume 27, Chapter 4 “Emperor / Merchant / Natsuki Subaru”, Parts 3-

5

Original Web Novel Chapter — [Complete](#)

Original Translation by Witch Cult Translations ([Kobosuhito](#), [Taurace](#)) — [Complete](#)

—The fall of the Fortress City of Guaral, that was the next move in Abel’s scheme.

As his brain digested the contents of that bold proclamation, Subaru instantly reached a conclusion.

That it was an absurd plan.

Subaru: “Though imperfect, it’s a Fortress City... It’s surrounded by walls on all sides, plus entries and exits through the gates are being monitored constantly. It’s not a place where you can just say something like “surrender” so casually.”

Abel: “Ho, you speak as though you have seen it... Oh right, you have. As nothing particularly useful has been heard coming from your mouth, I had nearly forgotten.”

Subaru: “That sharp wit is very nice. But, that sharpness is only usable against opponents sitting down for discussions like this. It won’t work against armed opponents.”

In the middle of the meeting place, encircling the fire, Subaru and Abel glared at each other.

Abel let no emotion behind the oni mask peek through, but that just made it all the more impossible for Subaru to guess what was going through his head, leaving Subaru both annoyed and confused.

Right now, the legitimate concern Subaru harbored, there was no way Abel would not have likewise realized it.

And in spite of that, he had proposed something like the fall of the Fortress City—

???: "...You intend to use a byway to invade the city, is that what you are saying?"

While Subaru was holding his breath, a quiet voice murmured those words beside him; it was Rem's.

Rem was sitting with her legs folded to one side, her light-blue eyes fixed intently on Abel. It was less of a glare, and more like her gaze was peering into him.

Receiving that look, "That goes without saying", Abel shrugged.

Abel: "As Natsuki Subaru said, the inspections imposed at the main gates of the city are the first obstacle. It is imperative we find a way to evade them to get into the city."

Rem: "Even supposing we got in, it looked like there was a large number of Imperial Soldiers within the city. Even ignoring the inspection, I think there would be too many enemies."

Abel: "Hm."

To Abel who was sorting the obstacles for the fall of Guaral, Rem gave a well-reasoned objection. Abel snorted at that attitude, but on the other hand Subaru's bewilderment intensified.

The source of which was, of course, the figure of Rem directly arguing with Abel.

Concerning the content of her argument, Rem's position could be said to be on the same side as Subaru, opposing an assault on Guaral.

However, her holding that viewpoint was really too fitting— As though during her short time sojourning in Guaral, she had completely made sure of that point.

Abel: "—Natsuki Subaru, what do you know of the difference between offensive and defensive military force in regards to battle?"

Subaru: "Ah? The difference between offensive and defensive military force, you say... Like, the Law of Threefold Attack?"

Abel: "The Law of Threefold Attack... Indeed, that is a perfectly fitting phrase."

When asked, Subaru reflexively answered, and Abel nodded as if impressed.

The Law of Threefold Attack was a theory of combat regarding military force, which stated that the attacking side should have three times the strength of the defending side.

This was due to the difference in the sense of objectives between offense and defense. The offensive side must defeat their opponents, whereas the defensive side could either defeat their opponents, repel them, or just avoid the attack, which was a significant advantage.

For example, in this instance, to procure Guaral Abel would have to command the Shudraqians to occupy the city, but the Imperial Soldiers and guards could withdraw from the attack and barricade themselves in the city to achieve their aim.

To cover for the difference for it to be possible to achieve the objectives, the idea was that such an amount of troops were needed, but—

Subaru: “Three times the force of the city, there’s no way we could get something like that together. Mizelda-san, how many people are in this village, give-or-take?”

Mizelda: “Altogether, eighty-two *people*. Including Abel and that man... Flop, it’s at least a *hundred*.”

Subaru: “I’m not sure how you’re counting men with nice faces, but it’s merely a hundred. Though I’d roughly estimate there were more than three times that force in the city.”

Setting aside Mizelda’s method of calculation, Subaru estimated Guaral’s military strength to be in that ballpark.

The scale of the city probably did not reach 10,000 people in size, but there should be a suitable number of soldiers protecting the city’s law and order to match. And on top of that, the Imperial Soldiers whose camp had been torched would join them.

—Those Imperial Soldiers, including Todd.

Subaru: “———”

Abel: “At the very least, it seems you possess some fundamental knowledge in that head of yours. Yet, the reason you held your tongue appears to be some other fear besides concern about the power differential.”

Subaru: "...It's true that there's something I fear, but it's also true that the power differential is dangerous."

Subaru clicked his tongue, and tasted the discomfort of having his inner feelings correctly guessed.

In truth, when Subaru had heard of the plan to capture Guaral, the first obstacle that came to mind was Todd. Even just the thought of facing him again was enough to make his guts squirm.

Anyway, if they thought in accordance with the Law of Threefold Attack, it was not worth discussing.

Subaru: "As for a means to overcome the difference in strength, I can't think of anything outside of a mighty warrior joining us or the enemy commander being fatally incompetent."

Abel: "Unfortunately, I do not believe we can anticipate either of those. With the Shudraq's abilities, we could scatter the masses of troops, but even if they used their numbers to surround us we would be defeated. Furthermore, I hear the enemy commanding officer is Zikr Osman. He is a solid and boring strategist, but he has no weak point."

Subaru: "Zikr... I've heard that name."

He must have heard that name from Todd, before their relationship had deteriorated.

The Imperial encampment had already been reduced to ashes, but he recalled the person in command of that military operation to be called Zikr.

However, since the camp had been burned, he had thought that person had been defeated as well.

Abel: "Those at the encampment were common soldiers. From the beginning, in order to conceal the primary objective, they were bestowed with minimal intelligence... Against a small tribe, a General Second-Class would not proceed to the front lines."

Subaru: "So you're saying the commanding officer remained in the city from the outset?"

Abel: "In truth, by doing nothing he ought to have achieved an adequate result. That plan went awry on my command... Ahh, and due to your presence, Natsuki Subaru."

Subaru: "Guh..."

Maliciously, Abel tried to force Subaru to face the responsibility he was averting his eyes from.

At that, Subaru ground his teeth and pressed his hand to his mouth.

At any rate, there was a high probability that General Second-Class Zikr was stationed at Guaral.

The Empire's upper ranks were said to be General First-Class, General Second-Class, General Third-Class and so on, so he could understand that a rank second from the top meant a pretty powerful person.

Subaru: "So what are you trying to say? On top of our inferior military strength, the enemy commander is a big shot counted among the elite. Furthermore, since we poked the beehive, they'll also be on-guard, right?"

Abel: "Precisely. Can you appreciate the weight of your responsibility?"

Subaru: "That's not what I'm saying!"

Abel condemned Subaru for his thoughtlessness, but the problem lay elsewhere.

It was Abel's stance of still refusing to give up the fight, even with an abysmal chance of success. Subaru resolutely maintained that it was pointless to even try.

In the first place---

Subaru: "I am vehemently against fighting itself. That should've been very clear when I left here. I...I just want to go home with Rem."

Abel: "Yet, that has already proved unfeasible. You think the Imperial Soldiers in Guaral are your only enemy? Are you convinced another village or town would be safe?"

Subaru: "-----"

Abel: "No matter where you go, your peace can no longer be secured. I intended to grant you the time to fully realize it, and let it seep into your blood. Or, is the poison still insufficient?"

Abel's mocking gaze was starting to peck at Subaru's feeble spirit.

Besides, as he felt pain like he was enduring great hardship, Subaru let out a long sigh; though annoying, he could not deny the truth of Abel's words.

The suffering he had gone through in the Fortress City had created a mental Barrier inside Subaru.

From now on, even if he attempted to take Rem and flee abroad, even if he went somewhere other than Guaral, the same vigilance and fear would not fade.

Subaru's pride had been lost in exchange for five deaths.

Subaru: "—If that's the case, what if I sell you out to the enemy?"

His way out blocked, and having been abused for thoughtlessness, Subaru asked the question, his face looking twisted.

In an instant, the words Subaru had uttered turned the air of the meeting room tense. At the edge of his vision, he could clearly see Rem next to him, her eyes wide.

However, the one he had threatened to sell out, Abel, gave a small laugh.

Abel: "Hmm. At last, your head appears to be beginning to function normally. And yet..."

Mizelda: "That's not up for *discussion*, Subaru."

In the blink of an eye, Mizelda drew her dagger and pressed the edge to Subaru's neck.

Subaru gasped at her quick feat, and looked up at the face of the tall tribal chief who had moved instantaneously. Mizelda's eyes conveyed a stubborn conviction on her beautiful face, they were the eyes of a ruthless huntress.

Mizelda: "We've already decided to fight together with *Abel*. That's the result of the Lifeblood Ritual, if it's the desire of the one we've recognized as a *compatriot*, there's nothing for *it*."

Subaru: "...I get that for me, who borrowed your strength to bring back Rem, this is audacious to say. Honestly, are you all okay with that?"

Mizelda seemed resolute, but Subaru's query jumped over her.

As chieftain, Mizelda must personify the way Shudraquians ought to be, and could not be persuaded. Even so, the other Shudraquians could have separate opinions.

The different opinions of those present, Taritta, Kuna, and Holly.

Subaru: “Just a moment ago, this guy also said as much. The gap in military strength is clear, and the opponent’s a greatly experienced courageous General. From the start, you can see you don’t stand a chance fighting him...”

Holly: “Maybe, Subaru’s got the wrong *idea*-.”

Subaru: “The wrong idea...?”

The first one to answer the question as Subaru searched for other opinions was surprisingly Holly.

At the edge of the meeting place, Holly, who had been listening to the conversation as she gnawed on some dried meat, fixed her eyes on Subaru, his movement prevented.

Holly: “If you’re talking about winning or *losing*, drawing back from here is also our *loss*-. If we can’t fight for our *compatriot*, our spirit will be *stained*-.”

Subaru: “A stain on your spirit, you say... Something like pride, or facing your ancestors, that kind of thing?”

Holly: “Yeah *yeah*, you got *it*, Subaru-.”

With a smile, Holly affirmed Subaru’s words.

But rather than that being evidence of mutual understanding, it was proof that they could not understand each other.

Subaru also understood that there were such points of view.

Things like pride and family honor, so to speak, were invisible vindications that did not directly contribute to one’s physical body— Thinking those were a matter of grave concern, certainly there existed attitudes that valued such things above all else.

Yet, as far as that went, it was a way of thinking that could not coexist with Subaru's belief that there was nothing more important than life.

Subaru: "Kuna! Taritta-san! You two share the same opinion!?"

Kuna: "...I don't really think about it as deeply as Holly or the *Chieftain*."

Taritta: "—I will abide by my older sister's *decision*. Since that is my *wish*."

Subaru: "I, see..."

He had fished for information from the other two as well, but Subaru was not able to get his desired response.

He had thought perhaps Kuna would, herself being a bit out of step with the other Shudraquians, but it seemed Subaru's hope was misplaced. Taritta's complete obedience to Mizelda went without saying.

As it was, Subaru was without allies, with a dagger against his neck, and it appeared the deadlock would drag on, but—

Rem: "...Mizelda-san, please withdraw your weapon. That person has no intention to hand Abel over to the enemy."

The one requesting Mizelda pull back her dagger was none other than Rem herself.

Meeting her gaze, Mizelda narrowed those eyes of hers.

Mizelda: "Are you giving me an order, *Rem*? You haven't taken the Lifeblood Ritual. I permitted you into the village on Subaru's *request*, but don't think that means you can backtalk *me*."

Rem: "So, that's all the more reason you should pull back your weapon. That person undertook the ritual... the Lifeblood Ritual as you call it, and was welcomed as a compatriot. To wound him would not be a good thing."

Mizelda: "Unh..."

Mizelda had tried to overpower Rem with her strengthened insight, but her undaunted retort left her at a loss for words. In the end, she swiftly returned her dagger to its sheath on her waist.

And like that Subaru was released, and he stared intently at Rem.

Mizelda: “What you said just now is *correct*. But, if Abel and Subaru’s opinions are divided again, I will side with *Abel*. Don’t forget *it*.”

Rem: “Is it because that person’s eyes are that of a heinous villain with fitting body odor?”

Mizelda: “A bit of sharpness in the eyes has charm *too*. But I have a fondness for beautiful *faces*.”

The touch-and-go situation had calmed down, but the ending exchange was a weak conversation.

In any case, Subaru was freed from the situation of nearly having his throat cut, and he gently rubbed the place where the knife’s edge had been pressed to. And then he looked intently at Rem.

Rem: “—What is it?”

Subaru: “...Nothing, I’m just lost as to whether I should respond to the fact you stood up for me or to the fact you disparaged my face.”

Rem: “I said nothing of your face. I spoke of your eyes. Then your body odor. My nose is wrinkling. Please sit further away.”

Subaru: “This again...!?”

Met with Rem’s glacial attitude, Subaru was hurt by the distance she made him sit away.

Yet inside his heart more complicated confusion plagued Subaru. In reality, why had she spoken up in defense of Subaru? He did not understand her true motive.

Nevertheless, maybe she disliked turning a blind eye to something illogical, or maybe it was something else. Maybe thinking that was Subaru’s bias?

After all, she had not unpacked at the inn in Guaral, so—

Abel: “Our conversation was interrupted. However, even supposing you were able to evade the Shudraquians’ eyes, the idea of selling me over to the enemy is futile.”

Subaru: “...Good job getting us back on track. While we’re at it, I’ll ask. Why’s that?”

Abel: “You also spent time in the city, albeit briefly. That being the case, did news of how the current Imperial Capital is being governed not reach your ears?”

Subaru: “The Imperial Capital you say... Ah! Right, that’s right! You’re...”

In sudden understanding, Subaru stood up on the spot without thinking. Then, as he focused on his visible surroundings he called out “Flop-san!”

Not having kept up with the change of affairs, the astonished Flop turned around with a “Yeah?”

Flop: “Wha-wha-wha-what is it Husband-kun? Honestly, I’m feeling extremely confused and bewildered right now, I’m becoming a mess! I’m not following this conversation in the slightest, all I know is it feels like we’re getting to the climax of the issue!”

Subaru: “Sorry for leaving you out of the loop, but confirm something for me. In Guaral you talked about the official notice from the Imperial Capital... or rather, about the Emperor’s proclamation.”

Flop: “The Emperor’s proclamation... You mean the trouble in the Imperial Capital?”

Flop snapped his fingers, and Subaru nodded at his understanding.

Immediately after, the intense fight with Todd, having been repeated six-fold, had been severely burned into his brain, but he had also exchanged such talk with Flop in Guaral.

Reflecting on the matter in question, Flop smoothed down his own long hair,

Flop: “Embers smolder in the Empire, and there’s some kind of disturbance in the Imperial Capital. The current Emperor has been reigning for a long time, and with no signs of civil war, imperial citizens have been enjoying peaceful days. But then this happened.”

Subaru: “Talk of trouble in the Imperial Capital has spread outside, and you said the Emperor himself had set out to resolve it, right? It was a kind of unusual announcement but...”

Flop: “Right. Actually, this is the first time since the current Emperor took the Throne. Nonetheless, he has an excellent track record managing the Empire so far. So I’m not worried! Viva Vollachia!”

Raising both hands, Flop unconsciously gouged Subaru’s old wound.

Those were the words extolling the Empire that he had heard so often in the Imperial encampment, but now Subaru did not have the presence of mind to innocently go along with it.

In any case, the problem was not the praise, but the movement of the Emperor that was spoken of just before.

That the Emperor was directly starting to move in order to suppress trouble in the Imperial Capital was an unprecedented situation. Not to mention, in the event that the Emperor were to do something like issuing a command before the public—

Subaru: “The you that’s here now, who are you and what kind of position are you in? Can you prove you aren’t some crazy nutcase with a screw loose?”

Abel: “Proof you say? Where is the need for that?”

Subaru: “What?”

Sitting with his knee raised, Abel snorted at Subaru’s skepticism. At the same time, he put his hand on his chest and, like he was trying to flaunt his own existence, spoke,

Abel: “Never mind the thoughtless ones who have turned on me. Seeing as you have reached a point of no return, if you were to still treat me as an insolent person who speaks nonsense, how do you explain the situation you have found yourself in?”

Subaru: “That’s...”

Abel: “Cease latching onto facile ideas that cannot fool even yourself, merely to obtain peace of heart. If you exclude the possibilities that do not align together at the precise time, what is left is nothing but the truth.”

Abel’s statement was harsh, but Subaru bitterly understood the logic behind it.

The oni-masked man in front of him was a fake being disguised as an Emperor and Subaru and also the People of Shudraq were being deceived by his falsehoods. That kind of development would lead to doom beyond saving and above that, was hard to believe.

In reality, Abel had utilized the Shudraqians' strength and the information obtained from Subaru to fight and win against the Imperial army. That real occurrence was something that could not be explained away by a habitual liar.

Subaru: "Then, what about the Imperial Capital stuff? If it's said that the Emperor directly took command, there's no way the Emperor wouldn't come out in front of people."

Abel: "I suppose they would then. A fake remarkably similar to myself... To halt mentions of the Emperor's absence, an exceptionally well-made double is used— Chisha Gold."

Subaru: "Chisha...?"

It was a name he had not heard before, but they were Abel's— No, they were the Emperor's body double.

In a land where the imperialistic "might makes right" ideology inhabited, it was easy to imagine that in preparation for assassinations, the Emperor would arrange for a body double.

However, having said body double be used by the enemy to usurp the seat of the Emperor was quite the misplacement of priorities.

Abel: "Silence, I am aware."

Subaru: "Right, thanks to you, we're in quite a mess. If only the Empire was at peace..."

The only problem Subaru needed to have was the salty interactions from the amnesiac Rem.

To reunite with Emilia and the others, a journey to struggle and escape the Vollachian Empire was to unfold. That was all it had to be. But now, due to some fate, they were in this mess.

Flop: "Um, um, ah, y'know, Husband-kun."

The one who called out to the sour-faced Subaru was Flop.

Wrinkling the space between his eyebrows of his graceful face, he tilted his head at a rather steep angle and,

Flop: “I’ve been thinking about it ever since I heard it before, but what you’re talking about with Village Chief-kun is a bit mysterious, isn’t it? To be honest, I’m still shocked because of your joke about causing the fall of Guaral but...”

Subaru: “A joke... No, don’t mind that. Umm, Flop-san, I’ve been meaning to explain but.”

Flop: “Yes, please explain, if you could! If not, I have no choice but to agree to somewhat accept what I hear without question.”

Saying that, Flop whipped his finger to Abel and poked it out towards him. Then——

Flop: “I have to agree to the absurd idea that Village Chief-kun over there is His Excellency the Emperor himself!”

Subaru: “———”

Flop: “Hohohoho? I’m conflicted if you stay silent there, Husband-kun. Thankfully, I have a reputation for jumping to conclusions. That’s why I have the flexibility to change and withdraw my opinion, you know...”

Abel: “——You, you have done something akin to drawing improperness into art.”

If they were trying to hide it, it was a conversation lacking the consideration to do so.

That was why, sitting next to Subaru, Flop was able to naturally reach the correct conclusion. And, being able to do so by himself, Abel was showing displeasure at that.

Putting disdain into his gaze, the one he had insulted with “improper” was Subaru. He was pointing out how Subaru had not made any of the situation clear to Flop, having brought him into the Shudraqian settlement.

However, accepting Abel’s disdain was difficult for Subaru.

Subaru: “I’m improper? Like you could say that! First off, even I know that that’s not something you can say out loud all willy-nilly.”

Abel: “Then, finish your ascertainment before bringing them here. It seems you still lack an understanding of the current situation. While being chased by enemies in Guaral, the time provided for thinking should have been more than enough.”

Subaru: “———”

Abel: “Putting something more important than yourself by your side, why did you give in to your thoughts. If you had no intention to line them beside yourself, bringing them back was a mistake from the start.”

“Something more important than yourself”, being told that, Subaru thought about Rem beside him.

The words that followed that also hurt Subaru like his flesh being cut open— What Abel was trying to say was clear as day. He was speaking on how Subaru had left himself exposed at a time he should have been protecting Rem.

Of course, Subaru had no recollection of putting his guard down or giving in at all.

However, in the eyes of Abel, whose thought process spun far deeper and farther than Subaru could, Subaru’s own was severely lacking. It was never enough, and never worth considering.

“Do not bring back someone who could not be trusted with the details”, that was how he was being criticized.

Subaru thought to not involve Flop and Medium in things. Abel exposed Subaru’s naive thought and coldly discarded it, saying that it was idiotic and stupid.

Subaru: “I...”

Flop: “——Village Chief-kun! Could I interrupt this discussion for a moment?”

Subaru was at a loss for words; but in his place, Flop energetically raised his hand.

Noisily advancing forward, he dropped into a cross-legged position with a thud and faced Abel’s oni mask head on.

Flop: “Or, perhaps you are not the Chief? How should I address you?”

Abel: “As of now I bear no title. I have taken the name of Abel, but you may call me what you like.”

Flop: “Is that so! Then, I’ll keep calling you Village Chief-kun, because it feels right. The lady soldiers over there don’t mind right?”

Mizelda: “*Ahh, you’re a sexy man. I’ll allow anything.*”

Taritta: “Sister...”

Putting aside the almost customary interaction between the sisters, Flop laughed with a “My thanks!”. As he did so, he strongly slapped his knees with his hands and,

Flop: “I’m scared because you didn’t deny it for the longest time, but I want to talk about what you said before the previous thing you said. Village Chief-kun, you wanted to ask about hidden routes into the city...?”

Abel: “Yes, I did. Any ideas, merchant?”

Flop: “I do! Is how it seemed I was going to answer, but apologies. If that’s going to be used to attack Guaral then I cannot answer.”

Putting a palm forward, Flop stated so with a cheerful expression.

Listening by his side, Subaru widened his eyes at Flop’s plain and resolute words. Even Abel had narrowed his eyes an inch from behind his oni mask.

That was how much seriousness Flop had put into his words, even if it did not show in his tone.

Abel: “———”

Flop’s statement was rather wild and made him stand out, but that was not because he was stupid.

He had also come to the conclusion that the true identity of the man in front of him, of Abel, was that of someone of high class and esteem. He had not been told he was right or wrong, so he figured his conjecture was close to the truth.

Meaning, he had, against the presumed Emperor, answered with a big “NO”.

Abel: “...Do you comprehend the meaning of what you have said?”

Flop: “You are nothing but a Chief, right, Village Chief-kun? Of course I do. If swords were to cross, I will reject that. I want to avoid causing harm to someone with the knowledge I hold.”

Abel: “That is a fairytale. In reality, something like malice will attack you without considering your personal history. You would raise your fist against all of that and request for them to withdraw?”

Flop: “If need be!”

Abel: “Even if you do, your efforts will bear no fruit— This is the land of wolves.”

A ghastly, freezing aura emanating from Abel’s body pierced through the air as he stated that.

The dreadful feeling of oppression from that was not because of their difference in strength. It manifested from the difference of their presences. Even Rem and the People of Shudraq, who would overwhelm Abel if they were to fight, held their breath and froze up.

Of course, Subaru was intimidated too, to the point his breathing had become irregular. Flop was not excluded from this feeling too.

However, while Flop was hit by the Emperor’s dreadful aura—

Flop: “Even in a land of wolves, sheep also live. If wolves were to come bite my buttocks, I would ride my ox cart and run away with my sister. I’ve repeated that over and over ‘til this day, Village Chief-kun.”

Abel: “———”

Even if his cheeks were frozen, Flop’s smile would not disappear. That was his protest.

Hearing that, the demonic aura emanating from Abel suddenly defused. The oppressive air that had swept over the meeting area suddenly disappearing, Subaru got back the ability to breathe freely.

Nevertheless, even if he had obtained some leeway to take a breath, Subaru's heart was in no shape to return to normal.

Subaru: "Ahh, Flop-san..."

Subaru called over to Flop with a raspy voice. The smile Flop showed to Subaru as the latter glanced over to him was bright.

It was close to a wry smile, but the side profile of Flop showed no sign of regret. However, even if he were to hold no regrets, for Subaru, who had brought him here in the first place, his regret would only grow exponentially.

For Flop had directly opposed the Vollachian Emperor.

Using that reason to incur Abel's displeasure, Abel could do anything to Flop as he held command of the People of Shudraq.

However, contrary to Subaru's worries—

Abel: "—Opposing my lazy argument, I can see your belief does not waver. A troublesome one you are, are you not, merchant?"

Flop: "Is that right? Even so, I acknowledge that my appearance is favorable to people you know!"

Mizelda: "I *agree*."

Pocketing his aura, Abel did not point his spear of anger towards Flop.

Flop reacted to that in a way that made it unclear if he had realized how dangerous of a tightrope he was walking on. No comment on Mizelda's remark.

Abel: "I shall withdraw my gratitude from before, Natsuki Subaru."

Subaru: "Huh?"

Subaru, unable to restore a sense of peace in his heart from before, was spoken to by Abel.

From behind his oni mask, the man with a sharp gaze nodded towards the stubborn Flop and,

Abel: “Your self-awareness is lacking but, if you were planning to bring someone, you should have brought someone more aligned to my interests. That way, things would be done without future complications.”

Subaru: “...If it were someone like that, I doubt they’d have been kind to us in the first place.”

Abel: “Hm, I suppose that judgement is correct. How aggravating.”

If the earlier gratitude had been given for bringing Flop along, then the obstinance Flop had shown certainly made Abel want to retract the commendation.

No way, Flop was snapping at the Emperor’s authority directly— No, he should say he was eluding it like a willow. Subaru had not thought there were people who would take such a stance.

Not to mention, it had also been unexpected that Abel would tolerate such an attitude from Flop.

Rem: “I expected Abel-san to be more obstinate.”

Subaru: “Hold on, Rem!?”

Rem’s brief comment seemed to reflect Subaru’s heart, and his eyes widened involuntarily.

In truth he also found that surprising, but he had not spoken because he thought there was nothing to be gained by saying it. It had come from Rem, and Abel’s oni mask turned toward her.

The oni and the oni mask faced one another, and for a moment the space between both of them yielded silence.

Abel: “—People with convictions are worrisome. Strong roots spread, and build up strength in the trunk.”

Rem: “...What, does that mean?”

Abel: “You cannot tell? No matter, it is a trifle.”

Rem knit her brow, hearing Abel’s quiet and somewhat uncharacteristic response. Displaying some disappointment towards Rem’s reply, Abel loosely shook his head.

No one knew the reason for his disappointment. Subaru however, could roughly guess as to what it was.

Subaru: "...Were you alluding to something?"

Abel: "Hoo, that was unexpected. You do not look like the type of person to have received an education."

Subaru: "I figured it was something of the sort. You sounded like you were quoting someone else."

Hearing Abel unexpectedly talk like a normal person was surprising.

However, the person in question, Abel, heeded no mind in having his true thoughts revealed and answered shortly with an "I see".

Abel: "As for your question from before, to say it was unexpected of me, you have quite the impression of me, do you not? First off, what did you expect me to do?"

Rem: "...I thought for sure you would at least torture them for information."

Questioned by Abel, the impression that Rem left with her answer was that of being too honest.

Saying that however, it was not an option that Subaru had not considered as well. If Abel wanted to make Flop obey to his will, it would be unsurprising if he ordered the Shudraqians to torture or perform other similar things to him.

Except, Abel shrugged his shoulders at those words and replied saying "It is useless."

Abel: "Certainly, there are times when pain is the best negotiation tactic. However, the veracity of the information extracted from that method is extremely low. Humans will lie without hesitation to free themselves from the pain before them."

Rem: "-----"

Abel: "And were you in such a scenario, your eyes tell me you would shield them with your life."

That was how Abel assessed Rem, who was motionlessly directing her stare at him.

Looking at Rem's side profile, her jaw was clenched shut and her pretty features were on the verge of being wiped away by a look of grim resolve. Her side profile made clear that Abel's brief assessment was true.

Abel: “I will not risk a foolish action that may reduce my troops in exchange for information low in accuracy— Therefore, I shall negotiate.”

Flop: “Negotiate?”

Abel: “Merchant, I will buy any knowledge you possess. Let us negotiate for that.”

Abel said, while lowering his raised knee and plunking down into a cross-legged position. Hearing that, Flop widened his eyes and faced Abel with a smile on his face. Then—

Flop: “When I hear the word negotiation, as a merchant, I can’t help but get excited. However! Before we start negotiating, let me get one thing straight. I’m very stubborn. Even if my head were to be split and smashed open, I won’t comply with anything I can’t agree on.”

Such was his declaration.



Subaru: “Even if your head were to be split open, that’s not funny at all... It’s not funny at all, Flop-san.”

Recalling Flop’s caustic words that kicked off the negotiation battle just before, Subaru made a bitter face.

Flop did not do it purposely, but having seen his head be split and smashed open multiple times in reality, his words had the impact of a surprise attack on Subaru.

Subaru: “———”

Narrowing his eyes, Subaru looked over at the meeting area from a hill slightly away.

Even now, in the meeting area, Abel and Flop’s negotiations, or “business talks”, were underway.

Abel wanted a foothold, required for the conquest of Guaral. Flop had the knowledge needed for that task, yet was not revealing it. That was the situation inside at the moment.

The reason Subaru had left the meeting area was because it was ordered that anyone unneeded for the negotiations was to be excluded. Basically, he was ordered out by Abel.

And, Subaru himself could not come up with a reason for him to stay at that place.

Subaru: “Using secret paths to enter the city, a blitzkrieg attack to go straight for the enemy general’s throat.”

Kicked out of the meeting, Subaru savored the jungle-scented wind as he recollected his memories.

From what he had heard, the plan Abel had outlined was something like that.

Although simple, it was difficult to come up with any other plan that would overcome the difference in manpower. If there was anything to change or add, it would be to attract attention in the city with a diversion, or perform little tricks to reduce the enemy general’s guards.

As for any problems with the plan—

Subaru: “Simple plans are easily anticipated. At least I think so... Especially if Todd’s against us.”

If there were no other methods of attack, then of course, the opponent would also take precautions against it.

Therefore, a plan that the enemy was already taking precautions against was, in baseball terms, something like throwing a straight ball right down the middle. From the perspective of the awaiting enemy, it would be a mouth-watering, easy ball to bat.

For Todd to miss this swing, Subaru could not fathom the idea of that happening.

Subaru: “Or am I being too paranoid? In the extreme case Todd was... If the average soldier is like Todd, then there’s no chance of winning.”

He did not know. There were far too many unknowns. But, he did not want that to be true.

He did not want to think of a scenario in which enemies like Todd existed, other than Todd. His affinity with Return by Death being the worst had been proven by pain, having piled up the most deaths in the shortest amount of time.

To think that that was the norm for the Vollachian Empire was—

???: “—The negotiations seem to be dragging on.”

Subaru: “———”

Subaru had at some point covered his face with his hands and shut his vision off from the world.

While Subaru was staring into the black void, the voice of a girl he had gotten used to hearing reached his eardrums. He had gotten used to hearing it, but it was a voice he wanted to always continue listening to.

However, that was only when Subaru’s heart and feelings were at peace.

Subaru: “Rem...”

Lowering the hands covering his face, Subaru nervously opened his eyelids. Resting on her cane, Rem stood quietly on the gentle slope of the hill. Her gaze pierced through Subaru, causing him to go rigid.

Right now, being able to stand face-to-face with Rem like this made his heart throb.

During the days spent coming back to the People of Shudraq’s settlement, Subaru had focused his anger on Abel, because his actions were equivalent to setting them up in a trap.

In doing so, it could be said he was avoiding talking with Rem. In reality, that was not wrong. He was scared of conversing with her and finding out about her true intentions.

That was why, he averted his eyes from the things he did not like and attempted a makeshift solution.

Nevertheless, there was a limit on how much he could run from the things he did not like.

There was a limit, and henceforth—

Subaru: “———”

Right now, he had no choice but to face himself against her eyes filled with seriousness.

Rem: “Abel-san seems to be adding various conditions and such, but Flop-san doesn’t seem to be budging at all.”

Subaru: “...Yeah, he’s a good person. He doesn’t want to help by providing knowledge that could get someone hurt. Being surrounded by the Shudraquians, he has some serious courage to be able to say that.”

Subaru had overseen the progress of the negotiations for a while, but Flop’s stubbornness was exactly as he proclaimed.

The focal point of the discussion was as expected, the casualties in the City of Guaral. People and material things—Flop had made clear that he would not compromise on both those things.

Abel had promised to minimize the human casualties as much as possible, but that was not enough to be the deciding factor.

Like parallel lines, they could not meet and reach an agreement.

Towards Flop’s stubborn attitude, Subaru also felt relief.

Shunning war, he rebutted Abel head on.

He was relieved that another person of such ilk was here, other than him. However—

Rem: “I don’t think this is the type of situation where you can simply say he’s a good person.”

Subaru: “...What?”

In opposition to Subaru who affirmed himself to Flop’s attitude, Rem quietly revealed her strong criticisms.

Surprised at the bite of her words, Subaru unconsciously stared at Rem. Though difficult to meet face-to-face with, and despite his wish to avoid it, in his field of vision, Rem stared straight at Subaru.

Without dropping her gaze, she continued on.

Rem: “He doesn’t want to hurt others with his knowledge. I understand those feelings. But... if you think about the overall situation, him included, how will he account for the casualties that will arise because he didn’t share his knowledge. Couldn’t you say that would be hurting others with knowledge as well?”

Subaru: “That’s just an argument for argument’s sake. Trying to blame Flop for all the casualties brought about because he doesn’t talk, that’s just a false accusation.”

Rem: “That may be right. But, I do not think it’s realistic to be constantly running away.”

Abel had declared that this was the Land of Wolves. And against that, Flop had proclaimed that sheep would run.

That was a fairytale, was what Rem pessimistically—No, realistically thought, and said. She was yet another person who had stepped foot into Guaral. The tenacity and relentlessness of the Imperial Soldiers seeped deep into her bones.

Could they shake off that oppressive pursuit again?

Under determined opposition and not vague malicious intent, could Flop, with Medium, keep running to the ends of the world?

And, could Subaru’s group, who shared the same fate as them, be able to—

Subaru: “Hang, hang on Rem. What you’re saying is crazy. You also said before that you didn’t want there to be a battle. But, the way you’re saying it now...”

Rem: “———”

Subaru: “It’s like you’ve accepted that we have to fight.”

His throat trembled. Subaru was unable to get his words out properly.

But, just like how it was said that the eyes could say more than the mouth, in Subaru and Rem’s precarious conversation, it was not just their words that spelled out their feelings. Their gazes did too.

The grim resolve that colored her eyes was the same as the one when she had defended Flop against Abel. That was what Subaru thought.

Subaru: "...It hurts that I can't understand you."

Seeing that attitude of hers on display, Subaru spit out the honest feelings floating in his heart.

She had criticized Flop for following Subaru's beliefs, but she regarded Subaru with the same eyes she used when defending Flop, when the latter was laying out his beliefs.

She had defended Subaru from Abel but she had not unpacked at the inn in Guaral. The interactions between the awakened Rem and Subaru were always inconsistent and one-way.

From the bottom of his heart, he was happy that she had woken up.

The sadness that assaulted him due to her memories not returning, he believed that they could find a way to solve that problem.

Nevertheless, in the Empire, where there was nobody he could trust from the bottom of his heart, from where he had to bring Rem back to Emilia and the others, her uncooperative attitude was like a knife piercing through his leg.

Every time that would happen, he would be on the verge of hunching over in pain.

Subaru: "...You didn't unpack at the inn in Guaral, right? Thanks to that, we reduced the time needed to escape, but I always thought it was weird."

Rem: "That was..."

Subaru: "The average person, after reaching an inn, will relax and settle down or start unpacking their luggage. At least, that's what I think. Of course, it's always possible that you aren't that sort of person. But..."

He did not want to finish the rest of that sentence.

If he could continue averting his eyes he would, but now that he felt he could not avoid questioning Rem on her inexplicable attitude, he could not continue averting his eyes.

That was why—

Subaru: “But, you tried to run away from me again, didn’t you?”

Rem: “———”

Rem’s silence was piercing. Subaru felt the blood coursing through his body.

However, a scab already peeled had no use. Letting the blood flow, heeding no mind to the exposed wound, he could only peel it off. Enduring the pain.

Subaru: “If... If you can’t believe me, that’s fine. It’s painful, but I get it. You don’t have any memories and for you, my smell reeks like that of someone unforgivable. Also, I don’t have anything to prove that you can trust me. I understand why you can’t believe me and want to distance yourself from me.”

Rem: “———”

Subaru: “But, the people waiting for you... The people who hold you dear in their hearts, are real. If you don’t like me, you don’t have to talk to me. I’ll endure it if you bat my hands away. But, please don’t try to leave.”

Rem: “———”

Subaru: “I’m begging you, so, please... Please don’t shut me out from your life.”

His begging voice was shaking, his eyes were on the verge of tears.

Whether those droplets of tears that gradually appeared were the result of his self-pity, or of his petition to Rem, was unknown even to himself.

Truly, he was just being exceedingly pathetic. It was so absurd it made him laugh.

Even if he was not given up on, it would not be surprising were he to be abandoned because of his begging right now.

—He continued to expose his hopeless and pitiful self in front of Rem.

It was a sight he would definitely not show to Emilia, Beatrice or his other friends.

At least, Subaru intentionally strived to not show it to his friends. Never mind if he was able to actually achieve that, that was what he had done now.

Because he had decided to show his weakness only in front of Rem.

However, that did not mean that he wanted Rem, amnesiac, with no one to rely on, alone in another country, to shoulder the heavy weight that was Natsuki Subaru. That was not at all what he desired.

Rem: “———”

Hearing Subaru’s shameful begging, Rem would not say a word in return.

Nonetheless, Subaru did not avert his blurry, tear-filled gaze from her. Neither did she avert her gaze from Subaru.

A brief silence enveloped the space between them.

Rem: “—I.”

Subaru: “———”

Rem: “I was not trying to abandon you.”

Rem said awkwardly, choosing her words carefully.

That was an emotion Rem had yet to show Subaru. Not even once.

She spoke to the person she should be wary of, with consideration and care. She spoke devoid of a wish to hurt his feelings.

Her words did not sound like she was speaking desperately and without thinking. Her tone made him believe that. Or it could be that that was also Subaru’s hope speaking for him.

Subaru: “Are you...”

Relying on that thin ray of hope, the thread of hope he should not be relying on, Subaru searched for the right words.

What was Rem thinking? What did she wish for? What did she believe in to put those words to her mouth?

Not even knowing if he should be informed of the answers to those questions, Subaru just wanted to hear her voice more, and tried to continue his sentence.

However——

???: “Aaaa, uuuu!!”

Subaru: “Guohh!?”

Faster than he could continue, a force jumped at him around his waist, and Subaru’s body blurred as it was launched to the side.

Unable to support his body at all, Subaru was blown away, sent sprawling on top of the hill. The atmosphere from before being ripped to shreds, Subaru’s head spun as he opened his eyes wide to try and make sense of the situation.

???: “Lou! Don’t sit on top of *Suu*! That’s *bad*! Uu tried to stop *her*. Lou was the one who did *it*.”

Subaru: “U-Utakata...? Meaning, this is...”

The one who ran over with an almost comical pitter-patter footstep, was a slightly flush olive-skinned Utakata. And, the one who was getting her sleeve pulled by Utakata, sitting atop Subaru’s chest, was the young girl who bundled her long, golden hair behind her head——

Rem: “Louis-chan, please come down. That person’s going to get squished.”

Louis: “Uuu?”

Overwriting her joyful and smiley face with a question mark, the one who craned her neck towards Rem’s words was Louis.

Resting her bottom on Subaru’s chest, Louis patted Subaru’s cheeks without a care in the world. It was, however, her carefreeness that got on Subaru’s nerves in the first place.

Subaru: “We’re in the middle of an important conversation. Get off now.”

Louis: “Aaa?”

Subaru: “Don’t aaa me. Utakata, please?”

Utakata: “I’ll listen cause Suu asked for *it*. Uu is a good wife and a good *mother*.”

Did she understand what that meant? In any case, Utakata pulled Louis’s arm to get her off Subaru’s chest. The pressure on him disappearing, Subaru raised his body up on the spot.

Even then, an unsatisfied-looking Louis entered his immediate field of view, and Subaru became annoyed.

Subaru: “In the end, there hasn’t been an answer as to what you are.”

The Sin Archbishop, the evil being, Gluttony, Louis Arneb.

If he were to pick some choice words to decorate the blonde girl in front of him with, he could think of many foul and uncomplimentary remarks. However, even if all those words were what correctly described her before, her current self did not match up with that.

That evil girl did not save Subaru, listen to him, or carelessly laugh towards him. However——

Louis: “Uuu?”

Louis craned her neck. Her actions until now flashed in his mind.

Saving him when Rem had been choking him. She had cried out and faced the many predicaments Subaru had been through, alongside him. Even the most recent one, being Todd and his axe.

The memory of her receiving Todd’s elbow hit and bleeding from the nose was still fresh in his mind.

Her face had no sign of the previous injury, and she acted as if that event had no negative bearing on her at all. That was infuriating in a way, but——

Rem: “Louis-chan.”

Louis: “Uuu!”

Beckoned, Louis quickly changed her expression into a happy one and ran over to Rem’s side.

As if she had learned how to jump on the cane-ridden Rem, Louis jumped on Rem with not too much force. Rem caught Louis and gave her head some soft pats.

She had caught the Sin Archbishop who was one of the reasons for her current state. She had caught one part of them, Louis Arneb.

Rem: “Those eyes of yours...”

Subaru: “Huh?”

Rem: “The eyes with which you look at this child. It puzzles me too. This child, she’s so attached to you, and yet you...”

Subaru: “———”

Rem uttered while hugging Louis’s small body. Subaru fell silent.

Was that the continuation of her interrupted words from before? The Rem who did not unpack at Guaral, the continuation of that would shine a light on the rest of the truth.

However, despite waiting, Rem did not say another word beyond that. She only wrapped the beaming Louis into her chest.

Subaru: “...What do you want me to do?”

Looking over at Rem, Subaru finally chose to use conclusive words.

It might have been an unfair method to make Rem give him an answer. However, if Rem were to brush aside all of Subaru’s chosen words and actions, this was the only option left.

What did Rem wish for, and what did she want him to do? He had to ask her directly.

On top of that, if the answer she brought out was something Subaru could not achieve for her, then it would be that time for sure that their relationship might become unsalvageable. Knowing that, Subaru asked her fearfully.

She held her breath for a moment against Subaru’s question, and,

Rem: "...I do not want it to turn into a battle."

Said that.

Subaru could accept that too. In reality, when the Imperial Army's camp had been reduced to ashes, she thought that Subaru had spearheaded that attack and so flared up at him with a strong, threatening attitude.

Rem did not wish for a war. She did not favor it. That was no mistake.

That was why he understood that her opinion had not changed.

However, just when Subaru was convinced of this fact, she added on that. That was—

Rem: "But I don't think we can keep running forever. Flop-san's words are not realistic. And..."

Subaru: "You can't agree with Abel's opinion."

Rem: "...Yes."

Quietly nodding, Rem agreed with Subaru's question.

Her timid agreement, it was the sign that she held the awareness that the words she spoke were outrageous. And of course they were.

She agreed with Flop's stance on not wanting to fight, she also agreed with Abel on his stance that they had no choice but to fight. That was an ideology that could be said to be an incarnation of opportunism.

In all honesty, even Subaru thought how good it would be if a fence-sitter opinion like that worked out.

Fighting was not desired. But fighting was an inevitable outcome.

They did not want to take lives. Yet, they were at the forefront of a fight where taking lives was inevitable.

They must confront a dichotomy that involved lives.

Rem: "Could you..."

Subaru: “Ah?”

Making a bitter face, Subaru agreed with Rem’s contradictory thinking. However, to that anguishing Subaru, Rem flicked her gaze towards him.

Holding Louis’s head to her chest, she directed her helpless-looking light blue eyes towards Subaru.

Subaru held his breath. As if she quietly hardened her resolve she—

Rem: “—Could you do something about this?”

She asked as if she were clinging onto him for an answer.

Subaru: “———”

The moment he received that question, Subaru froze as if struck by lightning.

It was... That was a completely... A completely unreasonable question.

Compared to Subaru, who thought himself to be unfair and cowardly, this question was far, far worse.

The want to not fight, the knowledge that there was no choice but to fight. A third answer that was neither of those choices— That was what Rem wished from Subaru.

Why?

Forgetting everything and anything, her trust and affection for Subaru had been lost. She also held caution and disgust because of the foul smell that surrounded Subaru. And yet, why had she asked that of Subaru.

Why did Rem look at Subaru with eyes that looked like she was holding onto him?

Subaru: “———”

That extremely one-sided, even selfish question started a fire in Natsuki Subaru.

Even if he were to get angry, curse her out loudly and denounce her naiveness now, he would no doubt be forgiven.



Illustration from Volume 27, coloring by Setowi ([source](#))

That was how selfish the option Rem chose was.

However, what grew in Subaru at that moment was a sense of duty that arose from the very bottom of his soul.

Subaru: “I...”

He must fight.

He must resist.

He knew that he must break open the present as it was now.

Evading combat, the person stopping himself from revealing his information. Flop O’Connell.

Preparing himself from the unavoidable battle, the person who would win his survival. Vincent Abellux.

In the situation they were in now, the inevitable pathways that these two held.

The person that must find an answer; a pathway that was different from these two answers. Natsuki Subaru.

Why was that? That was because—

Subaru: “—I’m the hero that Rem believed in.”

And also, because he was the man that kept on fighting in this other world using only his unwillingness to give up as a weapon.

It was not just his philosophy, the philosophy that did not function just because he crossed borders, that let Natsuki Subaru keep walking until today. That was what he believed.

Meeting Emilia, saved by her, the days spent running to save her.

Clutching Beatrice’s hand, bringing her out of the Forbidden Library, his promise to be together with her.

Saving Rem, being saved by her, loved by her and deciding that he would answer her faith and love.

—Natsuki Subaru’s blood boiled as he strived to change this current, constrained situation.

Something, anything, was there nothing at all?

The days spent in the Kingdom of Lugunica, the days spent since being blasted into the Vollachian Empire, the people he had met, the enemies he had faced, the people who stood next to him, the people who stood opposite him. All of them became fuel.

Think, concentrate, imagine, grasp all the possible possibilities.

In this world, where anyone and everyone was more successful than him, the option that was left for Natsuki Subaru was only one— His scrappy lifestyle and shrewdness.

Then, then, then, then—

Subaru: “—Ah.”

Hit by his uselessness, ruled over by a sense of loss, and with nothing else to do, Subaru had left the meeting area.

In that Subaru, in that Subaru’s mind, a thought appeared with a flash.

Reeling in that clownish possibility, Subaru seriously considered if he could convert this thought into an actual plan.

Rem: “———”

Towards the silent Subaru, Rem’s eyes quietly stared.

Putting a hand on Louis, who looked like she was about to cause a commotion and holding Utakata back, her head tilted, so that she would not leak any words out, she stared at Subaru.

Despite the fact she was not supposed to possess any memories, she stared at him with the eyes she had when she did.

As if she believed that Natsuki Subaru could reach the answer that others could not reach.

And then—

Subaru: “—Rem.”

Holding a hand on his chin, Rem straightened herself at Subaru’s call.

There was no answer. She somehow understood that he did not want one.

However, not noticing her reaction, Subaru quietly held his breath and continued.

Subaru: “What would I do if it were up to me? I found the answer.”



Lumbering, advancing with strong steps on the hard ground, the doors to the meeting area were pushed open.

Looking at the newly-appeared Subaru, the man donning a oni mask flared his nose in dissatisfaction. His attitude conveyed that he had been uncalled for.

Abel: “What is it, Natsuki Subaru? A person like you, one who cannot provide a constructive opinion, has no role for an appearance.”

He had actually been told in reality that he was not called for, and yet, Subaru’s legs did not stop.

Even if he had forgiven Flop’s disrespect, Abel would most likely not forgive Subaru for his, as Subaru held no reverence for him. Feeling the gazes of the faces still remaining in the meeting area, Subaru pressed his legs straight forward.

Standing right next to Abel, looking down at his oni mask up close,

Subaru: “Any developments? You arrogant shit.”

Abel: “———”

Extending his hand, Subaru forcefully peeled the oni mask off Abel’s face.

Mizelda and the other Shudraquians widened their eyes in surprise at his unhesitant action. It went without saying, but Flop too was shocked, laying his eyes upon Abel's true face for the first time.

However, the others' actions did not enter his eyes.

Towards Subaru's question, Abel shifted his demonic face into a cruel expression that would run a chill up anyone's spine. He shook his head curtly, saying "No,"

Abel: "Negotiations are progressing roughly. Contrary to expectations, this merchant is hard to crack."

Subaru: "Is that so. Then, since you're so terrible at being persuasive, I'll persuade him for you."

Abel: "What?"

Abel furrowed his nicely-shaped eyebrows together. Seeing his face, Subaru looked down at Abel with satisfaction.

Next, Subaru turned to face Flop.

Because a conclusion had not been made, Flop was in the middle of arguing with the presumed Emperor head on. Taken aback by the difference in Subaru's expression and attitude, Flop called over to Subaru, saying "Husband-kun?".

Then, towards the two that held differently shaped doubts, Subaru declared.

The contents of that declaration were—

Subaru: "—I got a plan for the bloodless fall of Guaral. If we can fight without any bloodshed, then the two of you can agree on a plan together, don't you think?"

Arc 7 Chapter 21 - Zikr Osman

Light Novel Adaptation found in Volume 27, Intermission “Zikr Osman”

Original Web Novel Chapter — [Complete](#)

Original Translation by Witch Cult Translations ([Kobosuhito](#), [Taurace](#)) — [Complete](#)

—Zikr Osman, General Second-Class of the Vollachian Empire, was known as The Womanizer.

There were many words to describe him, like sex-obsessed, lecherous, and lustful.

For an Imperial Soldier who had to set an example of true strength and gain the respect of his fellow officers, it was a rather disgraceful set of terms.

However, Zikr Osman himself liked being known as The Womanizer.

—No, it would not be an exaggeration to say he took pride in it.

The reason why?

It was because Zikr hated the nickname he had been given before being dubbed The Womanizer.

For a soldier, to be called by such a nickname, was an unbearable humiliation. Thus, he proudly paraded the title of Womanizer, which made his fellow soldiers forget that other nickname.

Anyway, although called such, the meaning of Zikr being labelled the Womanizer differed from that of so-called Casanovas or from the vices of the sort of men who looked down on women.

The Osman household had produced a lineage of soldiers for generations, but in Zikr’s generation the blood had been unbalanced, and, for some reason, the family had only sired females. Born and raised in an environment with four elder sisters and six younger ones, Zikr spent his childhood without even one brother.

Growing up surrounded by sisters on all sides, like most people, Zikr was instilled with various preconceived notions relating to women.

But what made him different from most people whose illusions about women were lost due to the existence of female family members, he instead sought fantasies and idealized outside women.

And then, he parted from his sisters, saddened to let go of their adorable and kind brother, and he started his career as an Imperial Soldier at a young age, making contact with outside women for the first time, and he cracked.

Ever since then, women had been like an ephemeral dream for Zikr Osman, an existence between ideal and reality, a forbidden fruit mixed with love and hate.

Having been raised being knocked about by a great number of women in his family, Zikr held a strong desire to treat women kindly, while also being treated kindly by them. Therefore, he considered it a supreme pleasure to serve women and to be served by them, which he put into practice.

This attitude differed from most of the dominant men of the Empire, which combined with jealousy and contempt for his precise tactics and safe victories, led to the name “Womanizer”.

But, as said at the beginning, Zikr Osman enjoyed that sobriquet.

“The Womanizer”, was it not rather splendid? After all, there were more men who liked women than disliked them, which brought opportunities to speak with many officers.

Zikr’s stance was clear and left no doubt, and his subordinates, knowing their superior officer’s taste, naturally looked up to him as the Womanizer, and respected him.

—“The Womanizer”, was it not rather splendid?

Zikr Osman was the man who had risen to the rank of an Imperial General Second-Class, despite being called such.

With the Emperor ousted from his throne, to squeeze the life out of him, his political opponents had chosen the very best within the limits of their dominion, which was none other than he.

It was surely the threatening General called The Womanizer, Zikr Osman.



From the beginning, Zikr had a hunch that something about the expedition smelled fishy.

Military exercises were held in the area around the Buddheim Jungle in the eastern part of the Empire every year, but this year they had been held earlier, and, including Zikr, only a portion of the commissioned officers had been notified of the expedition's purpose— negotiations with the People of Shudraq.

Zikr: "The People of Shudraq hiding in Buddheim..."

An indigenous people that lived in the Buddheim Jungle, the tribe was known for having a long history.

They were also famous for not emerging out of the considerably-dense jungle, and Zikr had never encountered them first-hand. But, he had heard that they were a matriarchal tribe, and he wished to meet them just once.

Living deep in the jungle, their approach of capturing outside men for use as tools to produce children was also fascinating. Likely, they were all strong, indomitable women, he thought.

Women were good. Strong or weak, gentle or harsh, all flavors.

After all, they could not all be lumped together. Older sisters, and younger sisters too, had times when they were gentle and times when they were harsh, times when they were sweet and times when they were bitter.

If a single woman displayed such kaleidoscopic splendor, how could one think of lumping multiple women together?

Therefore—

Zikr: "To make them swear fealty, or be destroyed... What is the Imperial Capital thinking?"

That was the secret order given behind closed doors to Zikr, before he departed for the expedition.

Word from the Imperial Capital of Lupugana affirmed that this expedition's true purpose was to either win over the People of Shudraq, or annihilate them. He attempted to ascertain that there was no mistake, but the reply from the Imperial Capital remained immutable, and Zikr had no choice but to comply.

However, he had heard about some kind of trouble brewing within the Imperial Capital, so he could imagine that had something to do with the purpose of the expedition on this occasion.

That much was clear from the fact that the common soldiers had been ordered to execute this plan while the purpose of the expedition was hidden from them— what His Excellency the Emperor was thinking, Zikr had no idea.

Zikr: “But then, no one can read that gentleman's deeper intentions, can they?”

—The Seventy-Seventh Emperor of the Sacred Vollachian Empire, Vincent Vollachia.

That was the name of the one who ruled over this Empire, the wisest man of this age, who never allowed others to read the depths of his thoughts.

In the Crystal Palace of the Imperial Capital of Lupugana, His Excellency the Emperor was considered to have a clear view of the entire vast Empire. Even though Zikr was a General Second-Class, his post was far removed from the Imperial Capital, and he had little opportunity to see his countenance. Yet, his ingenuity and renown crossed the distance to reach Zikr's ears.

Within an imperial society in which the strong consumed the weak, greedily climbing was seen as an inevitability.

In a world in which various clans and locales revolted, and the live coals of insurrection would flare up every day, Vincent crushed every problem before it could become a raging inferno.

In the eight years since the inception of his reign, the Vollachian Empire had become astonishingly peaceful.

Blood was spilled, flames were fanned, and lives were lost.

And still, these were the most tranquil days since the founding of the Vollachian Empire.

Therefore, this completely thorough approach towards the People of Shudraq caused Zikr to furrow his brow.

Though he was a perfect son of battle, His Excellency the Emperor avoided battle in some respects. It was not that he loathed war, but that he had deemed it foolishness, and that was the reason for his decisions. That was the supposition Zikr embraced of his own accord.

Perhaps this feeling was because of a sense that he had been betrayed?

???: “No, it’s not like that, General Second-Class Zikr. I understand your thinking, Sir. I’m just a common soldier myself, but I also have to consider all sorts of things.”

Said one of the common soldiers, listening to him with a charming smile.

They were having a moment in a tavern while they were stationed in the Fortress City of Guaral, where the expedition was based. On the nights that Zikr did not spend with women, he enjoyed drinking with his subordinates in such a manner. And in addition, rather than a retinue of high-ranked officers or Generals of the Third-Class, he would drink with lower-ranked ordinary soldiers.

Of course, most soldiers did not particularly want to drink alcohol with their superiors.

Even so, Zikr liked such rituals whenever he went on expeditions, as it helped him understand the thoughts and preferences of the subordinates he traveled with—but on this night, he may have spoken a tad too much.

The soldier he was drinking with that day was an awfully talkative, chatty sort.

As they drank, he was always looking around, brimming with curiosity. When asked what he was thinking about, he joked that he was hypothesizing what would happen if the tavern turned into a battlefield.

An attitude of constant combat readiness, and a lack of timidity towards his superior officer’s company. Such an Imperial mindset combined with his personal affection towards humanity led to him speaking of things he ought not to.

It was not like he had declared the contents of the secret order regarding the People of Shudraq, and though he did not state it explicitly, he got the feeling it was clear from how he had been listened to.

Had he been a spy from another country, Zikr would be executed for such a blunder.

Soldier: “You don’t have to worry, I’ll even be on the frontlines tomorrow by your order, Sir... Really, I’m sure the higher-ups have all sorts of motives, but it’s nothing to do with me.”

As his drunkenness faded and Zikr came to his senses, the soldier spoke as if to reassure him.

And then just as he had stated, he had departed for the encampment of the expedition at the frontlines, the camp site adjacent to the Buddheim Jungle.

This was confirmed, and as he remained in the city Zikr was once again faced with a lump of unease in his chest.

In spite of the Imperial Capital’s order for a completely thorough approach to the Shudraqians, urging either subjugation or death, if at all possible, Zikr intended to stick to a persuasive approach.

That was what Zikr put his faith in, and what he thought was closest to His Excellency the Emperor’s conviction.

However—

Zikr: “—The camp was burned down in a Shudraqian attack?”

Receiving the unexpected report at the requisitioned City Hall, Zikr was aghast.

Until last night, up till that very moment, he had intended to do as much as possible to accommodate the Shudraqians, and win over their tribe without a fight.

The camp had been set up in order to wall in the western side of the Buddheim Jungle, and when several of those from the People of Shudraq had charged, the Imperial Soldiers were routed without so much as a counterattack.

Those who fled were struck in the back, furthering the extent of the damage, leading to over a hundred casualties.

Zikr: “Ridiculous...”

Whether he was grumbling about his own decisions, the actions of the Shudraqians, or just the reality of it, even Zikr himself did not know.

Nevertheless, the amicable plan he had constructed in his head had collapsed, and the only thing that was certain was that the People of Shudraq had become enemies of his own Imperial Soldiers— No, of His Excellency the Emperor.

Zikr: “It is a shameful circumstance, but we will wait for reinforcements from the Imperial Capital, and defeat the Buddheim Jungle insurgents.”

Once they had received the soldiers who had narrowly escaped the Shudraqians’ raid into the city, and the appearance of an expeditionary force was arranged, Zikr came to that decision.

There was also the alternative of invading the jungle and fighting the Shudraqians with their present military strength. But the dense forest was those women’s domain, and they were quite capable of neutralizing a superficial advantage in numbers.

To secure a certain victory, rather than a superficial advantage, an overwhelming advantage was required.

And in addition to that, they would abandon lenient approaches like seeking negotiations, with elite soldiers for the purpose of annihilation.

Zikr: “Foolishly, they have swatted away the hand extended to them in peace. That being the case, we must act out of loyalty to His Excellency the Emperor, and bring down deadly retribution upon the insurgents without exception.”

And like that, once he had disciplined himself, even the warmth of his heart, of Zikr Osman, the Womanizer, was extinguished.

Even if his opponent was the matriarchal tribe of the People of Shudraq, every fragment of that bloodline must be destroyed, so they would not become a concern in the future.

For that reason—

Zikr: “Do not be caught off-guard preparing to close the main gate. I hear the People of Shudraq’s specialty is their bows, but they cannot pass through the walls of the Fortress City. Avoid leaving room for them to break through.”

He got information from the returned soldiers on the particulars of how the front lines of the camp had been razed by fire, and bearing in mind that the fires had been set by a select few, he shifted to a total defense plan.

Based on what was known of the Shudraqians’ lifestyle, it was difficult to imagine that the tribe’s entirety was numerous, and it did not seem likely that all members of the tribe could fight, children and elderly included.

If he supposed that their fighting strength was approximately a hundred people at most, in order to compete with the Imperial Soldiers, they could only take advantage of the dark of night for things like surprise attacks.

But even so, a method of preemptive strike would only bear on an opponent whose guard was lowered from a lack of attacks.

Zikr: “See to it that every hole is filled! Even the walls of the Fortress City are not solid. With its long history, I can imagine there being plenty of ways to pass through to the outside without using the gates. Do not overlook any sort of secret passage!”

???: “On that point, a report for you, Sir. Some of the soldiers who returned from the burned camp are already preparing for an outside attack by going around and blocking off secret passages.”

Zikr: “Is that right? It is heartening that there are soldiers besides Generals who have the guile to anticipate. Once this matter is put to rest, we must start giving promotions again. But for now...”

???: “—Sigh. Until reinforcements arrive, our stance will be total defense, right.”

Hearing Zikr’s instructions, his subordinate, a General Third-Class, bowed deeply at the waist.

Were these the words of an ordinary General, they would be ridiculed for such a passive approach. In fact, Zikr had formerly been the target of that kind of scornful laughter.

But, Zikr had already borne a severe blow from the opposing People of Shudraq, and if he were to return to the Imperial Capital he would not be in a position to escape some form of punishment.

With his back already to the wall, there was no reason not to take the very best measures in this situation.

His subordinates knew this as well, so they did not sneer at Zikr's stance.

And then——



Zikr: "...Excuse me?"

Confined within the Fortress City of Guaral. Zikr, resuming said operation, raised his eyebrow in irritation at his subordinate's report.

In the days spent waiting for reinforcements from the Imperial Capital to arrive and maintaining the gradually rising tension, the report brought out deep emotions that were exceedingly out-of-place in Zikr.

For as to why that was——

Subordinate: "Yes. It seems, in these past few days in the city, a troupe of travelling entertainers have become the topic of conversation."

Zikr: "Travelling entertainers..."

The report received from the subordinate was quite the carefree and leisurely kind.

It was an ill-suited report, considering the tense time of war they were in. However, there was no reason to reprimand the subordinate who had relayed it.

In the first place, it was Zikr himself who disliked intentionally forcing onto citizens a lifestyle in which they must acknowledge they were under wartime.

Even under normal conditions, discontent would easily build up in cities where troops were stationed. And, depending on the situation, being unable to manage public sentiments would lead to annihilation. That was how far the situation could progress.

Under that line of thinking, Zikr purposely did not carry out any action that would strongly restrict the opinions people held.

Staying vigilant against the threats outside of the city; preventing any infiltration from the People of Shudraq by authorizing his troops to perform thorough searches without exception. By doing this, he allowed the citizens to continue with their everyday lives.

He understood it to be contradictory, but that was the compromise between Zikr's commonsense and his military instincts.

In any case, because he had taken a position to do things this way, the day-to-day entering and exiting of the city—the security check placed at the front gate and the handling of merchants and peddlers, would remain unchanged.

For that reason, it was probably fine to let something like a band of travelling entertainers into the city, but—

Zikr: "...What do you propose with that information? If you are asking to keep them under strict control, I would very much prefer not doing so. Look around us. I can understand why the townsfolk would celebrate that troupe."

It was a situation where a non-negligible amount of Imperial Soldiers, together with the guards there stationed, were maintaining patrol around the city.

Having escaped the raid, many of the soldiers who entered the city had heightened their hostility and alertness towards the People of Shudraq, and, despite orders to be mindful, disputes with the citizens were constant.

It was not hard to imagine that a party of travelling entertainers appearing in the city during all this would bring a modest amount of peace for the citizenry. Therefore, if they were to take that away—

Zikr: "The citizens' antagonism will erupt. You understand, do you not?"

Subordinate: “Of course, your words exactly, Sir. That is why, I am not suggesting that we place them under strict control. Just...”

Zikr: “Just what? You are making this seem more important than what it truly is.”

Raising an eyebrow, Zikr impatiently urged the hesitant subordinate to continue his sentence.

Then, after a minute of silence, the subordinate lowered his head as if in resignation. Displaying his respect and non-hostility towards his superior officer by putting a fist on his palm, the subordinate controlled his breathing with a “Hah”, and,

Subordinate: “Actually that troupe... Those dancers are quite impressive but, your thoughts, Sir? What do you make of seeing them once too?”

Zikr: “Me? It is not that dancers are not tempting for me too, but...”

Hearing his subordinate’s unexpected proposal, Zikr widened his eyes in surprise.

His history with this subordinate was long, and they had walked on many worthy battlefields together. It was unthinkable that he would bring up this proposal without any thought to it.

However, Zikr could not infer the real reason as to why his subordinate wanted to show the dancers to Zikr.

Subordinate: “Sir, I cannot be saying this out too loud but discontent within the troops is also increasing.”

Zikr: “Mm...”

The subordinate straightened himself and disclosed that to the puzzled Zikr.

The grave observation told to Zikr naturally made his eyes narrow. When he wordlessly encouraged his subordinate to keep talking, the subordinate slightly lowered his voice and,

Subordinate: “They have certain thoughts about the reinforcements from the ungenerous Imperial Capital, but they seem to have doubts about you too, Sir, who decided to coop up in the city and take a defensive stance. There is also the case with the burnt encampment.”

Zikr: “—I see. No, that is a natural reaction.”

Receiving his subordinate’s unreserved explanation, Zikr felt something heavy settling at the back of his chest.

It was inevitable that the Soldiers’ discontent and distrust towards Zikr would accumulate and fester. Allowing the People of Shudraq to execute their preemptive strike, and in turn causing the death of numerous soldiers, had been Zikr’s fault.

After that event, the troops they reunited with were not given a chance to recover. So it was no surprise that they aimed their displeasure towards Zikr.

Subordinate: “Among the more critical gossipers, they call you, Sir, a—”

Zikr: “—Not another word.”

Subordinate: “—Hk, excuse my impudence.”

Interrupting his subordinate’s ongoing sentence, Zikr placed a hand on his forehead.

If a superior officer were to be passive towards their subordinates’ attitudes and discontent towards their superior, Zikr could imagine the curses those subordinates would spit out. He could think of those unbearable and straightforward slurs.

Even after receiving the position of General Second-Class, he could not come to accept those kinds of insults.

And, only when his thinking led him to this point, did he figure out what the intention behind his subordinate’s proposal had been.

Zikr: “I see now. Essentially, prepare a space where the troops’ grievances can be erased, is what you are saying.”

Subordinate: “Correct. Can we not utilize the dancers for this task? Once they see that splendid song and dance, many of the men will...”

Zikr: “Hohoho, I see. You speak as if you have seen them before.”

Zikr narrowed his eyes and pursued his suspicions, but the subordinate cleared his throat and avoided a straight answer. However, his reaction was more than enough evidence that Zikr's hunch was correct.

In any case, he was stuck in a position between that of a General and that of a Soldier, and so, his place was a difficult one.

As he was trying to obtain the method to heal the relationship between the two, to press him further was to quite literally embody the word "petty".

Additionally, this subordinate had seen these dancers of sorts with his own eyes, and had strongly proposed to use them to great extent.

Zikr: "I believe those dancers are extremely beautiful?"

Subordinate: "Of course! Ah, ahem, no doubt they will suit your eyes, Sir. Their dancing, the musician's song and performance are splendid too..."

Zikr: "Hmhm, that does raise my expectations quite a bit."

Even when responding in kind, Zikr thought their descriptions to be slightly exaggerated.

Thinking that however, it was indeed joyful that his subordinate had taken into consideration his own standing and the times ahead to provide this proposal. So there was no reason to be stubborn and decline it.

Zikr himself, having been hard-pressed and anxiety-ridden, had not invited and played with any ladies over at his bedchamber recently.

He could not put the same inconvenience on his troops as well.

Zikr: "Alright, understood. I will allow myself to be smooth-talked by you here. Invite that troupe of travelling entertainers and prepare a space to show appreciation for the soldiers."

Except—

Zikr: "—Make sure they do not bring in any weapons. Do not forget to search them."



Once approval from Zikr was received, the troops mobilized quickly.

Almost as if they had been suffering from severe dehydration and starvation, they immediately prepared a space for a banquet on the First Floor of the City Hall, readied alcohol and food, and gathered women to serve as waitresses.

Then, contacting the band of travelling entertainers in question, the troupe was invited to the top-floor of the City Hall.

???: “—Who you are about to lay your eyes on, is the beautiful danseuse from beyond the Great Waterfall. Her silky black hair that drinks up the sun’s light, along with her heavenly fair skin that has received the blessing of the Spirits, her utmost beauty is comparable to the divine beings, and tonight, she will lavishly perform for you all.”

After the musician's dramatic introductory speech was delivered, the veil was pulled back slowly with showmanship.

A female-only band of travelling entertainers, what the musicians revealed hidden under the drop veil was the dancer that was the hot topic of the city—the appearance of said dancer being revealed, Zikr widened his eyes in surprise.

Zikr: “_____”

Exposing her milky skin, the beauty who loosely let her hair flow down her back, her appearance betrayed what had been conveyed by the musician's introductory speech— Indeed, such comments were far from sufficient for describing the belle here.

Her bewitching black hair, her cream skin wrapped in a light garment. Certainly, there was a magical power to them, one that would mesmerize many of those who would come to gaze at her. However, those factors were merely one portion of the real reason for her beauty.

Including people other than dancers or musicians, if charisma was what charmed most humans, and if one were to equate charisma with talent, this dancer's aura and appearance was frighteningly overflowing with it.

Most of all, what led Zikr to feel such powerful sentiments, was none other than the dancer's eyes.

To say that those almond shaped eyes with long lashes were the core of her favorable features, was unsuited. It was no exaggeration to think that, on the golden ratio, they were positioned in the most perfect place.

The reason his throat unconsciously parched up was because Zikr instinctively felt a craving.

Whether that was because he was attracted to the dancer's physicalities, or because he was pulled to the charisma the dancer was entwined with, was a phenomenon that was completely unknown to even Zikr himself.

This dancer had already incited such deep emotion with nary a single movement. The size of the impact that would be brought about once she started to actually dance with song and music, would be of unimaginable proportions.

And, Zikr craved to be overwhelmed by an impact of proportions he could not dream of.

Black-haired Musician: "—Please, allow us the chance to display our danseuse's act."

In place of the silent dancer—No, danseuse, a musician with matching black hair bowed her head down.

The two musicians and the black-haired and blonde-haired ladies were likewise beautiful; however, to Zikr, who was enraptured by the danseuse's appearance, they could only be considered an accompaniment. Normally, any thoughts of dismissing women were to be met with self-examination and reflection, but he was burning with fervor, to the point where such thoughts did not even cross his mind.

Never, until now, had he so strongly become self-aware of his nickname, Womanizer.

In reality, Zikr probably was a Womanizer— Because, in front of beauty of this scale, staying at a peace of mind was, without a doubt, impossible.

And so, with his heart still burning with ardor, the banquet commenced.

Of course, seeing as Zikr was the commander, his seat in the banquet was at the very back. The gathered Generals—as the rank-and-file Soldiers had been excluded, the people of higher rank gathered and started to enjoy their alcohol and food.

The number one sight was however, as expected, the showcase from the band of travelling entertainers.

Originally, the objective was to show appreciation for the troops and let them release their dissatisfactions, but Zikr had forgotten the original aim and held his breath for the danseuse's turn on stage.

Bringing booze to his mouth to quench his thirst, he moistened his tongue, lips and throat. He brought his breathing back to normal that way.

Zikr's heart was spell-bound to that extent.

Black-haired Musician: “—Tonight, what you will witness is a dance from the hometown of our danseuse, a dance from beyond the Great Waterfall. Please, satisfy to your heart's content, the dance from the ends of the end.”

The voice of a singing musician started, and the plucking of strings led to the sounds of gentle music.

As an unfamiliar tune started to play, the Generals who were conversing noisily bated their breaths with faces of vermilion. They too, were unwilling to take their eyes off the performance that was about to start.

Then—

???: “———”

Then, the danseuse who slowly came into sight, started her breathtaking “dance”.

Everyone: “———”

Making full use of her long limbs, everybody lost their words at the figure with swaying black hair as she danced.

Forgetting to breathe, they stared— this, was the very definition of “enchanted”. Anyone who witnessed a dance like this and maintained a clear-headed mind had something wrong with them.

Someone like that did not understand the value of dance, and possessed the sensibilities of an animal.

The Imperial Soldiers were a pack of wolves, but they were not beasts who did not possess the power of intelligence and speech.

Subsequently, the Generals also held their breath, forgetting how to breathe, and were bewitched by the stunning danseuse’s act.

Each person lost their voice and were captivated by the danseuse’s performance.

Pitch-black hair, smooth, white skin with naught a blemish. An alluring face that would make artists want to cut off their dominant hand for its deep knowledge. They were charmed by that.

However, what continued to attract, boundlessly so, Zikr’s eyes, mind and heart, were none of those features.

—It was the eyes.

Just as he thought, he could not shift his gaze from the danseuse’s eyes.

Her long-slitted eyes lorded over the stage in which she was dancing on, and were boring right into the very back of the room, at Zikr.

Her eyes, which did not leave their target for a single second, directly took hold of Zikr’s brain and did not release their grasp.

Eventually, the danseuse crossed the hall, advancing right in front of Zikr.

Then, softly kneeling in place, raised her two hands and requested Zikr’s sword.

Naturally, Zikr understood her action, that it signified the wish for a sword.

With the world in her grasp, the danseuse's dance raised the tension and made it obvious that she would rise to the next level. On top of transitioning to a dance utilizing a sword; to a blade ballet, the danseuse wished for a blade.

Zikr did not have the option to refuse and not pass the blade over.

No one could stop it. The subordinates and Generals; no one could deliberately obstruct this act.

This was something that was to happen no matter what. That was how natural this course of action was.

That was why—

Danseuse: “—It is your loss, Zikr Osman.”

Having his unsheathed sword pointed at his throat, hearing that ruthless declaration, Zikr Osman did not process that he had been defeated by virtue of being the Womanizer.

Zikr: “———”

Even at this very moment, he could not avert his gaze from the eyes of the danseuse who had declared such words.

That cold charisma which attracted many— It was as if he had seen it before. That feeling of déjà vu was endlessly branded by flame into the mind of the defeated General Zikr.



Illustration from Volume 27, coloring by Norvak ([source](#))

Arc 7 Chapter 22 - The Bloodless Siege Plan

Light Novel Adaptation found in Volume 27, Chapter 5 “Musician Natsumi Schwartz”, Parts 1-3

Original Web Novel Chapter — [Complete](#)

Original Translation by Witch Cult Translations ([Kobosuhito](#), [Taurace](#), [Polaris](#)) — [Complete](#)

—Let us rewind the clock, to before the danseuse’s whirling dance at Guaral City Hall.

???: “—A bloodless siege, you say?”

Having entered the meeting place, in front of all those gathered there, Natsuki Subaru had made a powerful declaration.

The concealing oni mask forcibly ripped away, Abel looked up toward Subaru and, in a chilling voice, repeated the “pipe dream” that had vibrated his eardrums.

He sneered— No, there was no sense of mockery in it. It contained pure doubt, a kind of breath that conveyed that the person before him did not understand what they were proposing.

The intention was understood.

Subaru: “You may have devised a plan to get through with minimal sacrifices, but you wouldn’t think of a plan with zero sacrifices in the first place.”

Abel: “Naturally. Whether you accept it or not, what we are engaging in now is war. Come what may, casualties cannot be avoided. All that can be done, is planning to avoid the waste of human resources.”

Subaru: “Well, I don’t like your way of thinking about human resources to begin with.”

Looking down on Abel sitting cross-legged right in front of him, Subaru clicked his tongue.

The term “human resources” was the combination of two words, “humans” and “resources”, one that Subaru thought should not be combined into such an abhorrent term whatsoever.

That way of looking at “humans” by keeping them at a distance, was one step detached from viewing people as only numbers.

Or perhaps that was the sense of balance a ruler like Abel had to have but—

Subaru: “Well, I don’t accept it. Flop-san’s the same, right?”

Abel: “—And in place of that, you interject with this bloodless siege? That is a remarkably grand declaration. Coming from you, who was so haggard until just a moment ago.”

Subaru: “I won’t argue that I’ve been a worn-out, pitiful, disgraceful sight. To begin with, ever since I got blasted away to this country, I’ve been through a series of *kiremenonai*²¹ disasters.”

In response to Abel’s point, Subaru derided himself, then stared at his own palm.

His unduly clean right hand, that arm which had been replaced by a new one, could also be called part of those “*kiremenonai* disasters”. Albeit tough, the replacement of his right hand had been one of his few pieces of luck, had it not?

The replacement of his hand, and that Rem had awakened. That, and encountering the siblings Flop and Medium, could be considered good fortune without exaggeration.

Outside of that anyway, fortune and disaster were two sides of the same coin.

So was Abel before him, so were the People of Shudraq, and so were the Imperial Soldiers including Todd—

Subaru: “This series of hardships has been soul-draining. But.”

Abel: “———”

Subaru: “—The more friction, the more fire ignites.”

Staring hard at his clenched fist, Subaru announced that clearly.

²¹ English flip. Means “continuous” (切れ目のない), originally “ノンストップ” (non-stop).

Right then, Rem, who had been lagging behind Subaru, arrived at the entrance to the meeting place. Using her cane, she came in alongside Uakata and Louis.

She had likely come to see with her very own eyes.

Since it had been her selfish plea that had ignited Natsuki Subaru's soul.

Subaru: "A strategy to enter the city, after asking Flop-san for a secret byway... Are you planning a surprise attack? There's no way that'll work."

Abel: "Oh, why is that? It is a fortified city, protected by a bulwark. Do you possess some other method to pass through?"

Subaru: "If there's a wall, anyone'd think to look for a way to bypass it. That is, though the byway itself may be cleverly concealed..."

If there were a secret byway for going in and out of the Fortress City, naturally, it could be assumed that it was for allowing those of uncertain backgrounds and goods of dubious origin to get through.

Of course, it would probably be concealed so as not to be discovered by guards. But even that would only get past ordinary levels of vigilance.

Beyond that, it did not seem possible to evade the net of wartime vigilance especially. And above all—

Subaru: "That bastard who chased us down in the city isn't the type to overlook something like that."

He was quick-witted, cunning, and made decisions without hesitation.

Seeing that Todd knew of their survival, any sort of byway would be the most guarded opening. The enemy would not be so kind to leave it as it was.

Blocking it would be obvious, and there was also the fear that any left unblocked could have been converted into traps.

Subaru: "That's why a surprise attack would be absurd. It's likely the opponent waiting over there will smash your head in with an axe the moment you slip out from a byway."

Flop: “W-w-why are you looking at my face as you say that, Husband-kun! What a scary thought!”

He had intended to make the danger known to everyone, but his eyes subconsciously fixed on Flop’s face.

Subaru remembered how many times right in front of him the assassin’s dagger— No, the assassin’s axe, had felled the man before him. Subaru did not want to witness that again; even if it killed him, he could not let that happen again.

Abel: “...Were it to simply be a surprise attack, I am of the same opinion regarding the enemy being wary.”

Subaru: “What?”

At his unexpected assent, Subaru stared in wide-eyed wonder. The reason being that the one endorsing Subaru’s opinion was none other than Abel himself.

Abel raised an eyebrow at Subaru’s astonishment and continued,

Abel: “What? Is my affirmation unexpected?”

Subaru: “That’s right... Despite you acting as if you’re right about everything in this world, you do things like readily admit your own mistakes...”

Abel: “Nonsense, when did I admit to having been mistaken? I merely endorsed the idea that a strategy of using a byway to commence a surprise attack would not be successful.”

Subaru: “—? Then, how were you planning to use the byway?”

Abel’s denial had a different feeling than that of a sore loser who had had his thoughts correctly guessed.

As Subaru grilled him for the basis, Abel shut one of his eyes,

Abel: “There is no reason humans must be the ones going in and out. If it is only to paralyze the functioning of the soldiers confined in the city, merely smuggling something in would be sufficient.”

Subaru: “Something...”

Abel: “—Poison.”

Subaru: “They’re even less likely to overlook that!”

Abel’s dispassionate delivery all the more gave a sense of his unwavering resolve to get things done, and Subaru instinctively and loudly criticized his plan.

The use of poison or the like would be inexcusable— In truth, since Subaru had experienced the power of poison employed by the People of Shudraq, he vehemently opposed its use.

That hellish suffering, it was more wretched than dying in battle.

Subaru: “Anyway, weren’t we talking about trying to minimize suffering, or at least reduce harm to persuade Flop-san? How does a plan that uses poison...”

Abel: “What are you speaking of? A surprise tactic using a secret byway also has the possibility of our own troops being sacrificed in the event of an attack. With poison, that possibility is eliminated.”

Subaru: “———”

Abel: “Reducing the losses of the forces on hand. That is what it means to minimize damage.”

Abel spoke definitively, and in front of him Subaru held his breath.

Again, Subaru recognized anew, between his own position and Abel’s, the grand scale of difference between a Ruler’s and others’ fields of view. The gap was beyond Subaru’s comprehension.

In short, Abel did not take damage to the residents of Guaral into account— No, even if he did not bring harm to the residents, he thought nothing whatsoever of harm to the Imperial Soldiers.

That much had been clear ever since the Imperial Soldiers’ encampment that he himself had aimed for had been burnt to the ground.

Subaru: “Still, my thinking was naive. You...”

Abel: “That is correct, your thinking is naive. Consequently, you have no place here...”

As they confronted each other, sparks flew between Subaru and Abel’s glares.

Just as their views clashed with one another, and the discussion began to break down—

Flop: “—Now now now, wait a minute, you two! There’s no need to glare at each other and argue like this!”

Flop stepped between the two of them and created some distance.

A sodden smile appeared on his face as he looked back and forth between the glaring faces of Subaru and Abel; “Let’s calm down and discuss this!”, he said as he clapped his hands in front of his chest.

Flop: “To be frank, my discussion with Village Chief-kun was getting nowhere! And then, Husband-kun triumphantly returned. I definitely want to hear about this «bloodless siege» Husband-kun’s talking about! If it’s real, it’d be like a dream come true!”

Subaru: “Flop-san...”

In response to the grinning Flop’s expectation, Subaru quelled his prior anger. Somehow or another, taken aback by Flop’s behavior, Abel seemed to do the same.

Abel let out a “Hmph” with a small snort,

Abel: “—Very well, we shall hear him out. Should your idea manage to successfully fool this merchant, as long as you get the whereabouts of the secret byway, that will be that.”

Flop: “Huh!? Husband-kun!? Don’t tell me you...”

Subaru: “Nonono! We weren’t planning this! Just because it doesn’t seem like your own idea’s going to work, doesn’t mean you get to try to force me to be part of it, asshole!”

His remark needlessly invited Flop’s distrust, yet, moreover Abel showed no shame. He held on to his composed arrogance. “You hardly need that oni mask...”, Subaru spat at him.

???: “So...”

Like that, a faint voice slid into the gap created in the conversation.

Standing stock-still at the entrance of the meeting place, eyes fixed on Subaru’s back, came Rem’s voice.

Not fooled by the atmosphere of the place, Rem continued to stare only at Subaru.

Rem: “So, what would you do? Could you find some other way that isn’t a fleeting dream or a blood-soaked reality?”

Subaru: “...Every bit of the way you say things makes my heart sing.”

Rem: “———”

Rem stared with her lips pursed, and Subaru responded with a bitter smile, and strengthened his resolve once more.

Then, he surveyed the faces in the meeting place once more. Abel and Flop, along with the Shudraquians starting with Mizelda, and as he became the focus of everyone’s gaze,

Subaru: “My plan’s got no need for either byways or bloodshed. But, it does require Flop-san’s assistance.”

Flop: “Even though it doesn’t need a byway, it requires my help...? But Husband-kun, surely you know I’m just a helpless peddler with a bit of a mouth, don’t you?”

Subaru: “Yeah, of course. But Flop-san isn’t just a merchant, there’s a blessing you were born with— A nice face.”

Flop: “—Huh? My face?”

Wide-eyed, Flop put both his hands to his face.

Similarly, everyone in the meeting area tilted their heads as if to say, “His face?”.

Mizelda: “I *see*, that’s *true*.”

Taritta: “—! Sister, did you realize *something*?”

Mizelda: “No, I just approve of what Subaru said about him having a nice *face*.”

Taritta: “Sister...”

Mizelda nodded and crossed her arms, while Taritta sullenly hung her head.

But, since more or less no one had caught on to Subaru's intentions, an air of doubt was spreading among them. Same went for Flop and Abel, even.

However, Mizelda's stubborn interest in the appearance of others was not off-base. It was precisely her weakness and sense for beauty that had given Subaru a great hint regarding this situation.

Because Mizelda putting too much stock in good looks had been that which had inspired this Bloodless Siege Plan.

Subaru: "Evidence's better than debate— Flop-san, we can't tell until we try it, so follow me."

Flop: "Follow you? That's not a problem, but what in the world..."

To the still dubious Flop, Subaru pushily told him "Don't worry about it".

And then, his gaze turned to face Mizelda,

Subaru: "You dye your hair and draw designs on your body, so you use cosmetics, right? Could you try lending me those items for a bit?"



Everyone: "———"

Having returned to the meeting place after a while, everyone was lost for words upon witnessing the "results".

However, Subaru knew that it was not speechlessness born from negative sentiments such as being perplexed or fed up, but rather genuine awe and astonishment, perhaps even some moving emotion.

He could say with confidence that it was well within expectations for his handiwork to have that much of an impact.

Subaru: "Turns out, if given diamonds in the rough to work with, even I could deliver some decent results."

Everyone: “———”

Rubbing his nose, Subaru who had declared so was met with the same unresponsive crowd as before. While the silence continued without anyone returning from their state of stupefaction, an uneasy “M-Husband-kun” was voiced.

That came from the only person who, other than Subaru, was immune to the shock induced on those present.

Flop: “Something feels off, I haven’t seen the end-product yet, but how did it turn out? The sensation isn’t very pleasant...”

Subaru: “Oh come on, there’s no need to worry Flop-sa... Nah, don’t you worry about it, Flora.”

Flop: “Flora!?”

Eyes widened in surprise was Flop— nay, Flora. Yet even when his expression was washed over with surprise it was adorable nevertheless, thought Subaru nodding with confidence whilst caressing his face.

Then once again, Subaru grabbed Flora’s slender shoulders, and turned him to face forward.

Veiled behind the silky curtain of long, golden hair, were eyes that were more accentuated than usual from having had eyeshadow applied to them. The eyelashes had been adjusted in a way that showed off their length, and a hint of red adorned the cheeks to create a striking contrast with his naturally fair skin. Lastly, the lips were colored red and he had been changed into clothes that completed the look.

With his dainty physique, only the slightest bit of effort was required to disguise him as a “her”. Which meant—

Subaru: “—This is the key to a bloodless siege, the best strategy I can devise!”

Throwing his fist up in the air, Subaru debuted Flop-Flora to everybody in the meeting place.

Despite the limited time given, Subaru had been capable of bringing the most out of a gem from its unpolished state, something he took pride in. Surprise should be reserved for now however, for this was only a work born from inadequate preparation, the least adorable version of what Flora could be.

Having gathered all the necessary tools, as long as the person in question kept in mind the appropriate mannerism they should uphold, it would not simply add to their charms, but increase it exponentially.

Subaru: “Beauty can be made.”

Rem: “Are you fooling around here?”

Subaru: “Eh!?”

A cold piercing voice jabbed at Subaru, who had presented a feat without rival.

Taking a peek, the owner of that voice was none other than Rem with a frigid gaze. Those eyes that had regarded Subaru with expectation just before were nowhere to be found, and were instead replaced by those that Rem had since she first woke up.

Having swallowed his breath due to the harsh gaze, Subaru said “Hold on!” with an outstretched hand.

Subaru: “I-I’m not fooling around! I’m really not fooling around here whatsoever, so don’t look at me like that!”

Rem: “You aren’t fooling around? Stop with the absurdity. I was a fool... to even have tried putting the slightest amount of faith in you.”

Subaru: “You’re jumping to conclusions! This is somewhat late but you really are just like Ram in that sense!”

Rem: “Haa?”

Despite it being something that the current Rem did not recall, Ram too was quick to jump to conclusions.

Though his heart was warmed by the thought that they were, after all, sisters, his number one priority right now was regaining the lost trust from Rem.

In actuality, Subaru was not messing around. He was taking everything head-on with all seriousness, and giving it considerable thought.

The purpose of going through all that trouble to turn Flop into a woman named Flora was—

Abel: “—The target’s Zikr Osman, huh.”

Said the first person to arrive at the answer, Abel, who had his chin resting on his hand.

Unlike the rest who had been unable to conceal their surprises at the transformation from Flop to Flora, Abel was able to suppress it and stayed silent, presumably to probe for Subaru’s true intent.

And thus, he had been able to see through what Subaru was getting at completely.

—The target would be Zikr Osman.

General Second-Class of the Empire, and commander of the Imperial Soldiers stationed in the Fortress City of Guaral. A capable man who preferred solid and safe war tactics, and on top of that—

Subaru: “I heard he’s called the Womanizer. Sounded like it was well-known among the Imperial Soldiers.”

Abel: “The fact he is renowned for being one, and that he received a nickname because of it, is common knowledge.”

Rem: “Womanizer... doesn’t give off a very likable impression to me.”

Having heard the conversation between Subaru and Abel, Rem made a grimacing face.

Subaru could not help but agree with Rem’s impression of him. Upon hearing that a military officer was a womanizer, one would probably imagine a filthy pervert with a vulgar personality. However, that’ was an opening they could use to their advantage.

Subaru: “At the Imperial Soldiers’ encampment, there was even talk of doing things like presenting a captured woman to General Zikr. Basically, as long as a woman’s harmless there’s a good chance she can get near him.”

It was something he would rather not recall, but at the encampment, Jamal had directly told Subaru that he would do something such as offering Rem to Zikr.

Rem was a beautiful girl, so it could be said that Zikr’s sense of beauty was a normal one.

Subaru: “That being the case, with the power of Flora, it should be doable.”

Flop: “M-Husband-kun? You’ve been calling me Flora with intense anticipation for a while now, but what do I look like right now? I don’t know what’s going on and I’m scared!”

Subaru: “Don’t worry, Flora. I won’t make you do this alone, of course. I’m going to fight the same way too.”

Mizelda: “No matter how you look at *it*, that’s *absurd*, Subaru!”

Subaru soothed the bewildered Flora, and Mizelda stood up at his remark. Her eyes were overcast with a strong, hard expression, and she gripped her hands on Subaru’s shoulders, shaking her head.

Then, she lowered her tone of voice as if imparting a truth that was difficult to convey,

Mizelda: “Your eyes have a charm to them as *well*. But as for what you were born *with*...”

Subaru: “Hey hey, come on now, Mizelda-san. Didn’t you hear what I said?”

Mizelda: “What was *that*?”

Subaru: “—Beauty can be made.”

Subaru affirmed reassuringly, placing his hand atop the one Mizelda had placed on his shoulder.

Hearing this, Mizelda opened her eyes wide and gasped. Then, directing her gaze at Flora, she squinted as if the makeup on that face were something radiant.

Mizelda: “You’ve got me *beat*... Let’s see *it*, your *potential*.”

Subaru: “Yeah, just watch.”

Kuna: “What are you talking *about*, I don’t geeet *it*.”

Mizelda entrusted the matter to Subaru, and he accepted. Kuna watched the exchange between the pair with exasperation, but had no comment to give.

Anyway, the problem now was—

Abel: “As for utilizing Zikr Osman’s preferences, what is your intention? Even he, is still a wolf. Merely dangling a pretty thing in front of him, he is not a dog who shall bite at such bait.”

Subaru: “Well, dangling something purposelessly is hardly worth discussing. So, we need to devise a way to get him to bite. For instance, enticing him to an *enkai*²².”

Abel: “A banquet? Alas, it shan’t be easy to draw him in. Naturally, there is no reason for him to emerge from inside the walls until reinforcements from the Imperial Capital are present. He shall not be tempted by a suspicious invitation.”

Subaru: “Sure. I’m still narrowing down the choices, but...”

Rem: “W-wait, please!”

Like that, while Subaru and Abel were in the midst of arguing back and forth, Rem raised her voice.

She looked back and forth between the two, a surprised expression affixed to her face,

Rem: “Are you being serious? I can’t believe you’re going through with this, centered on pranking Flop-san.”

Flop: “Wha, they’re pranking me? Seriously, what do I look like right now? The Wife-san says I look like I’ve been pranked... Niece-chan, what’s going on?”

Louis: “Auu? Uu! Uu!”

Beside the tense Rem, Flora, who had not yet been able to see his reflection even once, sought solace in Louis. But having never met Flora before, Louis panicked and hid behind Rem.

In other words, in Louis’s view, it appeared as if Flora and Flop were different people.

Abel: “Setting aside whether that girl’s reaction is appropriate as a litmus test, I do not consider this a prank. At last, you have proposed an idea meriting discussion.”

²² English flip. Means “party/banquet” (宴会), originally “パーティー” (party).

Subaru: “Then you also recognize it. The beauty of Flora.”

Abel: “—I recognized that your idea was one I had not thought of. Do not get it twisted now.”

Subaru’s lips curled in an expression of dissatisfaction with Abel’s obstinate reply.

However, Abel paid him no mind, and for a short period held his hand to his mouth in careful deliberation. Then, he shot a jagged look in Subaru’s direction,

Abel: “Natsuki Subaru, I have one question... Your cosmetics, can only the merchant make use of it?”

The question came.

Subaru: “———”

For a moment, Abel’s inquiry left him dumbfounded.

But Subaru turned over the intent of the question in his mind, and shook his head.

Subaru: “I already told you. I said I’m in the same boat as you if we go through with this operation!”

Abel: “Nonsense. Who would place their trust in you? Take a look at yourself in the mirror and only then speak.”

Subaru: “Watch your mouth!”

Brow furrowed, Abel spat out his contempt from the depths of his heart. Ignoring Subaru’s hurt from this comment, he pressed his hand to his chest,

Abel: “To handle this alone is beyond the capabilities of a mere merchant— Thus, I shall follow suit.”

Mizelda: “A-Abel *too*!?”

Hearing that brazen self-recommendation, the air of the meeting place around Mizelda began to buzz.

Of course, Subaru had also been surprised by Abel’s proposal. Truly, he had never dreamed he would suggest that on his own.

Subaru: "...Honestly, I thought the main issue was going to be how to talk you into it."

Abel: "In ordinary times, it would be a fool's errand, something not even worth considering. But as it stands, we possess few cards to play, and our potential plans are also limited. If it is indeed effective, it is a necessary situation we must stoop to."

Subaru: "Tch, you have a freaking terrible way of putting it. This is why bastards with charisma are..."

Never mind that he had been chased off the throne, there was no wavering of the fact that he was the Emperor.

That was Abel's creed, and a belief that he would not yield on. Having been shown a glimpse of it so blatantly, Subaru had no choice but to genuinely commend him.

Were he an example of an inept person with authority, he would make a blunder by being too preoccupied with his own safety.

However, ever since Abel had first encountered Subaru in the jungle, he had continued to win big gambles using himself as a chip, Lifeblood Ritual included.

This time would be no exception as well, and he probably had zero intention of backing down from it.

Abel: "An ingenious scheme is something that starts producing results only when performed from outside the enemy's expectations. Taking advantage of the General's biases, it conceals itself in their unavoidable negligence. There is value in discussing this plan."

Subaru: "Yeah, it's also written in a book called the Kojiki²³. It says that crossdressing's the best option when aiming for the enemy General's neck."

Rem: "You can't seriously just accept the contents of such a suspicious book..."

²³ Translation note from Witch Cult Translation: "The Kojiki (古事記), translated literally as «Records of Ancient Matter», is one of the oldest surviving literary works about Japanese history and contains many myths, stories and semi-historical accounts (plus more) of Japan. The crossdressing Subaru is referring to is most likely the story on how Ousu-no-mikoto (afterwards known as Yamato Takeru-no-mikoto) crossdressed as a maid attendant to kill Kawakami Takeru, an enemy general and leader of the Kumaso. For further reading, check [here](#) and [here](#)."

It was a reference to an old book of ancient and honorable origin, but even if he were to explain the trustworthiness of the Kojiki to Rem now, he would not get a reply from the current her. As of now, he could not think of a way to quickly regain the trust Rem had in him.

He feared rejection without the chance to explain himself, so he was grateful yet surprised that Abel had accepted his proposal.

Subaru: “When you said poison, I really thought you were the *tagui*²⁴ to execute anyone who opposed you, but...”

Abel: “If required, I am willing to do so. Nevertheless, emotions are far from being a necessity for future decisions. After all, what I must obtain is not limited to the city of Guaral.”

Subaru: “———”

Abel: “If General Zikr Osman were to be secured, we can devise means to procure what I desire without bloodshed. If the concerns of an internal insurrection can be reduced, that would be celebratory.”

Subaru: “...*Right*. There’s *definitely* value in the words from the guy who’s lost his place because of an internal insurrection.”

A restrained taunt he said in the spur of the moment, but Abel’s expression did not give the slightest twitch.

Was this level of sarcasm and disrespect not worth getting aggravated over? —Or perhaps, like Abel himself had stated, he was not as pigheaded as to not recognize his own shortcomings. In any case—

Subaru: “If you’re cooperative then there’s nothing more that I could ask for. Your name... Abel, Vollachia... Is Bianca fine?”

Abel: “I am not particular about my fake name, call me as you prefer. More importantly, there is hardly enough manpower with just you, me and the merchant. Let me see...”

Crossing his arms, Abel surveyed the faces in the meeting area.

²⁴ English flip. Means “kind/sort/type” (たぐい), originally “タイプ” (type).

Then, closing one eye with a “Hm”,

Abel: “The ones we can use are Kuna and Taritta, that would be about it.”

Subaru: “Wha?”

Abel: “It is the preparation needed. Even if we successfully draw out Zikr Osman, the requisite manpower to suppress him is needed. Saying that, anyone who is instantly recognizable as one of the People of Shudraq should be avoided.”

Abel said while pointing with his chin. Hearing that, Subaru also understood Abel’s thinking.

Suddenly being put under the spotlight, Taritta and Kuna were perplexed. While they were members of the People of Shudraq, compared to the others, these two were the types that did not give off a wild atmosphere.

Mizelda, at first glance, looked like a fiery and aggressive fighter. Similarly, Holly on first look, gave a unique impression on people. They were not suited for this situation, which called for the concealment of their Shudraquian identities.

In the end, what was needed to not raise alarms in the enemy’s mind was a feminine charm—

Subaru: “I think that’s the limit of what my dress-up and makeup can do. I can’t give them a womanly charm with these cosmetics after all.”

Rem: “—Me too.”

Subaru: “Rem?”

Then, the one who swiftly raised her hand there was Rem.

This was the Rem who did not hide her disbelief towards Subaru after the case with Flora. Yet, as if she’d had some reconsideration after seeing them continue a serious discussion of this plan, her expression was likewise weighty.

And, with resolve and determination shining in her light-blue eyes,

Rem: “Please, let me take part in this. I’ll definitely be of use.”

Subaru: “Rem... Sorry, but that’s not possible.”

Rem: “—Hk! Again, you’re unnecessarily trying to distance me from danger...”

Her resolution on the verge of being crushed, Rem’s eyes shot daggers at Subaru.

Without a doubt, Subaru held a sense of overprotectiveness that would most likely infuriate Rem. His sentiment to distance her from danger and let her peacefully spend her time inside a cradle was no lie.

However, that was not the sole reason for stopping her participation in this battle.

Subaru: “It’s true I’m worried for your safety. But, the reason I’m rejecting your involvement is simply because the plan’s success rate will decrease... Rem, your face has already been seen by the Imperial Soldiers.”

Rem: “—Ah.”

Subaru: “There was that time you got caught at the camp, and also when we were running away from the city. We can’t use Medium’s help for the same reason. We made too much of a scene.”

After causing such a commotion, the guards at the security checkpoint would definitely not forget Rem and Medium’s faces. Louis too, for that matter.

The operation this time, was a battle on whether or not they could get the better of the enemy’s thinking and slip under their radar. Unless they wanted to endanger that core idea, there was no way they could bring Rem along.

Rem: “But... But, if the condition is whether our face has been seen or not, then it should be the same for you too!”

Subaru: “Yes, but no. Because, it won’t be *me* who’ll be passing through the main gate of Guaral. It’ll be Natsumi Schwartz.”

Rem: “Huh?”

As if she thought she was being deceived again, anger blazed in the determined Rem's eyes. However, in regards to this case, nothing could be explained through words.

Just like how Flop had been transformed into Flora, Natsuki Subaru had to simply disguise himself into Natsumi Schwartz— He had to walk the walk, not just talk the talk.

Subaru: "Anyways, the reason I can't bring you along's just as I explained. But, Taritta and Kuna, you guys too, this'll be a dangerous operation so I'll have to convince you two first before..."

Mizelda: "Nah, this is *interesting*. I'll allow *it*. Take them *both*."

Just as Subaru was trying to confirm the thoughts and intentions of the two Shudraquians, Mizelda interrupted with those words.

Turning his head in surprise, Subaru saw the shining eyes of Mizelda focused back on him with blazing curiosity. She stared with the intensity of a hunter; it felt like she was peeling his skin off and trying to take a peek underneath.

For a brief moment, Subaru could even feel an intense fear sweep through him.

Subaru: "Mizelda, san?"

Mizelda: "Subaru, you and Abel have already proven your *valor*. Shudraq respects those blessed with *valor*. But, that doesn't mean we cut and throw away ingenuity as an unblest *value*. Might and *wisdom*, those excelling in both become supreme *warriors*... Go and prove *yourselves*."

Her cheeks warmed in joy, as if the operation that targeted the enemy's weakness was favorable for her as well.

Based on assumptions, Subaru had believed without question that Mizelda and the rest of the People of Shudraq would dislike this sort of scheme. That was why he planned on inquiring Taritta and Kuna whether they would like to participate in this operation or not.

However, after Mizelda gave her answer, Taritta and Kuna nodded along as if it were the most natural thing in the world.

Kuna: "If the Chieftain says so, I have nothing else to reaaally say."

Taritta: “I will follow Sister’s *direction*... I am also interested in this, *makeup*.”

Linking her hands behind her head, Kuna accepted with an attitude that said she did not care either way. Taritta held the same opinion but she would flick her gaze towards Flora on and off.

It seemed like she had gained an interest in Subaru’s makeup handiwork. He thought the scene was somewhat lacking in the tension expected from the preparation of a life or death operation, but—

Abel: “If there are no objections, then let us swiftly prepare. We must settle this battle before the cowards in the Fortress City receive encouragement from the Imperial Capital.”

Subaru: “... Okay, got it. If everyone’s good with that too. Rem, is this alright with you?”

Rem: “—You’re not going to listen no matter what I say, are you?”

Laden with embarrassment from what she had spoken before, Rem glared at Subaru intently. He was sorry about dismissing her resolve but, after considering her safety and the success of the operation, there was no path in which she could join them.

That was why Subaru cast his eyes downwards, and resigned himself to bear Rem’s fury. However—

Rem: “But, the one who asked you to do something about this, the one who requested that, was me.”

Subaru: “Rem?”

Rem: “And for me to make a fuss about it, there’s no way I can do that... Please be successful.”

Her frustration had not vanished, and it was not as if she had forgiven Subaru as well. That she would respect the decision made, was what was communicated to him through her averting gaze.

Just by that, the dark clouds within Subaru cleared up.

Subaru: “Only Rem can do this, but man is it calming... Wait, that’s not right is it?”

Just by showing her very slight approval, Subaru was giddy to the point that he felt like he could fly up high in the sky.

But also, when Emilia smiled, he felt like he could rise up to the heavens by that smile alone, and when Beatrice would explain something with her smug face, his chest would become super warm and comfy.

With a “Huh”, Subaru only now noticed that he was easier to deal with than he’d thought.

Abel: “What is the matter? Are you only now getting cold feet?”

Subaru: “Not now, that’s not quite right... It’s just that, I’m getting pumped up.”

Abel: “Hoh? Show that with your utmost efforts, then.”

Receiving courage from Rem’s comment, Subaru answered while Abel flared his nose.

Needless to say, that was what he intended to do— Once this Bloodless Siege succeeded, the path to return to the Kingdom of Lugunica might open up.

Even if that were not the case, Subaru would not let any tragedy occur within his sight’s reach. He would not let it happen.

???: “—Heeey, big brooo! It’s not nice to Bote-chin if we don’t let her rest so I wanna put her somewhereee.”

Then, in the meeting area where zeal was rising, Medium peeked her face in without hesitation.

Even when compared to the muscular Shudraquians, Medium stood one head taller, and so was very noticeable with her height. The said-noticeable person then looked over the meeting area with her round eyes and,

Medium: “Eh, where’s big bro?”

Flop: “Ohhh, dear sister! To lose sight of your brother is quite cruel of you. I’m present, right here!”

Medium: “—?”

Towards the head-tilted Medium, Flora stood up and made her existence aware. And towards Flora’s words, Medium scrunched her eyebrows and fell into deep thought.

Staying silent for a while, she then yelled, as if she had come to a realization.

Medium: “Big bro, all this time you were actually my big sis!”

Flop: “Husband-kun!? What’s going on here!? This is actually scary!”

If even the eyes of a blood-related sister could be deceived, this would certainly be a firm foothold for this operation²⁵.

²⁵ Comment by Tappei, left at the end of the chapter: “In regards to Subaru’s crossdressing addiction (this is a misleading description), this has happened before in the Light Novel, in Tanpenshuu 3 and 6. There really was no good timing to slot it in the Web Novel so they weren’t put in here but, as the author, this has always been part of the plan, ever since the beginning. It’s taken eight years since I started writing to introduce this. Hahaha, nice obsession.”

Arc 7 Chapter 23 - Musician Natsumi Schwartz

Light Novel Adaptation found in Volume 27, Chapter 5 “Musician Natsumi Schwartz”, Parts 4-6

Original Web Novel Chapter — [Complete](#)

Edited Machine Translation by Witch Cult Translations (Original by Heretic Translations, Translation checked by [Ice/Ice Occultism](#) & Averitius) — [Complete](#)

Subaru: “———”

Looking at his reflection in the crude mirror, Natsuki Subaru— or rather, the being who used to call himself that, squinted their eyes and carefully inspected themselves over and over again.

Dark eyeshadow and carefully curled eyelashes reflected back. The texture of their skin, the greatest point of difference between men and women, was coated with white powder; his lips were painted with a vermillion color that made them look fresh.

The costume had been quite the challenge, but he had been able to disguise his physique by wearing a lot of loose clothing, despite struggling to achieve a style that matched the southern climate.

At any rate, this time he would have to act not as the daughter of a nobleman, but in a looser and casual manner— that of a traveling entertainer. Therefore, aside from gestures, the appearance needed to be more “female” in order to fit the design.

Subaru: “I’m going to gather as much of my body to my chest and stuff it to the limit...”

He had utilized every technique he could think of, pictured the encounters he had so far in his mind.

Starting with Emilia, then Felt and the loathsome Elsa, followed by Ram and Rem, plus Beatrice and Petra, setting Meili aside. After that, Priscilla, Crusch, Anastasia, and Ferris, who he should look up to as a mentor, and then Frederica. Then there were the Witches, well-dressed only in appearance, annoyingly— he had gathered his imagination of “beauty” from all the beautiful girls, beautiful women, and beautiful girl-like beings he had met in this other world so far.

—He must constantly imagine himself as the most beautiful version of herself.

He did not need to think about anything else beyond the vision he held.

He had made the best move he could with what he currently had on hand, and arrived at the place where he needed to be.

Therefore—

Subaru: “—This is me.”

His sight left the mirror, then he slowly took a deep breath and turned around.

Alone, after hours of trying to fight in solitude, he finally pushed open the door. Beyond it, he could see his friends with bated breath, waiting for the success or failure of this mission to take hold.

The women turned their attention to Subaru as he opened the door and stepped out.

Subaru: “———”

There was silence, and he could feel the tense atmosphere.

His immediate anxiety refused to allow him to understand which emotion was causing the silence. Certainly, he was lacking a number of cards to play with. If he’d had that, if he’d had this, there would be no end to his regrets.

However, thinking about it, was it not about taking initiative?

One could not always go into battle in perfect condition. In any case, life was all about playing the cards one had been dealt, wasn’t it?

And it was when he found himself making excuses as if he had already lost the battle.

???: “...Brilliant.”

He heard the faint sound of air bursting and looked up.

There he saw that the true nature of this burst had been nothing of the sort. It was the sound of hands coming together. It was the sound of applause. The sound was a mixture of congratulations, admiration, and respect.

Subaru: “Mi...”

He looked at the person clapping and was about to call out in a manner unbecoming a lady, but stopped himself in time.

It was still incomplete. He gently put his hand to his throat and let the air bounce there in small puffs. Then, just as the gears clicked in his mind, he smiled,

Subaru: “Mizelda-san.”

Mizelda: “—Hk, no way, your voice? What in the *world*, what in the *world*, how in *the*...!?²⁶”

Subaru: “Once I’ve decided to do something, it’s my duty to do my best. There are lives that can be saved if I don’t cut corners. If that’s the case, then there’s only one thing I have to do.”

Mizelda: “Ohhh...!”

The smile disappeared and he pointed one finger up towards the heavens.

The close thicket of trees prevented him from seeing the sun, but it was not the heavenly beings he had to show this to, only the many friends gathered here.

Look at them, from head to toe.

It didn’t matter if it was from the front, the back, the right, the left, or anywhere in between.

—He must constantly imagine himself as the most beautiful.

If he succeeded in tracing that image, succeeded in recreating the ideal, then he would have nothing to fear.

²⁶ Translation note from Witch Cult Translations: “Mizelda’s reaction here is because of how much Subaru’s voice and speech mannerisms have changed. Keep in mind that, for most of the time from now on, Subaru is using feminine and polite speech.”

Here, with authority—

Subaru: “—Natsumi Schwartz’s advent.”

That's what Natsumi Schwartz heroically—or rather, declared like a lady.

Mizelda, the woman who had stopped clapping in front of him, nodded deeply. She then lined up next to Natsumi, supporting his back with her hand,

Mizelda: "My world was too *small*. You were right, Subaru... No, Natsumi."

Subaru: “You understand now, don’t you, Mizelda-san?”

Mizelda: "Ahh, it's *frustrating*, but I do understand *now*... Beauty can be *made*."

Mizelda lowered the corners of her eyes and smiled gently, while Natsumi smiled back.

The People of Shudraq that were gathered there also looked at each other as they witnessed the beautiful scene. Then, applause rained down, coming as a belated blessing.

The applause continued to pour down, congratulating Natsumi on her unveiling.

And then—

???: “What is *this*?”

???: “Uh~.”

The ones who couldn't quite get over it watched the scene with their cheeks contorted into a frown.



Subaru: “And so, Natsumi Schwartz was born. I was a bit confused, since the different makeup tools and all, but I managed to get this much done.”

Rem: "Are you kidding me?"

Subaru: “Eh!?”

After returning to the meeting place and setting up another assembly, Natsumi— or rather, Subaru’s words were answered by Rem, her gaze gelid, her tone glaciated.

Rem’s chilly attitude did not change even after showing her the results. Subaru pointed to his face and said,

Subaru: “I need fake eyelashes after all... For the wig. I managed to borrow some black hair from the Shudraq...”

Rem: “I’m not talking about that. I think the makeup and wigs are well done. But you don’t have to talk like a woman forever.”

Subaru: “Yes, but... the state of mind is also important, isn’t it? If I’m not careful on a regular basis, I never know where I might fall apart. Besides...”

Rem: “Besides?”

Subaru: “If I indulge in the fact that I’m a man, the goddess of beauty will turn her back on me and... Ouch ouch ouch!”

Just as Subaru was about to speak seriously, Rem pulled his ear quite hard.

He couldn’t help but get teary-eyed as he quickly moved away. Subaru decided to slip close to Mizelda, who was watching the proceedings.

Subaru: “Mizelda-anesama, I’m afraid of Rem-san...”

Mizelda: “Umm, don’t *cry*, Natsumi... Strangely *enough*, you look so cute, even though I know you’re Subaru. Taritta should learn from *you*.”

Taritta: “Sister!”

While her sister patted Subaru’s head, Taritta rolled her eyes at Mizelda’s ruthless comment.

However, Taritta's face was much softer than it would normally be. That was because Subaru had rearranged the heavy makeup she usually wore, which could be called the war paint of the People of Shudraq, to make her look cuter.

The Shudraq were best known for their bravery and strength, but this time they were required to be both glamorous and dangerous, with a magical and sensuous quality that could drive men crazy.

Taritta and Kuna's makeup was fun to apply once they decided to focus their beauty regimen in that direction.

Subaru: "You have a much younger face than I expected, Taritta-anesama. Your makeup looks great, it's nice to show off your cuteness once in a while."

Taritta: "Please don't tease *me*! First of all, I can't be as pretty as *you*..."

Subaru: "Well, your lack of confidence is also cute! Right, Mizelda-anesama?"

Mizelda: "Yes, *dear*."

Mizelda's cheeks relaxed as Subaru leaned up to her and spoke softly. Taritta flinched at the sight of the two of them, and turned over with a slight blush on her cheeks.

Her brown skin made it hard to see her cheeks redden, but the makeup on her eyes and lips gave the impression of a slight blush, so it was easy to see the adorable change in her appearance.

Rem: "When are you going to stop fooling around!?"

Rem shattered such a flowery scene with a single shout.

Subaru and Taritta shrank as if hit by a gust of wind. Rem glared at them with her pale blue eyes, then looked at Kuna at the edge of the room.

Kuna, who, like Taritta, also had her makeup done along with her hair, jerked away.

Kuna: "W-what is *it*, for the record, I have nothing to do with *this*..."

Rem: “Kuna-san, I’m counting on you. Looking at those two, I see you’re the only one who’s sane... Are you seriously going along with this plan?”

Kuna: “I know I’m the only sane *one*, but...”

Kuna, who had her hair in twin tails, looked at Subaru and Taritta with an unmotivated look in her eyes.

It was an unpleasant assessment, but Subaru could only wait to see what would happen. Her look told him that he was insane, and thus was different from Taritta, who was shaking in shock.

Kuna let out a small exhale at the reaction of Subaru and the others.

Kuna: “The reason why he couldn’t do the mission has *disappeared*, you understand that *too*, right, Rem? Natsumi... Subaru doesn’t have a *problem*. Yeah, he’s more of a woman than the *Chieftain*.”

Rem: “I think that’s too rude to say about Mizelda-san...”

Kuna: “I don’t think it’s a *problem*. What’ll be a problem are our results over *there*...”

And just as Kuna was nearly done answering Rem’s questions,

???: “—It appears everyone is here.”

Kuna: “Ohh, speaking of the *devil*...”

A pompous, undeceiving tone of voice enveloped the meeting hall, and a new figure appeared.

When Kuna’s gaze turned in that direction, Rem had no choice but to turn in the same direction. Naturally, Subaru, Mizelda, and the others’ gazes were drawn there as well.

Everyone: “———”

At that moment, time stopped for everyone.

—No, to be precise, time stopped for everyone aside from the figure that appeared and Subaru, who had applied makeup to them.

Subaru: “I left the fine-tuning to you, but... you’re so good at it, it’s almost disgusting.”

Abel: “It does not elate me to be praised for my makeup skills. Nevertheless, your skills are impressive. So, even a finished product may become a whole new thing, huh. It looks even better than I imagined.”

Subaru: “Kuh, my margin for victory...!”

As he said this, Subaru gently bit his pinky finger in frustration.

Of course, there was no doubting his belief that beauty could be created. Subaru was also proud to say that he had proved this with his own body, using the few cards he had in hand.

However, there was still a difference in materials.

That was why—

Rem: “Ah, Abel-san, right?”

Abel: “Who else would it be? Do not inquire such a silly question. No, if I have changed that much, then your surprise is appropriate for reference.”

In response to Rem’s trembling words, Abel— or rather, Bianca, the being born from makeup, a wig, and a change of costume, clutched his five thin white fingers.

His raven black hair was long and lustrous, creating a perfect harmony with his beautiful face and slit eyes. The dancer’s costume bound his waist, splitting down his legs, showing just enough skin to attract attention.

Standing there was a beautiful dancer who had recreated extreme beauty, the best joker card in hand, that was essential to this plan.

Everyone else: “———”

Bianca’s perfection was such that even Mizelda and the others had lost their voices.

That was different from Subaru’s Natsumi, where the shock was over the magnitude of the change. This was the pure shock that was brought about by the perfection of beauty that Abel’s Bianca had in spades.

The Shudraqian jewelry, which adorned the dancer's costume and long hair, served only as a garnish to accentuate his real beauty.

Subaru remembered the smile on Mizelda's face when she had lent them to him.

For some reason, Subaru's heart ached when he remembered that smile. However, out of concern for Mizelda and the others, Subaru did not have the option of cutting corners.

How could he ruin this perfection himself?

Subaru's ego as Natsumi Schwartz would not allow for such a thing.

Subaru: "It was surprising to me that you weren't afraid of wearing makeup..."

Abel: "What, you think it a disgrace to dress up as a woman? For the record, this is not the first time I have done this. I have undergone such things many times in my childhood."

Subaru: "As a child?"

Abel: "Yes. Considering my position, I would state it is a good idea to possess a wide range of ways to protect oneself."

Subaru's lips curved at Abel's words, not Bianca's, a beautiful woman who crossed her arms adorably.

Perhaps his past experiences were referring to the secret feuds he'd endured as a candidate to become the next Emperor, before actually taking up the seat.

In Vollachia, where the succession to the throne was apparently much more tumultuous than in Lugunica, it was easy to imagine the possibility of assassination being employed in the battle over who became the next Emperor.

In order to survive such a harsh life, he would have sometimes had to disguise his appearance and even gender.

Abel's willingness to make sacrifices, including his own, seemed to have been shaped by his childhood, before he won the throne of the Emperor.

That was how it had come about, and now appeared in Abel's Bianca, now dressed as a woman.

Subaru: "Still, it's kind of annoying that you're aware that you're beautiful...!"

Abel: "That is exactly what is ridiculous. How can someone be in a position where they must be capable of looking at their country from a broad perspective, and not be able to see themselves objectively? Though you seem to have subverted that objective assessment of yourself through your own skills, I have no need for those kinds of petty tricks."

Subaru: "Guh... Hk."

Abel: "Do you know why tigers are strong? Tigers are strong because they are strong."

Subaru was struck by a concept that he had heard from Garfiel as well.

The theory that tigers were strong because they were tigers, became attributed to the fact that Abel was beautiful because he was Abel. It was no longer the logic of violence.

It was the same as saying that Reinhard was strong because he was Reinhard.

In other words, it was a blunt view of the world.

Subaru: "Well, anyway... Flora's thinking the same thing, isn't she!?"

Flop: "Aren't you jumping to conclusions there, Husband-kun?!"

Behind Abel followed an astonished Flop, now disguised as Flora.

He was also dressed up, and had the type of beauty that Subaru knew would make a finished product more complete just by fully utilizing the potential of his resources. In fact, unlike Subaru and Abel, he'd had his originally long hair only slightly tweaked, so it could be said that he was the one who brought out the most charm from the materials.

In fact, Subaru was confident that if they stood side-by-side, he wouldn't be greatly inferior. But—

Subaru: "There is a difference in the amount of time and effort that is put in... Must be divine favoritism...!"

Flop: “I’m sorry to hear you lamenting this, but you look great Husband-kun. You’re no longer Husband-kun, you’re Husband-san!”

Subaru: “...I’m not satisfied with a compliment like that anymore.”

Flop: “Was that a compliment? I didn’t know it was.”

Flop’s frankness hadn’t changed even though he was now Flora. Anyway, that was fine in his case. Although he would need some acting guidance to follow the plan’s directions.

In this situation however, it was Abel who would be the most important.

Subaru: “Flora and I can play instruments. Therefore, your role is...”

Abel: “Dancing, huh. I do not require being told, I have the plan in my mind. The importance of my role alike. Besides...”

Subaru: “Besides?”

Abel: “I am not as excellent at dancing as my dead sister, but I am pretty close.”

His cheeks twisted, and even his triumphant, arrogant smile was beautiful.

Abel’s confident attitude was reassuring, and at the same time, it made Subaru’s heart burn with anticipation. In fact, Abel had demonstrated his devilishness without regret as a complete Bianca.

If Abel’s self-awareness was correct, Subaru could have high hopes for the dancing as well.

Subaru: “—Alright then. If you have that much confidence, show me how good you are. After all, you can’t take back whatever you’ve spat out.”

Abel: “Whatever I spat out, huh...? Hmmm, as in, when one is being spat down upon by the clouds, you mean? That is quite a roundabout way of saying it, but that is fine. I shall display it to you.”

Subaru: “———”

Abel: “It is the least I can do, to reward you for offering this plan.”

It was uncertain if they had respected Subaru, the one who had come up with the plan, or if no one cared about the name of the operation in the first place, but it was a good thing that there had been no trouble over it.

At any rate, there was no point in a plan in which the element of luck inevitably came into play.

Of course, they would spare no effort to improve their chances of success, but it was difficult to accrete luck. However, it was not a bad thing to gain a favorable condition, even if it was a small one.

—Leaving the Buddheim Jungle, the group set course for Guaral.

The five members of the party were Subaru's Natsumi, Abel's Bianca, Flop's Flora, Taritta, and Kuna. The rest of the People of Shudraq were led by Mizelda in a separate party, with Rem, Louis, and Medium among them.

Hiding away from the city, they would need to attack the walls of the Fortress City and act as a diversion if the need arose. However, that was only an insurance policy.

A less-than-ideal insurance policy in case the plan fails. If the plan were to fail, Subaru and the others would be in a very dangerous situation by then. Anyway—

Subaru: "Personally, I think the first checkpoint's the most important one."

Subaru muttered this, looking up at the main gate, in which the front was glaring down at them from high above.

They were going to challenge the main gate again, which they had once forced their way through, albeit that had passed a few days ago. Naturally, after what had happened the other day, the security level at the checkpoint was higher than before.

In preparation for another invasion by rebels, special emphasis had been placed on dragon carriages, ox carts, and other vehicles that could hide people in their cargo. He could hear the shouts of merchants and travelers as their tools of the trade were mangled, their carts turned over, and their straw carefully poked with swords.

To be honest, he felt quite bad for them. However, considering the chaos that would occur in the city ahead, he thought it might be wise of them to turn back here.

Of course, there was no way he could give them that kind of advice, but—

???: “—Next, what about you guys?”

A stern man’s rough voice struck Subaru’s eardrums as he pondered.

Upon looking up, he saw a bald-headed guard with a strong physique beckoning toward him. The man called the group forward, and Subaru hung his head reverently at the head of the group.

Subaru: “We are a troupe of traveling entertainers. We come to this city from the north.”

Guard: “Ohh, traveling entertainers...”

Raising an eyebrow in curiosity, the guard also looked at the group behind Subaru.

Flora, carrying a musical instrument on her back, waved; Taritta, carrying her luggage on her back, bowed; Kuna draped a parasol over the person next to her, whose face was covered by a veil, not allowing anyone to see her expression.

The guard’s admiration for this rather atmospheric group could be sensed.

Subaru: “———”

On the other hand, while maintaining an amiable smile, Subaru’s insides were tense.

He was familiar with the guard. He was the one who had been in charge of the main gate when Subaru had first met Flop and Medium when entering Guaral.

In other words, he could not have been a better choice for the first obstacle.

Guard: “But coming from the north, that must’ve been tough. It’s rumored that the Scorching Lady’s territory’s bustling with activity over there. Flocks of flying dragons are flying around.”

Subaru: “Yes, yes, that’s true. That’s why we couldn’t stay there for too long... On the other hand, this is a city protected by such a magnificent wall, so I’m sure it’s safe, right?”

Guard: “Uhhh, that’s...”

When Subaru flirted, with a faint smile on his face, the guard’s expression grew uncomfortable.

The reason for his reaction was probably that he too was aware that the Imperial Soldiers, whose camp had been burned to the ground, had fled into the city. On top of that, the commotion caused by Subaru and his companions the other day had probably made the Imperial Soldiers in the city more alert and the atmosphere tense.

That must have been the reason for the guard’s slurred speech.

That being the case, there was no reason not to take advantage of it.

Subaru: “...Are you worried about something in this city, by any chance?”

Guard: “...Yeah, kinda. It’s something that’s easy to find out even if you try to hide it. As a matter of fact, the Imperial Army’s stationed in this city right now, and they’re having trouble with the tribes to the east. So...”

Subaru: “Ohh dear! That must be suffocating for the people of the city.”

Guard: “That’s right.”

Apparently exasperated, the guard leaned forward at Subaru’s words.

Although it was hard to distinguish between the two when not in contact with each other, guards and soldiers basically had different positions. Guards in a city belonged to that city only. Soldiers, on the other hand, belonged to the country, in this case the Empire. Their chain of command was also fundamentally different.

The guard in front of him was also a member of this city and had a duty to protect it.

However, the current situation was that the Imperial Army had taken over the City Hall, and the guards were being ordered to do this and that. The guards had no reason to be used as a toy by the Imperial Soldiers.

Guard: “In addition, they took over the city taverns by themselves, calling it “night patrol”. And since they don’t pay well, it’s not good for business. I can’t handle it anymore.”

Subaru: “Ohh dear, ohh dear, how terrible! My heart goes out to you. Between you and me, I’ve had my share of rough experiences with the arrogance of the Imperial Soldiers.”

Guard: “Ohh, really? A beautiful woman like you...?”

After he threw in some agreeable reactions, the guard’s response softened at once at Subaru’s deep and loud approval. Actually, the man seemed to be quite friendly, so Subaru lowered his voice slightly, then said, “Yes”, and turned his head to look away.

Seeing that meaningful gesture, the guard said, “Ohh, miss?” before he became flustered.

Guard: “Are you okay? If you don’t wanna talk, don’t bother...”

Subaru: “No, I’m fine. It’s an old, old story. It’s just that before, I was forcibly captured by the Imperial Soldiers and put in a cage and treated like a slave.”

Guard: “That’s...”

Subaru: “They sometimes did things like intentionally extend their feet to make me trip and fall, and at other times they would even threaten me with blades...”

Guard: “Tha-that’s unforgivable...!”

The guard clenched his fists in righteous indignation as Subaru tearfully recounted his past.

Seeing the man’s ears reddening in fury, Subaru muttered softly, “You’re so kind.”

Guard: “No, no, I’m not trying to be nice. Anyone’d feel the same way you do.”

Subaru: “Then, hey, Guard-sama. If you feel sorry for me, please let me in. If you do...”

Guard: “Then what?”

Subaru: “Then I’ll give a makeover to the atmosphere of this city, which the Imperial Army has made so bleak.”

His voice was quiet, but the enthusiasm in his voice was passionate.

Hearing this, the stern face of the guard flushed with surprise. His gaze turned to the troupe of traveling entertainers lined up behind Subaru.

Guard: "...Ladies, what arts exactly are you gonna show us?"

Subaru: "Of course, we have traveled around the world and learned many different arts. I also like to sing, play a bit of music, and do a little magic. But..."

Guard: "...Gulp."

Subaru: "The best part of the show is the dance of the troupe's flower, the danseuse."

With those words, Subaru pointed to a figure standing in the center of the group, protected by a parasol. Her face was hidden by a veil, and she was the main attraction of the troupe.

The guard's eyes widened and stiffened as he took in the gaze from behind the veil.

His throat was frozen, even though not everything was exposed.

Guard: "-----"

It was natural to be blinded and unable to move.

It was a masterpiece that would have frustrated even Subaru. "Beauty can be made", he had boldly stated, but true beauty was a creation of God.

After all, Subaru's beauty was nothing more than touch-up work in comparison to that.

However, even that one step was enough to sharpen his devilish beauty even more.

Subaru: "In addition to the danseuse, we'll also sing and play music for you. We hope you will allow us to stay in Guaral."

Guard: "-----"

Subaru: "Guard-sama?"

Guard: "...Ah, ahh, that's right. I don't see anything suspicious among your possessions..."

The guard muttered to himself as he came back to his senses after being nipped in the shoulder with a little pinch. He then put his hand on his chest and looked around at the group, breathing softly to check the beating of his heart.

And as much as possible, while consciously averting his gaze in order to not become mesmerized by that fiendish visage.

Guard: "You can come in. If you're gonna perform somewhere, it's better to stay away from the main gate. The main street in the middle of town's a good place to start. The City Hall's too crowded with soldiers to be a viable candidate."

Subaru: "Well, that's very kind of you... When will Guard-sama be available?"

Guard: "Ohh, me? My shift ends just before dinner at dusk, and then I'll go eat..."

Subaru: "Then please let me know where that restaurant is. I'm sure that if you bring some of your colleagues with you, we'll be able to thank them for their hospitality towards us."

He gently leaned in and whispered so into the guard's ear.

When the guard raised his eyes in surprise, Subaru smiled at him and moved away. Then turning to his troupe mates, impatiently waiting at the checkpoint,

Subaru: "Okay, here we go, folks. Let's clear the atmosphere in this city as a gift."

With that, Subaru led the people who had stopped in their tracks and passed by the guard.

With the guard holding his ears and looking on in amazement, Subaru and the others walked proudly and unhindered through the main gate into the city.

Watching them go, the guard exhaled quietly—

Guard: "...Let's try to finish work as soon as possible for today."

He blurted this out.

Flop: “Well, that was a thing of beauty, Husband-san! I’m beginning to think that maybe you have more talent as a merchant than I do!”

A few moments after passing through the main gate with his luggage, Flop a.k.a. Flora praised Subaru’s behavior at the checkpoint with a twinkle in his eye.

There was no lie in his open-hearted words, and Subaru nodded cheerfully.

Subaru: “Yes! I’m honored by your praise. But I’m not a merchant by any means. I got my own business that I need to attend to.”

Flop: “Things you need to do? Like what?”

Subaru: “Of course, it’s not about being a lady...it’s about helping the people important to me.”

Flop: “———”

Flop’s eyes widened slightly upon hearing Subaru’s words. However, he quickly relaxed his gaze and nodded, “Well, yes”.

Flop: “Then we need to make this plan work, and reassure the Wife-san as soon as possible.”

Subaru: “And Flora, we don’t want to make Medium-san feel uneasy, do we?”

Flop: “Hahahaha! My sister would never be worried. My sister is a very tough girl, both physically and mentally. I can’t imagine her feeling down!”

Subaru agreed with Flop, who smiled cheerfully, albeit unlady-like.

Like Flop, he could not imagine Medium feeling down either. The two siblings must have helped each other through many a rough times.

That was why Subaru had a responsibility to help the two people he had gotten involved.

Subaru: “It’s getting harder and harder to mess up, isn’t it?”

???: “Wait, please *wait*, Subaru... No, Natsumi.”

Subaru braced himself, as he heard a weak voice from behind.

He looked over to see that it was Taritta, who was carrying the group's luggage. She was unlike her usual self, as, after leaving the jungle, Taritta had changed her makeup.

Instead of the amazon-esque Shudraqian attire, she wore more fluttery clothing, and her image now was that of an exotic ethnic dancer.

Rather, it was less revealing than her usual attire, but as Taritta glanced around, her cheeks dyed red with embarrassment,

Taritta: "Hey, isn't this kind of attention *grabbing*? There's something weird about Kuna and I..."

Kuna: "Don't drag me into this, *please*. If you're talking about something *strange*, there's no one stranger than Natsumi. What the hell was that with that checkpoint just *now*? You're too good with *men*."

By the side of the flustered Taritta, Kuna touched Subaru with her usual low intensity.

After those words from her, Subaru put his hand on his cheek with an "Ohh my",

Subaru: "It's not the first time I've dealt with a gentleman. And don't worry, Taritta-san. It's not that you or Kuna stand out. It's all of us who stand out... Because we're beautiful."

Flop: "Because we're beautiful!"

Nodding profoundly, Flop and Subaru both agreed.

In response, Taritta looked incredulous as she voiced out a "Beau... tiful..."

Taritta: "I-if you're going to use words like *that*, then give them to my *sister*..."

Flop: "What are you saying, Miss Taritta? Your charm and your sister's are two very different things. First of all, by no means am I disregarding my admiration for Miss Mizelda when I pay my compliments to you. She's a different case, and you two are in entirely different categories!"

Taritta: "—Hk!"

In an instant, Flop took Taritta's hand and said this with a radiant smile.

Taritta's eyes widened at the vigor of it, and her mouth slowly opened and then closed rapidly. As the blush on her cheeks grew, Subaru put his hand over his mouth and let out a "My ohh my".

Kuna: "Give me a *break*. Taritta's particularly attached to the Chieftain, and has hardly ever left the *forest*. That's why she's not very *tolerant*."

Subaru: "Well, she's smiling. But you're calm, right?"

Kuna: "I've been sneaking out of the woods more often than *not*, and I've never had a great and fearsome *sister*... I have a younger sister who's quite a *handful*."

In the back of Kuna's closed mind, the person was probably Holly.

They were like sisters, like best friends, like parent and child. However, Taritta's words could not be ignored.

???: "———"

Around them, attention was certainly focused on the crossdressing Subaru walking down the streets past the checkpoint.

In addition to their unusual attire, the entire city was on edge as the Imperial Soldiers were on high alert. Naturally, the citizens of the city would be very suspicious of strangers.

If that was the case, then——

Abel: "——It is an opportunity."

Subaru: "Only for curious eyes, isn't it?"

Under the parasol, a sharp gaze pierced Subaru's profile from within the veil's shadow.

Nudged to stop talking nonsense, Subaru replied with a sultry, "Yes". However, Subaru agreed with the danseuse that this was a good opportunity.

Therefore——

Subaru: "Let's follow the advice of the guards and make our debut on the main street!"

Flop: “All right, Si... No, Miss Natsumi!”

Flop followed along as Subaru decided to start the performance off with a bang right on the spot.

They took off part of their costumes, exposing their shoulders, stomachs, and backs. They then stepped out, each holding an instrument in their hands, poised at the sides of the main street.

And then—

Subaru: “Come on, come by and take a look! I will now show you a song and dance that has been handed down through time and across the world, from beyond the Great Waterfall of the far East! This is from a traveling troupe that has come to the city today to perform!”

Subaru intoned a promotional line loudly, and then Flop, who had received eye contact, began to play the Lyulyre, a stringed instrument held in his hand.

The light sounds combined to form music, which drew even more attention from the people who heard it.

???: “Ohh, what’s going on?”

???: “They say they’re traveling entertainers! Music, music!”

???: “Wow, that’s quite a collection of beauties...”

The people walking down the street, lured in by Subaru’s words and Flop’s music, stopped or peeked out from the inside of buildings, having their attention drawn by the troupe.

Subaru and Flop were on the lead instruments, as Taritta and Kuna followed with simpler percussion instruments, such as castanets.

Subaru was grateful enough that since Flop was more skilled than expected, so he had no qualms with the music. More importantly, the odds of victory were roughly fifty percent.

Subaru: “From now on, we will sing and dance a story from a different world, far, far away! It is a story of people, dragons, demons, and strange beings that cannot be expressed in words. Please, everyone, relax and enjoy to your heart’s content!”

With a smile on his face and an excited tone of voice, the anticipation built up as Flop's performance with Subaru reached its first climax.

Everyone was in love with their performance and the beauty of the musicians, but the real deal was right after this.

And just as the music crescendoed into its apex---

???: "-----"

A black-haired dancer slowly removed the thin silk she was wearing, and stepped out into the street.

Upon lifting the veil with one hand and revealing his face, the people who had been listening to the music turned their gazes towards him, as a shock feeling like a punch to the gut permeated them.

Yes, that was it. He wanted that reaction, that look, and yet, he was upset.

Subaru: "It's so frustrating."

As he played his instrument, Subaru expressed his inner frustration of being beaten.

Deep in his heart, he felt defeated. But it should feel good to be beaten by something of such high caliber. But that was a lie. A sense of defeat was ultimately a sense of defeat, and it was frustrating.

However, this calmness just before it all turned into a frenzy was the key to this plan

Then, to the fullest extent, they could charm the people of Guaral with this dance.

Subaru: "Now, you're up, Bianca---!"

Abel: "-----"

After glancing at Subaru with a flushed look, Abel a.k.a. Bianca slowly raised his arm.

One fluid movement, of merely raising an arm. In spite of this, his gestures had an elegance that exuded from deep within his being. It melted into the air and instantly dominated the main street.

A flowing, beautiful, and solemn dance began.

The dance that accompanied the music was something that Abel had originally mastered, but with Subaru's own twist, was probably new to everyone.

Yet, it even dispensed a need for any sort of manipulation or petty tricks.

With Subaru's tweaks, what had been a solid dance was now far superior.

Audience: "———"

The audience forgot to breathe as their gaze was enraptured by the beautiful dance. It was a cry of beauty that appealed to their instincts, it told them not to take their eyes off it even for a moment. To put it bluntly, this was what the eyes were meant to behold.

Abel's dance was arrogant and pompous, confronting his audience with such thoughts.

——It said, "Look at me".

The sight of the mesmerized and stunned crowd was frightening to Subaru, even though he had been the one to come up with the idea.

If there were a thief here, the people standing around would have their pockets openly searched and would not even notice if someone took their wallets—— No, that assumption was not valid, since even a thief would not be able to take their eyes off Abel's dance.

???: "———"

It was only one song and dance, lasting less than five minutes of time. The performers had been concentrating on not making any mistakes, but Subaru wondered if anyone would have even noticed if they had messed up. To be honest, Subaru's true thoughts were that it would be doubtful.

Once the performance ended, Abel's heels and toes made ground.

Seeing this posture, the audience finally realized that the dance was already over and Abel was just standing there.

Immediately, the main street was filled with applause and cheers.



Just as Subaru had hoped, just as he had aimed for, it was a resounding response.

However, unlike Flop, who was holding up his instrument and responding to the cheers, Subaru was smiling to the crowd with mixed feelings.

At any rate---

Abel: “---Hmm.”

He had no idea what to say to Abel, who smiled triumphantly at him.



The reputation of the troupe in the Fortress City of Guaral had been determined by the great success of their first performance.

A demonstration of sorts set on the principal avenue, but the response had been far greater than they had expected, and so the troupe’s activities after that became much easier.

However---

Subaru: “Don’t forget that we were only brought into the spotlight because of our novelty. Our performance is just a hasty effort... Our act now is merely a passing fancy.”

Flop: “I see! In other words, we need to work on our skills steadily, don’t we, Husband-kun?”

Subaru: “Yes. That’s why we need to work tirelessly and be alert every day!”

Subaru clenched his fists firmly while Flop, who sat upright, nodded with a smile.

In contrast to his loud voice, Flop was a very good listener and responded quickly. Admirably, Subaru’s speech gained momentum thanks to Flop.

Anyway, it was not Flop that Subaru really should be talking to.

Subaru: “You two! Don’t let your guard down.”

Taritta: “Uh-ohh, now we got caught in the *crossfire*.”

Kuna: “W-we *did*...?”

When Subaru pointed at them, Taritta and Kuna immediately looked displeased.

Inside the inn, the two of them had taken off the clothes they’d dressed up in, and gone back to their Shudraqian style, which appeared almost like underwear. While working as members of the troupe, they were properly dressed, but as soon as they entered the secluded inn, they looked like this.

Subaru: “You’re slacking too much.”

Taritta: “I’m not saying we’re not *relaxing*, but on the other hand what about *her*...?”

Subaru: “What do you mean? Actually, what are you even talking about? You know, I find these conversations without a clear subject pretty annoying.”

Taritta: “Natsumi, that’s *what*. Why you would pretend to be something you’re not, even when no one’s *looking*, is beyond Kuna and I. Is it really *necessary*?”

Subaru: “Pretending to be something I’m not...?”

Having no clue, Subaru replied questionably, and Taritta and the others were taken aback.

Naturally, “It’s a joke” Subaru said, as he dispelled their surprise.

Subaru: “Nevertheless, I can’t accept that notion. You know why? “The devil is in the details”, as they say, and it’s the seemingly useless details that bring about the reality of the situation. That’s precisely why it’s essential to...”

Flop: “Not cut corners in places outside the public eye, is what you’re saying. Hhm hhm, as expected, Husband-kun... No, Miss Natsumi! I’m learning a lot!”

Flop was truly a student worth teaching, as that was an answer worth one hundred points.

That said, in regards to the point that he couldn't correct himself from using "boku" as his first person pronoun no matter how much he tried²⁸, Kuna looked in protest at Subaru, but he passed it off with a smile.

—At that moment, Subaru and his troupe of traveling entertainers were staying at an inn in Guaral.

It had already been three days since they had begun their infiltration, and in that time, they had performed a total of ten times, receiving a more-than-adequate response.

He had not been in need of money to begin with, as he had the proceeds from the sale of the Elgina's horn, but a good amount of money continued to come in for each show, so he thought it to be a really profitable venture.

Subaru: "I think it's time to move on to the next phase."

Gently placing his finger on his chin, Subaru hoped for a change in their stagnant situation.

In fact, their current situation was going so well that it was almost too good to be true. Every show was a great success, and the citizens, including the guards, displayed a lot of interest.

This was due to the perfection of Bianca's dancing, as well as the conversational skills of Natsumi and Flora.

Bianca's mysteriousness was also a selling point, and since she rarely appeared in public except to dance, Natsumi and the others naturally took over the role of gathering information.

Initially, the plan had been for Subaru's Natsumi and Flop's Flora to take over the task, since Abel a.k.a Bianca was unable to speak in a female voice.

Subaru: "Strangely enough, no one's suspicious of Flora, right? She hasn't even changed her voice."

Flop: "Haha, I don't have any special skills like Miss Natsumi. But I've been traveling alone with my sister for a long time. Maybe I've picked up some of my sister's habits or something, and that could've given me this feminine-like aura."

²⁸ Subaru normally uses "ore" (俺) as pronoun, but while crossdressing, he switches to "boku" (僕).

Subaru: “So it’s from Medium...”

Flop happily proposed his new theory, but the Medium that appeared in Subaru’s brain was beautiful in appearance, and her ever-changing facial expressions were adorable and charming. However, the theory that her presence’d had an effect on Flora’s current perfection was something that could be debated.

Abel: “—You have a lot of time to waste, do you not?”

Subaru: “Hm.”

A cold, icy voice interrupted the conversation between Subaru and the others.

It was Abel, the dancer of the troupe, who was sitting on a chair by the window without the wig on his head, that had finally decided to join the conversation.

Abel had danced in various places as the star of the show day after day, and although he attempted not to show it, a slight hint of fatigue could be seen.

Of course, he would never admit it, but spending time in Guaral placed a heavy burden on the body and mind. They were always keeping their guard up being behind enemy lines. Subaru, as Natsumi, was also constantly reminding himself to not lose his calm demeanor.

One never knew what tragedy would await them if they became discouraged behind enemy lines.

At first, this strategy had been regarded as a joke by both Rem and Mizelda.

However, Subaru had proposed the plan in a serious manner, and they had discussed it together to increase the chance for success. He was not so pessimistic as to give up and lament that the plan had failed.

Therefore—

Subaru: “Bianca, why don’t you get some rest? After all this time, I’ve never seen you sleep.”

Flop: “I’m not sure what you’re talking about, Miss Natsumi. It’s impossible that... huh? Huh? Now that you mention it, I don’t remember seeing Miss Bianca sleeping either.”

Flop tried to laugh at Subaru's point, but then went serious upon noticing how that rang true. Not paying attention to Flop, Abel snorted and ignored it.

Abel's strong sense of caution was ongoing, and he did not lower his guard with Subaru and the others.

Of course, Subaru understood that it was not easy for a man in his position to be able to open up to others.

But the fact that he could not show any signs of relaxation, even to his comrades who were undertaking this life-threatening mission alongside him, was more than a little tiring.

As usual, he would not even blink both eyes at the same time, Despite the fact nobody here would do anything were he to close both of them.

Subaru: "That way of life is tiring, isn't it?"

Abel: "—Are you really the one telling me this?"

Abel frowned back at Subaru, the latter conveying his honest thoughts.

Hearing this, Subaru was unable to comprehend it all. It was true that Abel's way of life was definitely suffocating, and Subaru's was not.

Abel: "It is especially pathetic that you are not aware of it, but I forgive you. Keep doing your best."

Subaru: "You don't have to tell me, I'll keep living. As for you..."

Abel: "Closing both eyes signifies surrendering the right to life and death to the other. I do not take myself lightly enough to allow that to happen, even for a moment."

Subaru: "——"

Abel: "Do not lose your sense of tension, I am sure you have touched on it before."

With those words, the ones Subaru wished to retort with were blocked.

Subaru stared at Abel's profile with a bitter feeling, but he was no longer being taken seriously. Abel, who had taken off his wig and jewelry, wore feminine outfits at the inn, so that he could change into

Bianca as soon as something happened. That was the justification as to why he looked so good without his wig, even though he should be in an unbalanced state without it.

This was the beauty of the tense atmosphere that was the result of the “ever-present battlefield” mindset Subaru had told the others, Flop included, to maintain.

And while he was thinking about Abel’s cold profile—

Abel: “—There is movement.”

Subaru: “Wha?”

Muttering this, Abel stood up from his chair and went to his bunk. Subaru was taken aback as he witnessed how quickly he had put on the wig that had been left there. However, the meaning of that action was made clear immediately.

Loud and uninhibited footsteps came up from downstairs, and the door to Subaru and the others’ room was violently slammed.

???: “So this is where the traveling troupe is. Open up. It’s a messenger from the City Hall.”

Subaru: “Ah, j-just a minute, Sir!”

???: “Haha, don’t make me laugh, I ain’t waiting. We’re soldiers.”

A hoarse voice mocked the panicked Subaru, and the door of the room opened unceremoniously. Then, a man dressed in the red and black uniform of a soldier strolled into the room.

The man had two swords on his back, his face twisted with joy as he hid his violent impulses, one that Subaru had already seen— Jamal.

Subaru: “—Hk.”

Jamal: “Don’t be so frightened, I ain’t gonna eat you.”

Jamal snapped his teeth at Subaru, who involuntarily gasped and stiffened. With an eye patch over his right eye, he glared over the room with his left, not bothering to hide his unrefined attitude, chuckling “Heh heh”. He then looked at Taritta and the others in their underwear, who had been slow to react.

Behind him, other than Jamal, there were four other soldiers. Apparently, it was Jamal who led them, and no one dared to interrupt his rough and brutish demeanor.

With his men following behind him, Jamal nodded his head in agreement.

Jamal: “I see, we got some beautiful ladies here. When I heard those lovestruck bureaucrats talking ‘bout it, I thought they were exaggerating...”

Subaru: “Soldier-sama, what can I do for you...?”

Jamal: “—I’m talking right now, woman.”

The tension in the air made Subaru chew the inside of his mouth. Jamal suddenly grabbed Subaru’s neck with his hand.

Not with the intention of breaking it, but with a soft touch to stop him from speaking— still, the agility of his movement and the strength of his grip made him feel just how vast the difference of their abilities was.

After all, Jamal, despite his appearance and bad attitude, was very good at what he did. Up to that point, he was probably the most skilled person Subaru had laid eyes upon in the Empire— although scary and strong were two different things.

Jamal: “You’ve got a nice, defiant look in your eyes. I like those sharp eyes, too.”

Subaru: “Ah, I’m flattered by your compliments... Kh.”

Jamal: “I also like the fact you don’t talk too much. How ‘bout I invite you to my bedroom tonight and...”

Jamal’s face was close to Subaru’s, as he looked at him with a lascivious stare.

Even at such a close distance, he did not seem to have noticed Subaru’s true identity. That in itself was welcome, but it seemed to have tugged at his heartstrings in the opposite sense.



Illustration from Volume 27, coloring by Floating ([source](#))

He had received such invitations before, but he had always been able to avoid them with a smile and a good story. But when dealing with Imperial Soldiers, it became hard to refuse.

—It was then that a strong wind blew.

Subaru: “—Ohh.”

Unexpectedly, a breeze more forceful passed through the room, and Subaru’s black hair flew up and tickled Jamal’s cheek. After a moment of annoyance, Jamal turned his attention to the window and saw a figure standing there.

It was the black-haired dancer who was causing a stir in Guaral, standing there, wig back on and holding his elbows in a relaxed manner. Catching the figure head-on, Jamal whistled in surprise.

It was a great show of boldness, whereas most of the people were stuck admiring her.

Jamal: “Haha, so this is the danseuse I’ve heard so much about. No wonder you could pull it off.”

Abel: “Hmph.”

After Jamal released Subaru with a breath of surprise and admiration, he quickly approached Abel. He then grabbed him and made the danseuse face him.

Even though he was unaware, he was holding the Emperor’s precious face in his grasp, giving him a crude smile.

Subaru thought that was exactly what someone had meant when saying ignorance was bliss.

Abel: “———”

Jamal: “You’re a thick-skinned woman, unlike that one. But that’s also okay.”

Abel squared his jaw and quietly stared at his opponent. While Subaru was on edge, Jamal sniffed as he engaged in the Empire’s utmost level of disrespect.

Then, Jamal turned around with his grip still on Abel’s chin and—

Jamal: “Rejoice, traveling entertainers! I’m here to invite y’all to a feast at the City Hall. Zikr Osman, General Second-Class, who runs this city, requests your presence.”

Subaru: “Zikr Osman, the General Second-Class...!”

Jamal: “Ah, ain’t it an honor? For a traveling entertainer to be invited to join a General Second-Class of the Empire.”

—Subaru clenched his fists subconsciously, as if to say “So it begins”.

Jamal’s pompous words overcame the disrespectfulness of the scene and sent a shock of surprise and joy through Subaru.

Zikr Osman, General Second-Class! It seemed as though they had caught the exact fish they were trying to hook.

Jamal: “No way you traveling entertainers are gonna turn me down, right?”

Subaru: “That...”

Flop: “Of course not! We’d hoped to bring song and dance to the Imperial Soldiers! It was the true meaning of our trip!”

Jamal: “Good answer! I like that.”

Subaru’s hesitation was overshadowed by a more immediate answer from Flop.

Flop’s charm, which allowed him to open himself to any opponent, was on full display here against Jamal.

Jamal, feeling good about Flop’s crisp answer, quickly and roughly released Abel’s face, then staggered to the entrance of the room. And then—

Jamal: “Get ready to go. I’m taking y’all to the City Hall.”

Subaru: “What? If you’ve invited us, we’d like to join you lat...”

Jamal: “Hahaha, don’t worry ‘bout it. We’ve been told to bring you there. This is our job, too. You can change right now. I’ll also have my men in the back carry your belongings.”

Subaru: “———”

Jamal: “It’s a Generals-only banquet tonight. We lowly soldiers can only hope for more after tomorrow. So...”

With no intention of letting them go, Jamal’s vulgar gaze harassed everyone in the room

Apparently, they could not afford to ruin his good mood. Fortunately, Subaru, Abel, and Flop were all at least dressed as women.

Taritta and Kuna, who were in most danger, were clearly women, so there was no need to worry that their lack of preparation would derail the mission. That said——

Jamal: “Take your time.”

But the humiliation of having to clean up the room while they watched them unceremoniously change their clothes and pack their bags was hard to shake off. However——

Flop: “Got it! Come on, everyone, let’s get ready! We don’t want to keep the soldiers waiting! Let’s get this done right!”

Subaru: “Flora...”

Flop: “This is so unlike you, Miss Natsumi! Neither blood nor tears suit you.”

Subaru: “———”

His boiling anger disappeared at Flop’s words, who then smiled at him.

The words which he had taken the trouble to add at the end, were taken as a dare to remind Subaru of the purpose of the Bloodless Siege.

Subaru: “——Yes, you’re right. Here, you and Bianca prepare yourselves! Especially since Bianca is a clod who can’t do anything but dance!”

Abel: “———”

Taking advantage of Abel's inability to speak, Subaru delivered a scathing assessment of Bianca. Abel's gaze stabbed him, but Subaru brushed it off.

He quickly cleared up the luggage in the room, changed his clothes to go up to City Hall, and forced himself to behave as Jamal wished.

At best, he could only whistle and enjoy watching them change.

Subaru was sure the biggest shock and regret of Jamal's life would be waiting for him at the time the operation went according to plan.

That was the reason why—

Flop: "No! I don't think you have to go so far as to need to shake your butt, Miss Natsumi!"



Even to the untrained eye, there was nothing in the City Hall that looked like military equipment.

Since the building was used for the management of the city during peacetime, it was only natural that no military equipment was prepared here. Even so, there were currently more than three-hundred Imperial Soldiers in the city, and more than five-hundred if the guards were included, so the defensive power was sufficient. More importantly—

Subaru: "We've succeeded in sneaking into their bosom, but..."

Inside the building, Subaru chuckled as he took a look at the map in his mind.

Operation "Kumaso Takeru" was progressing unexpectedly smoothly.

He hoped that if the beautiful traveling entertainers became the topic of conversation in the city, the General known as the Womanizer would take an interest in them— and ultimately invite them to a banquet which would allow Subaru and the others to seize their target.

By being invited directly to the City Hall, Subaru could see an opportunity to realize their plan.

At the same time, however, another problem surfaced.

Subaru: “We’re going to have to carry out the operation tonight...”

There was no time to tell this to Mizelda and the others in the second squad.

Jamal, who had come to pick up Subaru and the others at the inn, had not allowed them to make contact with the outside world, not out of caution, but because of his perverseness.

There was no mistake that Jamal was a troublesome person, as he had bad intuition, yet compensated with good skills.

Even inside the City Hall, Subaru and his team’s activities were restricted, and since they could not take separate actions for any reason during the course of the meeting, they had yet to inform the other team of tonight’s plans. Therefore—

Subaru: “We need to contact the outside world from inside the City Hall.”

There was also the possibility of failure, but if Subaru and the others’ operation succeeded, it would be necessary to disarm the other Imperial Soldiers inside the city.

Naturally, this would require a certain amount of strength, so regardless of the success or failure of Operation “Kumaso Takeru”, they needed to be in a position to cooperate with the outside world.

That was why he was undergoing a lot of trial and error.

Subaru: “I don’t know what she’s thinking, but Bianca’s unreliable...”

It sounded good to say that he was concentrating on this evening’s banquet, but ever since they had been invited to City Hall and isolated in confinement within the waiting room, Abel had been silent.

Of course, he understood that cooperation with the outside world would determine the success or failure of this plan, but he had not responded to Subaru’s advice.

Flop was also extremely supportive, and to be honest, he had been a great help, but he did not pose as an appropriate person to discuss the plan to bring down the City Hall with. First of all, Subaru did not want to do something that would cause him any more trouble. In other words—

Subaru: "I have to do something about it."

Clenching his fists, Subaru fired himself up in the bathroom he was led to.

Subaru and the others had been ordered not to leave the waiting room, but as expected, they would never forbid them from going to the bathroom. Nevertheless, they could not act recklessly, as the City Hall would immediately be flooded with Imperial Soldiers if they showed any suspicious behavior.

Subaru glanced at the windows, but unfortunately could not even try to go outside, as they had been fitted with iron bars, and because the waiting room itself was located on the Third Floor of the building.

He did not think the soldiers were particularly wary of Subaru and the others. However, the idea of leaving them completely unguarded was out of the question. That may be the manifestation of imperialism.

In the worst-case scenario, the idea of reconsidering the decision to go ahead with the operation tonight at the banquet came to Subaru's mind.

Subaru: "...Even if we could miss the banquet, we wouldn't be able to avoid the invitation afterwards."

They were a troupe of traveling entertainers with beautiful women.

In the first place, when it came to bringing down the so-called Womanizer, it was easy to imagine that the goal was dancing, performing arts, and the nightly fun that lay ahead.

Even if he could avoid the advances of the citizens, it would be difficult for him to refuse the advances of an Imperial Soldier, and a General at that. And there was nothing he could do if they took him to the bedroom.

After all, this was still just crossdressing, and there was no universal guide to what to do from there on out.

Subaru: "I mean, if that happens, it's game over with a bad ending."

So, he needed to settle things tonight at all costs.

Besides, even if by some miracle they were able to avoid tonight's invitation, if Jamal's words were true, there would be a banquet tomorrow that would be attended by ordinary soldiers, rather than the Generals.

Common soldiers— that would, of course, include the one Subaru wanted to meet the least.

Subaru: “———”

To be honest, when Jamal had come into the inn, Subaru thought his heart would stop.

He was relieved that he had not recognized Natsumi as Subaru, but that didn't erase all of the danger— there was still a chance that *he* could have been killed by that arrow.

Subaru: “I don't want to call that too high a hope, do I?”

It was a difficult state of mind to be in.

He did not want to see *him* again, yet he also did not want *him* to be dead. It was complicated.

Even Subaru knew that there was evil in this world that could not be allowed to live. The Sin Archbishops were one of them, and they all stood for unforgivable sins.

So, if it were a Sin Archbishop, Subaru would be willing to let them die without hesitation. But *he* was not one of them; *he* was only the object of Subaru's fear, not evil.

First of all, if he were to put it that way, what about Louis, one of the Sin Archbishops, who he continued to overlook without a second thought?

Subaru: “—It's no good. Right now, I need to focus on the plan in front of me.”

It was ridiculous to be worrying about his foundation collapsing now.

Generally speaking, it was not just his foundation. Although he was now wearing makeup, his body and mind were still in tatters everywhere.

Subaru was good at making use of what little he held in hand, and that was what made him special.

Subaru: “I can't stay here much longer, can I?”

After a thorough search of the bathroom, he concluded that, unfortunately, there was nothing there that could be used. He needed to think about other methods of contacting the outside world.

There was also the guard waiting in front of the bathroom, the watchmen who kept them from wandering around inside the City Hall, and besides, Subaru really didn't want to be suspicious.

They may have to rethink the plan. If the situation became more pressing, Abel might understand this viewpoint.

Subaru: "I'm sorry to keep you waiting. I've been a little nervous."

Guard: "Hmm, ohh, don't worry. I just found someone to talk to."

Subaru: "Someone to talk to?"

As Subaru quietly walked out of the bathroom, the soldier on guard duty who had been waiting for him responded. He seemed to be talking to someone who was passing by, who, with a twitch of their chin, looked over and said—

???: "—Ohh, so you're the dancer invited as this evening's entertainment."

—Subaru's heart froze as he saw a face there that he definitely did not want to see.

Subaru: "Ah, kuh..."

???: "Hm? What's the matter? You look so startled. Ohh, come on, I'm not going to eat you."

Seeing Subaru's throat tremble, the other person laughed and cracked a joke.

It was a quip that he had heard from Jamal at the inn only a short time ago. But unlike Jamal, who had delivered it because of his dirty mind, he couldn't brush it off this time.

He wanted to ask if he really did not want to eat him.

Guard: "What, did you do something, Todd?"

Todd: "Me? Don't be ridiculous, there's nothing I can do. My wounds are so severe that I've been bedridden for quite a bit. I'm barely able to walk around."

Guard: “That’s true, too. So it’s like she hated your face physiologically?”

Todd: “That’s rather hurtful...”

The man scratching his head and having a friendly conversation with the soldier on guard— Todd.

The object of fear that made Natsuki Subaru most wary, and the one that made him question the morality of killing those outside of the Sin Archbishops. That was the nightmare personified that was chatting in front of him.

Subaru: “—Ah.”

He needed to say something; Subaru thought, his brain revolving at high speed.

Silence was not good. He must not give even a hint of suspicion. Todd would find out and use it as an excuse to attack.

He did not need evidence or proof. If he had a suspicion, he would try to crush it. Therefore—

Todd: “Hey, seriously, what’s wrong with you? Wait, have we already...”

Subaru: “Ah, I’m sorry... it’s just that...”

Todd: “It’s just that?”

The same words were repeated quietly, but his heart felt like it was going to flip over.

He wanted to end the conversation by saying he just didn’t feel well. But just before he said it, he wondered if it was really okay.

Illness was a common excuse, but it would be a lie. He felt like Todd could see through a lie.

If Subaru tried to use his knowledge gained from Return by Death, Todd would understand his intentions and thrust a knife into him. Lies would be found out. Definitely.

Lies must be avoided.

He was not just feeling bad, Subaru was having a hard time breathing right now—

Subaru: "I'm a little, well, scared..."

Todd: "Scared? Of me?"

Subaru: "Not just you. I hate to say this, but... I was brought here a little too forcefully."

He averted his gaze, and tried not to look Todd in the eye.

Each and every movement caused doubt to swirl in Subaru's mind, as he tried to ascertain if he had succeeded or failed. He felt like if he were to be looked in the eye, his lie would be found. He felt like if he lied, they would see through him.

He was not lying. He was definitely afraid of Todd. There was no twisting that fact.

Hearing Subaru's desperate answer, Todd closed one eye.

Todd: "When she says they were forced to be brought here, who was it that took them?"

Guard: "Uh, I believe it was Private First-Class Aurélie."

Todd: "Ohh, Jamal. That makes sense, then. Well, sorry if he scared you."

Subaru: "Eh..."

Todd, who was convinced by the exchange with the guard, said so and apologized to Subaru.

When Subaru peeled his eyes away at his unexpected attitude, Todd scratched his cheek with his fingers.

Todd: "I wouldn't say he's a bad... guy. Jamal's got a bad mouth and personality, and he's not very smart. But he's not a bad guy. He's just being himself."

Subaru: "Ha, ha..."

Todd: "If you could, would you please be open-minded and forgive him? It looks like he's going to be my brother-in-law. His angelic sister, who looks nothing like him at all, is my fiancée."

Subaru was puzzled by Todd's words that came with a wry smile.

From the looks of it, Todd did not seem to be distrustful of Subaru's words or actions. Rather, he seemed to be sympathetic and concerned about Subaru's involvement with Jamal.

Here, Subaru was unable to hide his astonishment at the skill he had mastered for the art of crossdressing and the fact that he had been saved by Jamal, who was usually crude and problematic.

His days of pursuing beauty, having thought they were for nothing, had not been in vain.

Even the sexual harassment he had received from Jamal proved itself useful.

???: "—Ohh! Hey, Todd, what the hell are you doing out here!"

While Subaru was thinking about it, a shout of anger echoed through the corridor.

It was Jamal, raising his voice and making rough footsteps. Upon noticing Jamal's approach, Todd put his hand on his forehead.

Todd: "Oops. You found me..."

Jamal: "I didn't find you! The guy with a hole in his stomach should rest! You thought you can't trust what you don't see with your eyes, didn't you?"

Todd: "No, no, no, I trust you. I trust you. You're surprisingly diligent and you do your job well. But even if they work diligently, screw-ups are always gonna be screw-ups, right?"

Jamal: "That's what I mean when I say you only trust your eyes...!"

Jamal clicked his tongue at Todd's reply, who raised his hands and shrugged his shoulders.

But when Jamal, who was approaching with a snort, noticed Subaru beside Todd, his expression changed from anger to a smile.

Jamal: "Ohh, you're that sideshow girl, aren't you? You're the one I like the most out of all of them. Hey, if you don't get invited tonight..."

Todd: "Ah, yes, yes, enough enough."

Jamal, with a fond look in his eyes, reached out and tried to grab Subaru's shoulder. However, of all people, it was Todd who stopped Jamal's hand.

Todd grabbed Jamal's wrist and gave him another "Enough" as his cheeks contorted.

Todd: "You're scaring her with your attitude. This girl who I'd never met before got scared all of a sudden, and that stung."

Jamal: "I didn't do anything at all. I don't know why you're interrupting me in the first place... No way, you... with that woman...!?"

Todd: "Don't joke about it, Jamal. Your sister's the only one for me. You know that, right?"

Jamal: "It's complicated for a brother to be told that his sister is someone's only love..."

Jamal muttered with a venomous look on his face, as he shook off Todd's hand.

He then glanced at Subaru, but the way his cheeks were drawn together seemed to dissuade him from messing with him any further.

Surprisingly, Jamal also had some sense. Or perhaps he had the heart to be hurt by being scared by someone he thought was a little too nice. Either way—

Todd: "Anyhow, let's get going. We're not going to be able to attend today's banquet anyway."

Jamal: "That said, I'm getting tired of trying to close the holes in the city's defenses."

Todd: "It won't be boring. It's a guarantee, a guarantee— That's where the enemy will come from, absolutely."

With a chuckle, Todd's sharp words scratched Subaru's chest.

He praised his choice in his heart, thinking that the idea of using a secret path had been seen through. Then, after praising himself—

Todd: "By the way, what's your name?"

Subaru: "———"

Subaru was not sure if Todd had seen his distraction.

The feint-like question made Subaru seriously think that he was going to lose consciousness.

He had been asked for his name. Why, why, why, the questions raged.

Wouldn't he at least ask his name? —No, Todd wouldn't ask. That was why Rem had been wary of Todd from the beginning. Because of his bad relationship with him, Subaru had not exchanged names with him this time. Should he give his name, or not, what should he do?

Todd: "Please, just tell me."

The request was repeated, and Subaru gasped.

Resigned to not being able to pull off an answer, he smiled as nonchalantly as possible and reluctantly said his name.

Subaru: "—Natsumi Schwartz, that's my name."

So he voiced his name.

He could not think of any other choice but to do this. He hoped and prayed that it was the right answer, and waited for the other person's response.

When he heard the reply, Todd nodded his head, stroking his chin with an "Hmm",

Todd: "You heard her, Jamal. Aren't you happy you got her name now?"

Jamal: "Shut up! I'm getting the fuck outta here!"

Todd: "Okay, okay... Ohh, can I follow you outside too?"

Jamal: "You're a really untrustworthy guy... Do what you want!"

Todd followed, shrugging his shoulders upon perceiving Jamal's angry voice, the latter barking with a red face.

With that, the two men disappeared from Subaru's sight, never once looking back. They turned a corner in the hallway and disappeared. Out of sight, out of mind.

Subaru: "...Really?"

Guard: "Hey, are you okay? You're looking really pale."

Subaru exhaled as he looked away, wondering if he would ever come back. The only remaining soldier on guard was concerned about Subaru, as he saw how exasperated he was.

There was no time left for Subaru to respond.

However, he managed to make amends with the soldier on lookout duty, and accompanied him back to the waiting room to join Flop and the others, who were standing by inside.

Flop: "It took you long enough, Miss Natsumi...! Are you okay? You look really pale."

Subaru: "I've already heard that... For the moment, the storm has passed. But the problem remains."

Back in the waiting room, seeing the worried look on Flop's face, he finally had time to worry about his heartbeat and his breathing.

Slowly, Subaru calmed himself down by taking deep breaths to correct his rough physiological reactions.

Yes, he had escaped the storm he had suddenly encountered. Probably.

They could not let their guard down until the very end, but for now, the tempest should be over.

However, they still had not overcome the big obstacle that was their initial problem.

Subaru: "We have to find a way to contact the outside world. If we go on like this, even if our plan succeeds..."

Taritta: "Ah, then don't *worry*, Natsumi. Kuna and I left a signal that my sister will *understand*."

Subaru: "What?"

Subaru's eyes widened as he was told that the problem he had been facing had been solved just like that.

Taritta looked apologetic for his reaction, while Kuna seemed unconcerned. His gaze, directed towards them, was asking what was going on wordlessly.

Taritta: "Well... Natsumi will be the *bait*, and I will signal the others, so get your job *done*. That's what Bianca *said*."

Subaru: "Wha, wha, wha...?"

Subaru's eyes widened and he looked at Abel in the corner of the room.

Then, noticing his leer, Abel narrowed his eyes, shook his head loosely, and declared—

Abel: "Rather than telling you and having you move unnaturally, I used you as a natural decoy. Fortunately, you seem to have performed your task reasonably well. I shall praise you for that."

Subaru: "Shut up! Do you know what I've had to deal with...!?"

Flop: "Ohh, calm down, Miss Natsumi! You're ruining your pretty face!"

Subaru: "Shut up!"

He was about to get mad at Abel's attitude, but Flop stopped him from behind.

He really wanted to punch that arrogant demonic face, but Subaru had no choice but to remain calm. As this strategy would not be possible without that face.

It was unbelievably terrible that he would use his own face as a hostage.

Subaru: "You, I'm definitely going to hit you when it's over...!"

Abel: "If you have so much time to think about what you shall do after its terminus, then I am sure you shall be able to perform without fault."

Subaru: "Flora! We're going to rehearse until it's time!"

Flop: “Okay, okay, okay.”

Subaru gritted his teeth in anger, as if saying “you are the very epitome of always having a comeback for everything I say”.

Whatever the case, if they had made contact with the outside world, all they had to do was wait for the time in question.

At most, yes, at most—

Subaru: “—It’ll be awful if the plan doesn’t work.”

He muttered in defeat, but Subaru had been convinced over the course of the past few days that it would definitely work.

It was really frustrating, because it seemed as though there was nothing that would not fall in love with this arrogant danseuse, except perhaps a Sin Archbishop.

Arc 7 Chapter 24 - Arrogance

Light Novel Adaptation found in Volume 27, Chapter 6 “Arrogant Crimson”

Original Web Novel Chapter — [Complete](#)

Edited Machine Translation by Witch Cult Translations (Original by Heretic Translations, Translation checked by [Ice/Ice Occultism](#) & Averitius) — [Complete](#)

—As the beginning of the banquet approached, the tension increased.

???: “———”

There was no conversation in the waiting room where the five of them had gathered, and it was quiet.

Nobody could utter a word, neither Abel, who was concentrating, nor Subaru. Even Flop was silent, so the weight of the atmosphere was overwhelming.

They had made it this far, so there was nothing to worry about.

Or, at least, they should be able to think that way, but human beings were not so simple. No matter how good the crossdressing was, the anxiety grew as the main event was about to happen.

Despite how loudly his heart screamed, and how much the cold sweat wetted his back, the flow of time could not be halted, and the promised time would yet come.

???: “The banquet is ready. It’s time for you to go.”

The voice of the soldier on guard duty rang out, and the moment of the release of the tension arrived.

Looking at each other, Subaru and the others picked up their instruments and followed the soldier leading the way out of the waiting room. They underwent a quick physical examination, but Subaru and the others, wearing only light clothing, had no way to carry concealed weapons.

They passed the inspection, receiving curious and perverted looks, and were ushered into the banquet room.

Only---

Taritta: “---Hk.”

Subaru: “Taritta-san?”

Subaru raised an eyebrow at Taritta’s stiff cheeks and heavy gait.

Although he whispered so that the soldiers leading her would not hear him, his voice had definitely reached Taritta, but she did not respond. From the look in her eyes, it was easy to grasp her mental state.

The extreme tension in her body was strong and overwhelming.

Leaving her familiar village, not being able to rely on her sister, the chieftain of the tribe, and going behind enemy lines almost unarmed, may have put her under a lot of stress.

Her breathing was rough, and she looked like she was about to collapse. Subaru tried to cheer her up, but he could not think of what to say.

It would be easy to say comforting words like “don’t worry” or “leave it to me”.

Would that soothe Taritta’s Spirit in this moment?

So, while Subaru was unable to take a step forward due to his inner hesitation---

Abel: “---Taritta.”

Taritta: “-----”

Abel: “There is nothing to worry about. Just look at me.”

It was a voice that sounded terribly arrogant and pompous, but full of absolute confidence.

The words were baseless, no different from the comforting words Subaru had thought just before. However, the effect of those easy words of comfort was tremendous.

Letting out a faint breath, Taritta blinked her eyes.

She had forgotten to breathe, and the color in her face had been almost gone, but she was brought back to her senses. It was a voice that contained simple words, but it held the power to strongly affect the hearts of others.

The haves would instantly outstrip the hard work of the have-nots.

He had been made painfully aware of this many times, but now, he had been able to witness it clearly.

Subaru: "Guess I'm not angry anymore."

Subaru muttered this to himself as a consolation. But he soon realized that not only had Taritta's nerves relaxed, but his own as well. And so, he bent his lips.

Of course he was not going to tell him that, though, because he'd probably triumph in it, were he to do so.

And then—

???: "—Welcome. I heard that you guys are going to perform a great song and dance."

In the hall where the banquet had been prepared, Subaru and the others were greeted by nearly thirty strong men. They had been told that no ordinary soldiers would be allowed to enter the banquet hall today, so the people here must be the so-called commissioned officers and Generals. In the midst of all these Generals, a man sitting in a chair at the far end called out to the troupe.

Subaru: "...Is that Zikr Osman, the General Second-Class?"

After Subaru muttered under his breath, he glanced sideways at Abel, the danseuse of the group, whose face was hidden by a veil, who pulled his chin slightly as to answer positively to Subaru's question.

In response to the affirmation, Subaru looked at the other party again, and furrowed his spruced up eyebrows.

Zikr Osman, the commander of the Imperial Soldiers stationed in the Fortress City of Gual.

As a General Second-Class of the Empire, he was expected to be a strong warrior, but his appearance betrayed Subaru's imagination in more than one way.

First of all, he was short. He looked about half a head shorter than Subaru, who was by no means a tall man. He was almost as tall as Kuna if she stood up straight.

Of course, there was a precedent in Garfiel, who was short yet strong, so physique was no reason to underestimate him. However, he did not appear like someone of real importance either.

The most striking thing about him was his distinctive, puffy haircut.

If he had to describe it in words, he would say it was an afro, but just the fact that it was on top of a short man's head gave him a sort of mascot-like charm.

Subaru had been told beforehand that Zikr was a military strategist. He certainly did not look like the type to make a military career out of martial prowess.

Zikr: "Now, we have a tricky problem. We've been holed up in the city, feeling more and more depressed by the day. That is why we have set up this feast. You know what your roles are, don't you?"

Subaru: "—Yes, Sir. We are extremely honored to be invited."

Subaru kneeled before Zikr, who had thrown an exaggerated remark with his chin resting on the armrest.

Flop, Taritta, and Kuna followed, but Abel, who stood at the end of the line, did not. For a moment, Zikr's gaze narrowed, and a sense of anxiety spread through the Generals.

Sure enough, one of the soldiers with a cup of sake at his feet stood up, putting a cup of alcohol near his own feet, and glared at Abel.

Soldier: "Why don't you kneel? You know you're in front of the General Second-Class..."

Zikr: "Wait. Don't be so uptight. This place was opened for drinking and feasting. What we want from those who make their living in the arts is not etiquette, but unrelenting comfort."

Soldier: “Mh... If you say so, General...”

It was Zikr, of all people, who rebuked the soldier who was bothering Abel.

The soldier reluctantly sat down in response to his generous attitude. All the while, Abel kept his face hidden under his veil and did not show any sign of wincing.

Zikr: “You don’t even falter in the face of a warrior’s Spirit? You seem to have a lot of confidence in your dance. But your first impression was not good. I expect you to overturn it.”

Subaru: “Thank you for your generosity... But please do not worry.”

Zikr, who had a curious view of Abel’s arrogance, replied with a “Hm?” to Subaru as the latter knelt down, raising his eyebrows in interest.

It hurt to think about the rest, but this was the opportunity Subaru had been bestowed with. He was going to make the most of it. He would let Zikr taste complete defeat.

Subaru: “—Who you are about to lay your eyes on, is the beautiful danseuse from beyond the Great Waterfall. Her silky black hair that drinks up the sun’s light, along with her heavenly fair skin that has received the blessing of the Spirits, her utmost beauty is comparable to the divine beings, and tonight, she will lavishly perform for you all.”

As he stood up, Subaru laid out his opening words.

As if to prove that his overly exaggerated preamble was not a bluff, the veil that hid Abel’s face was slowly lifted.

As soon as the veil revealed that enamoring visage, all those present gasped in unison at the haughtiness of the danseuse.

Zikr: “———”

In particular, the shock of Zikr, who had gotten lost in Abel’s gaze, was massive.

As he had shown a tolerant stance towards them from the start, perhaps he had already been prepared to deal with the situation magnanimously, or perhaps he had received a shock tantamount of being blindsided.

It was as if he had literally forgotten how to breathe and speak.

Subaru: “—Please, allow us the chance to display our danseuse’s act.”

Subaru hung his head down out of politeness, as he propositioned to Zikr. Likewise, Flop bowed his head and raised his respective instrument to ask for permission to begin the feast.

In response, Zikr nodded his head, prompting Subaru to exchange a glance with Flop.

They then nodded to each other, signaling that they were ready, and began to play.

Subaru: “—Tonight, what you will witness is a dance from the hometown of our danseuse, a dance from beyond the Great Waterfall. Please, satisfy to your heart’s content, the dance from the ends of the end.”

That it was from beyond the Great Waterfall, was an exaggerated expression.

However, it was not a lie in the sense that it was a dance unknown to the Imperial Soldiers. Both the song and the dance had been brought not from this world, but from Subaru’s.

Of course, they had been arranged accordingly, but as the basis of the dance was different, the dance alone was enough to attract the attention of the audience.

However—

Abel: “———”

He was a danseuse who charmed others with his beauty and fluid dancing, so he probably did not even require the help of an exotic song and dance from another world.

Abel: “———”

You've got the concept of appetizers with drinks, however this was not just the food being served at the drinking party, if you had a type of entertainment that promoted the drinking of alcohol, anything could be called an appetizer.

Naturally, sideshows were also included, and the dances are called appetizing dances, so they very much served as an appetizer for drinking— But they would hardly have this much of an effect.

The dance of the danseuse dazzled the soldiers, burned their throat, and made their souls thirsty for alcohol.

They naturally tipped their cups more frequently and quickly, while their cheeks turned a shade of vermilion all over. General Second-Class Zikr, in an attempt to heal the numbness in his cerebellum, was a stand-out for sipping booze at a particularly fast pace.

With his judgment robbed by alcohol and dance, he would commit mistakes that he would not normally make.

For example, the unprecedented mistake of giving in to his desire to see a sword dance, which resulted in handing over his own sword, as per the danseuse's request.

Abel: “—It is your loss, Zikr Osman.”

Therefore, even with the tip of the sword pointed at his neck, and with the unquestionable voice of a man coming from the mouth of the danseuse, the eyes of the Womanizer, Zikr Osman could not escape from this euphoria.



—“We did it”, Subaru shouted inwardly, now that victory had been secured.

The sword in Abel's hand was in a position to pierce Zikr's throat with ease.

Zikr, who had bent backwards, exposing his neck, had no chance to fight back. Without a doubt, the enemy commander had been seized successfully.

And they had even done it earlier than originally planned, at the appropriate timing.

Originally, Subaru's plan had been to make a name for themselves in the city as a traveling troupe and infiltrate Zikr Osman's bosom. Ideally, they would then be summoned to Zikr's bedchamber, where they would be able to catch him off-guard, take him into custody, and force the Imperial Soldiers stationed in Guaral to surrender.

That premise had been overturned by the holding of this banquet.

Abel: "—At the banquet, we shall neutralize all the remaining soldiers in the city."

These had been the words of Abel, who had announced the change in strategy when they had been summoned to the banquet.

A high-risk, high-reward strategy, which would be fruitful if successful, yet dangerous— Subaru agreed to change the plan on the condition that they would switch back to the original one depending on the situation.

He had not expected it to work out this well.

Zikr: "——"

Abel: "I shall say it again, Zikr Osman. You have lost. Surrender now and have your men disarm. Otherwise, your cup shall be filled not with alcohol, but blood."

Abel, holding his sword to the motionless Zikr, advised him to surrender once again.

But there was no fear in Zikr's eyes, despite the fact his life was being threatened. Those were not the eyes of a determined Imperial Soldier. Rather, there was hesitation in his eyes.

Hesitation, doubt, and other similar emotions.

Zikr: "Dancer, you... No, you're..."

The hesitation manifested itself in Zikr's eyes much if he had seen something awe-inspiring. It did not seem like the reaction of a man in front of a mere dancer.

General: “—Hk! You bandits! You got no right to...!”

One of the dumbfounded Generals came to his senses and immediately tried to jump Abel.

But, faster than they could reach for Abel’s back, their arms and legs were pierced by thrown knives—
Blades pitched by a concealed Kuna.

Kuna: “I’m sorry, but the Chieftain told me to protect Abel’s face.”

She had secretly sneaked knives from the banquet in the tambourine-like instrument in her hand during Abel’s dance.

The Generals hesitated at the sight of the fallen soldier, his limbs perforated by the blades.

However, there was one figure that dodged Kuna’s blade, and jumped out of the way.

???: “Stop joking! Do you think you can stop Imperial Soldiers with something like this?”

The howling bearded giant of a man caught an additional throwing knife with his arm and brushed it away.

Then pulling out his own greatsword, he flew straight at Abel, with a desire for blood,

Subaru: “Abel—!”

Abel, who had captured Zikr, was presenting his stick-like back.

Subaru screamed Abel’s name, but the danseuse did not even blink.

As things were, a large sword would be brought down at Abel’s back—

Taritta: “—Kuh!”

At the same moment, Taritta gritted her teeth and aimed at the man, taking a bow from one of the soldiers.

Prepping an arrow, she aimed it at the bearded colossus approaching Abel. Taritta’s green eyes lit up with murderous intent.

She was steeled to take the man's life in order to save Abel and stop the assault.

Flop: "Don't kill him!!!!"

Taritta: "—Hk!"

But just before the arrow was released, Flop shouted in a panic.

Hearing this, Taritta's eyes hesitated, and the arrow's aim blurred slightly. And so, the arrow pierced not into the man's back, but into his right shoulder.

Bearded General: "Gah!?"

The man screamed in agony and turned over after the tremendous impact. But the momentum of the greatsword in his hand could not be killed, and it spun around and headed for Abel's back.

It seemed as if the sword would smash Abel's head from behind. However, the tip of the sword narrowly grazed the back of his head and fell to the floor with a violent thud.

Abel had almost lost his life, but he had escaped disaster just in the nick of time.

And then—

???: "...Ah."

With a flutter, Abel's braided black hair was undone and spread.

The tip of the big sword sliced through the hair clip, untying the knot— No, it did not stop at that. The frayed wig lost its function, and the fake black hair fell to the floor.

The danseuse's long hair had been replaced by Abel's own sable hair.

—The ruthless Emperor, who, along with the hair clip, had shorn off the soft impression of the danseuse.

???: "General Second-Class! It's our opportunity to get these guys now...!"

Zikr: "—Stop! Do not disobey me!"

While the soldier whose limbs had been pierced by knives and the one who had gotten shot in the right shoulder by an arrow groaned, Zikr silenced the appeals of the a General who was still attempting to resist.

If they recklessly stood their ground, regardless of how many fell, they would be crushed in one go by Subaru's forces. And that was the counterattack they most wanted to avoid.

However, Zikr would not let his subordinates fight on. He understood that, now that he himself had been pinned down, and his subordinate Generals had also had their movements suppressed, the outcome had already been determined. So—

Zikr: "If I do as you say, can you guarantee the lives of my men?"

Abel: "That also depends on your attitude, Coward."

Zikr: "Guh... Hk."

Zikr showed his willingness to accept the recommendation to surrender while reddening and biting his lip as he was abused by the relentless Abel.

That was the face of a man who had experienced humiliation beyond having been caught in a plot against him and having his person captured.

Abel snorted, looking down at Zikr's humiliation.

Abel: "I heard about you, Zikr Osman. Before being labelled the Womanizer, you had been dubbed the Coward."

Zikr: "...An unbecoming epithet for an Imperial Soldier. Is that why you chose such a strategy?"

Abel: "———"

Zikr: "If I'm the Coward on top of being the Womanizer, I would surrender to a woman at the point of a sword..."

If so, what a humiliation that would be.

Or, if that was the case, Zikr would have died of humiliation. But the reason why Abel had deemed it feasible was different from the reason Subaru and the others had heard.

It was because—

Abel: “A strategist who, through his skillful and steady use of troops, has achieved few notable results in battle, but has also caused little casualties to his allies. An excellent commander, but lacking aggressiveness. Hence, Coward.”

Zikr: “Yes, that is correct, too. I am, but...”

Abel: “What are you confused about?”

Zikr: “Eh?”

Zikr’s eyes widened as Abel narrowed his eyes and asked that question.

Like that, with confusion plastered on the other party’s face, Abel continued with his sword in his hand.

Abel: “When others denigrate you as a coward, they are either pretending to see the results, or those are the rantings of a fool who cannot see the results. I made use of that nature to win.”

Zikr: “———”

Abel: “You abhor useless casualties. So, I decided that you, as the Coward and a military strategist, would not resist in this situation— Are you going to disappoint me?”

Keeping his gaze sharp and the blade against his neck, Abel inquired that of Zikr.

To someone who was unaware Abel’s true identity, that would seem like a rant that would make one wonder what the hell he was talking about.

He had trusted his opponent’s cowardice and incorporated it into his plan to win.

There was no certainty that he would not upset his opponent by telling such things bluntly. Rather, it was as if he was deliberately attempting to provoke his opponent’s anger; it was really a statement that could make things worse.

Even when dressed as a woman, he was incapable of any kind of humility.

But, in front of Abel, Zikr Osman gasped.

What came to his eyes was a feeling that was hard to describe— if he dared to verbalize it, it would be a surprise that was close to excitement.

It seemed to be a fresh and new reaction, like a maiden receiving something from the person she loved.

Zikr: “—We’ll disarm ourselves. I’ll give strict orders to my subordinates to do so.”

Abel: “That is a wise decision.”

Abel quietly nodded in assent to Zikr’s quiet, head-down answer.

Even though he was dressed like a dancer, no one could resist his dignified nod of the head. As Zikr, their commander, surrendered, the Imperial Soldiers dropped their weapons one after another. And—

Abel: “What, are you doing fooling around? Go up and burn the flag on the roof.”

Subaru: “Ueh? Wha, me?”

Abel: “Yes you. Only you. You are the sole one who has not performed a single deed since things started to proceed.”

Abel’s cold eyes pierced Subaru, who pointed at himself and blinked.

With those words, Subaru looked around the hall.

Kuna, who had blocked the enemy with a throwing knife, Taritta, who had shot the giant of a man, Flop, who had not allowed the giant of a man’s death and therefore had desperately defended the materialization of the Bloodless Siege, and Abel, who had disarmed the General.

Indeed, the only one who had not done anything was Subaru, who had fallen on his butt when that behemoth tried to assault them.

Abel: “Get a move on, I shall not even be able to disarm them without Mizelda and the others.”

Subaru: “Okay, I understand! Yeah, yeah, I’m sorry!”

Saying this, Subaru headed for the balcony, crawling carefully up to the rooftop. The rooftop of the City Hall, overlooking Guaral at night, was absolutely spectacular.

Then, while bathed in the cold breeze, Subaru retrieved a torch from the wall, ignited the flag of the empire on the roof of the City Hall—the flag of the Sword Wolf, and set it ablaze.

—That was proof that the fall of the Fortress City of Guaral had been achieved here.



The first person to notice something off was Jamal, who had been paying attention to the City Hall.

Jamal glanced around, being mindful of the people he had left behind in the building. Todd, who had grown tired of his naive attitude, continued the patrol of the city.

As a city with a certain amount of history, there was no end to the ways to get past the walls, which posed as a powerful Barrier. Smuggling schemes, such as underground passages in private houses, or holes used by children to pass through, also existed. While accurately uncovering these, Todd had his guard up for any possible attacks.

Todd: “It’s not like they’re going to back off. If that’s the case, they’ll definitely try to bring down the city. They could use some secret path and take over the City Hall all at once, or set the city on fire... Hmm, are there other means?”

If it was simply to make the city fall, he could think of many ways to slaughter both soldiers and citizens indiscriminately.

For that matter, people would perish if they were buried in fire, water, or soil. If the means were in place, human beings could be as cruel as they wished.

What kind of brutal methods would the black-haired boy use?

That may seem not to be his forte at first glance, but the fact that he was so good at it made it all the more frightening.

No matter how hard he tried to crush them, there still seemed to be some undiscovered byways.

So even if he had a hole in his stomach, Todd would not have been able to sleep in his quarters.

Todd: "They're all so rude and sketchy..."

Not all of them were of Jamal's caliber, but many of them had an inability to pay attention to details.

Todd did not believe himself to be neither brilliant nor clever, but if he's aware of his own stupidity and shortcomings, there were plenty of ways to fill in the gaps.

He could not understand how people could live their lives without questioning their stupidity.

Every single human being was an idiot, and so, they should do their utmost to compensate for it.

Jamal: "—Ah?"

While thinking about this, Todd was about to go into the next private house, when he suddenly stopped due to the surprised voice raised by Jamal behind him.

He stopped and looked at Jamal, who was looking at City Hall in the distance, with an expression of dumbfoundment on his face.

Todd frowned, wondering what was going on.

Jamal: "Ohh, come on, is this some kinda joke?"

Todd: "What's up, Jamal? What's happening at the..."

"City Hall", he almost said. Standing beside Jamal, Todd also looked in the same direction.

He was sure the City Hall was having a banquet at the moment, with the dancers they had invited providing entertainment and comfort to the Generals.

So it was not surprising that some of them would get a little carried away and make fools of themselves.

It would not be strange, but—

Todd: “—No way.”

No matter what, burning the flag of the Empire on top of City Hall was unacceptable.

That barbaric act was so beyond the realm of rudeness that even Todd was taken aback. The flag, being scorched by flames while fluttering in the hot wind, swayed and burned, lighting up the night sky with the red glow of its blaze.

And right beside the flag set alight, he saw the figure of a woman he had already met in the City Hall.

A musician with rich black hair and sharp eyes. He believed her name was—

Todd: “—Natsumi Schwartz.”

That was what she had stated upon having had her name inquired.

A weak woman, who had become small and frightened when Jamal had crowded her. However, he could clearly see that she was boldly burning the Imperial Flag with a torch in her hand.

There was no sign of the weakness he had encountered before in the City Hall.

Certainly, it could not be something charming like a drunken act of violence.

That was undoubtedly an intentional attack on the Empire. And if the flag of the base was burned, it meant that the place had fallen into the hands of the enemy.

Just as he was thinking about it, a possibility suddenly surfaced in Todd’s mind.

Todd: “No way, is it you?”

With his eyes wide open, Todd studied the dark-haired woman with the torch in her hand, Natsumi Schwartz, and was struck by the minuscule possibility that had sprung up within him.

But the more he thought about it, the more it matched, and the more he looked at it, the more it diverged.

But that was why the effect was so extraordinary.

Who in the world would think of doing something like this?

Of such a method to break through the enemy's guard from the front, and take their base of operations?

Todd: "I thought it was impossible. I can't believe they tried to sneak through the front gate."

Who could possibly use such a life-threatening approach?

Of course, the possibility of hiding behind cargo or inside dragon carriages had been carefully considered, and the checkpoints had been reinforced. However, an intrusion on foot, in a way that would attract attention, had been unexpected.

Even so, the first infiltration had strengthened their vigilance. On top of that, it would be a natural response to opt for a stealthier approach—

Jamal: "You don't think that was just a setup, do you? Did they deliberately find us and instill in us the preconceived notion that a frontal breakthrough was impossible?"

And following that, he had managed to get into the city, was invited to the hall as a dancer, brought down the City Hall, and ignited the Imperial Flag— It had been just as Natsumi Schwartz had intended.

Todd: "...This is bad."

What a meticulous plan, he thought, a chill running down his spine.

He thought he had done everything in his power to have the upper hand, but on the other side, the poster child of war had easily surpassed and ridiculed him.

Todd was surprised to find himself shuddering.

Jamal: "Shit! What the fuck's going on here! Anyway, we gotta back to the City Hall..."

Todd: "Idiot, stop. You're going to die, too."

Jamal: "Huh?"

Unlike Todd, Jamal was unaware of the identity of the person who had set the Imperial Flag on fire.

Due to the distance, his eyes could not perceive any details on the roof of the City Hall. Todd could see it only because of his special eyes. And it was because he could see them, that he was holding Jamal back.

Now that the Imperial Flag at their base had been set ablaze, the fall of the city was decided.

By now, all the Generals who were participating in the feast, Zikr included, had already been murdered. Even if they were to go back in, they would probably end up being defeated themselves.

Jamal: “You’re freaking out, ain’t you? And you still think of yourself as an Imperial Soldier, huh?”

Todd: “You can’t win and stay alive by being proud. Besides, you know that City Hall’s been taken; the General Second-Class is dead. The Shudraquians will be in the city before long.”

Jamal: “———”

Todd: “If we don’t get out of here before that happens, we won’t have any other choice but to die too.”

Jamal was not the kind of person to accept the humiliation of disarming himself quietly.

The alternative would be to jump into the enemy ranks weapon in hand, wielding bravery, and die while taking out about ten people.

It could be said that it would be exactly how a Sword Wolf would die, but from Todd’s point of view, it was as good as a dog’s death.

Life was akin to a finite hand of cards.

To use it for victory was justified, but it would be a waste to utilize it for a regretful defeat.

Jamal and Todd had known each other for a while. It would not be strange to think that they had enough of a relationship between them to advise each other on this. Probably.

Todd: “You see that hole in the wall that I just plugged? I’m going to run through it. What about you?”

Jamal: “Guh, guh... You wanna make me feel humiliated again?”

Todd: “If you’re alive, you’ll get a chance to rinse your shame off. But if you die, that’s it. So, I’m going. I won’t get into a fight I don’t think I can win.”

He really wished not to get into a fight with a low chance of winning, let alone one with a one-hundred percent chance of losing. But he did not have time to argue with Jamal about the details.

He quickly turned his back to him and started to run. Jamal hesitated for a moment before shouting a curse, a “Damn it!”, then followed behind Todd.

It would be nice if everyone were as simple as him, but the world did not work that way.

In any case——

Todd: “I guess I’ll remember you as Natsumi for now—— You poster child of war.”



As soon as they realized that the Imperial Flag had been set on fire and the City Hall had fallen, the Imperial Soldiers unexpectedly obeyed the call for surrender.

The same was true for the guards protecting the city, which was a great help to Subaru, whose goal was to seize the city without bloodshed, but this was also a surprising development.

Subaru: “I’ve always thought it strange that, when I watched battles of the Sengoku period in historical dramas, the battle would end when the head of the other side’s general is taken off...²⁹”

If the general were killed, the next person in charge would become the general and the battle would resume.

A layman would think that the battle would not end until one side was annihilated or in shambles, but this was not the case in this actual battle.

²⁹ Translation note by Witch Cult Translations: “The Sengoku period was a period of near-constant civil war in Japan occurring from 1467-1616; for more information, see [here](#)”.



Illustration from Volume 27, coloring by rodo ([source](#))

Because the Imperial Army, which should be overwhelmingly superior in strength, had agreed to disarm as soon as they found out that their commander, Zikr, had been apprehended.

Mizelda: “Well, that was quite a feat, Subaru... No, Natsumi.”

Subaru: “Mizelda-san.”

As Subaru patted his fake chest at the results of the battle and the success of the operation, he was approached by Mizelda, happily slurping down alcohol directly from a bottle.

The women, who had been hiding outside the city as a detachment, had entered the city too, upon realizing that the City Hall had fallen, signaled by the burning of the Imperial Flag. The guards, becoming aware that the Imperial Soldiers had been defeated, did not attempt to stop them from proudly marching into the city as well.

Thanks to Shudraq’s cooperation, they had succeeded in capturing most of the Imperial Soldiers.

In the hall where the feast had been held, the drinks and food had been cleared away, and in their place, the bound Imperial Soldiers were lined up in a row.

It would have been a shame to throw everything away, Subaru thought. Mizelda and the others were sipping their drinks, but doing so made them look more like barbarians who were willing to loot.

Subaru: “But with this many people... It would’ve been tough to go head-to-head.”

Mizelda: “No matter how many enemies we have, the pride of Shudraq won’t falter. There’s no such thing as too many enemies... And yes, simple numbers can be insurmountable. But you and Abel have defeated them.”

Subaru: “———”

Mizelda: “I’m proud of you, Natsumi. You’ve shown courage through wisdom. We couldn’t have done this.”

With a vigorous pat on Subaru’s shoulder, Mizelda left him with a handsome smile.

She then stood up and headed over to congratulate Taritta and Kuna for their contribution to the fall of the City Hall.

Even from a distance, the sight of Taritta's eyes shining from her sister's praise made Subaru smile. Kuna was hugged by Holly, having confirmed that she was safe, making her look like a rolled mackerel.

Subaru: "Keeping things up like this, it would be nice if Kuna's life wasn't snuffed out, given all the great deeds she's done..."

???: "———"

With a sense of relief, Subaru let out a small smile. Then, as he turned around, he nearly collided with the person standing right behind him.

That other person was——

Subaru: "R-Rem..."

Rem: "...Yes."

Staring up at him from a close distance, Subaru could not help but step back.

Rem, holding her wooden cane, looked at Subaru from top to bottom with her pale blue eyes. Feeling uncomfortable under her gaze, Subaru cleared his throat and said,

Subaru: "What's the matter? I'm fine, you know."

Rem: "Yes, so I heard. But I had a feeling that even if you were injured somewhere, you'd hide it and say the same thing."

Subaru: "You really don't have any trust in me... But I'm not very good with pain either, so I'll report even the slightest injury right away. Really, I mean it."

Rem: "That sounds suspicious, too."

Subaru: "Tch ha ha..."

Subaru's shoulders slumped under Rem's gaze devoid of trust.

But then he quickly turned his head in realization. “Huh?” Subaru uttered. She may have been a bit curt, but she was probably worried about whether Subaru was injured or not.

Subaru: “You’re worried about me, aren’t you?”

Rem: “Huh?”

Subaru: “Ohh! I’m sorry! I got carried away! Of course you weren’t! It can’t be that Rem’s worried about me...”

Rem: “Yes, I was.”

Subaru: “Wha?”

Waving his hands in the air, Subaru hurriedly tried to correct his misunderstanding. But he was interrupted by none other than Rem’s words.

Rem’s expression did not change, but the color of her eyes wavered slightly.

Rem: “I said, I was worried. Of course I was. No matter how much of a joke the plan was, I was the one who made you do it. And yet how could I not be worried? How in the world do you think I could be such a heartless person?”

Subaru: “No, no, no, it’s not that, I don’t think Rem is heartless! I really don’t! Rem is affectionate, a bit presumptuous, and a bit reserved before she gets to know someone, but that difference is also very attractive...”

Rem: “_____”

Subaru: “Rem, don’t tell me you’re impressed...?”

Rem: “No, I simply thought it was weird.”

And with just a simple statement, Subaru’s fake chest was pierced, prompting an “Ugh!” out of him.

Rem gave an annoyed sigh as Subaru backed away, holding his fake chest in pain. She then took a step toward Subaru,

Rem: “Just so you know, no matter what you said or did, you managed to do it. Really, you managed to bring this city down. And that’s without causing any deaths.”

Subaru: “...If only we kept the bloodless part, I hoped that no one would get hurt if possible. But I wonder if that was too much to ask.”

Rem: “I wonder about that. However, if it’s you and Abel-san, then you may be able to pull it off... Why are you looking at me like that?”

Subaru: “...It’s nothing, nothing, nothing, okay?”

Rem raised an eyebrow at Subaru’s sullen face.

In fact, she had a good point. Without Abel’s help, this plan would not have been possible, and it was true that he was a man of terrifying wisdom.

Still, hearing words of praise for another man from Rem’s mouth made his heart squirm.

Subaru: “Even with those fake breasts, there’s still something to be impressed by, isn’t there...?”

Rem: “I feel like you’re talking about something stupid again...”

When Rem started staring at him, Subaru waved his hands and said, “No, no, no,” to cover it up.

If he told Rem about his current jealousy, she would probably just feel weird about it. It was unavoidable, but it nevertheless hurt. One-sided affection was painful.

Subaru: “No, in this case, it’s just a reflex...? Though they’re passable compared to Emilia-tan’s, nevertheless they still feel like the real deal, don’t you think...”

Medium: “Ohh! Natsumi-chan, you’re here! I heard you guys did great, congratulations!”

Subaru: “Ah, Medium-san.”

Medium ran into the room with a loud voice and sluggish footsteps. Subaru recoiled at the sudden approach of the taller woman, but his step back was meaningless as she filled the distance between them by leaning forward.

Medium had a big smile on her face, looking happily at the soldiers in the hall, as two girls rode her shoulders— Utakata and Louis.

Medium: “These people were all captured by Natsumi-chan and the others, weren’t they? I’m so surprised! So, so, where’s sis? Did she do her best?”

Subaru: “Sis? Ah, yes. Flora is...”

Flop: “—I’m here, dear sister!”

Medium: “Ohh!”

Medium’s round eyes widened even more when she saw Flop appear in the hall, a beautiful man who had accompanied her and whom she had become accustomed to seeing for so long. He quickly asserted his presence with a single loud clap of his shoes.

Medium: “Big bro! Isn’t that big bro!? I knew it, big bro isn’t my sister, and the sister I thought was my sister’s big bro!”

Flop: “Hahaha, I have no idea what you’re talking about, dear sister! But no matter what, I’m still here. So whether I’m your brother or your sister, it doesn’t matter!”

Medium: “That’s true too! Then maybe I’m not a sister, but a brother! I’m so big after all!”

Flop: “Younger sister or younger brother, older brother or older sister, we’re still family!”

The conversation between the O’Connell siblings was peculiar, but it kept its unique tempo until its settlement.

The laughing Flop hugged Medium’s waist, and Medium, with the girls on both shoulders, started spinning around in circles as he did.

As a result, both of Flop’s legs floated up and a grand spin began, as the happy laughter of the siblings and children echoed in the hall.

Subaru: “Surreal, isn’t it...?”

Rem: “I’m sure Medium-san was worried about Flop-san too... So, how long are you going to stay dressed like that? The rest of your life?”

Subaru: “The rest of my life has to be an exaggeration!? No matter how cute I am, this is only a temporary appearance... And I’m destined to have to go back to normal eventually.”

Rem: “Does that mean that for the time being you’ll be dressed like that?”

Subaru: “I just happen to not have time to change right now!”

Subaru wasn’t mentally tough enough to endure such suspicions, or to put it another way, to endure how Rem looked at him like he was a pervert.

In fact, the only reason he was still dressed in women’s clothing was that he had been busy with minor tasks, such as burning the Imperial Flag, and welcoming the People of Shudraq who entered the city afterwards.

The situation simply had not permitted him to change into his ‘Subaru’ clothes. It was not that he intended to stay as Natsumi Schwartz.

Subaru: “Or isn’t it?”

Rem: “Ahh, right. If you’re searching for Abel-san, he’s in the back room with the commander.”

Subaru: “You’re acting like you don’t believe me!”

Pointing at Rem, who had given him a blank stare, Subaru turned and walked towards him.

He’d like to celebrate the success of the bloodless siege with Rem and the others, but he could not just sit there with his hands up in the air and be overjoyed.

After all, the fall of Guaral was only a checkpoint. They had to think about the future civil war that would rumble the Empire, and what kind of position Subaru would maintain. To that end—

Subaru: “If you’ll excuse me.”

With that, Subaru pushed open the door to a separate room at the back of the hall.

It was originally supposed to be a private, office-like room for the city manager, the master of the City Hall, but now the master had been sent away, and the replacement for the Ruler was sitting on the chair.

Originally, it had been Zikr, the General Second-Class, but now, it was a more pompous man.

Abel: “—You. You are still dressed like that.”

So said Abel, resting his cheek on hand as he snorted, having already shed his dancer’s costume and rolled up his sleeves into a more masculine attire.

In front of him was the disheveled head of a kneeling Zikr, with no one else in the room.

Subaru: “Please don’t mention my outfit. What’s more, you are alone with the General Second-Class without any guards? Do you want to throw your life away?”

Abel: “Of course, had he any intention of resisting, I would have put him to the sword. But he has no such intention. Am I not correct, Zikr Osman.”

Zikr: “—Yes. That is correct, Your Excellency.”

Jerking his chin, Zikr called out to Abel when prompted to respond.

The respectful manner in which he addressed His Excellency and his obvious superior, was a sign that he judged Abel to be more than just a crossdressing bandit.

In other words, Zikr understood Abel’s true identity, and because of that he was kneeling there.

Subaru: “Did you tell him?”

Abel: “I needed not such a thing. Apparently, this guy figured it out during the dance. No, I should say that after the dance, he understood in his head the right thing to do.”

Subaru: “—?”

Subaru tilted his head, not comprehending the meaning of those words.

However, at Abel’s observation, Zikr sank his head more deeply, as if to show further respect.

The result was a valuable person who firmly recognized and expressed respect for the fact that Abel was the Emperor, a fact that had not been felt very much up to this point.

Abel: “But it is convenient that you guessed it without needing to disclose it. Zikr Osman, follow me. You will not be wronged.”

Zikr: “Yes! If it is for you, I, Zikr Osman, will risk my life!”

Subaru: “Wait, wait, wait, are you serious? You haven’t heard anything about this yet, have you?”

Zikr made an immediate dedication to Abel, who had requested vassalage toward him while sitting on the chair.

It was convenient, sure, but too good to be true. Zikr, however, shook his head in response to Subaru’s question.

Zikr: “His Excellency is right in front of me, and he needs my aid. If so, it is my duty as a General of the Empire to respond to his request. Above all, I swear to be even more loyal to you than before.”

Abel: “Ohh, why? Were you so fascinated by my dance?”

Zikr: “It was very, very beautiful. But that is not all.”

Zikr’s heat was intense as Abel made a cold joke without even smiling. He pressed both fists to the floor, with strong and intense joy on his face.

Zikr: “I’m surprised that His Excellency remembered my two names... That I cursed as nothing but a disgrace, and that you believed it after all.”

Abel: “Of course. If one wishes to be the Ruler of the Empire, they must understand the land. The same is true for the subjects that serve. I never know when I’m going to use you, a General, as my own hand and foot. Do you earnestly believe the Emperor’s steps shall be unimpeded without knowing their own hands and feet?”

Zikr: “Absolutely not! That is why I am truly honored!”

Zikr shuddered with indelible joy, and swore fervent loyalty to Abel.

Honestly speaking, solely regarding the events, it was a too-good-to-be-true turn of events, but Zikr's profile was so uncanny that even Subaru could not find any room to doubt his inner feelings.

At the same time, Subaru was overwhelmed by the charisma of Abel's words, as well as his strong pride and conviction as the Emperor that supported it.

He did not know how many Generals there were in the empire, but even if Zikr was outstanding among them, would he be able to remember enough of every one of them to be confident that he could bring down the city regardless?

Well, even if another General had been in charge of the city, Abel seemed sure that he would have pulled the same result.

The Emperor, an opponent transcending even the clouds above, knew him, knew his strengths and weaknesses, and upon that, built his strategy, wonderfully entangled him in his expectations and defeated him.

Perhaps it was similar to a high-school baseball pitcher getting his pitch hit for a home run by his favorite professional baseball player. But actual war is too disturbing to be compared to that. In any case...

Abel: "If Zikr Osman shall follow, then the Generals under him shall likewise follow. Together with the Fortress City, I can say that we have finally gathered a strong fighting force."

Zikr: "However, if we stand against the rest of the country, we will inevitably lack strength. First of all, I think we should invite the reinforcements that are supposed to be sent from the Imperial Capital into the city, and call for their surrender."

With the addition of allies familiar with the situation of the Empire, able to formulate strategies, the discussion quickly turned into a full-fledged military one.

Unlike Abel, who accepted it without hesitation, Subaru felt a great deal of resistance to the beginning of preparations for a full-scale war. Therefore, he would prefer to have a discussion with Abel before discussions on such matters could begin.

He wanted to discuss with Abel about what to do with himself and Rem after the Fortress City was seized.

However, unfortunately, the proposal that Subaru wished to bring up was not tackled. Because—

Abel: “—Reinforcements from the Imperial Capital.”

Abel muttered in response to Zikr’s comment, and the air in the room trembled.

Subaru and Zikr widened their eyes at the sight of Abel as he stood up from his chair with great vigor and walked back to the hall. And then—

Abel: “—Close the main gate of the city right now! Do not let anyone enter, messenger or not!”

Everyone in the hall was startled by Abel’s bellow.

Of course, much like Subaru and Zikr, who had been talking with him just before yet could not comprehend it, Mizelda and the others could not discern Abel’s true intentions either.

However, Abel’s urgent look was enough for them to know that this was no ordinary matter.

Mizelda: “Taritta, go tell them to close the main gate.”

Taritta: “Ohh, sister, what in the world is...?”

Mizelda: “—Go! Don’t disgrace Shudraq’s name!”

Mizelda’s fierce voice struck the hesitating Taritta; the latter’s eyes widened at the sound of her voice, which even sounded murderous, and she promptly rushed out of the hall. With that, Taritta would order the guards to close the main gate.

And so, Abel’s instructions would be fulfilled, but—

Flop: “Village Chief-kun, what is going on? It’s rare to see you change your expression.”

Abel: “Now is not the time for your nonsense, merchant. Zikr Osman, persuade the Generals, Mizelda, you are...”

???: “Uuuuuuuuh— Hk.”

Abel quickly instructed the others, treating the worried Flop with disregard.

Abel ordered Zikr and Mizelda, the heads of their respective groups, to get their people together, but his instructions were cut off mid-sentence by a high-pitched child's tantrum.

Medium: "Whoa, whoa, whoa, what's happening!? Louis-chan, what happened!?"

Louis: "Uhh! Uhh! Ahuh!"

Utakata: "Lou! Calm down! Uu's here!"

Medium's eyes turned in surprise as she was yanked by her highly decorated hair.

Being carried on her shoulders, Louis was screaming desperately as Utakata attempted to soothe her down.

However, the rampaging Louis did not calm down at all. On the contrary, Louis was shedding large tears, her expression tense as if she were afraid of something.

Rem: "Louis-chan, please calm down! What's wrong? If there's something wrong, I'll listen to you, so don't cry..."

Louis: "Uhh!"

Rem: "Huh? Over there, what's going on?"

Unable to witness the sight of a sobbing Louis, Rem headed towards her. Upon noticing Rem's approach, Louis pointed to a corner of the hall, tears streaming down her face.

Subaru and Abel also looked in that direction. But there was nothing— There should have been nothing.

Abel: "Mizelda!"

Mizelda: "Ohh, OHHHHHH—!!"

Staring into the void, Abel was the first to call out Mizelda's name.

As if in response, Mizelda quickly readied the bow on her back, seized four arrows in her right hand, attached them to the bow at once, and drew them.

Mizelda's strong body unleashed a tremendous blow from the Shudraq chieftain.

Four arrows flew wildly, pushing into the empty space Louis was pointing to. Each one of the arrows was reminiscent of the blow of the Hunter who had killed Subaru in the jungle.

It was so powerful that it would have torn Subaru's form to shreds had he been struck by those.

The floor and walls, which were supposed to be stronger than arrows, were shattered, and the crushing sent a cloud of smoke into the hall.

As the soldiers jumped for cover and gasped for air, Subaru and the others looked closely at the smoke to ascertain if there was indeed a cause for Louis to make such a commotion.

???: "Something like that isn't going to kill me."

From somewhere, a languid voice fell softly into the smoke-filled hall.

He recognized the voice as that of a woman. Subaru's eardrums judged it to be a slow, carefree voice, lacking in emotion, and of modest volume.

It felt terribly out of place, in the momentary tension of the situation.

However, the result of that voice, was powerful.

Mizelda: "———"

—In the blink of an eye, Mizelda's entire body was engulfed in tremendous flames, having been set alight.



Mizelda: "—Tchtch!!"

In the blink of an eye, Mizelda's entire body was wrapped in a conflagration, causing her to let out an inaudible scream.

The sight of Mizelda, who had turned into a humanoid mass of flames, prevented everyone from taking any immediate action.

Kuna: “—Tch, Holly!!”

Holly: “U-understood-!!”

Immediately after Kuna called out, Holly hurriedly hastened to a container filled with a large amount of water. She lifted it with her monstrous strength, and threw it with all her might at the burning Mizelda.

The water overflowing from the broken container enveloped Mizelda her, and the immolated woman fell to the floor.

The flames had scorched her for nary a moment, but it was impossible to imagine the pain of one’s entire body being incinerated.

Subaru was unable keep up with how quickly the situation had morphed, wondering what the hell had happened. However, he did notice an increase in the number of unfamiliar figures in the center of the chaotic hall.

Not only Subaru, but the rest of the group gradually took noticed of the new figure.

—The person standing there was a beautiful girl with most of her brown skin exposed.

She had silvery-white hair, an eyepatch covering her left eye, a lush furry tail growing out of her rear, and a branch in her hand that looked like it had been picked up in the middle of nowhere.

Her emotionless face gave a somewhat unbalanced impression, when compared to her frame of lush youthful, feminine proportions.

However, there was no doubt that this pretty girl had been the trigger for the previous occurrence.

What she had done, what she desired, who she was, everything was unknown—

???: “—It is you, Arakiya.”



Illustration from Volume 27, coloring by Norvak ([source](#))

But while everyone was frozen in place, there was one person who knew the girl's name and so beckoned her.

The one who stood there with his well-shaped eyes sharpened— Staring at Arakiya, was the Emperor who had been ousted from the throne of the Sacred Vollachian Empire.

The intimidating person that Zikr had immediately sworn to obey, faced Arakiya face-to-face, but she waved the branch in her hand from side-to-side without nervousness,

Arakiya: "Long time no see, Your Excellency."

Abel: "You too, appear to be still in good health— Chisha, too, is sparing no quarter."

Arakiya: "No, he's not? That'd be dangerous."

It was not a tense conversation, from Arakiya's point of view.

Even if they were able to communicate, Abel's tense expression showed that she was not the kind of person with whom one could converse with.

In the first place, who was this woman who treated Abel so casually after recognizing him as the Emperor?

Zikr: "General First-Class, Arakiya..."

Subaru: "...What did you just say?"

With the two of them lined up, Subaru's cheeks tightened at the stifled words from Zikr.

He hoped he had misheard, but Zikr's eyes were serious, and Subaru realized that the possibility of having misheard his words had disappeared.

Then, as if to prove that it was not an illusion, Zikr piled on.

Zikr: "General First-Class Arakiya... One of the empire's strongest, one of the Nine Divine Generals!"

Abel: "She also ranks as Second among the Nine Divine Generals. That means she is the second strongest in the Empire."

Subaru: “The second strongest in the Empire...!?”

Zikr’s cry was supplemented by Abel’s words, and Subaru exclaimed, unable to conceal his surprise.

At the center of the astonished gazes in the hall, having gathered attention, Arakiya raised a branch and—

Arakiya: “Indeed!”

She puffed out her chest proudly.

Subaru: “———”

Slowly, the Shudraq that were gathered in the hall began to form a circle around Arakiya. Mizelda had been felled in the first attack, and only seventeen Shudraqians remained, including the non-combatant Utakata, so it was hard to tell if they were strong enough.

Nevertheless——

Shudraqian: “We can’t let you interfere with victory finally within our grasp——!”

One spat out a curse, and picked up one of the swords that Subaru had seized.

Driving her away, or knocking her down and capturing her. If they could achieve one of the two, they would ensure their victory in the fall of Guaral.

Arakiya: “Try as you might, it’s no use.”

The next moment, a tremendous wind blew, jumbling the entirety of the hall. Subaru, the Shudraqians, and the bound Imperial Soldiers were all moved together.

Arakiya: “———”

The heavens and earth were turned upside down, Subaru could not see up, down, left, right, in front of him, or behind him, and his entire body slammed into the floor, the wall, and the ceiling, nearly knocking him unconscious from the intense pain.

Subaru: “Kah!”

His whole body was thrown on the ground, and as he looked at the broken ceiling, his brain slowly analyzed and understood what had come to pass— Perhaps, a tornado.

In an instant, a tornado of tremendous size had erupted in the room, swallowing Subaru— or rather, Subaru and everyone else, and threw them around wildly.

Arakiya's tornado overran the room, making no distinction between people or objects, friend or foe.

Even so, Subaru barely managed to stay conscious—

Zikr: "I am not going to let you... hurt her any more than you already have..."

Zikr, holding Subaru, grunted and threw his arms out sluggishly.

The moment the tornado had spouted, Zikr had quickly pulled Subaru's body nearer to his own, in an attempt to protect him from the impact of the destruction. Its effect was limited, but it had cushioned Subaru's body, and kept him from losing consciousness. However—

Subaru: "It's a joke, right...?"

Looking around the hall, Subaru spat that out in despair.

In the midst of the mess of people and things, the Shudraq, who had raised their will to fight just before had all fallen to the ground, unable to fight.

In fact, those who had displayed hostile intentions had been the ones to suffer the most damage.

He wondered if Arakiya's tornado had even chosen which people to attack while wrecking so much destruction.

Subaru: "—Re... m."

Enduring the pain in his whole body, Subaru searched for Rem in the hall

She, like the Shudraq and the others, might have lost consciousness from the attack. Were she to be hit in the wrong place, the worst would be a possibility.

Then, Subaru gazed around the room and spotted someone.

Not Rem, however. Not Rem, but despite that, they had caught Subaru's attention.

Because even after being overrun by that tornado, they had gotten to their feet and fled to the half-destroyed balcony, leaning their back against the railing, gazing at Arakiya.

Subaru: "Abel..."

He did not know how in the world Abel had been able to protect himself in that tornado. Abel's injuries were very minimal— yet it was still painful to see him bleeding from his forehead and with one arm slumped down.

However, Abel was looking straight at Arakiya with eyes that had not lost their supremacy.

Abel: "The obedient puppet, engaging in such grandiose conduct. Have you forgotten as to why you have joined my ranks??"

Arakiya: "...Your Excellency, you lied. You deceived me. That's why, I'll never forgive you."

Abel: "—Did Chisha also put that idea in your head??"

Abel exhaled a heavy, bloodied breath, his eyes slightly downcast.

Arakiya's face was lacking in emotion, but she still held a recognizable anger in her eyes. She slowly stepped on the rough ground, and walked towards Abel on the balcony.

The thought of Abel running out to the balcony to look good never crossed Subaru's mind, but he did not think he, injured and not holding anything, had an ace up his sleeve.

The steps Arakiya took while shrinking the distance between them sounded like a countdown to Abel's very life.

One step, two steps, Arakiya approached Abel, and then—

???: "Uh, AAAAAAAAAAAAAA— HK!!"

A high-pitched voice rang out, and immediately afterwards, a pillar came crashing down on the spot where Arakiya was about to pass.

There was a roar of stone shattering and cracking, and a primitive weapon that must have weighed no less than several hundred kilograms struck Arakiya.

It was Rem, who had been hiding behind a pillar, watching for the right moment to strike.

Rem, who had remained conscious and hidden behind a pillar despite having been swallowed by the tornado, was probably visible from Abel's position. Hiding her presence, she had timed her attack with Abel's gaze as Arakiya advanced, and then pushed down the pillar.

It was the last attack he could come up with in this situation, utilizing Rem's strength.

It was well-aimed, and so it crushed Arakiya's slender body—

Arakiya: "Hmm?"

Rem: "—No way."

The floor beneath Arakiya's feet, which she had not even looked at, deformed like *amezaiku*³⁰, and stretched upwards as to support the fallen column.

It was as if they had witnessed the completion of avant-garde art from the beginning to the end.

Rem's full power did not reach Arakiya, nor did it even distract her.

Then, as Rem kneeled at the base of the broken pillar, Arakiya regarded her back. After taking a look at Rem, her eyes suddenly widened.

Arakiya: "Ohh, an oni. That's unusual."

Rem: "You're..."

Arakiya: "...Don't get in my way. I don't want my people to get hurt."

Rem: "Your people...?"

³⁰ Translation note by Witch Cult Translations: "Amezaiku is a form of Japanese candy craft artistry, which results in beautiful sculptures of animals such as fish and insects; for more information, see [here](#)".

Rem's face reddened with anger, wondering what she was talking about.

But sadly, because of the existence of a large discrepancy in power between her self and her opponent, anger was merely an emotion, and the will to resist was useless.

Rem reached for rubble, and this time tried to show her intent to attack by throwing stones.

However, Arakiya swung the branch in her hand, conjuring a wind that blew the debris around Rem away.

Literally, they had been swept away. Not only the debris on the floor were blown away, but the walls and ceiling behind Rem, the upper levels of the building, one after another, were as well.

Arakiya: "I'm not good at controlling my strength. You, too, will fly away, at this rate."

Rem: "If that's the case, then why don't you do it? After all you've done, what's there to hesitate about now? It's not like that..."

Arakiya: "...Disappointing."

Rem's clenched-teeth answer made Arakiya's shoulders slump in dejection.

But despite the cute gesture, Arakiya's actions were caustic and simple. Slowly the branch was lifted, and a phenomenon of a different dimension would shatter Rem's existence.

—There was no way Natsuki Subaru could tolerate such a thing.

Subaru: "AH, AHHHHH— Hk!"

With a yell, Subaru's body leapt into action, chasing away the pain in his entire body.

Only at this moment, cowering fear, unpredictable anxiety, and everything else were in the way.

Abandoning his fears, he moved forward as his instincts told him to, and intervened in front of Rem and Arakiya.

He hoped to at least protect Rem from the destruction that was about to befall her.

He was willing to die, if it meant protecting Rem.

He really did not want to die, and everything would be ruined if Natsuki Subaru died here, but he did not mind dying here.

Dressed as a woman, with fake breasts, makeup on his face, a wig on his head, and even an ingenious way to make his skin look white, in such a ridiculous appearance that sought beauty, Natsuki Subaru stood up for the girl he had to protect, with the thought of spitting blood.

Rem: “—Hk.”

Protecting Rem against his back, he spread his hands.

He could notice that Rem had gasped upon dawning on her that Subaru had intervened in front of her.

But what she thought or felt about Subaru’s action, he would never know. That opportunity would never come again.

It was snatched away in a flash before the destruction named Arakiya—

???: “—What a comical sight. But it is not so bad.”

That was the voice that reached Subaru’s ears as he prepared to have everything taken away, and nothing to be left.

As he closed his eyes in an attempt to accept the coming end, he gasped when he registered that no heat, loss, pain, suffering, thirst, or any of the other factors that lead to “death” had befallen his body.

Then slowly opening his eyes, he saw it.

Before that Subaru, spreading out his upper limbs, shielding Rem to his back— there was someone else’s back.

It was not Arakiya. Arakiya was standing on the other side of that back. He could see her standing there, stunned, astonishment plastered on her face.

The being that had brought that stupefaction to Arakiya turned around, cutting down all the destruction that was supposed to come, while holding up a glowing red sword in their right hand.

Pompous, arrogant, crimson eyes convinced that everything in this world would kneel at their feet. The one who hugged their arms as they bounced their ample breasts, with scornful looks that were the embodiment of cruel beauty, a person who he was not supposed to see here.

Subaru: “—Ah.”

Subaru simply gasped at the appearance of an existence that was not supposed to be there.

Looking at him, the owner of the beautiful face, the manifestation of the word “crimson”, snorted.

And then—

???: “No need to say your name, fool. I shall, however, permit you to say my name.”

As she said this, she— Priscilla Barielle, had a blood-colored smile on her face.



Illustration from Volume 27, coloring by DdukaE ([source](#))

Character Pages

トッド

Todd

帝国軍人。目的のためには手段を選ばない冷酷さを持つ。

Todd



Louann
ロウアン

Louann

酒浸りの大酒飲み。
剣の實力は高く、判断力も
相応に身につけた腕利き。

Characters

Re: Life in a different world
from zero

Characters

Re: Life in a different world
from zero

only ability I got in a different world "Returns by Death"
I die again and again to save her.

フロップ

Flop

ヴォラキアの商人。妹と共に
帝国各地で行商している。



ミディアム

Medium

フロップの妹。二振りの
蜚刀が武器。



Other Volumes

Main Story (Root folder at [Link](#))

- Arc 1 (Single volume):
 - Volume 1 - [Link](#);
- Arc 4 (Full arc at [Link](#)):
 - Volume 10 - [Link](#);
 - Volume 11 - [Link](#);
 - Volume 12 - [Link](#);
 - Volume 13 - [Link](#);
 - Volume 14 - [Link](#);
 - Volume 15 - [Link](#).
- Arc 5 (Full arc at [Link](#)):
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- Arc 8 (Full arc at [Link](#)):
 - Volume 34 - [Link](#);
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 - Volume 37 - [Link](#);
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- Arc 9 (Full arc at [Link](#)):
 - Volume 39 - [Link](#);
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 - Volume 42 - [Link](#);
 - Volume 43 - [Link](#);
 - Volume 44 - [Link](#).

Side Content (Root folder at [Link](#))

- Side Stories:
 - Heroic Tale from Zero (Arc 2 spoilers) - [Link](#);
 - Oni Sisters of the Hidden Village EX (Arc 4 spoilers) - [Link](#);
 - Artbook Short Stories (various) - [Link](#).
- IFs:
 - Rem IF (Arc 2 spoilers) - [Link](#).